

CHINA

A HISTORY

VOLUME I

永和九年歲在癸丑暮春之初會稽山陰之蘭亭脩禊事也羣賢畢至少長咸集此地有峻領茂林脩竹又有清流激湍映帶左右引以為流觴曲水列坐其次雖無絲竹管絃之盛一觴一詠亦足以暢敘幽情是日也天朗氣清惠風和暢仰觀宇宙之大俯察品類之盛所以遊目騁懷足以極視聽之娛信可樂也夫人之相與俯仰一世或取諸懷抱悟言一室之內或因寄所託放浪形骸之外雖趣舍萬殊靜躁不同當其欣於所遇暫得於己快然自足不知老之將至及其所之既倦情隨事遷感慨係之矣向之所欣俯仰之間以為陳迹猶不能不以之興懷況脩短隨化終期於盡古人云死生亦大矣豈不痛哉每覽昔人興感之由若合一契未嘗不臨文嗟悼不能喻之於懷固知一死生為虛誕齊彭殤為妄作後之視今亦猶今之視昔悲夫故列敘時人錄其所述雖世殊事異所以興懷其致一也後之覽者亦將有感於斯文

*From Neolithic Cultures
through the Great Qing Empire*

HAROLD M. TANNER

CHINA

A History

VOLUME 1

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FROM NEOLITHIC CULTURES
THROUGH THE GREAT QING EMPIRE
10,000 BCE–1799 CE

Harold M. Tanner

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My education in China's history, language, and culture has been a long journey—both real and metaphorical—a journey in which this book marks only a milestone, not an end. It has taken me from my home in New Jersey to Taiwan and China, to London and New York City, and to my new home in Texas. The many people who have helped me along the way have enriched my knowledge and transformed my thinking, though perhaps not as thoroughly as they would have liked. Their teaching, advice, and support have made this book possible. The list of those to thank begins with my teachers: Parry Jones, who introduced me to the study of China's history at the Princeton Day School in New Jersey; Stuart Schram, Paul Chen, and Ian Nish at London University's School of Oriental and African Studies; and at Columbia University, Madeleine Zelin, Andrew Nathan, Tom Bernstein, Gari Ledyard, Bob Hymes, Wm. Theodore de Bary, Irene Bloom, Morris Rossabi, and Hans Beilenson. I hope that this book reflects, at least in some small way, the breadth and depth of the education that I have been fortunate enough to receive from these and other teachers over the years.

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[A Note on Transliterations](#)

Chinese names in this text have been written using the Hanyu pinyin system of Romanization. Most words are pronounced roughly the way an English-speaker would guess. There are a few important exceptions to this rule: “c” is pronounced as “ts,” “q” as “ch,” and “x” more or less like “s.” I have used nonpinyin spellings for a few individuals and entities whose names have become universally recognized under those earlier spellings in English-language literature. Thus, Sun Yat-sen (known in Chinese as Sun Wen or Sun Yixian), Chiang Kai-shek (pinyin Jiang Jieshi), the Kwantung Army (pinyin Guandong Army), and “Manchukuo.”

Mongolian names have been rendered in line with the system used in Christopher P. Atwood, *Encyclopedia of Mongolian and the Mongol Empire* (New York: Facts on File, 2004), ix. For Tibetan names, I have followed the system used by the International Association of Tibetan Studies (online at <http://thdl.org>).

About the Chinese Characters

Chinese characters from the Zhou Dynasty divination text, the *Book of Changes* (*Yi jing*), have been used as symbols for the Introduction and for each of the three parts of this book. The *Book of Changes* uses sixty-four hexagrams (combinations of broken and unbroken lines) to represent the stages of change in a cyclically changing universe. The hexagrams used in this text, their names, and their meanings are as follows:

Introduction: 乾 (*qian*) “The Creative.” The first hexagram of the *Book of Changes*, *qian* symbolizes beginnings, justice, the way of the superior man, and the primal creative force of the universe.

Part I: 噬嗑 (*shihe*) “Biting Through.” This, the twenty-first hexagram, refers to the establishment of institutions and the judicious, yet forceful use of laws and punishments to bring about order and harmony.

Part II: 大有 (*dayou*) “Possession in Great Measure.” The fourteenth hexagram stands for blessings extended to all, just as the sun in the heavens shines equally on all below, bringing clarity and order to the world.

Part III: 豐 (*feng*) “Abundance.” The fifty-fifth hexagram conveys the meaning of having surmounted challenges in order to achieve a glorious abundance, like the sun standing high in the sky at midday.

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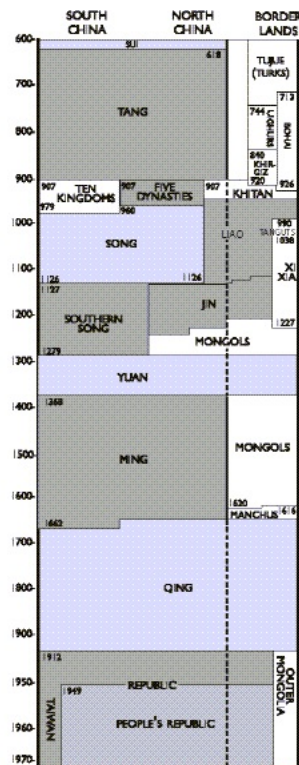
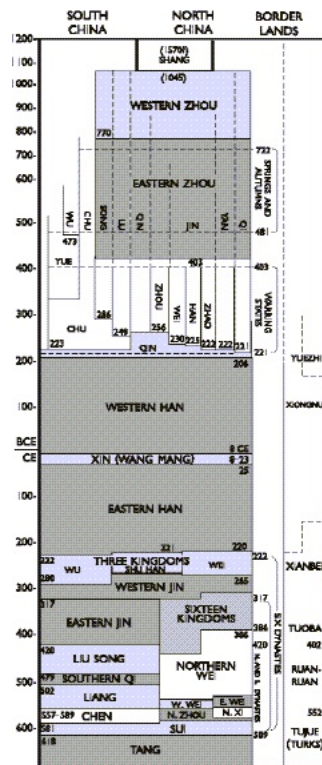
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China

A HISTORY

乾

At 8:08 p.m. on the eighth of August, the eighth month of 2008, China reintroduced itself to the world with the grand opening ceremony of the Beijing Summer Olympics. China's Communist Party leaders had chosen the date and time in accord with popular superstition: the Chinese words for "eight" and "to get rich" are homophones, which makes eight a very fortunate number. The theatrical opening ceremony, the ultramodern Olympic venues, extensive investment in urban infrastructure (including a new international terminal at Beijing's airport), and the Chinese athletes' record haul of fifty-one gold medals (more than any other country) all stood as testimony to China's wealth and power.

An event like the Beijing Olympics is often portrayed as a symbolic moment in the history of a nation. But symbolic of what? That all depends on the way you write the history of the decades, centuries, or millennia that preceded the time of the event itself. As they watched and discussed the Beijing Olympics, Chinese and American audiences attached different meanings to the same event because they approached it with different histories of China in mind.

For Chinese audiences, the opening ceremony and the games themselves symbolized a recovery of lost glory. Until the early 19th century, China had been one of the largest and most productive economies on earth and the dominant military and cultural power in East and Central Asia. Then, in the mid-19th century, came what Chinese history textbooks and politicians often refer to as a "national humiliation." The industrialized nations of the West and Japan invaded China, took its resources, dominated its markets, stunted its economic growth, and mistreated its people. Now, in 2008, after more than a century of poverty, war, and revolution in which it had been dismissed as the "sick man of Asia," China was back on the road to wealth and ready to join the ranks of the developed industrialized nations as an equal.



[The People's Republic of China and neighboring areas.](#)

Most American spectators approached the Beijing Olympics with a very different idea of China's history. The American media portrayed the games as China's "coming-out party." The picture created for the American public was one of a country emerging from centuries of isolation and/or a country "opening" to the capitalist, democratic West after decades of control by an anti-Western Communist leadership. American journalists and spectators tended to interpret much of what they noticed in Beijing—Starbucks coffee, rock and roll, and Chinese fans' enthusiasm for American basketball stars like Kobe Bryant, for instance—as encouraging signs of "opening." Americans were also quick to point to evidence that China's Communist leadership had not completely signed on to the spirit of "openness." Much was made, for example, of continued government blocking of politically sensitive Web sites.

These two versions of Chinese history—one Chinese, the other American—are mutually contradictory. On the one hand, we have invasion; on the other, self-imposed isolation. Both stories are fundamentally wrong. China's history is not a drama of strength and glory, downfall at the hands of Western imperialists, and redemption through rapid economic growth, nor is it an object lesson in the dangers of isolation and the value of open doors and open markets.

The goal of this book, the first of two volumes, is to trace Chinese history from its beginnings around 10,000 BCE through the reign of the Qianlong emperor (r. 1736–1796) of the Qing Empire (1644–1912). Volume Two will pick up the story in the Qianlong reign and take it into the first decade of the 21st century CE. Together, the two volumes will tell the story of China in a way that goes beyond the simple but misleading narratives of glory to downfall to redemption or of isolation to opening.

During the millennia covered in volume one there was, in fact, no one nation or state corresponding precisely with the people and territory of the contemporary People's Republic of China. The story of China's past presented in these pages is not, then, the story of a single unchanging country. It is, instead, the tale of various Paleolithic and Neolithic cultures followed by a number of dynastic governments whose territories included various parts of what are now China, Vietnam, Korea, Mongolia, Russia, and the Central Asian Republics. Nor is this the story of a single, unchanging Chinese people and culture. It is, rather, the story of how the Chinese people and their culture (including language, government, philosophy, religion, literature, architecture, art, and music) developed through centuries of interaction between the settled agricultural people of northern China's Central Plains and the peoples of southern China, Southeast Asia, Korea, Central Asia, India, the Middle East, Europe, and, especially, the hunters, nomads, and traders of China's Inner Asian periphery (see pg. 8). It is only appropriate, then, that we begin the story by looking at the land and its people, and by asking: What is China? And who are the people of China?

The Lay of the Land

The territory that we now refer to as China is vast: over 3,705,386 square miles (9,596,960 sq km), extending from over 50 degrees latitude in the north to below 20 degrees latitude in the south, from the alluvial plains and river valleys of the east to the forbidding mountains, high plateaus, and deserts of Tibet and Xinjiang in the west. This territory has been home to a variety of ethnic groups. Kingdoms and empires have risen and fallen on this huge landmass: in many cases, what we now refer to as “China” has been home to two or more different kingdoms or empires at the same time. In the 20th century, we observe the emergence of a unified, modern nation-state, the Republic of China, and then the People’s Republic of China, dominated by a single large ethnic group—the Han, whom we generally call “Chinese.” In addition to the Han (who comprise 91.5 percent of China’s population), China has fifty-five other ethnic groups, or “minority nationalities” as they are called in China.

The unification of all the territory and peoples now falling within the borders of the People’s Republic of China is the relatively recent product of a very long historical process. The origins of that territorial unity lie in the empire-building of the Han and later dynastic regimes and in waves of migration in which Han people, their agricultural civilization, and the power of their dynastic governments spread across the land. The process of migration and government action and the ethnic, economic, and cultural transformations that follow continue in the 21st century as Han Chinese migration changes the ethnic composition of the western areas of Tibet and Xinjiang, and as the market economy and globalization change the lifestyles and customs of all Chinese, the Han majority and the many ethnic minority peoples.

The homeland of the Han people is that area which geographers refer to as “China Proper.” The territory includes the drainage areas of three major river systems and their tributaries: the Yellow River in the north, the Yangzi River in the center, and the Xi (West) River in the south. The area includes the Central Plains, the Yangzi Valley, the Guangdong (Canton) Basin, and the Sichuan Basin—the latter relatively isolated behind mountain ranges and (until recently) the forbidding Three Gorges of the Yangzi River. China Proper is well suited to settled agriculture and is the area in which the Han Chinese came to be the dominant ethnic group by the tenth century.

China Proper itself may be divided into two parts, north and south. The line of division is created roughly by the Qin (or Qinling) Mountains, running along the Han River until the river turns south, and then cutting across to the Huai River and following its path to the Yellow Sea. North China is relatively dry and cool. The soil and climate are suitable for the cultivation of millet, barley, wheat, and soybeans. South China is a place of heavier rainfall and is blessed with an abundance of rivers and lakes. The soil and climate are suitable for irrigated rice agriculture. As we shall see, south China was originally home to many ethnic groups other than the Han. Some remain today as ethnic minorities; others were gradually absorbed or displaced as Han Chinese migration, supported by military force, changed the ethnic composition and the economy of this fertile area.

Standing in contrast to China Proper is a vast area that we will refer to as China’s Inner Asian periphery. The Inner Asian periphery includes Tibet, Xinjiang, Ningxia, Inner Mongolia, and Manchuria.¹ These areas have historically been the homelands of people other than the Han ethnic group. Relations between the predominantly Han people of China Proper and the various peoples of China’s Inner Asian periphery have been characterized at times by trade, and at other times by warfare. Government based in China Proper sometimes conquered and administered parts of the Inner Asian periphery. At other times, nomadic confederations, kingdoms, or imperial states ruled over parts of the Inner Asian periphery, asserting their identity against and variously trading and/or fighting with the states of China Proper. Occasionally Inner Asian peoples subjugated and ruled northern portions of China Proper or even, in the cases of the Mongols and the Manchus, brought all of China Proper under their control. Also peripheral to China Proper was the island of Taiwan, lying 150 miles (240 km) off the southeast Chinese coast. Only in modern times, under the Qing dynasty (1644–1911), did a government based in China Proper build an empire that included the entire Inner Asian periphery and the island of Taiwan.

People and Provinces

It would be historically inaccurate to assign a single ethnic identity to any one of the regions of the Inner Asian periphery or Taiwan and to assume that it has always been the homeland of that particular ethnic group. Many peoples have come and gone, fought, intermarried, and melded with one another, not just in these outlying areas, but even in China Proper itself. Nonetheless, it is useful to make some general statements about the major ethnic groups of Taiwan and the Inner Asian periphery.

Taiwan was originally inhabited by aboriginal people whose native languages are related to the Polynesian

languages of the Pacific islands. Migration of Han Chinese from the mainland, gradual and small in numbers at first, increased markedly in the 17th century. Han Chinese migrants clashed with the aboriginal people, pushing them up into the mountains. In 1684, the Qing government incorporated the island as a prefecture of Fujian province, thus marking the beginning of Taiwan's administration from the mainland.² Before the third century CE, the southwestern areas of Yunnan, Guizhou, and Annam (now northern Vietnam) were also parts of the periphery of China Proper. The numerous ethnic groups of these areas, including Hmong (whom the Chinese refer to as Miao), Dai, and Annamese, interacted with Chinese migrants and with the imperial states that absorbed what became China's southwestern provinces and, at times, Annam as well.

To the west of China Proper, at elevations of 6,500 feet (2,000 m) and more above sea level, lies the area inhabited by Tibetan people. This includes the contemporary Xizang Autonomous Region (Tibet), Qinghai province, some of the western fringes of Sichuan and Gansu provinces, and parts of northern Yunnan province. The Tibetan region consists largely of sparsely inhabited plateaus on which nomadic herders of sheep and yak eke out a living. In river valley areas, sedentary farmers cultivate barley, potatoes, and other crops. Over a period of time, but particularly in the eighth century, the Tibetans converted from their animistic religion, Bon, to Buddhism—although retaining many of the elements of Bon, so that the resulting variety of Buddhism has distinct Tibetan characteristics.

To the northwest lies the Xinjiang Uighur Autonomous Region. This area has been home to various people, including Buddhist kingdoms (during the Tang period) and, more recently, to the Uighur and other Turkic peoples whose religion is Islam and who sometimes refer to the area as “East Turkestan.” The center of Xinjiang is dominated by the forbidding Taklamakan Desert. At the outer edges of this desert area are rich oases fed by run-off from the snowcovered Tian and Kunlun Mountains. In the northern corner of Xinjiang the Zunghar Basin (Zungharia) is defined and watered by the Altai and other mountain chains. Together, these various mountain chains define Xinjiang, dividing it from the other Central Asian Turkic lands, while the trade routes across the desert and down through the Gansu Corridor (that finger of Inner Chinese cultivated land lying between the Gobi Desert and the Tibetan Plateau) bring the area into commercial and cultural contact with China Proper. Thus the people of Xinjiang have functioned as middlemen, agents of trade and cultural exchange between Turkic Central Asia and Han China Proper, developing their own mixed cultural identity in the process. The independence of the Central Asian states after the fall of the Soviet Union re-invigorated the old trade routes: Xinjiang once again functions as a route of contact between China Proper and Central Asia.

To the north of China Proper is Mongolia—an area that includes both the contemporary Inner Mongolian Autonomous Region and the republic of Mongolia. Mongolia includes the Gobi Desert, mountains in the northwest, and, in between, vast grasslands that have supported nomadic pastoral peoples, most recently the Mongols, but in previous centuries others, including the Uighurs (during the Tang dynasty) and the Xiongnu (during the Qin and Han periods). The nomadic economy relied on a triumvirate of animals: sheep for wool and food, horses for warfare and communications, and camels for transport. The tribal peoples of the grasslands would sometimes form larger federations, the largest and most significant being that formed by the Mongol leader Chinggis Khan. The relations of the nomads of the steppe with the settled agricultural people of China Proper have varied from trade to raiding to conquest. To the east of Mongolia lies Manchuria. In premodern times, this area was populated by tribal peoples who practiced a combination of farming, animal husbandry, hunting, and trading.

As we move on through the histories of the peoples and kingdoms, the wars, the cultures, and the remarkable individuals who came and went on this vast stage that we call China, we will be harking back to these basic geographical areas and features, adding refinements here and there and taking note of change over time. We will also be referring to China's provinces.

From the Qin dynasty (221–206 BCE) through the present time, Chinese governments have divided their territories into larger administrative units that we generally call “provinces.” In some periods, two or more provinces and their governors would be grouped together under a governor-general. Each province was subdivided into a number of counties. At times there would be an administrative layer consisting of a number of counties between county and province. Provincial and county boundaries and even names changed over the years. Nonetheless, there is enough stability in enough of the provincial names that it is useful to become familiar with them as they appear on a contemporary map of the People's Republic of China. The names and boundaries of China's provinces reflect the country's multi-ethnic character and the way in which China Proper became the economic, political, military, and cultural center of a country that includes the Inner Asian periphery.

China Proper consists of nineteen provincial-level units. In the north are Shandong, Hebei, and Shanxi, with Shaanxi and Gansu in the northwest. Gansu is the province whose “corridor” reaches up toward the oases of

Xinjiang and thus carried trade over the famous “Silk Road” to and from the Central Asian kingdoms and beyond. Straddling the border of north and south China are Jiangsu, Anhui, Henan, and Hubei provinces. The Yangzi River flows through all four, bringing with it the blessings of irrigation and transport and the curse of periodic floods. Firmly in the south we have Zhejiang, Jiangxi, Hunan, Fujian, Guangdong, and Hainan. In the mountainous southwest lie the provinces of Yunnan, Guizhou, and Sichuan.

Also in the southwest is the Guangxi Zhuang Autonomous Region, a mountainous region with a sizeable population of non-Han peoples collectively referred to as “Zhuang.” China’s “Autonomous Regions” (there are five of them) are provincial-level units whose populations have a majority or a very sizeable minority of non-Han people. The logic behind the autonomous regions is to provide a degree of self-rule to the non-Han people who have historically been the majority population in these peripheral areas. In the same way, ethnic minority areas within some provinces have been designated as autonomous counties or autonomous prefectures. In practice, the “autonomy” has been largely ceremonial, as Han Chinese Communist Party bureaucrats hold real power.

China’s Inner Asian periphery includes both provinces and autonomous regions. The Tibetan ethnic area is divided among the Tibet (Xizang) Autonomous Region, the province of Qinghai, and a number of autonomous counties and prefectures in Yunnan, Sichuan, and Gansu provinces. In the extreme northwest, the Uighurs and other Turkic Muslim groups make up a slim majority of the population of the Xinjiang Uighur Autonomous Region. The Ningxia Hui Autonomous Region, bordering on Gansu and Shaanxi, is home to a large population of Hui people—Chinese Muslims who trace their descent from Arab and Central Asian Muslim traders who came to China centuries ago. The Hui are a minority even within Ningxia. Mongols likewise are a minority in the Inner Mongolia (Nei Menggu) Autonomous Region. Manchuria, where the overwhelming majority of the people are Han Chinese, is divided into China’s three northeastern provinces: Heilongjiang, Jilin, and Liaoning. A few rural areas that have Manchu communities have been designated as autonomous counties or prefectures.

Villages, Towns, and Cities

For all of Chinese history, the vast majority—eighty percent or more—of the Han people of China Proper were farmers. Their world was the world of the village—but not merely of the village itself, but also the standard marketing area within which the males of the family, in particular, were accustomed to doing business with men from other villages and even from one of the larger cities that served as the intermediate markets to which the standard market towns were oriented.

Certainly, farmers spent most of their time in their home villages and found their identity in “family, fields, and ancestors.”³ For most of Chinese history the best arrangement, from the point of view of both government and the farmers, was a system of independent land holding by small family farmers. Family identity and solidarity was very strong—the ideal was to have “three generations under one roof.” In practice, this was rarely achieved for long, as families went through natural cycles of growth and contraction. But even while most families were nuclear families most of the time, they were knit together into clans. Clan organizations were stronger in the south than in the north. Throughout China, however, clan identity was symbolized and maintained through ancestral temples and sometimes through clan leadership, commonly held land, and other clan-run institutions.

For all their deep local roots, Chinese farmers were not self-sufficient peasants, living their lives in the narrow confines of their fields and villages. Instead, they were actively involved in a wider community—the standard marketing area—in which they shared not only goods, but culture. These marketing areas ranged from 5 or fewer square miles (approx. 15 sq km) to over 60 square miles (150 sq km) in sparsely populated mountainous and infertile border areas. Market systems and market towns grew in numbers over time, so that by the Qing period (1644–1911), virtually every farming household lived in an area that was accessible to a market town.⁴ These market towns were not grand places. Typically, they would have one real street, some permanent shops, and various discrete market areas, each dedicated to a particular product or craft. Marketing would be on a regular schedule, generally once every three or five days, for a few hours on each designated market day.

Each of these standard market towns would be linked to two or three larger “intermediate” market towns, which occupied a position between the central and the standard markets. It was in the intermediate market towns that one would expect to see members of the landholding local elite—those families who had accumulated larger amounts of agricultural land, which they rented out to farmers who had little or no land of their own. There, these elite families would have access to books and writing implements, fine fabrics, and other luxury goods that would not be found in

a humbler standard market town.

Above the intermediate market town one would find the central market towns and, above them, local and regional cities. These larger and more sophisticated central market towns, local cities, and regional capitals would typically be located at important transportation junctions and would be the sites of warehousing and wholesaling. The higher one went in this hierarchy of central places, the more likely it would be that one would find fully walled cities that not only had marketing functions, but also served as administrative centers. These were Chinese cities in the real sense—urban settlements with walls and a government office. It is to the cities that we shall now turn our attention.

The productivity of Chinese farmers supported one of the most sophisticated and, in terms of sheer numbers, one of the largest urban civilizations in world history. China's cities were the natural environment of the elite, the centers of trade, administration, and higher culture. Towns and cities and town and city people thus take up a disproportionate amount of the attention of students of Chinese history.

China's towns and cities are as varied as its landscape—from the flat, dry, and dusty cities of the north, laid out in squares, to Sichuan's Chongqing in the southwest, where the streets writhe up and around (and, in the future, will punch through) the hills, to canal-laced southern cities like Suzhou and Ningbo. Some towns had exclusively commercial functions, while other towns, and virtually all cities, were both administrative and commercial centers.

There was an ideal model, informed by cosmological principles, according to which a city should be constructed.⁵ This model called for walled and moated rectangular cities laid out on a north-south axis, horizontal and vertical streets, palaces in the center of the city facing south, and markets in the shady position to the north. When it came to real-life urban construction, Chinese rulers were practical, not slaves to tradition or to one ideal model. Some capital cities more or less approximated the ideals expressed in the classical model; others followed quite different plans.⁶ Some cities, for example, had designated marketplaces (but generally not in the north), while in others (such as the Northern Song capital of Kaifeng), business took place everywhere. City walls often departed from the ideal square model to accommodate natural features like rivers or hills. Tang Chang'an had the imperial palace on the northern edge of the city, facing south. The Mongol Yuan capital of Dadu placed the imperial palace in the center, according to the classical model. So too did Ming-Qing Beijing, which was built on the site of Dadu. Smaller cities were often walled (some were not), and could be roughly square, rectangular, or even round.

Whether it is the urban environment and its culture, the world of the rural areas and small towns, or, indeed, the land itself, we need to be aware of the great variety, and the significant changes that have taken place over thousands of years. But for now, let us return to the land and the first people on it.

The Origins of the Chinese People

Where do the Chinese people come from? How did they become “Chinese” in terms of appearance (race) and culture? These questions are inextricably intertwined with the larger question: Where did we all come from? What evolutionary process led the earth to be populated by groups of *Homo sapiens* of a variety of skin colors, hair textures, cranial and facial configurations, languages, and cultures?

In 1921, archeologists discovered the fossilized remains of over forty *Homo erectus* individuals in a cave at Zhoukoudian, near Beijing. “Peking Man” and other *Homo erectus*, whose fossilized remains have been discovered at other sites in China, were once thought to have been the ancestors of the modern Chinese.⁷ More recent scholarship argues that the Chinese, like all the world's contemporary human population, are the descendants of *Homo sapiens*—a hominid that evolved in East Africa around two hundred thousand years ago and spread to the rest of the world in the last hundred thousand years.⁸

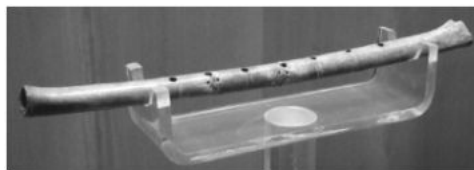
The evidence for this hypothesis includes both the fossil record and studies of mitochondrial DNA. The latter studies indicate that all humans—Chinese included—share a common ancestral origin in Africa. If this is the case, then “Peking Man,” like *Homo erectus* elsewhere around the world (the Neanderthals, for example), was an evolutionary dead end—a variety of advanced hominid that was replaced by the new wave of *Homo sapiens* coming out of Africa, and who thus did not contribute to the genetic makeup of the people of modern China.⁹ This suggests that the physical characteristics—shapes of noses, eyes, and so on—that we use to place people in racial categories are a fairly recent development.¹⁰ Related research indicates that China Proper may have been populated by migrations from two separate directions. One route brought people from Africa to the Eurasian continent, across Central Asia and Siberia and thus down into northern China. Another route brought people to South China via Southeast Asia.¹¹

Some archeologists and anthropologists in the West and in China reject the “out of Africa” theory. They prefer to interpret the fossils discovered in China—Peking Man and various other *Homo erectus* and *Homo sapiens* remains—as evidence that *Homo erectus* in the area that we now call China evolved independently into the modern Chinese people. This interpretation fits well into contemporary Chinese nationalist ideology, since it suggests that the people of all the various ethnic groups of China (including Taiwan) evolved together, on the territory of the modern People’s Republic of China, share common ancestors, and are therefore members of the same big family.¹²

Neolithic Cultures and the Beginnings of Chinese Civilization

Whatever their origins and genetic background, modern humans inhabited numerous regions of China before and during the time of the Neolithic Revolution when, some ten thousand years ago, humans around the world, including China, made the drastic leap from hunter-gatherer economies to the settled agricultural lifestyle.

Archeological discoveries of Neolithic settlements allow us to piece together the story of the development and interaction of more than a dozen distinctly separate Neolithic cultures in China. Cultural interaction led to the emergence of one particular region—the Central Plains—as a center of economic, military, and cultural power. As a result of this concentration of power in the Central Plains area, it came to pass that later, when myths were recorded and histories written, they told a story of the emergence of civilization that is at odds with the archeological record.



Neolithic bone flute unearthed in Henan province.

Myth and myth-based history represented the Central Plains as the point of origin of all the elements of civilization, which were then dispersed outward to the other regions of China. This version of events—clearly apocryphal—is important because it is the basis of an important element of Chinese identity and of Western perceptions of China: it is the foundation of the relatively modern, and misleading, idea that China is the Middle Kingdom whose people invented culture, defended their cultural area from barbarian onslaughts, and exported their culture to the surrounding barbarian peoples, exercising on them (as far as possible, given their barbarian natures) the moderating and improving influences of civilization.

The story of civilization developing in the Central Plains and spreading slowly outward is powerful in its simplicity. To cast this myth aside and understand the real story, we must go back to the archeological record, back to a time when the Central Plains were smaller and less distinct from the rest of China than they are today.

Between 8000 and 3000 BCE all of China, including southern Manchuria, southern Mongolia, and the Central Plains, was considerably warmer and moister than it is today. The Shandong Peninsula was an island, separated from the mainland by ocean and swamps, which gradually dried and filled in over the millennia; southern Manchuria and southern Mongolia were dotted with lakes, and the Central Plains was considerably smaller, expanding slowly with cooler, drier weather and as silt from the Yellow River contributed to the outward growth of the east China coast. This was a north China and southern Manchuria of forests and rich grasslands. Among the local fauna were cattle, sheep, deer, panda, tiger, black bear, and leopard, and also typically southern animals such as musk deer, rhinoceros, elephant, jackal, peacock, and alligator.¹³

South China, too, was warmer and more humid than it is at present, although the contrast between contemporary and Neolithic climatic conditions in the south is not as strong as it is in the north. In both south and north China, the climate cooled gradually, from 3000 to 1000 BCE, and more noticeably during the millennium following 1000 BCE.

It was in the context of this warmer and moister climate in China Proper that the ancestors of the modern Chinese began to practice agriculture, to establish more or less permanent settlements, to build walled cities, and to develop pottery, writing, and, eventually, bronze technology. Archeological work done in China over the past century has

enabled us to roughly understand the stages through which Neolithic cultures rose, changed over time, and fell in various parts of China. The evidence reveals a process by which some of the basic elements of what we understand as Chinese civilization developed in various places, and, ultimately, were amalgamated through a process of interaction between a number of distinct Neolithic cultures.

As in many areas around the world, hunter-gatherers in China began to domesticate plants for food and animals for food and for power around 10,000 BCE. The reasons for this move toward agriculture remain unclear. Anthropologists suggest that farming was in general a more difficult way of life than hunting and gathering and, with the exception of highly developed agricultural societies, offered a less healthy diet.¹⁴ The development of agriculture coincides with the generally warmer climate of the early Holocene period and a stronger East Asian monsoon, which brought more moisture to the Central Plains of north China.¹⁵ Some hypotheses associate this warmer period with a decline in the amount of game and wild edible plants, and with an increase in population densities. Theoretically, this would lead people to turn to agriculture because agriculture provides a more stable source of food, one which will support more people on a given amount of land than hunting and gathering can.

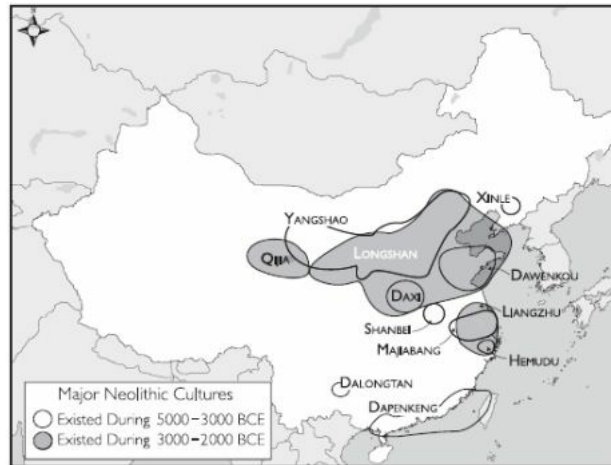
There is evidence of agricultural societies in both northern and southern China dating back to a period roughly between 10,000 and 5000 BCE. Despite the generally warmer conditions that continued throughout China, we see already in these earliest cultures a distinction between the north and the south. The earliest settled farming peoples of the north are known as the Peiligang culture. Remains of their villages have been found in Henan and Hebei, with related finds in Shaanxi and Gansu.¹⁶ Their staple crop was foxtail millet. In the south were a people whose culture is identified by their distinctive cord-marked pottery and who cultivated rice.¹⁷ Cord-marked pottery culture sites have been found in Jiangxi, Guangdong, and Guangxi.¹⁸

The Peiligang and southern cord-marked pottery cultures each had their own distinctive styles. Peiligang sites are typically clusters of round (sometimes square) houses, 6–10 feet (2–3 m) across, with plastered floors sunk below ground level. Also present are underground storage pits and burial sites. Thus far, the remains of the cord-marked pottery culture have been found predominantly in limestone caves which appear to have been their permanent dwellings as well as where they dumped their garbage and buried their dead. Both cultures used a variety of stone tools—mortars and pestles, axes, scrapers, awls and chisels, long sickles with sharp teeth (found at Peiligang sites), digging stick rings (polished stone disks with holes found in cordmarked pottery sites), and others. Both cultures made bone tools such as needles, awls, arrowheads, harpoon-heads, and hairpins. While they differed in their staple grain (millet in the north, rice in the south), both cultures had domesticated pigs, and perhaps chickens and dogs, for food, and both also continued to hunt and gather: game, mollusks, turtles, clams, and snails remained significant parts of their diet.

There is very little that we can say about the cultural lives of these very early farmers. Both peoples made coarse pottery: that of the northern Peiligang culture area was generally plain-surfaced, while the southern people usually marked their pottery with a variety of patterns by imprinting it with cords, and occasionally painted it red. The Peiligang people have left tantalizing hints of their cultural life in the form of turquoise ornaments included in a few of their burials, a single seven-holed bone flute, and two turtle shells—each of which has a single symbol inscribed on it. These turtle shells are particularly intriguing: six thousand years later the Shang people would develop a sophisticated form of divination using turtle shells, many of which were inscribed with writing. The two Peiligang symbols are said to bear some resemblance to the sort of symbols used in the Shang writing system that, in turn, is the ancestor of the modern Chinese writing system.¹⁹

Multiple Centers of Culture

Can we, then, trace the pedigree of Chinese civilization back to the Peiligang culture and assume that this Chinese culture then spread out from the core area of the Yellow River Valley and adjacent areas of the Central Plains to eventually dominate all the territory that we now call “China”? Unfortunately, the story is not that simple. First, it is quite possible that there were other cultures present in China during the period from 10,000 to 5000 BCE and that they have left no traces of their existence—or none that we have yet found.



[Major Neolithic cultures, 5000–3000 BCE.](#)

Second, there is evidence of eight distinct regional cultures existing in various parts of China between 5000 and 3000 BCE. In these regional cultures we see the independent development of various characteristics that we later identify as parts of “Chinese” culture. We also see a process of interaction between these regional cultures—first at a fairly low level, but then increasing in intensity and culminating with the spread throughout the north and south of a set of shared cultural characteristics (particular types of pottery and bronze vessels, divination with turtle shell or deer scapula, burial customs) as those eight (or perhaps more—the archeological record could be incomplete) evolved into five, one of which is known as “Longshan.” The coexistence and interaction of multiple cultures was crucial in the development of what later became a culture identifiable as the culture of the Han Chinese people of historical times.²⁰

Although these cultures were distinct and different, we can make a few valid generalizations about them. Those in the north, including the Yangshao, Dawenkou, Xinle, and Hongshan cultures, relied on millet for their staple food crop. In the south, the Majiabang, Hemudu, Daxi, Qujialing, and Dapenkeng people cultivated rice. Hunting, fishing, and collecting wild plants supplemented the diets of people in the north and in the south. Likewise, the people of these northern and southern cultures made pottery, used stone and wooden tools, and buried their dead.

Despite some broadly shared characteristics and their extended (and increasing) interaction over time and space, it is clear that these cultures were very different from one another. For example, the Dawenkou people in Shandong and the Majiayao people of eastern Gansu and Qinghai both buried ceremonial grave goods with their dead. Analyses of changes in mortuary practice indicate that both societies became more hierarchical over time. However, where the Dawenkou elite were buried with increasingly diverse collections of pottery, the deceased elite of Majiayao society simply had larger numbers of the same types of pottery vessels in their tombs. This leads archeologists to speculate that the Dawenkou elite gained and maintained power through a broadening and diversification of relationships, while the leaders of the Majiayao culture based their power on storage and distribution of grain.²¹

In the south, the Majiabang people built their houses close to rivers and ponds on either naturally high ground or on artificial mounds and made reddish-gray pottery. Just to their south across the Qiantang River and Hangzhou Bay the Hemudu people, who also lived near the water, built houses on wooden piles along the shores. Hemudu craftspeople made a distinctive black pottery quite different from that of the Majiabang people to their north. These two cultures coexisted for two thousand years, and while they were in contact with each other and influenced each other, they maintained their distinctive, separate identities.²²

Yangshao Culture

The best known of the various early Neolithic cultures of China is the Yangshao culture. The fame of Yangshao culture is disproportionate to its importance relative to the other cultures at the time. This is because the Yangshao

culture happens to have developed along the Yellow River valley, and particularly in the Central Plains area—an area that later emerged as a center of political and economic power and which ancient Chinese historians regarded as the central place from which their civilization originated. In modern times Chinese archeology, often driven by nationalism to find evidence for the ancient historical accounts, has paid particular attention to the Central Plains, and interpretation of archeological discoveries made in that area have in turn reinforced the preconceived notion of the status of the Yangshao culture as the single, central precursor of Chinese civilization.

While we now realize that Chinese culture did not originate in and emanate from the Central Plains alone, it is nonetheless useful for us to look particularly closely at Yangshao culture, its characteristics, its relations with other cultures, and its eventual disappearance. To do so will help us to put the Yangshao culture into perspective. It will also assist us in understanding the process by which the Central Plains did, in fact, become the place where strong states emerged and thus, in historical times, came to be portrayed as the place in which civilization developed and from which civilization emanated, slowly, to the less civilized world around.

The Yangshao culture extended from the middle Yellow River valley up to the eastern portions of modern Qinghai and Gansu provinces. Clearly descended from the earlier Peiligang culture, the Yangshao culture was present in this area from roughly 5000 to 3000 BCE. This period of two thousand years coincides with the climatic optimum of the Holocene. North China was relatively warm and humid. Conditions were excellent for vegetation, wild animals, and agriculture.

The Yangshao people were agriculturalists who supplemented their diet with wild game and plants. Their economy was dominated by millet, and millet accounted for more than half their caloric intake. The rest was wild plants, game, and domesticated animals including dogs, pigs, and (far less common) cattle, sheep, and goats.²³ They cultivated hemp and raised silkworms for textile production. Their tools included stone and wood agricultural implements, stone and pottery knives for cutting, scraping, weeding, and harvesting, stone chisels for woodworking, millstones for grinding grain, stone and pottery spindle whorls, and eyed bone needles.²⁴ The earliest bronze artifact to have been unearthed in China is a knife blade from the Majiayao area on the western fringes of the Yangshao culture, but overall, metal does not seem to have played any significant role in the Yangshao economy.²⁵

Yangshao villages, around 10 to 14 acres (about 50,000–60,000 sq m) in area, were typically composed of houses arranged around a central square. The houses were round or square semisubterranean buildings with wattle and daub walls and thatched roofs. Separate from the houses were areas for cemeteries and for kilns. Because the Yangshao people practiced slash-and-burn agriculture, the villages were not permanent. The people shifted village locations frequently as the fertility of their fields declined. They often returned to the same previously occupied areas repeatedly after leaving the fields to recover their fertility over a period of years.²⁶ The Yangshao people had hard lives. In a typical graveyard almost nineteen percent of the dead were under fifteen years of age, and fifty-four percent had died between the ages of twenty and forty.²⁷

All we know about the Yangshao people's social organization, their religious beliefs, and their aesthetic sense is whatever we can glean from the remains of their settlements and especially from their graves. They buried their dead carefully and with ceremony. Both the layout of the cemeteries and the way in which their houses were arranged around the central plazas of their villages indicate that the Yangshao people organized themselves in lineages or clans.²⁸ In general, the pottery and bone ornaments buried with the dead vary little from one grave to the next. It was common for one or two individuals in a cemetery to be buried with significantly more goods than the others. Thus archeologists conclude that in general, Yangshao society was fairly egalitarian, although evidence including large residences or public buildings indicates emerging and increasing degrees of stratification from the mid-Yangshao (around 4000–3500 BCE) onward.²⁹

The religion of the Yangshao people was related to the clan structure of their society. Their clan structure is evident in the way that they selected certain types of people to be honored as ancestors while others (women who married out of the clan and poor men, for example) did not receive the ritual burials and offerings that archeologists associate with the recognition of the deceased as an ancestor.³⁰ Aside from the evidence of reverence for selected members of the deceased, there is some evidence to suggest that the Yangshao people may have practiced a shamanist religion. Skeletal depictions of human figures, an obscure, possibly bisexual motif in pottery, and the grave of a man with clamshell depictions of a tiger on one side and a dragon on the other are all taken as possible evidence of shamanism.³¹ Terracotta human figurines with Caucasian or Central Asian facial features may also represent practitioners of ritual.³²

The Yangshao pottery is a distinctive red pottery with the designs painted in black. The major types of pottery include bowls, water bottles, jars, and urns.³³ Decorative motifs include rows of dancers (perhaps depicting ritual

ceremonies), fish, birds, and abstract patterns. A variety of incised symbols are found on some of the pottery. Some of the symbols bear a strong resemblance to later Chinese characters, but there is no evidence that they were part of a system of writing; instead, it is thought that they were symbols indicating the identity of the makers or the owners of the pottery. It is likely, however, that these symbols were at least one of the sources of the Chinese writing system.³⁴



Yangshao pottery. This vessel was probably used to draw water. The design on this piece is thought to represent a fishing net.

The Central Plains area in which large concentrations of Yangshao culture remains have been discovered would, much later, become the center of economic, political, and military power where great empires made their capitals and from whence they would project military force to far-flung areas to the south, the north, the northeast, and the northwest. But at the time, the Yangshao people were but one of a number of cultures that interacted with each other. This interaction, along with changes in climate and economy, would eventually lead to the demise of Yangshao culture and its replacement by another, more broadly distributed culture, the Longshan. Longshan culture, in turn, would provide the basis from which the first strong states of the Central Plains area would emerge—strong states whose bronzeworking, weapons, ritual, written language, family and state structure, and ways of thinking place them firmly at the beginning of written Chinese history.

Longshan Culture

Interaction between the various Neolithic cultures increased significantly in the period after 4000 BCE. By around 3000 BCE, this interaction had led to the development of common characteristics, particularly a fine black pottery, that could be found in different Neolithic communities from Manchuria in the north down to the Yangzi Valley, and south along the coast to the Guangzhou area and across to Taiwan. The broad scope of this interaction makes it impossible to point to a single place of origin. Nevertheless, the defining characteristics of this culture seem to have first taken form in coastal and south China, outside the Central Plains. Archeologists refer to the years between 3000 and 2000 BCE as the “Longshan period,” but thus far, research has focused heavily on only one of the various cultures that existed during this period: the Longshan culture.³⁵ The development of Longshan culture in Jiangsu and Shandong was particularly significant for the Central Plains, for it is in interaction between Shandong and the Central Plains in particular that Longshan culture came to replace Yangshao culture in the Yangshao home territory.

Longshan culture existed roughly from 3000 to 2000 BCE, with its center in modern Shandong province, with the contemporaneous Hongshan culture to the north in Liaoning and the Liangzhu culture to the south. Longshan culture is defined by its unpainted gray, and later black, pottery that was elevated by either a circular base or tripod legs. Also characteristic of Longshan culture were small copper objects, use of the potter’s wheel, rammed earth defensive walls, bird and animal motifs in ritual art, the use of jade ritual objects, the use of mammal scapulae for divination, an increasingly stratified society, and the practice of institutional violence, both warfare and human sacrifice.³⁶



Longshan black pottery. This goblet, made of a very thin material, was excavated at Jiaoxian, Shandong Province. Its black color is the result of exposure to carbon during kiln firing at low temperatures.

The decline and disappearance of Yangshao culture and the rise of Longshan culture coincide with a period of environmental change. Between 4000 and 3000 BCE there appears to have been a notable drop in the density of Yangshao settlements in the Central Plains region. This is associated with the end of the warm, moist climate in which the Yangshao had flourished and the onset of drier, cooler conditions. The drier, cooler climate caused a decline in the availability of game and wild plants, a consequent shift to even greater reliance on millet, and, at the same time, a decline in soil fertility as the soil structure came to be dominated by windblown dust rather than the fertile brown soil which had supported the growth of early Yangshao agriculture.³⁷ After 3000 BCE, the Neolithic population of the north China area began to grow once again. As the marshes that had separated the Shandong peninsula from the Central Plains dried up, the Longshan people of the Jiangsu-Shandong area spread into the Central Plains, enveloping, absorbing, and replacing the remnants of Yangshao culture. The details of this process are not clear, but it is best thought of as the result of exchange of cultural characteristics between the Jiangsu and Shandong Longshan cultures and the Yangshao culture: it was not the product of Longshan people invading and defeating Yangshao people.

The reasons for this population increase and the spread of Longshan cultural characteristics are not clear. The evidence does suggest, however, that these events took place under stressful circumstances. It may be that there was something about the Longshan technology and social organization that was conducive to survival under the conditions of the period; but survival did not come without a price. Analysis of skeletal remains indicates a deterioration of community health from the Yangshao to the Longshan periods. Compared to the Yangshao people, the Longshan population was shorter in stature and had greater incidence of dental caries and of anemia. The possible causes include a greater reliance on millet, more use of processed (ground) millet, longer cooking times made possible by better pottery (which reduces the iron content of the millet), and greater reliance on fatter domestic animals instead of wild game.³⁸

High population density and lack of sanitation in the Longshan towns and villages is also thought to have contributed to the decline of community health.³⁹ Excavation of Longshan towns and villages reveals a distinct hierarchy of settlements. A centrally located major town would be connected with a number of smaller surrounding settlements. In some cases, there were three or four levels in the hierarchical relationships between settlements of varying sizes and varying degrees of importance. The territory controlled by Longshan central towns excavated in Shandong appears to have been no more than 30 miles (50 km) in diameter, but hierarchies of settlement in other places spread over areas of a few hundred square miles.⁴⁰

The coexistence of many such settlement hierarchies gives us the impression that the Longshan period saw the development of a multitude of small, rival states. The fact is, we do not and cannot know precisely how strong the central towns were, what degree of control they had over the people and products of the surrounding areas with which they were so clearly connected, or whether or not they had a clear concept of territorial sovereignty over those areas.

Many of the major Longshan settlements were surrounded by defenses including moats and very substantial rammed-earth walls. These walls were built by piling layer after layer of earth into a wooden frame. Each layer was pounded thin and hard with heavy wooden tampers. The rammed-earth wall around one of the Longshan settlements

in Shandong, for example, is estimated to have been 20 feet (6 m) high and to have measured 30 feet (9 m) wide at the top. The remains of such walls and moats suggest that warfare was a common occurrence. The walls and moats, along with the remains of impressive public buildings (perhaps palaces), roads, and drainage systems show that the rulers of major Longshan towns were able to mobilize large numbers of people as laborers to work on such projects.⁴¹

Within their rammed-earth walls, the people of the Longshan towns lived in round or square houses with rammed-earth and lime-plastered floors, wattle-and-daub or clay slab walls, and thatch roofs. A walled settlement at Hougang in Henan province had several dozen such houses in the 1,300-by-800-foot (400-by-250-m) area within their defensive wall.⁴² In general, the household unit was a nuclear family.⁴³ The distribution of objects found in tombs and in house floors suggests a division of labor between men and women: larger numbers of agricultural tools, axes, arrowheads, and awls were found in men's tombs and parts of houses thought to be used by men. Tools for sewing and spinning (spindle whorls and needles) are more typical of women's tombs and are found in different parts of Neolithic houses than the tools associated with males.⁴⁴ Social hierarchy seems to have been enacted and reinforced through ritual feasting: elite families appear to have owned and used sets of ceramic food storage, cooking, and serving vessels far larger than needed for a single household.⁴⁵

The social hierarchy of the Longshan settlements is evident not only in household items, walls, and moats, but also in the Longshan people's carefully organized burial grounds. Separate clusters of burials seem to indicate a society of distinct clans, while three or four well-defined classes of grave, ranging from a simple hole in the ground to elaborate coffins and plentiful burial goods (including pottery, jade, and musical instruments such as boneflutes and alligator-skin drums), suggests that there was a clear hierarchy within each clan.⁴⁶ Higher-ranking men and women had larger graves and more goods than lower-ranking men and women, adults had more elaborate burials than juveniles, and males had more elaborate burials than females of the same social level.⁴⁷ One possible interpretation of the evidence gleaned from Longshan burial grounds is that the differences in burial indicate the selection of particular deceased family members for reverence as ancestors; thus, the "ancestral cult ritual became a part of the political institutions and reinforced the stratified, but still kin-based, social system."⁴⁸

In their daily lives, the leaders of the Longshan people practiced scapulimancy, in which an indentation is made in the shoulder blade of a mammal (generally sheep, cattle, or deer) and a heated object is thrust into the indentation, thereby creating a crack on the other side. The diviner then interpreted the crack as the answer to a question or a directive concerning future conduct. The charred remains of such scapulae have been found at numerous Longshan sites. Archeologists have also discovered potsherds bearing incised square-shaped graphs, possibly a predecessor of the Chinese writing system. The few graphs that have been discovered are indecipherable.⁴⁹ We thus have evidence that there may have been a writing system, but no written evidence from which we can derive any knowledge of the lives or beliefs of the Longshan people.

The social hierarchy of these people and the relationships among their various walled towns were both characterized by the practice of institutional violence. Within the settlements it was common for infants and adults to have been buried in the foundations and the walls of houses: they are thought to have been the sacrificial victims of rituals associated with house building.⁵⁰ The massive defensive walls of many Longshan settlements and the many weapons unearthed from Longshan graves all point to the significance and common occurrence of warfare. So, too, do two abandoned water wells discovered at the Longshan site at Jiangou in Hebei province: within the wells are five layers of human remains, with indications of beheading and struggle. In the foundation of a nearby house are the remains of six people who had been killed and then scalped.⁵¹

Conclusion

Neither the Longshan communities of Shandong and the Central Plains nor the Longshan culture as a whole existed in isolation. Longshan communities interacted and traded with each other and with neighboring peoples. The distribution of items like jade ornaments and alligator-skin drums in Longshan period tombs indicates the existence of long-distance trade in ritual items.⁵² Interaction among the many cultures of China, including the Longshan culture, along with changes in the environment, produced a significant sharing of technological, social, and religious characteristics which we call "Longshan culture." The spread of this common Longshan cultural repertoire did not erase all difference among regional cultures ranging from Manchuria and northern Hebei in the north to the coast of

Guangdong and the island of Taiwan in the south, from the Shandong peninsula and the Yangzi River delta in the east to the upper Yangzi and Yellow River Valleys in the west.

While the many different cultures of the Longshan period (many of which we know little about) had much in common, a certain set of characteristics seems to have come together in the Longshan culture of Shandong and the Central Plains. These characteristics include: 1. square-shaped symbols, possibly pictographs, which may be an early (though indecipherable) form of the Chinese written language; 2. clan organization; 3. reverence for ancestors, in which wealthy and important deceased family members are honored with rich graves and thought to still be concerned with the lives of their descendants, while poor or unimportant deceased family members receive less respect after death; 4. highly stratified societies with hierarchical networks of towns and villages; 5. rammed-earth construction of walls and foundations; 6. pottery styles, notably the tripod (*ding*) and the round-footed vessel (*dou*); 7. the beginnings of bronze technology; 8. drinking and feasting rituals associated with social solidarity and social hierarchy; 9. human sacrifice; 10. a multitude of hierarchical networks of settlements; and 11. relations ranging from trade to war with neighboring peoples.

These features of Longshan culture, coming together on the Central Plains, created the context in which networks of Longshan communities coalesced into the first strong Chinese states: polities whose rulers established bureaucratic governments and controlled extensive territories and populations, and who developed a system of writing. Although other, quite sophisticated civilizations existed alongside the Longshan people and shared many characteristics with them, the Central Plains, its people, and its governments came to play a leading role in the development of Chinese culture and Chinese identity.

Notes

1. It is necessary from the outset to admit that labeling this entire territory as “China’s Inner Asian periphery” is to take a China-centered view of history. Since the purpose of this book is to relate the history of regimes centered in China Proper, for which Inner Asia really did lie on the periphery, perhaps this act of Sinocentrism can be forgiven. A history placing Inner Asia or some part of Inner Asia (Mongolia, for example) at the center and relegating China Proper to the role of periphery would be different, but just as valid as the Sinocentric perspective adopted here.
2. Denny Roy, *Taiwan: A Political History* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2003).
3. The phrase is taken from Lloyd Eastman, *Family, Fields, and Ancestors: Constancy and Change in China’s Social and Economic History, 1550–1949* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1988).
4. G. William Skinner, *Marketing and Social Structure in Rural China* (Ann Arbor: Association for Asian Studies, 1964, 1965), 6.
5. This and the following paragraph draw on Arthur F. Wright, “The Cosmology of the Chinese City,” in G. William Skinner, ed., *The City in Late Imperial China* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1977), 33–73.
6. Nancy Shatzman Steinhardt, “Why Were Chang’an and Beijing So Different?” *The Journal of the Society of Architectural Historians* 45.4 (Dec. 1986): 339–57.
7. This and the following discussion are based on Barry Sautman, “Peking Man and the Politics of Paleoanthropological Nationalism in China,” *Journal of Asian Studies* 60.1 (Feb. 2001): 95–124.
8. Christopher Stringer and Robin McKie, *African Exodus: The Origins of Modern Humanity* (New York: Henry Holt and Company, 1996), 130–5.
9. Stringer and McKie, *African Exodus*, 261n1; Yuehai Ke et al., “African Origin of Modern Humans in East Asia: A Tale of 12,000Y Chromosomes,” *Science* 292.5519 (11 May 2001): 1151–3.
10. Stringer and McKie, *African Exodus*, 162. It is interesting to note that a study of mitochondrial DNA from 2,500-year-old human remains in Linzi county, Shandong, led to the conclusion that “the three smallest genetic distances for the 2,500-year-old Linzi population were from the Turkish, Icelandic, and Finnish, rather than from the east Asian populations.” Wang Li, Oota Hiroki, Saitou Naruya, Jin Feng, Matsushita Takayuki, and Ueda Shintaro, “Genetic Structure of a 2,500-Year-Old Human Population in China and Its Spatiotemporal Changes,” *Molecular Biology and Evolution* 17.9 (2000): 1398; Peter Brown, “Chinese Middle Pleistocene Hominids and Modern Human Origins in East Asia,” in L. Barham and K. Robson-Brown, eds., *Human Roots: Africa and Asia in the*

Middle Pleistocene (Bristol: Western Academic & Specialist Press, 2001), 144.

1. Nayan Chanda, *Bound Together: How Traders, Preachers, Adventurers, and Warriors Shaped Globalization* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2008), 15–6.
2. Barry Sautman, “Peking Man”: 95–124.
3. David Keightley, “The Environment of Ancient China,” in Michael Loewe and Edward L. Shaughnessy, eds., *The Cambridge History of Ancient China* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 34.
4. Stringer and McKie, *African Exodus*, 235–7.
5. Li Liu, *The Chinese Neolithic: Trajectories to Early States* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004), 24.
6. Kwang-chih Chang, *The Archaeology of Ancient China*, 4th ed. (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1986), 88–95.
7. Kwang-chih Chang, *The Archaeology of Ancient China*, 3rd ed. (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1977), 87, 95; Kwangchih Chang, “China on the Eve of the Historical Period,” in Loewe and Shaughnessy, eds., *The Cambridge History of Ancient China*, 46–7. The following description of the Peiligang and cord-marked pottery cultures is based on Chang’s discussion in these two sources.
8. Chang, *Archeology*, 4th ed., 100.
9. Chang, “China on the Eve of the Historical Period,” 46.
0. The concept used here is that of the “Chinese interaction sphere” suggested in Chang, *Archeology*, 4th ed., 234.
1. Francis Allard, “Mortuary Ceramics and Social Organization in the Dawenkou and Majiayao Cultures,” *Journal of East Asian Archeology* 3.3–4 (2002): 5, 18.
2. Chang, *Archeology*, 4th ed., 197–212.
3. Ibid., 113; Ekaterina A. Pechenkina, Robert A. Benfer, Jr., and Zhijun Wang, “Diet and Health Changes at the End of the Chinese Neolithic: The Yangshao/ Longshan Transition in Shaanxi Province,” *American Journal of Physical Anthropology* 117 (2002):15–36.
4. Chang, *Archeology*, 4th ed., 112–4, 122.
5. Ibid., 143–4.
6. Ibid., 116–7, 121.
7. Ibid., 121.
8. Ibid., 119.
9. Ibid.; Li Liu, “Ancestor Worship: An Archaeological Investigation of Ritual Activities in Neolithic North China,” *Journal of East Asian Archaeology* 1 (2000): 1–2, 138; Pechenkina et al., “Diet and Health Changes,” 15; Liu, *The Chinese Neolithic*, 88, 239.
0. Liu, “Ancestor Worship,” 138, 145, 150.
1. Chang, *Archeology*, 4th ed., 150.
2. Liu, *The Chinese Neolithic*, 93. Liu suggests that these also indicate the possibility of some interaction (falling far short of significant cultural influence) between the Yangshao communities of China and Central Asia.
3. Chang, “China on the Eve,” 50.
4. Chang, *Archeology*, 4th ed., 122.
5. Liu, *The Chinese Neolithic*, 2–4.
6. Ibid., 288; Louisa Huber, “The Relationship of the Painted Pottery and Lungshan Cultures,” in David N. Keightley, ed., *The Origins of Chinese Civilization* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1983), 186–7; Shao Wanping, “The Longshan Period and Incipient Chinese Civilization,” *Journal of East Asian Archeology* 1.1–2 (2000): 198–9.
7. Chang Huang Chun, Zhou Jie, Pang Jiangli, Han Yuping, and Hou Chunhong, “A Regional Aridity Phase and Its Possible Cultural Impact During the Holocene Megathermal in the Guanzhong Basin, China,” *The Holocene* 10.1 (2000): 135–42; Pechenkina et al., “Diet and Health Changes,” 15–6.
8. Pechenkina et al., “Diet and Health Changes,” 30–3.

9. Ibid., 33.
0. Shao, "The Longshan Period," 202; Anne P. Underhill, Gary M. Feinman, Linda M. Nicholas, Gwen Bennett, Hui Fang, Fengshi Luan, Haiguang Yu, and Fengshi Cai, "Regional Survey and the Development of Complex Societies in Southeastern Shandong, China," *Antiquity* 76 (2002): 747–54.
1. Chang, *Archeology*, 4th ed., 248; Shao, "The Longshan Period," 205–6; Liu, *The Chinese Neolithic*, 112.
2. Chang, *Archeology*, 4th ed., 269.
3. Liu, *The Chinese Neolithic*, 71.
4. Ibid., 35–7.
5. Ibid., 41–3.
6. Chang, *Archeology*, 4th ed., 249; Liu, *The Chinese Neolithic*, 121–2.
7. Liu, *The Chinese Neolithic*, 144, 153.
8. Liu, "Ancestor Worship," 156.
9. Shao, "The Longshan Period," 214.
0. Chang, *Archeology*, 4th ed., 270, 273.
1. Ibid., 270.
2. Liu, *The Chinese Neolithic*, 136.

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Part I

THE
EARLY EMPIRE

*Building Institutions
and Identity*
2070(?) BCE–220 CE

噬嗑

[*The Beginnings of the
Chinese State and Culture
in the Xia, Shang, and
Western Zhou Dynasties*](#)

In the Introduction, we saw how a number of Neolithic cultures interacted to produce a set of characteristics —“Longshan culture”—that was broadly shared across the northern and southern parts of China Proper. In this chapter, we will focus on developments on the Central Plains between 2070 and 771 BCE. It is here that we see the development of states: the Xia (whose existence is a subject of debate) and the historically verifiable Shang and Western Zhou kingdoms. We see also a highly developed Chinese writing system and with it the earliest written origins of Chinese literature, religious, aesthetic and philosophical ideas, and political organization.

Like most people, the Chinese later idealized their distant past. Much of what they traditionally had to say about the origins of the universe, human beings, and their own culture and rulers is now regarded as myth. It is with these myths that we will begin, for these myths, even today, convey ideals and role models that are central to Chinese identity.

Origin Myths, Politics, and Morality

Myths supply answers to questions that ordinary logic cannot address: What are the origins of the universe, our world, and ourselves? In doing so, myths explain who we are and, perhaps, why we are that way. China developed a rich tradition of myths; some may have begun as oral tradition. Many, including the origin myths described below, seem to be of relatively recent origin, having been assembled and written down in the Han dynasty (206 BCE–220 CE). In other words, many Chinese myths, including the origin myths, developed long after the very early times in which they are set. Instead of being a vague reflection of historical events, they are often stories with little or no historical basis that later came to be regarded as history.¹

The Chinese had a number of myths to explain the origins of the universe. In some myths, either misty and pure vapors, or yin (the power of femininity/ darkness) and yang (the power of masculinity/light) generated or transformed into the myriad things. In another, the goddess Nü Wa kneaded aristocrats from yellow earth, and poor commoners from brown mud. A later myth tells of Pan Gu, who was born in a chaotic mixture of Heaven and Earth, like a chicken’s egg. For eighteen thousand years he grew, and as he grew, Heaven and Earth were separated. When he died, his body parts and vital fluids were transformed into the sun, moon, and other heavenly bodies and the waters, rivers, plants, metals, and rocks of the earth, while “the mites on his body were touched by the wind and were turned into the black-haired people [the Chinese].”²

These and other cosmological myths were of secondary importance to the Chinese. Of greater interest to them were myths that described the origins of human society, culture, and government. Their mythical accounts began with a series of culture heroes who taught the common people how to build houses, cultivate crops, and distinguish beneficial plants from poisonous ones, and invented marketing. One of these mythical rulers, Huang Di (the Yellow Emperor), was said to have reigned for one hundred years, beginning in 2697 BCE. He is described as a heroic character who defeated a number of enemies and absorbed their territories. He was also said to have invented bureaucracy, writing, sericulture, medicine, boats, and wheeled vehicles.

The next significant rulers in this mythical history were the “three sage kings”—Yao, Shun, and Yu. All three were said to have been benevolent, wise rulers. Yao passed over his sons to give the throne to the most suitable man in the kingdom, Shun, as did Shun when he passed the throne to Yu. The myths describe Shun as a model of filial

piety, showing love and respect in spite of the fact that his blind father, his stepmother, and his younger stepbrother were evil and morally bankrupt and attempted to murder him. Yu is best known for the stories of how he controlled the floods of the Yellow River by channeling the water to the sea, working tirelessly for thirteen years at the task. Yu also established the principle of dynastic rule: he is said to have passed the throne to his son, thereby founding the first dynasty, the Xia.

According to traditional Chinese historical accounts, Yu's descendants ruled over the Xia kingdom for generations until the time of Jie, the evil and lustful last king of Xia. Then, a hero named Cheng Tang overthrew the Xia dynasty by force and established a new dynasty, the Shang. Cheng Tang's descendants then ruled until their last king, who, with his nobles, had descended into a life of cruelty, misrule, sensuality, and alcoholism. A new hero, Wen Wang, arose in the west, and he and his son, Wu Wang, overthrew the Shang and founded the third Chinese dynasty, the Zhou.

In this traditional myth-history the Xia, Shang, and Zhou dynasties succeeded one another in linear fashion, each falling when its leader behaved immorally. These traditional accounts were written hundreds of years, or even thousands, after the events that they claim to describe. Nonetheless, they were accepted without serious question. For over two thousand years, Chinese referred back to this "golden age" and to moral exemplars: the wisdom, benevolence, and exemplary moral behavior of Yao, Shun, Yu, Cheng Tang, and Wen Wang, and the depravity of the evil last rulers of the Xia and Shang dynasties. Even today, Chinese often, more as a matter of habit than of belief, refer to themselves collectively as "descendants of the Yellow Emperor."

Between Myth and History: The Xia Dynasty

In the 20th century, Chinese and Western historians questioned the myths and the traditional account of the three dynasties, insisting on verifiable evidence. At the same time, archeologists in China looked for evidence that would restore the credibility of the traditional narratives, provide grounds for revision of those narratives, or even create a new and different account of the history of ancient China. As a result, the various culture heroes—the Yellow Emperor, Yao, Shun, and Yu—were consigned to the world of myth. The Xia dynasty, however, remains uneasily between myth and history.

The capital of the Xia was said to have been on the Central Plains, somewhere near the modern city of Luoyang. Archeological work in that area was accordingly carried out with the explicit goal of finding evidence to prove the existence of the Xia state. At a site called Erlitou, they found the remains of a civilization at least some of whose dates seem to correspond with the dates of the Xia dynasty.

The remains found at Erlitou include a sizeable city surrounded by a rammed-earth wall, rammed-earth house foundations, storage pits, pottery, roads, the foundations of two palatial buildings, stone implements, bronzes, and the remains of a bronze foundry. Also found were burials, some of them with human sacrifices.³ These are clearly the remains of a significant civilization whose leaders were able to control the labor and the agricultural produce of large numbers of commoners. Are some or all of the four levels of the Erlitou site the remains of the capital of the Xia kingdom? Archeologists continue to debate, with many (including the vast majority of Chinese archeologists) accepting Erlitou as evidence of the existence of the Xia dynasty.

If the Erlitou site was, indeed, the Xia capital, what sort of a state was the Xia, and what were its relations with the neighboring peoples? The Xia kingdom is thought to have flourished roughly between 2070 and 1600 BCE.⁴ Archeologists and historians no longer, however, accept the linear narrative in which the Xia, the Shang, and the Zhou followed one another in succession. Instead, the evidence seems to point to the existence of tens or hundreds of small states in China during the time of the Xia (if it existed) and Shang periods (that is, from around 2070 to 1045 BCE). The strongest theory is that the Xia, the Shang, and the Zhou were three such states, with the Xia in the center, the Shang to the east, and the Zhou to the west. The three overlapped in time, with Shang eventually taking over the territory of Xia (around 1570 BCE), and Zhou doing the same to Shang later, in 1045 BCE.⁵ The idea that the three states succeeded one after the other in linear fashion, as represented on a simple timeline, is an invention of the Zhou people, who wanted a theory that justified Zhou control over a single feudal kingdom which had not, in fact, previously existed.

The Shang Kingdom

The state of Shang had its origins and early territory in an area corresponding to eastern Henan, western Anhui, and northern Shandong on a modern map. Their state was contemporaneous with Erlitou culture (associated with the Xia), which lay to the west in the area around modern Luoyang.⁶ Traditional accounts tell how a Shang king named Cheng Tang first annexed neighboring states, then attacked and defeated the Xia to form the larger kingdom that we know as the Shang. In “The Speech of Tang,” a text that may reflect later Zhou dynasty ideology rather than Shang reality, King Tang argues that the King of Xia, an evil and repressive ruler, deserves to be overthrown: “[He] does nothing but exhaust the strength of his people, and exercise oppression in the cities of Xia.”⁷ He concludes his call to action with a promise and a threat:



[The Shang kingdom and neighboring peoples.](#)

Assist, I pray you, me, the one man, to carry out the punishment appointed by Heaven. I will greatly reward you. On no account disbelieve me. ... If you do not obey the words which I have spoken to you, I will put your children with you to death—you will find no forgiveness.⁸

We have no other evidence on which to judge the veracity of this and other accounts of the early Shang. The remains of King Tang’s capital (said to have been occupied by him and the next eight kings for a period of 183 years) have not been located, nor have the sites of several other capital cities of the Shang. There is, however, enough archeological evidence to draw some broad outlines of the historic trajectory of the Shang kingdom in its early and middle phases. This evidence includes many bronze vessels, tombs, and a major urban area, possibly a capital city, at a place called Erligang in the city of Zhengzhou.

Archeological sites with Shang cultural characteristics similar to those at Erligang have been found over a large area, from central Shandong in the east to central Shaanxi in the west, from Beijing in the north to the middle Yangzi Valley in the south.⁹ As with the Xia, archeologists continue to debate the meaning of this “Erligang culture.” Many argue that the Erligang culture corresponds to an early or middle period of the Shang, sometime between 1500 and 1300 BCE, and that the presence of Erligang sites over a broad area indicates that the Shang kingdom was already a rich, powerful urban state and that it engaged in a sudden, aggressive expansion, particularly toward the south.¹⁰ The strongest evidence for this expansion is the remains of a city at Panlongcheng on a tributary of the Yangzi River.

Panlongcheng was a walled city modeled after the walled city at Erligang, but much smaller. Like Erligang, Panlongcheng was the center of a wealthy urban elite whose bronzes, like their city, resembled those in Erligang, 300 miles (500 km) to the north. Panlongcheng pottery, on the other hand, was quite different from that found in the Yellow River area of the Shang, thus leading archeologists to conclude that the powerful ruling elite of Panlongcheng had come from the Yellow River area and had superimposed themselves over a weaker local people.¹¹

It is very unlikely that the Shang kings ever firmly incorporated such a broad area into a single, coherent state administered from Erligang. At any rate, the period of territorial expansion came to an end. By 1300 BCE, the Shang kingdom was in retreat, pulling back, most notably from the south: Panlongcheng was abandoned, and the center of gravity of the Shang state shifted from Erligang farther north, eventually to Anyang, which served as either the capital or the ritual center at least from the time of King Wu Ding (r. 1198?–1189? BCE¹²) until the end of the dynasty.

Perhaps the Shang was a victim of its own success: the outward expansion of its power and culture stimulated the rise of urban bronze-working states on its southern, southwestern, western, and northern peripheries. These peoples, while using bronze technology, adapted it to their own needs and artistic tastes. The huge bronze bells and drums of the middle Yangzi Valley, for example, are quite different from the bronzes of Panlongcheng and Erligang.¹³ Civilizations in Jiangxi and Sichuan had the beginnings of their own writing systems, unrelated to the writing system of the Shang. Sichuan was also the site of a civilization which is best known through artifacts unearthed at Sanxingdui near the city of Chengdu. The bronzes discovered at Sanxingdui are artistically distinct from Shang bronzes and include a figure of a man on a pedestal, 8 feet (2.4 m) in height, bronze heads decorated with gold leaf, large masks, and other ceremonial objects. Bronze workers of the northern fringe from Xinjiang to Manchuria, too, made a variety of different bronze items, including daggers—a distinctive weapon not part of the Shang bronzeworking tradition.¹⁴



This bronze mask, unearthed at Sanxingdui in Sichuan, uses bronze technology similar to that of the Shang, but is strikingly different in style from contemporaneous Shang bronzes.

Pressure from the new states to the south may have contributed to the Shang withdrawal. At the same time, the discovery of sources of copper, tin, and salt to the northwest in Shanxi province may also have prompted the Shang to look toward the north, and to shift its capital and ceremonial center from the Zhengzhou area north to Anyang. From 1300 BCE, the Shang kings ruled over a relatively small core territory. There, they were one state among many. Cultural influences flowed among the various states of the Central Plains, the north and northwestern fringe, the Yangzi Valley, and Sichuan, which were all at a similar level of economic, cultural, technological, and military development.¹⁵ What, then, makes the Shang distinctive and important, while other states and peoples either drop out of the historical record entirely or become peripheral to a history that traces the lineage of China to the Shang?

Shang Culture and Society

One important reason for Shang's power and for its long-term historical significance was its writing system. The origins of the Shang writing system are unclear. The symbols incised on Neolithic pottery cannot be identified with any of the symbols of the Shang script and are, at any event, one thousand to three thousand years removed from the Shang in time. This leads some scholars to conclude that Chinese writing, with its distinctive characters rather than an alphabet, was developed not many centuries before 1200 BCE.¹⁶ No matter what or when its origins, writing enabled the Shang elite to organize a bureaucratic government and to keep written records, including the so-called "oracle bone inscriptions."

The Shang people practiced divination by boring a series of pits into either a tortoise plastron (the bottom part of the tortoise shell) or a cattle scapula. A hot bronze rod was applied, producing cracks, which were interpreted as answers to questions that the king and/or his diviner had posed. Sometimes the questions, a record of the divination,

and occasionally even a record of the actual outcome were inscribed on the plastron or scapula.

Discovered and translated beginning in 1899 CE, these oracle bones are the earliest written records of Chinese civilization. The inscriptions give us a highly selective picture of some of the concerns and events that were relevant to the Shang elite. The earliest of these records date to the reign of King Wu Ding in the late Shang. Whatever we know about the early and mid-Shang periods must be gleaned from brief references in the oracle bone inscriptions, from archeological research, and from cautious reading of texts produced much later during the Zhou and Han dynasties.

Also contributing to the power of the Shang was a highly productive agriculture. Interestingly enough, agricultural technology itself and living conditions of the average Shang farming family were no different from those of the Longshan period. Like their Longshan predecessors, Shang farmers prepared the fields with stone hoes hafted to wooden handles and harvested their grain with stone sickles. The staple crops were still varieties of millet, with barley, wheat, and rice being of much less importance.¹⁷ Substantial herds of animals—cattle, sheep, pigs, deer, dogs, and horses—were kept for the elite, who ate large amounts of meat at sacrificial rituals for their ancestors.¹⁸ Farmers continued to burn the vegetation from fields to prepare them for planting—a practice that was combined with hunting, as the burn could be managed to drive wild animals into places where they would be easy to shoot. As in Longshan times, game continued to be an important part of the diet.¹⁹ Irrigation was not used. The climate of the Central Plains was still moister and, on the average, 3.6 degrees Fahrenheit (2 degrees Celsius) warmer than it was in the late 20th century.²⁰

What was different about Shang agriculture was organization. The king owned all land, and the king directly controlled many large farms that were “cleared and worked by royal labor gangs.”²¹ The king’s income was mainly in grain, both from his directly controlled farms and in the form of tribute from all the fields in the kingdom.²²



This ivory mask was carved in the taotie pattern. The same pattern was commonly used in Shang and Zhou bronzes.

The well-organized but technologically stagnant agricultural sector of the Shang economy supported a technologically innovative ruling elite. Indeed, one scholar quips that “virtually all advances in Shang technology were directed toward conspicuous consumption.”²³ Aside from writing, the most significant aspects of Shang innovation were in the areas of bronze, religion, and the military. The earlier Shang city at Erligang and the late Shang ceremonial center at Anyang both had substantial palaces, ceremonial buildings, and houses for the elite.

Such buildings were constructed on raised, rammed-earth platforms. Commoners lived in small, semi-subterranean pit houses with wattle-and-daub walls and thatch roofs. Other structures included storage pits, stone and bone workshops, and bronze foundries.²⁴

Shang cities were typically surrounded by a rammed-earth wall (the city at Anyang is an exception) and surrounded by a network of villages in which farmers and artisans lived.²⁵ The common people, while not chattel slaves, were certainly subject to the control of their superiors and could be mobilized for large projects such as the construction of rammed-earth walls and platforms and the excavation of elaborate tombs.²⁶

The Shang people's use of bronze was impressive both for the sheer amount of material produced and for its technical and aesthetic qualities. Shang craftsmen used elaborate molds and multi-casting techniques to create heavily decorated tripod vessels, ewers, tureens, boxes, and other vessels, whose size and beauty are still impressive today. Some of the larger pieces weigh as much as 1,900 pounds (862 kg).²⁷ The bronzes are richly decorated with geometrical and animal motifs: rams, elephants, oxen, antelope, tigers, horses, amphibians, and more. Mythical animals were also portrayed, including the *taotie* and the dragon (*long*). The *taotie* is a fearsome mask with horns, a large mouth with no lower jaw, and without a body. Its meaning is unclear: some believe that it signifies the theocratic power of the Shang rulers, others that it is related to shamanistic communication with the spirit world.²⁸ The dragon, which bears no relation to the European dragon, is a water spirit and symbol of fertility which later came to be identified with emperors and their power.

Shang Religion

Much of what we know about the Shang elite and their lifestyle we learn because of their religious practices: divination and burials. Tombs are particularly rich sources. For example, objects recovered from the tomb of Fu Hao (Lady Fu), one of King Wu Ding's many consorts, give us a picture of a very powerful woman. Fu Hao had led military campaigns, managed a large landed estate, and was in charge of particular rituals. Fu Hao's coffin itself was placed in a square wooden building, as big as a room, constructed at the bottom of a pit 25 feet (7.5 m) deep. Also in the tomb, at various places, were seventeen human sacrificial victims and seven sacrificed dogs. The grave goods interred with Fu Hao included a few pottery, shell, and ivory items; 564 objects of carved bone; 110 objects of marble, turquoise, and other stone; 755 jades (including a collection of Neolithic jades from various locations around China); 271 weapons, tools, and small bronzes; and 195 bronze vessels. Many of the bronze vessels were made especially for Fu Hao, her name cast into the surface. Also in the grave were nearly 7,000 cowry shells.

Many of the bronzes were cast for use in religious ceremonies and/or for burial in the tombs like that of Lady Fu—thus the accusation that Shang innovation was wasted on conspicuous consumption. The Shang people believed in and consulted a multitude of spirits who were closely connected to the world of the living. Their supreme deity was called Di (or sometimes Shang Di, translated as “The Lord on High”). Di was so distant, yet so powerful, that he was rarely sacrificed to. Nonetheless, he was respected and feared, for he controlled the spirits of rain, thunder, and wind, and could punish or benefit the dynasty, sending down blessings, bad weather, or enemy invasions as he saw fit. Lesser but more accessible spirits included various nature powers and a host of ancestors and ancestresses.

The gods, spirits, and ancestors could affect crops, the weather, childbirth, the king's health, warfare, and so on. It was, therefore, important to sacrifice to them. Ancestors were represented by a physical symbol such as a spirit tablet engraved or painted with the ancestor's honorific name. Rituals were held to honor these ancestors, and sacrifices of millet ale, cattle, dogs, sheep, and humans were offered. The scale of the sacrifices varied, but at important rituals, hundreds of animals and/or human victims would be slaughtered.²⁹

Believing that the spirits of the dead continued to exist and to take an interest in the world of the living, the Shang elite buried their dead in elaborate and well-furnished tombs. Lady Fu's tomb was a modest one. Large tombs typically consisted of a vertical shaft 30 to 43 feet (about 10 to 13 m) deep with two, three, or four sloping ramps opening onto the shaft from the cardinal directions, the south shaft opening onto the bottom of the shaft, the others entering the shaft higher up.³⁰ At the bottom of the shaft would be a small sacrificial pit with an armed man, and sometimes a dog. Built over them was a wooden burial chamber where the coffin would be placed. Bronze vessels and other bronze goods such as shields, helmets, chariot fittings, weapons, chimes, jade ornaments, and other goods would be placed on the vertical shaft and in the ramps. Human sacrifice was an important part of burials. High-status relatives of the deceased would be sacrificed and buried with them, along with close dependents, personal servants, and tens or even hundreds of sacrificial victims who were probably prisoners of war.³¹

As described above, the Shang elite continued to honor their ancestors with rituals and sacrifices and to seek understanding of the causes of good and bad fortune and the possible course of future events through divination. Divination records carved on tortoise shells and cattle scapulae reveal the concerns of the Shang elite. Many of the questions posed had to do with the weather and the prospects for a good harvest: “Di, when it comes to the fourth moon, will order the rain”; “In praying for harvest to Shang Jia, we offer in holocaust three small penned lambs and split open three cattle.”³² Some concerned the king’s health: “There is a sick tooth. It is not Father Yi [King Wu Ding’s father] who is harming it.”³³ Childbirth was another topic of interest, with the following divination record clearly reflecting the desire for male heirs to carry on the royal lineage:

Que divined: “Lady Hao’s childbearing will be good.” (Prognostication:) the king read the cracks and said: “If it be on a *ding*-day that she give birth, there will be prolonged luck.” (Verification:) after thirty-one days, on *jiayin* [day 51], she gave birth; it was not good; it was a girl.³⁴

This concern with male heirs to carry on the family line is one of many aspects of Shang culture which remained an integral part of the evolving Chinese culture long after the Shang had fallen and the oracle bones were forgotten relics, buried deep in the ground of the Central Plains. The Shang writing system, their ability to organize agricultural production to support the lifestyle and wars of the elite, and their reverence for their ancestors would all become part of the heritage which the Shang passed to their successors.

Warfare and the Fall of the Shang

During the period covered by the oracle bones, from around 1200 BCE onward, the Shang was one state among many. Boundaries were vague and shifting. Relations between states included diplomacy, trade and tribute, marriage alliances, and war. The Shang were often at war with their neighbors.

Shang soldiers were infantrymen armed with bronze dagger-axes, spearheads and arrowheads, bronze shields, and helmets.³⁵ Infantry forces were raised in numbers of three thousand, five thousand, or even ten thousand and were organized into two corps, each corps divided into left, right, and center sections.³⁶ Around 1200 BCE, Central Asian chariot technology reached the Shang (who had not previously used wheeled vehicles) from the north. The Shang chariot carried three men in a box mounted on eighteen- or twenty-six-spoke wheels. The chariot played little or no role in fighting in the Shang period: it was a mobile elevated command platform and, in funerals, a luxury item to be buried with aristocrats.³⁷



This bronze axe, a symbol of military authority, may have also been used in hand-to-hand combat.

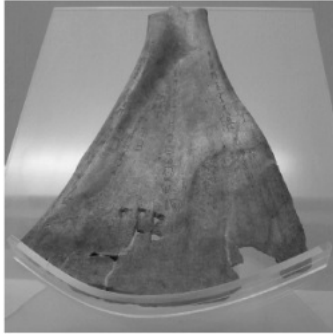
On their borders, the Shang faced at least twenty-six neighboring territories—*fang*—ruled by local leaders who were sometimes their allies and sometimes their enemies.³⁸ King Wu Ding fought a series of wars with the Tufang, the Gongfang, and the Qiangfang. Many Qiang prisoners were captured and offered as human sacrifices in Shang rituals. Later Shang kings were defeated by the Gongfang to the northwest and by other northwestern and northern peoples. Shang territory shrank to a small area around the ceremonial center at Anyang.³⁹ The Shang was still a power to be reckoned with—but just barely. The last Shang king, Di Xin, personally led two major expeditions against the troublesome Renfang in the Yangzi Valley—an impressive projection of force. He also led a large punitive action against former Shang allies, the Yufang, to the northeast of Anyang.⁴⁰ That Di Xin could mobilize men and resources to undertake three major wars shows that he still had considerable power. At the same time, having expended resources on these wars, the Shang kingdom was weakened and unable to respond when it faced its final challenge: an invasion from its western neighbor and former tributary, the Zhou.

The Origins and Rise of the Zhou

The origins of the Zhou people are unknown. They were probably from somewhere on the northwestern periphery of the Shang. Legend has it that they were initially an agricultural people who switched to nomadism and then, after a few generations, reverted to farming when a leader named Zhou Danfu brought them south to settle in the Wei Valley. There, the Zhou was a minor state, peripheral to the Shang world. At times, they were allies of the Shang, at other times, enemies. Oracle bone remnants discovered at the site of an early Zhou palace indicate that the Zhou sacrificed to Shang ancestors (as an ally of the Shang would do) and that they were once visited by a Shang king on a hunting trip (a standard way in which Shang kings built solidarity with allies and practiced for war). On the other hand, one Zhou leader died while in Shang custody, and another—later known as King Wen—was a captive of the Shang for seven years before the Zhou ransomed him.⁴¹

Climatic conditions at the time make the legendary accounts of the Zhou's early history plausible and help to explain the collapse of the Shang. There was a sudden decrease in average temperatures and an increase in aridity in Central Asia and northern China around 1100 BCE. Increased aridity brought more wind-blown dust from Central Asia to the north China loess plateau, reducing the soil's ability to retain moisture. Climate change also affected the nomadic economy, pushing nomads farther south into areas of the loess plateau previously cultivated by farmers. Under pressure both from nomadic incursions and crop failures, farming peoples moved southward themselves.⁴² In the Shang kingdom, drought-induced famine caused social instability and reduced the resources available to the last Shang kings. A Chinese history compiled sometime after 476 BCE stated simply: "The collapse of the Shang Empire was due to the drying up of the Yellow River and other rivers."⁴³

Around 1053 BCE King Wen began to conquer some of the other small states on the periphery of the Shang. His son and successor, King Wu, turned the attack on the Shang itself. In 1045 BCE King Wu, supported by eight allied states, led forty-five thousand troops and three hundred chariots across the Yellow River at the Mengjin ford and struck north into the Shang heartland. Zhou and Shang forces met at Muye (Shepherd's Range) just south of Di Xin's capital. The Shang are said to have had the numerical advantage. The Zhou had superior weapons, including an improved pole-mounted dagger-axe, bronze armor, and three hundred chariots (an unusually large number of chariots to be employed in a single battle at the time). Some historians argue that the Zhou used their massed chariots as an attack weapon. Others believe that the Zhou simply made more efficient use of their better-equipped infantry than the Shang.⁴⁴ Whatever the reason, at the end of the day, the Zhou and their allies were victorious.



Oracle bone of the Shang dynasty.

King Wu had defeated the Shang, but he did not live for long afterward. His heirs would have to create a form of government that would unify the Central Plains. On King Wu's death, one of his many sons took the throne as King Cheng, but real power lay in the hands of one of King Wu's brothers, the Duke of Zhou. The Duke of Zhou took it upon himself to stand as regent for his nephew, the king, although there is some evidence that King Cheng did not actually need a regent.

The Duke's arrogant assumption of power nearly caused the end of the Zhou kingdom. Several of the Duke of Zhou's brothers joined remnants of the Shang nobility in a major rebellion. It took the Duke of Zhou and King Cheng two years to defeat rebel forces in a fratricidal civil war that raged across the eastern regions from Hebei in the north to the Huai Valley in the south. In response to this war and in order to extend royal control across a vast kingdom, King Cheng and his successor, King Kang, created a new political system that we can call "kinship feudalism."

By the time of the philosopher Confucius (551–479 BCE), and for many generations afterward, King Wu, King Wen, and the Duke of Zhou had gone down in history as the heroic and moral founders of a new dynasty. For Confucius, Shang was ancient and shrouded in obscurity. Zhou, however, was a model of government, society, and culture of which he had direct knowledge by way of oral and written records—it was a model which he would idealize, and to which Chinese would refer over and over again in debates on policy, morality, and agricultural economy for the next twenty-five hundred years. We too, then, though we may not share his idealism, must, like Confucius, look to the Zhou, and specifically to the first part of the Zhou period: the Western Zhou (1046–771 BCE).

The Zhou Feudal System

The Duke of Zhou, King Cheng, and King Kang incorporated into the Zhou kingdom a vast domain, stretching from the Ordos to the Liao River in the north, and south into the Huai and Han River Valleys to the north banks of the Yangzi. Zhou rule brought to this territory an unprecedented level of political and cultural unity. The Zhou elite considered their domain to be a unified kingdom and the people of the Central Plains to be a single people, the Huaxia (Chinese), ruled by kings to whom Heaven had given a mandate and extending the radiance of their civilization outward toward the "less civilized" peripheral areas of the Zhou world (such as the Liao River in the north and the Yangzi in the south). There were, however, limits to Zhou political and even cultural unity. The Zhou kings were not rulers of a centralized state: the Zhou was a feudal kingdom consisting of a number of states whose rulers accepted the overall authority of the Zhou kings. The feudal states of the Zhou era were collectively referred to as "Zhongguo." At the time, this term meant "the Central States"; later, it took on the more general meaning of "Middle Kingdom" or even, in modern times, "China."

The Zhou system was in some respects comparable to the European feudalism of the Holy Roman Empire. As in European feudalism, the Zhou kings enfeoffed nobles, stationing them in strategic garrison towns. Their state, granted by the Zhou king, consisted of people (farmers) and land, although the extent of the land and its borders were often not clearly specified.⁴⁵ The enfeoffment process included ceremonies and written descriptions of the places being granted. For example:

Full of activity is the Chief of Shen
 And the King would employ him to continue the services (of his fathers)
 With his capital in Xie
 Where he should be a pattern to the state of the south

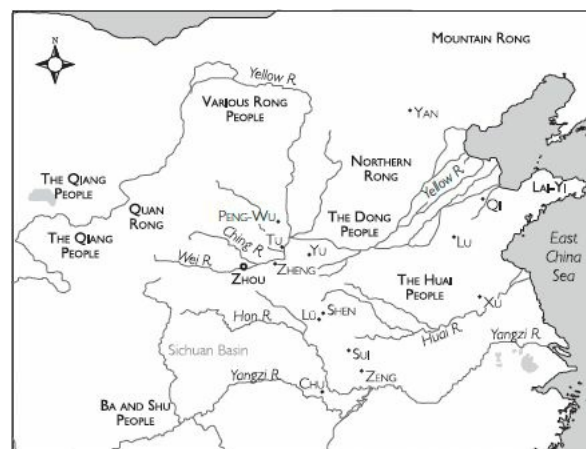
 The King gave charge to the Earl of Shao
 To make the statutory definition of the territory and fields of the Chief of Shen.⁴⁶

The enfeoffed nobility were expected to support the royal house economically (with tribute) and militarily, and to show appropriate ritual deference. The entire system, however, was defined in terms of kinship: the kings sent members of the royal family and relatives by marriage to occupy existing Shang towns and other states, or to establish new garrison towns as capitals of new feudal states. Other enfeoffed lords, including close allies of the Zhou house and powerful local rulers whom the Zhou found it wiser to enfeoff than to fight, were incorporated into the kinship system through marriage or by establishing fictive kinship relations.

The Western Zhou kingdom was thus a patchwork of seventy or more feudal states. The hereditary lords of each feudal state in turn enfeoffed parts of their states to their subordinates. The feudal lords lived in their capital towns and cities, generally laid out in a square or rectangular shape on a north-south axis and protected by rammed-earth walls. The size of walled urban areas ranged from approximately 1,000 square feet (approximately 300 sq m) to approximately 28,000 by 13,000 feet (approximately 8,300 by 3,950 m).⁴⁷ Every city had an altar to the god of the soil, a temple of the ancestors (which was the setting for many military, religious, diplomatic, and political events), and the ruler's palace.⁴⁸

The Zhou kings, for their part, ruled from their capital in the Wei River Valley, near modern Xi'an. Because they feared further rebellion on the Central Plains, the Zhou built a secondary eastern capital near the site of the modern city of Luoyang. From this location, they controlled both the east-west and north-south lines of communication and trade. The Zhou had realized what other power-holders based in the Wei Valley would later learn as well: he who would control the Central Plains from the Wei Valley must control Luoyang as well.

Within the royal domains and the many feudal states, farmers made up the vast majority of the population. These common folk still lived in semi-subterranean houses. With simple two-pronged and one-pronged wooden digging sticks for turning the soil, spades of bone, shell, or stone hafted to wooden handles, and stone, bone, and shell sickles, farmers grew the staple crop of millet and minor crops such as wheat, hemp (for fiber and for the seeds, eaten as food), rice (in the south), beans, and peas. Most vegetables and fruits were gathered from the wild.



The Western Zhou, with capitals of major feudal states and names of stateless peoples. State boundaries shifted and are therefore not indicated.

Aristocrats might eat rice at banquets, but for most of the people most of the time, boiled or steamed millet was the daily food. Fish was the major source of protein, available even to common folk. The elite ate beef, pork, mutton, rabbit, poultry, and game. However, consumption of beef, mutton, and game declined over time as

wilderness and grazing lands were converted to farmed fields. By the late Western Zhou, meat consumption was overwhelmingly pork and chicken (both resource-efficient scavengers that do not require large amounts of dedicated grazing land).⁴⁹

There has been much debate over how Western Zhou agriculture was organized. As far as we can tell, there were some instances of gang-labor in large fields belonging to feudal lords. This system resembles the large-scale farms maintained by the Shang kings. For the most part, though, individual farming families worked fields that they had some sense of ownership of or at least proprietary rights to. Nonetheless, they were obliged to offer a part of their crop to their feudal lord and to perform *corvée* labor (obligatory labor performed for a feudal lord or for a state).⁵⁰

However, several centuries after the fact, the Eastern Zhou philosopher Mencius and others described a Western Zhou system in which nine fields were laid out in a tic-tac-toe pattern resembling the Chinese character *jing*, which means “well.” According to Mencius, each of eight families would cultivate one of the eight fields on the sides for themselves and work together on the central field, whose product went to the feudal lord. There is no evidence from the Western Zhou itself that this system was ever used, although it, or something like it, may well have existed. In any case, the well-field model, as we shall call it, expressed an ideal: an egalitarian peasant society in the willing service of a feudal hierarchy. It should be no surprise, then, that it became a very powerful concept in Chinese discussions of political economy and morality in subsequent millennia.

Political Philosophy, Culture, and Identity

For commoners and for the elite, life was attuned to the changing seasons of the agricultural year and to the progress of the stars and planets shining brightly overhead in the night sky. The progress of the seasons was tracked with a calendar system with its roots in the Shang. Turning points in the year were marked by ritual celebrations of planting, harvest, and so on. Rituals also marked turning points in human affairs, such as coming of age, marriage, and death. Capping ceremonies celebrated a young man’s coming of age, hair-binding ceremonies a young woman’s. Simple communal meals and wine-drinking rituals underlined social solidarity and social hierarchy in local communities.

More elaborate rituals and feasts did the same for the community of the elite. Rituals of enfeoffment, rituals of worship at the altar of soil, ritual offerings to the ancestors, and elaborate funeral rituals helped to create a common cultural and political identity across the formerly multistate, multinational territory that was now the Zhou kingdom. Later dynasties would seize upon Zhou rituals both as a way of borrowing legitimacy from the ancients and to build solidarity and harmony in local communities. Later rulers and philosophers would also draw on three important concepts which the Zhou contributed to Chinese philosophy: correlative thought, the idea of a constantly changing universe, and the Mandate of Heaven.⁵¹

The term “correlative thought” refers to the way in which the Western Zhou people saw correlations between the phenomena of the natural world and the emotional, social, and political affairs of humans. This could be as simple as a parallel between a peach tree and a young woman:

The peach tree is young and elegant
Brilliant are its flowers
This young lady is going to her future home
And will order well her chamber and house.⁵²

Correlative thought could, however, be ominous, as when natural disasters were interpreted as hints that the government of a king or of a feudal lord was immoral, corrupt, or even about to fall.⁵³

The idea of change is most powerfully expressed in the Western Zhou divination text, the *Book of Changes* or *Yi jing*. The *Book of Changes* assumes that the universe is in a process of constant, but orderly, change. Therefore, it advises us to adapt ourselves to the current situation by correctly carrying out divination and correctly interpreting the part of the opaque text to which the divination points us: to do so will lead to success.

The concept of the Mandate of Heaven is related both to correlative thought and to the idea of constant change. The roots of the idea go back to the Shang deity, Di, a mysterious and fickle god who could punish the Shang royal house by inflicting natural disaster or by sending enemies against them. The Zhou were familiar with Di, but they worshiped their own supreme power, Heaven. There was not an anthropomorphized sky god: Heaven was what you

saw when you gazed upward at the night sky. It was also a source of human nature and portents, and a process of constant and (usually) orderly change as the seasons and the years passed.

After the conquest, the Zhou leaders referred to both Di and Heaven to justify their overthrow of the Shang and thus to legitimize their position as rulers. This legitimization was expressed in speeches and in poetry such as this “Ode to King Wen”:

August was King Wen,
Continuously bright and reverent.
Great indeed was the Mandate of Heaven.
There were Shang’s grandsons and sons,
Shang’s grandsons and sons,
Was their number not a hundred thousand?
But Di on high gave his Mandate,
And they bowed down to Zhou.⁵⁴

As they articulated the concept of the Mandate of Heaven, the Zhou elite explained that Di Xin, the last Shang king, had been cruel and corrupt, and that the Shang elite had fallen into drunkenness and evil. Thus, it was that Di and Heaven had chosen the Zhou to overthrow the Shang and re-establish moral, responsible government. In doing so, the Zhou created a new historical narrative. In this narrative, a moral ruler, Yu the Great, had founded the Xia dynasty, ruling a unified kingdom in the Central Plains. His descendants had ruled until at last the corrupt and evil King Jie was overthrown by the moral paragon, Cheng Tang, founder of Shang. Now, the story went, the Shang elite, too, had fallen into corrupt and evil ways, and so the Mandate of Heaven had shifted to the Zhou.

The Mandate of Heaven concept legitimized the Zhou, but it also contained within it a warning: “The Mandate is not easy to keep,” said the *Book of Odes*. “May it not end in your persons. Display and make bright your good fame, and remember what Yin [Shang] received from Heaven.”⁵⁵ As another of the Zhou poems said: “It is not easy to be king.”⁵⁶

There was also the question of just whom the Mandate was issued to: To the king as an individual, or to his people?⁵⁷ The Duke of Zhou argued that the Mandate was given to the Zhou nation, and particularly to the king’s wise ministers. The Duke’s half-brother, the Duke of Shao, had a different perspective: “It is the king who has received the Mandate.”⁵⁸

This debate over the Heaven-bestowed wisdom and responsibility of the ruler versus the wisdom and responsibility of his officials (and by implication the ruler’s responsibility to listen respectfully to the advice of his officials) was, like the Mandate of Heaven concept itself, to be returned to again and again throughout Chinese history. As to this particular instance of the debate, the evidence is subject to differing interpretations, but it seems likely that King Cheng favored the Duke of Shao’s position. The Duke of Zhou, despite his considerable contributions in consolidating the kingdom, may have been pushed into retirement.⁵⁹

Internal Weakness, External Threats, and the Fall of the Western Zhou

The Zhou feudal system succeeded brilliantly in bringing political and, at least at the level of the elite, cultural unity to a large area of China Proper north of the Yangzi. Nonetheless, as generations passed, cracks began to appear in the system. Legal disputes over land ownership increased as families established branch lineages. The Zhou kings had less and less land available to grant to new members of the court, and feudal states competed with each other for land.⁶⁰ The strength of the kinship ties between the feudal lords and the Zhou ruling house became weaker over time. Zhou weakness was exacerbated when King Zhao (r. 977–957 BCE) launched an ill-advised invasion against the Yangzi Valley kingdom of Chu, losing his own life as well as the main force of the Zhou military.⁶¹

In response to these problems King Zhao’s successors undertook a number of reforms. They began to define government posts (which were occupied by a hereditary nobility) more precisely and to consider an official’s talent and job performance in addition to his heredity when making appointments.⁶² As government became more bureaucratized and standardized, so too did ritual. In the mid-Western Zhou new ritual vessels and other ritual

paraphernalia were introduced, heralding a change so striking that archeologists refer to it as a “Ritual Revolution.”⁶³

The new ritual implements included much larger bronze vessels than before, sets of bronze bells, and lavish use of jade for scepters and pendants and as covering for parts of the face of the deceased. Both the bronze bells and the use of jade were distinctively southern practices adopted by the Zhou.⁶⁴ The large, impressive ritual vessels (standardized throughout the kingdom) indicate that ritual had changed from being a participatory experience to being a spectacle: this introduced both a greater physical and psychological distance between those carrying out the rituals and those witnessing them.⁶⁵

The move toward bureaucratic professionalization and the standardization of ritual as spectacle may have provided a veneer of cultural unity, but it could not stop the centrifugal forces of regionalism, which were pulling the kingdom apart politically. The practical difficulty involved in transporting grain over long distances was a fundamental problem for a kingdom whose capital was in the Wei Valley, but its economic center of gravity, its grain production, lay to the east in the Central Plains. Added to this were problems in the Wei Valley itself.

In the last years of the Western Zhou period, the Wei Valley was under constant pressure from nomadic people to the north and northwest.⁶⁶ At the same time, the eastern subsidiary capital at Luoyang grew more and more important as the base from which to control the southeastern and southern regions of the kingdom and as a collection point for tribute from these very productive areas. The feudal lords of the east, southeast, and south paid little heed to the Zhou kings. It was to underline the need for such feudal lords to respect the royal house that King Yi (r. 865–858 BCE) captured Duke Ai of the eastern feudal state of Qi and boiled him in a cauldron.⁶⁷ Still, Qi and the other feudal principalities of the east and southeast remained difficult to control.

The Western Zhou fell during the reign of King You (r. 781–771 BCE). In the second year of King You’s reign, the Wei Valley experienced a severe earth quake and eclipses of the sun and the moon. The earthquake is said to have dried up the three river systems of the Wei Valley. Traditional Chinese histories interpreted these events as portents through which Heaven expressed its displeasure with the king. Traditional histories also make much of King You’s relations with a concubine, Bao Si.

Bao Si, so the story goes, was King You’s favorite concubine. He loved Bao Si so much that he demoted his queen and her son, the crown prince, and installed Bao Si and her son in their respective places. The demoted queen’s brother, the Marquis of Shen, a powerful feudal lord important for the defense of the capital area, was enraged.

Bao Si, one would think, should have been quite cheerful but, on the contrary, she never laughed or smiled—much to King You’s concern. Then one day, the beacon fires, a system to warn of impending attack on the capital, were lit by mistake. The vassal lords and their troops hastened to battle positions, only to find that it was a false alarm. Bao Si found the whole thing tremendously funny and laughed. King You was so pleased that he had the beacons lit again and again, until the feudal lords tired of the game. Then, when the Rong nomads, allied with the still-angry Marquis of Shen, invaded, the beacons were lit, but no one came to defend the capital.⁶⁸

This fanciful story was devised by Chinese historians to supply a moral reason for the fall of the Western Zhou and thus to serve as a warning to men in general and rulers in particular not to let the whims of women affect their judgment. The kernel of truth within the story is that the Rong did indeed attack the Zhou capital area in the Wei Valley in the eleventh year of King You’s reign, killing the king and capturing the alluring Bao Si.

The Western Zhou dynasty thus drew to an inglorious close. Its founders—King Wen, King Wu, and the Duke of Zhou—were, however, to be firmly established in Chinese culture as moral exemplars. Its feudal system and wellfields, both highly idealized, would be touchstones for later Chinese scholars and philosophers who sought ancient examples with which to criticize the alleged (and often real) corruption and rapaciousness of the centralized bureaucratic imperial governments of later times. Scholars, bureaucrats, emperors, and politicians would draw on the rich literature and ritual of the Western Zhou for their own purposes through the 20th century and beyond. All this, however, lay in the future. In 771 BCE, forces from the Zhou feudal states of Jin and Qin helped many of the hapless Zhou elite to escape, resettled them in Luoyang, and placed one of King You’s sons on the throne as King Ping. There at Luoyang, the Zhou kings, much weakened, would continue to reign as the Eastern Zhou dynasty.

Notes

1. William G. Boltz, “Kung Kung and the Flood: Reverse Euhemerism in the ‘Yao tien,’” *T’oung Pao*, Second

- Series, 67.3/5 (1981): 146; K. C. Chang, *Early Chinese Civilization: Anthropological Perspectives* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1976), 153; Ann Birrell, *Chinese Mythology: An Introduction* (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins University Press, 1993), 25.
2. Birrell, *Chinese Mythology*, 33.
 3. Kwang-chih Chang, *The Archeology of Ancient China*, 4th ed. (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1986), 309–16.
 4. Dates for the Xia and early Shang are subjects of debate. The traditional dating was Xia 2205–1766 BCE and Shang 1766–1122 BCE. The dates for Xia used here are from Yun Kuen Lee, “Chronology of Early Chinese History,” *Asian Perspectives* 41.1 (2002): 18.
 5. Edward L. Shaughnessy, “Calendar and Chronology,” in Michael Loewe and Edward L. Shaughnessy, eds., *The Cambridge History of Ancient China: From the Origins of Civilization to 221 B.C.* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 23; Kwang-chih Chang, “China on the Eve of the Historical Period,” in Loewe and Shaughnessy, eds., op. cit., 72.
 6. K. C. Chang, *Shang Civilization* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1980), 345–6.
 7. “Speech of Tang,” in James Legge, trans., *The Chinese Classics, III: The Shoo King* (Hong Kong: Hong Kong University Press, 1960), 175.
 8. Ibid.
 9. Chang, *Shang Civilization*, 790.
 0. Robert Bagley, “Shang Archeology,” in Loewe and Shaughnessy, eds., *Cambridge History of Ancient China*, 156–7; Robert L. Thorp, “The Growth of Early Shang Civilization: New Data from Ritual Vessels,” *Harvard Journal of Asiatic Studies* 45.1 (June 1985): 8. Archeologists continue to debate whether the Erligang culture (or particular phases of the Erligang culture) should be defined as early and/or mid-Shang. To resolve such disputes is far beyond the scope of this book.
 1. Bagley, “Shang Archeology,” 168–70; Robert W. Bagley, “P’an-lung-ch’eng: A Shang City in Hupei,” *Artibus Asiae* 39.3/4 (1977): 165–219; David Keightley, “The Shang,” in Loewe and Shaughnessy, eds., *Cambridge History of Ancient China*, 277.
 2. Keightley, “The Shang,” 247.
 3. Bagley, “Shang Archeology,” 171–5.
 4. Chang, *Shang Civilization*, 305–6; Steven F. Sage, *Ancient Sichuan and the Unification of China* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1992), 57–9.
 5. Chang, *Shang Civilization*, 319.
 6. William G. Boltz, “Language and Writing,” in Loewe and Shaughnessy, eds., *Cambridge History of Ancient China*, 108.
 7. Paul Wheatley, *Pivot of the Four Quarters: A Preliminary Enquiry into the Origins and Character of the Ancient Chinese City* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing Co., 1971), 67.
 8. Keightley, “The Shang,” 281.
 9. Ibid., 279.
 0. Ibid., 277; Wheatley, *Pivot*, 68.
 1. Keightley, “The Shang,” 277; Chang, *Shang Civilization*, 221–3.
 2. Chang, *Shang Civilization*, 236. The kings also received tribute of tortoise shells, cattle scapulae, cowry shells, horses, cattle, elephants, and prisoners of war, all sent by the regional lords.
 3. Wheatley, *Pivot*, 73.
 4. Ibid., 43.
 5. Ibid., 47.
 6. Ibid., 76–7; Chang, *Shang Civilization*, 226–7.
 7. Bagley, “Shang Archeology,” 137.
 8. Ladislav Kesner, “The Taotie Reconsidered: Meanings and Functions of the Shang Theriomorphic Imagery,”

- Artibus Asiae* 51.1/2 (1991): 52; K. C. Chang, "The Animal in Shang and Chou Bronze Art," *Harvard Journal of Asiatic Studies* 41.2 (Dec. 1981): 527–54; Jordan Paper, "The Meaning of the 'T'ao-T'ieh,'" *History of Religions* 18.1 (Aug. 1978): 18–41.
9. Keightley, "The Shang," 258.
 0. This description of tombs is drawn from Bagley, "Shang Archeology," 185–6.
 1. Keightley, "The Shang," 266–7; Chang, *Shang Civilization*, 228–9.
 2. Translated by David Keightley in William Theodore de Bary et al., eds., *Sources of Chinese Tradition, Vol. 1: From Earliest Times to 1600* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1999), 9, 11.
 3. *Ibid.*, 8.
 4. *Ibid.*, 9.
 5. Keightley, "The Shang," 284.
 6. *Ibid.*, 284–5; Wheatley, *Pivot*, 59.
 7. Edward L. Shaughnessy, "Historical Perspectives on the Introduction of the Chariot into China," *Harvard Journal of Asiatic Studies* 48.1 (June 1988): 192–3, 198.
 8. Wheatley, *Pivot*, 58.
 9. Keightley, "The Shang," 288; Shaughnessy, "Introduction of the Chariot," 218.
 0. Chang, *Shang Civilization*, 252.
 1. Edward L. Shaughnessy, "Western Zhou History," in Loewe and Shaughnessy, eds., *Cambridge History of Ancient China*, 302.
 2. Chun Chang Huang, Jiangli Peng, and Pinghua Li, "Abruptly Increased Climatic Aridity and Its Social Impact in the Loess Plateau of China at 3100 B.P.," *Journal of Arid Environments* (2002): 52, 87–99; Cho-yun Hsu and Katheryn M. Linduff, *Western Chou Civilization* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1988), 66.
 3. Guoyu, "Zhouyu" (Historical stories of the states: Zhou), quoted in Huang et al., "Abruptly Increased Climatic Aridity," 97.
 4. Shaughnessy, "Introduction of the Chariot," 230–1; Hsu and Linduff, *Western Chou Civilization*, 77–8.
 5. Hsu and Linduff, *Western Chou Civilization*, 157.
 6. "Song gao" (Announcement of Song), translated in Hsu and Linduff, *Western Chou Civilization*, 155–6. Romanization changed from Wade-Giles to pinyin.
 7. Wheatley, *Pivot*, 181–3.
 8. *Ibid.*, 175.
 9. *Ibid.*, 351–7.
 0. *Ibid.*, 346–51.
 1. These three and the discussion that follows are based on Shaughnessy, "Western Zhou History," 314, 336.
 2. Ode VI, "Tao Yao," translation from James Legge, trans., *The Chinese Classics, IV: The She King* (Hong Kong: Hong Kong Chinese University Press, 1960), 12.
 3. Shaughnessy, "Western Zhou History," 336.
 4. Odes, "Wen Wang," translated by Burton Watson, in de Bary et al., eds., *Sources of Chinese Tradition, Vol. 1*, 38. Translation slightly modified.
 5. Odes, "King Wen," translated by Burton Watson, *ibid.*, 38. Translation slightly modified.
 6. "Da Ming," Legge, trans., *The She King*, 432.
 7. The following discussion is drawn from Shaughnessy, "Western Zhou History," 315–7.
 8. "Announcement of Shao," quoted in *ibid.*, 316.
 9. Shaughnessy, "Western Zhou History," 317.
 0. Hsu and Linduff, *Western Chou Civilization*, 279; Shaughnessy, "Western Zhou History," 327–8.
 1. Shaughnessy, "Western Zhou History," 322–3.

2. Hsu and Linduff, *Western Chou Civilization*, 249–57.
3. Jessica Rawson, “Western Zhou Archeology,” in Loewe and Shaughnessy, eds., *Cambridge History of Ancient China*, 433.
4. *Ibid.*, 430–3.
5. Hsu and Linduff, *Western Chou Civilization*, 328.
6. *Ibid.*, 258.
7. Shaughnessy, “Western Zhou History,” 329.
8. *Ibid.*, 349–50; Hsu and Linduff, *Western Chou Civilization*, 259–60.

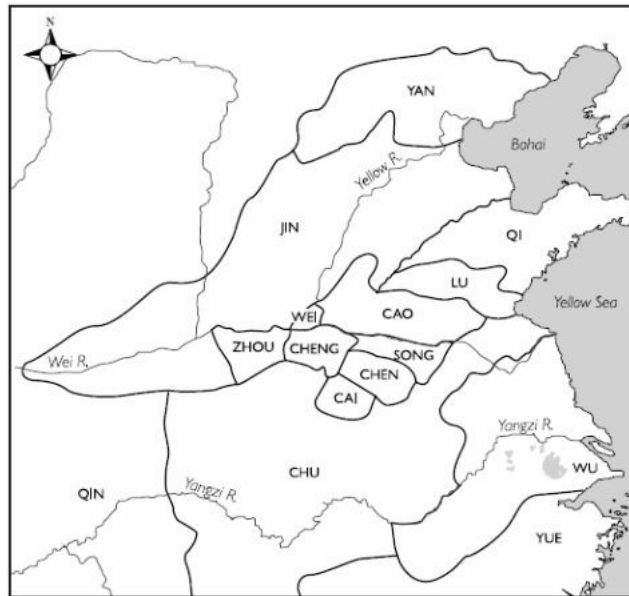
The Eastern Zhou Dynasty

The Zhou kings never recovered from the loss of their capital city. For nearly five and half centuries, the descendants of King Wen reigned in the Eastern Zhou capital at Luoyang, fading into weakness and irrelevance. As the wealth and power of the kings ebbed away, the feudal lords, aristocrats, statesmen, philosophers, and strategists of the Eastern Zhou held center stage. The result was an untidy multistate system. The Eastern Zhou (770–221 BCE) is conventionally divided into two sub-periods. The Springs and Autumns period (770–475 BCE) is named after the *Springs and Autumns Annals*, a record of major events in the state of Lu from 722 to 481 BCE. The aptly-named Warring States period begins in 476 and ends when the state of Qin unifies the feudal states in 221 BCE.

Political pluralism and warfare proved an ideal environment for the development of many contending schools of philosophy, strategy, and government—what the Chinese later referred to as “a hundred flowers blooming, a hundred schools of thought contending.” Schools of philosophy such as Confucianism and Daoism, the strategic thought of Sunzi, the arts of government as taught by the Legalist thinkers, and the many philosophical, historical, and literary texts ascribed to the Eastern Zhou period—collectively, these came to play a key role in the formation of a Chinese cultural identity. Not surprisingly, the very complexity, variety, and wealth of the many texts describing the world and thought of the Eastern Zhou also inspired Chinese over the millennia to take different positions about issues of philosophy, culture, government, and life. Ironically, while creative thought flourished in the context of a warlike multistate system, the educated men of the time generally regarded the political fragmentation of the Eastern Zhou as an unhappy aberration. Thus, much of their thinking was directed toward solving the problem—or at least surviving in troubled times.



This Eastern Zhou bronze vessel features dragon patterns and an openwork ornamental rim.



[The Eastern Zhou in the Springs and Autumns period.](#)

The Eastern Zhou Multistate System

At the beginning of the Springs and Autumns period there were over 120 feudal states in the Eastern Zhou kingdom. Some had territories the size of modern France or Britain. Others were little more than walled towns and the immediately surrounding fields and villages. Boundaries were not clearly delineated or firmly fixed.

It was impossible for the Zhou kings to maintain the peace among the many feudal states. The kings themselves had only a small feudal territory with few resources. The larger states were free to prey upon the smaller ones and to fight among themselves. The smaller states sought to survive by making strategic alliances with their neighbors and/or the enemies of their neighbors.

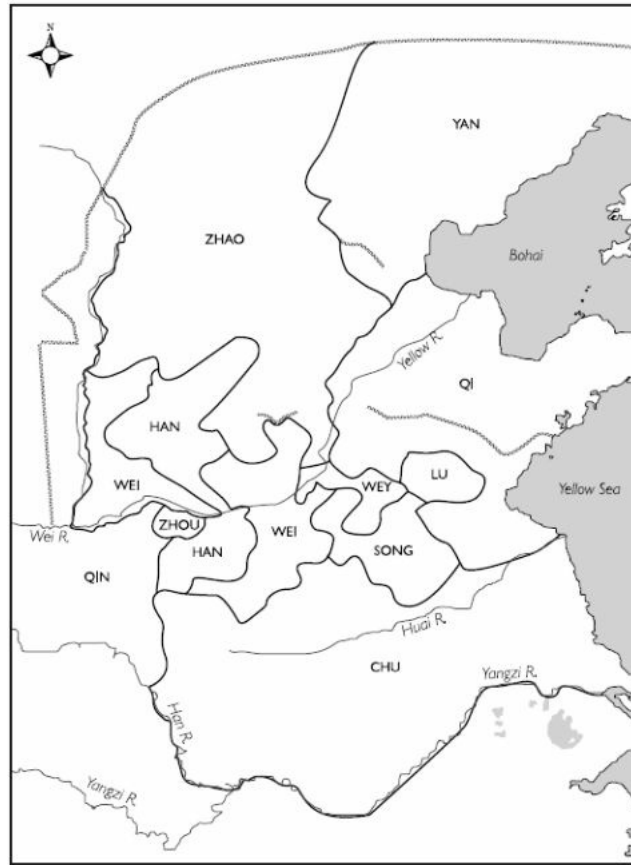
The patterns of such alliances shifted constantly. In the early Springs and Autumns period, most of the states of the Central Plains agreed that the major threat to their existence was Chu, the powerful Yangzi Valley state whose “arrogant” ruler already called himself “king,” a clear insult to the Zhou ruling house. In 671 BCE the Zhou king tried to preserve peace and order in the world by appointing the powerful Duke Huan of the state of Qi as hegemon to coordinate and lead defensive actions against Chu and other aggressors. Duke Huan (who had previously strengthened Qi by absorbing a number of his smaller neighbors) acted as hegemon for twenty-four years, fending off Chu expansionism, defending northern states against non-Chinese enemies, and intervening in succession struggles in the Zhou ruling family and in some of the other feudal states.¹

Later, the post of hegemon was passed to the Dukes of Jin, then Wu, and finally, in 475 BCE, to the Duke of Yue, who immediately attacked and thoroughly defeated his neighbor, the previous hegemon, Wu. No longer was any one state willing or able to even make a pretense of preserving peace, maintaining a balance of power, and acting as the agent and defender of the Zhou ruling house. All that was left was the powerless Zhou royal house and seven major states competing ruthlessly with each other. This Warring States period continued until the state of Qin conquered all the other states of the Central Plains in 221 BCE.

Dramatic power struggles and wars of consolidation were two aspects of the Springs and Autumns and Warring States periods. Another side of the story was social and political change within the states. Each state had its hereditary ruling family, its hereditary aristocracy, a hereditary elite warrior class (the *shi*), commoners (artisans, merchants, and farmers), and slaves. The social structure was patriarchal, but elite women could play powerful roles as advisors to sons and husbands on matters of state and could, like elite men, be granted huge tracts of land to

provide them with an income.² Merchants, though low in social status, played the leading role in the strong growth of private trade, which was spurred by increases in production, regular markets, and the introduction of money in the form of bronze, copper, gold, and silver coins issued by the various states.

Economic growth and political instability perhaps contributed to making the Springs and Autumns period a time of social mobility. This should not be exaggerated. Instances of slaves or merchants rising to become ministers of states were no more than inspiring exceptions. Most people at the bottom of society stayed right where they were. The major changes were the decline of ruling and other noble families and the rise of the *shi*.



[Major states of the Warring States period.](#)

The ruling families of the feudal states saw their power decrease because, like the Zhou kings, they granted fiefs to their own relatives and supporters. This created competing centers of power within a state and deprived the central government of revenue and resources. In the small state of Lu, for example, in 562 BCE the three branches of the Huan clan (ministerial collateral branches of the ruling house) simply divided the armies and the tax revenue of Lu among themselves. The state of Lu continued to exist, but its rulers were powerless, and with its resources divided three ways, the state was unable to build the kind of strong and aggressively expansionist government that was the key to survival.³ In the state of Jin, the Han, Zhao, and Wei clans gained so much power that in the early Warring States period they simply divided Jin among themselves to form three new states, Han, Zhao, and Wei.

As the Zhou court saw its power undermined, a new class rose up: the *shi*. The *shi* rose to power as officials and advisors to rulers, not as rulers of states in their own right. They were originally a warrior class, trained in both the arts of war and of civility: ritual, music, archery, charioteering, writing, and mathematics. In the hurly-burly world of the Springs and Autumns period, rulers needed competent men to advise them on strategies for survival and to fill posts of responsibility in their bureaucracies. The *shi* were the ideal men for these tasks. Thus, “by the fifth century their functions, once purely military, had become almost purely administrative.”⁴ Even as administrators, however, the *shi* could not help but be concerned with the arts of war, and with the management of the agricultural economy,

which was essential in supporting all aspects of life, military and civil.

Agriculture and War

In the words of Lord Shang, advisor to the state of Qin, “The means by which a country is made prosperous are agriculture and war.”⁵ Every state needed to be able to wage war, and every state’s army rested on the foundations of its farming families and their production of grain. Advances in agricultural technology and new ways of organizing and taxing agricultural production put more resources into the hands of the leaders of large, well-organized states. The key innovations were iron, irrigation, crop rotations, and private land ownership.

Bronze tools such as sickles and weeders were used during the Springs and Autumns period along with tools of stone and wood.⁶ The first iron farm tools appeared in the early or middle Springs and Autumns period, but iron did not play a major role in agricultural production until the late Springs and Autumns period and especially the Warring States period. It was in the Warring States period that iron plowshares and oxen were teamed up, significantly increasing the Chinese farmer’s productivity.⁷ Like iron, irrigation, which was not important during the Shang and Western Zhou periods, developed during the Springs and Autumns period to become a significant factor in increasing agricultural productivity in the Warring States.⁸

While the introduction of new technology improved agricultural production, so too did changes in the organization of farming. In the north, crop rotations were developed. Winter wheat was planted for summer harvest, and millet was planted for harvest in the fall.⁹ At the same time, the feudal land tenure system was gradually brought to an end. No longer did all the land under Heaven belong to the Zhou kings to be assigned to feudal lords. Instead, land came to be privately owned by farming families who paid a part of their crop (probably around twenty percent) as tax to the state. With a few exceptions, all future Chinese regimes (until the 20th century) were built on a foundation of landowning, taxpaying individual farming families.

Private ownership made land a commodity and thus opened the way for powerful families (nobility, officials, even merchants) to build up large holdings of agricultural land as investments.¹⁰ As we shall see in the later dynastic periods, concentration of land ownership often provoked social and political tensions as more and more farmers sank into tenancy and poverty. Furthermore, as land fell into the hands of fewer and more powerful owners, individual farming families lost their land and dropped off of the tax rolls. Since large, powerful landowners were better able to resist taxation than individual families, this often meant that the state’s tax revenue declined. We will see these unintended long-term effects of private landownership played out again and again over the course of history. In the short term, however, private landholding probably contributed to increased productivity in the Warring States period by giving farmers greater incentive to increase production.¹¹

As agricultural technology and organization improved, so too did military technology and organization. During the Springs and Autumns period, warfare was transformed by the crossbow, iron, and infantry. High-quality iron swords, some of them over a meter in length, were in use by the late Springs and Autumns period. Iron was also used to manufacture new versions of traditional weapons: the lance and the dagger-axe.¹² Many weapons, however, continued to be made of bronze. Bronze was also used to manufacture triggers for a new weapon: the crossbow. This new and more powerful bow was most effective when used en masse to send volley after volley of arrows flying at the enemy.¹³ Iron weapons and the crossbow spurred the production of armor, traditionally made of lacquered plates of leather laced together, and, in the late Warring States period, of iron plates similarly laced.¹⁴

The chariot, which had been used more as a mobile command platform in the Shang, saw its heyday during the Springs and Autumns period. Huge numbers of chariots were deployed in offensive warfare. Major states like Jin and Chu could mobilize three to four thousand chariots in all. Pitched battles of the Springs and Autumns years involved thousands of chariots at a time.¹⁵ The chariot did, however, have its disadvantages: it was expensive; effective use required long training; it was likely to get stuck in holes; and it was useless in hilly, swampy, and riverine terrain. By the late Springs and Autumns period, the chariot had again been relegated to the role of mobile command platform, while fighting became the business of cheap, plentiful, and easily trained infantry supported by cavalry.¹⁶

The move from charioteers to infantry was accompanied by a change in the prosecution of war. In the early and even middle Springs and Autumns period, war was still an affair of the chariot-driving elite. Battles were oneday meetings of noble enemies, and ritual civility was shown to one’s opponent. Moving into the late Springs and

Autumns and Warring States years, wars became larger in scale, campaigns lasted for months and involved armies of tens and, by the late Warring States period, hundreds of thousands of men. Noble gestures of courtesy toward one's enemies, if they occurred at all, were taken as signs of weakness and would earn a sneer at best, but more likely death at the hands of an unimpressed opponent.¹⁷

With survival depending on victory in war, many states employed experts in military strategy. The most famous of the military strategists is Sunzi (Sun Wu), the putative author of a collection of teachings entitled *Sunzi's Art of War*. There is no firm evidence that Sunzi existed. He is supposed to have been a contemporary of Confucius, but the book bearing his name was compiled a hundred years later, sometime in the second half of the fourth century BCE.¹⁸

The *Art of War* teaches that a successful general knows himself; knows his enemy; turns the terrain and the climate to his advantage; uses deception, surprise, and creativity; and fights only when he is certain of victory. Indeed, the truly great general manages things so that his enemy gives up without a fight. Influential across East Asia for over two thousand years, the *Art of War* has become standard reading in Western military academies and is also popular in the business world.

Searching for the Way of Heaven

The men whose ideas found expression in the *Art of War* served various feudal lords as advisers on strategy. Many other men traveled the states of Eastern Zhou offering advice and teaching on the arts of government, ritual, and morality, on man and nature, and sometimes simply on how to survive in an unpredictable and dangerous world. There was great variety to their thought, but they did share some core assumptions: they regarded disunity and chaos as a problem to be solved, they assumed that patriarchal hierarchy is natural for families and for states, that there is a natural "Way" (dao) of Heaven, and that those who discover and follow that Heavenly Way will be successful. In the long term, the two most significant varieties of teaching were those that scholars during the Han dynasty labeled as "Confucianism" and "Daoism."

Confucius (the latinized version of Kong Fuzi, "Master Kong") or Kong Qiu (551–479 BCE) was a man of Lu. Like many other *shi* of the Eastern Zhou, Confucius traveled among the states, offering his services as a political advisor and official to feudal rulers and taking on students whom he would teach for a fee. Confucius had an unsuccessful career as a petty bureaucrat, but a highly successful one as a teacher. A couple of generations after his death, first- and second-generation students gathered accounts of Confucius' teachings together. These anecdotes and records of short conversations go under the English title of the *Analects*. As seen in the *Analects*, the basic elements of Confucius' teachings can be summed up as: ritual, filial piety, reciprocity, benevolence, and rectification of names.

Confucius believed that ritual (the rules of decorum as well as formal rituals governing family, social, and political interaction) was needed in order to moderate the natural human appetites and thus to maintain peace and orderliness in the world. He assumed that humans exist and find their identity or purpose within relationships with other people. The five basic relationships were: ruler–minister, father–son, husband–wife, elder brother–younger brother, and friend–friend. Four of the five are hierarchical, and there are clear parallels between the hierarchical relations within a family and the hierarchical relationships of ruler to minister, and by extension, subjects to ruler and subjects to the ruler's officials.

Filial piety was an essential ingredient in making these hierarchical relationships work. Children should respect, obey, and care for their parents, not merely going through the motions, but with feeling from the depths of their hearts. Inferiors in a political system should likewise show respect, care, and obedience toward their superiors.

Clear parallels were drawn between filial sons and loyal subjects. This did not, however, mean that fathers, rulers, and other superiors could play the tyrant. Reciprocity was an essential part of hierarchical relationships. Rulers, fathers, husbands, and elder brothers had the responsibility to love, educate, and care for the material needs of their inferiors. There was also the suggestion that superiors should respect the valid opinions of their inferiors. When asked how to serve a ruler, Confucius replied: "You may not deceive him, but you may stand up to him."¹⁹



The grave of Confucius as it is today.

This mutual respect and care for others within hierarchically defined relationships was the core of what Confucius called humaneness (*ren*, also translated as “benevolence”). A true ruler would administer his state, thus treating his ministers kindly and respectfully and caring for his people. The essence of rulership (or fatherhood) lay in setting a good moral example: “The virtue of the noble person is like the wind, and the virtue of small people is like the grass. When the wind blows over the grass, the grass must bend.”²⁰ Through the power of his moral example, a good ruler would transform those below him.

Clearly, the rulers of Confucius’ time were not behaving that way. Thus, the need for a rectification of names; that is, a need to return to a situation in which there was a close correspondence between terms and realities. Explaining government, Confucius said: “Let the ruler be a ruler; the minister, a minister; the father, a father; the son, a son.”²¹ If everyone from the king on down truly fulfills the ideal role designated by his or her name (king, duke, husband, wife, and so on), the result will be peaceful, stable hierarchical polities, societies, and families. Since it all begins at the top, this puts a great burden of responsibility on the ruler. How is one to be a good ruler? By ruling people by example, not by threatening them with punitive laws, and by conforming to ritual in one’s daily life: “Through mastering oneself and returning to ritual one becomes humane. If for a single day one can master oneself and return to ritual, the whole world will return to humaneness.”²² For Confucius, it all came back to ritual.

Not everyone agreed. Mozi, who lived in the late fifth to early fourth centuries BCE, was a vociferous critic of Confucius. Mozi’s teaching revolved around three themes: utility, conformity to the will of superiors, and concern for everyone (also translated as “universal love”).²³ The Confucians, said Mozi, wasted time and resources on elaborate rituals, music, and dance. In the case of funerals, for example, Mozi asked if the complex rituals and prolonged mourning (three years of mourning for a dead parent) “can really enrich the poor, increase the population, secure the endangered, and order the disorder.”²⁴ Concluding that they did not bring any such practical benefits, Mozi condemned Confucian funeral and mourning rituals as a waste of resources.

Mozi also criticized the Confucians for encouraging selfishness. Confucius, he said, taught people to be concerned only about the welfare of their own parents and their own families. The result was disagreement and fighting not within families, but among families. How, then, would Mozi bring peace and stability? He argued that

Heaven showed concern for everyone, not the partial concern for one's own that the Confucian doctrine taught. The ruler of men and all people should imitate Heaven in its concern for everyone, or "universal love." If all men regarded the families, cities, and states of others with the same concern that they would show for their own, there would be no more bloody wars between the states.

The secret to achieving this enviable state of affairs was for the ruler to emulate Heaven's concern for everyone, and for his ministers and his people to obey and emulate their superiors. Mozi's vision of good government was a centralized bureaucracy in which the king raised up men from all levels of society, even farmers and merchants, appointing them to official posts according to their talents. This "Mohism" stood in sharp contrast to the teaching of Confucius and his followers, who would have preferred a return to the genteel hereditary feudalism of the idealized past. In terms of immediate action, Mozi and his followers, although opposed to aggressive warfare, were experts at defensive warfare and were often employed by feudal lords as consultants on defensive operations.

Mozi's ideas were not influential in the long run, but they were powerful enough to elicit a vigorous reply from Mencius (385?–312? BCE). Mencius was a powerful advocate and interpreter of Confucius' ideas. Mozi's teachings, said Mencius, implied denial of one's parents, and were bringing the world to ruin. His response to the chaos of the Warring States period was to expand on the ideas in the *Analects*. Mencius is particularly associated with: 1. his strong belief in the innate goodness of human nature; 2. the idea that a loyal minister has the duty to reprimand his own ruler; and 3. proposing the well-field system as a model for the management of land and population. Unlike Mozi, Mencius' teachings proved to be very influential, particularly from the Song dynasty through the 20th century.

Like Confucius, Mencius was an unabashed elitist. As far as he was concerned, the common people were uneducated masses who needed to be managed, led, and cared for by their superiors, ultimately by a king who would look after their material needs and set a good moral example. Mencius' faith that a good ruler can transform his people was based on his optimistic view of human nature: people are basically good. Thus, a good ruler would bring out the innate goodness of the people. The dark side of this belief is that if you assume that the ruler is good (as most rulers are likely to assume), then by implication anyone who does not behave in an exemplary fashion is stubbornly violating his or her own nature, or perhaps is less than human. In the hands of a more powerful and less humane person than Mencius, such a belief could lead all-powerful rulers to treat troublemakers as little more than beasts.

Mencius himself was not so confident in the innate goodness of rulers as rulers themselves might have been. In discussing government with the Duke of Qi, Mencius explained that high-ranking ministers of a ruler's own clan should "remonstrate with him" if he had faults, "and if he does not listen to them after they have done so again and again, they ought to dethrone him."²⁵ On another occasion Mencius reminded King Xuan that the last Shang king had been overthrown and killed—an event that Mencius explained was not regicide, but simply the "punishment of a common fellow."²⁶

In echoing Confucius' teaching that a loyal official should correct the errors of his ruler and "stand up to him," Mencius had added even further to the position associated with the Duke of Zhou, who, as we saw in Chapter 1, argued that the Mandate of Heaven is given to the king and his officials together. This particular aspect of Confucian thinking gave Chinese officials a strong philosophical basis on which to point out the errors of the Son of Heaven. Chinese emperors did not always appreciate such criticism.

In justifying the overthrow of an evil ruler, Mencius was looking back to the founding myths of the Zhou dynasty. Like Confucius, Mencius used an idealized vision of the past as an example of the best of what human beings are capable of and should aspire to. For Mencius, the well-field system was an integral part of his idealized view of what life had been like during the Western Zhou. As we have seen, the well-field system was nine fields laid out like a tic-tac-toe game. Eight families would each cultivate a field, and all eight working together would cultivate the center field, whose product would go to the feudal lord.

There is no evidence that this system was practiced during the Western Zhou period, but that is of no consequence to the moral lessons that Mencius derived from the model. Embedded within the well-field model of agricultural production are three ideals: egalitarianism, hierarchy, and reciprocity. The well-field system is egalitarian in that each family has the same size plot of land to cultivate. It is hierarchical in that all the families cultivate the common field on behalf of their feudal lord. It is reciprocal in that the feudal lord has granted the people their land and maintains social order. Everyone—inferiors and superiors—has their place in the system, and everyone is taken care of.

For the next two millennia, Chinese officials and emperors would look to the well-field system as described by Mencius for inspiration as they debated the difficult problems of land tenure, rural poverty, taxes, and tenancy rates.

Occasionally an idealistic official would suggest that the well-field system be implemented. More often, the well-field system would be used as a model to which officials would refer when arguing for their own more practical proposals that would, hopefully, help to realize some of the ideals inherent in the well-field system without actually dividing Chinese agricultural land up into well-field-like blocs and reinstating feudalism.

Mencius was confident of the innate goodness of human nature and looked back to the Western Zhou for the ideals that would serve as the basis for government and society. Xunzi (310?–219? BCE) had a somewhat different interpretation of Confucius' teachings. Xunzi declared that "human nature is evil." People, he observed, are born with a fondness for profit, feelings of envy and hate, and desire for pleasure of all sorts. Left to themselves, people will indulge these tendencies and thus be devoid of any sense of modesty, yielding, loyalty, good faith, rightness, refinement, and principle. This, Xunzi said, was the reason why ritual is so necessary. The standards of ritual, devised by men, can straighten out human nature just as a carpenter straightens warped wood by steaming it and bending it into shape. Without ritual, the world would fall into chaos. Xunzi's understanding of ritual, ethics, and government was very influential until the Song period (960–1276 CE), when scholars elevated Mencius to second place of importance after Confucius.

Xunzi, Mencius, Mozi, and Confucius all used the term "dao," translated as "Way," in their teachings. For them, the term meant the way of life, the way of rulership, the way of elite men's participation in public affairs. The term "dao" is, however, most firmly identified with Zhuangzi and Laozi. Zhuangzi is said to have lived somewhere around 360–280 BCE. The long book that bears his name is a combination of material that represents his own thinking and other writings incorporated by various compilers and editors. The identity of Laozi (the name means "the old master") is a subject of intense debate. The book attributed to him, the *Dao de jing* (*Classic of the Way and Its Power*) is a compilation reflecting a strain of thought from around 400 BCE.

During the Warring States period, Zhuangzi and Laozi were not considered to be part of a single school of thought. Zhuangzi is more concerned with escaping from the world, Laozi with cunning ways of ruling it. During the Han dynasty, both works' concern with the dao and their mystical understanding of that term inspired historians to lump them together under the single category of "Daoism." The name stuck. Zhuangzi and Laozi are now linked as the two great founders of Daoist philosophy.

Zhuangzi's peculiar wit makes him the more charming character of the two. He pokes fun at the narrow-mindedness of folks who cling proudly to their limited view of the world, comparing them to the little quail who is convinced that his feeble fluttering for yards at a time is the ultimate in flying and laughs in disbelief when told of the great Peng-bird whose wings beat like a whirlwind as they carry him ninety thousand *li* into the southern darkness. In a world that respects usefulness, Zhuangzi finds value in uselessness, pointing out that a great, crooked tree, useless for timber, will live long, while the trees that are useful to men are abused and their lives cut short.

Seeing uselessness as a virtue, Zhuangzi rejects what Confucius holds most dear: devotion to government service. One of the stories in the book of Zhuangzi has a character teasing Confucius: "You can't bear to watch the sufferings of one age, so you go and make trouble for ten thousand ages to come! Are you just naturally a boor?"²⁷ Rejecting the dangerous world of politics, Zhuangzi exudes a charmingly bemused acceptance of the constant changes of the natural world, and of the human body, including death. All things are always in a process of transformation, and death is simply a part of that process. A willow tree suddenly sprouting from a man's left elbow is just change catching up with him.²⁸ An illness that leaves a man's body so deformed that his chin is in his navel and his shoulders above his head inspires him to say that perhaps the Creator will "transform my buttocks into cartwheels. Then, with my spirit for a horse, I'll climb up and go for a ride."²⁹

Zhuangzi's vision of the universe and human life as a process of constant change is one side of his understanding of the dao, the Way. Another side of Zhuangzi's understanding of the dao is seen in the story of Cook Ding, who butchers oxen with ease, sliding his knife through the points of least resistance. It is in such a view of the world that the *Zhuangzi* shares some common ground with the *Dao de jing*.

Like the *Zhuangzi*, the *Dao de jing* conveys an emphasis on simplicity, naturalness, yielding to the ever-changing and incomprehensible Way, surviving and thriving by not struggling, but going with the flow. But the *Dao de jing* also offers cunning advice for rulers: gain the empire by being weak, crafty, and not meddling (which is to say, by following the dao). Rulers should care more for self-preservation than for gaining dominion and use men who think likewise. A good ruler should conform to the Way, act early and unobtrusively, and never reveal the instruments (rewards and punishments) with which he controls people. He should manage people by not pressing down on them with onerous taxes, but also by keeping them simple-minded and well-fed, by treating them as children. The ideal state will be one in which the people are few and satisfied with their simple farming lives, uninterested in the tools

of war, in boats, carts, or even writing, content to spend their whole lives within the borders of their tiny states.

In the long term, the *Dao de jing*'s philosophy of naturalness and simplicity served as an inspiration for the art and the lifestyles of painters and poets. In the Han dynasty and after, religious leaders appropriated the text of the *Dao de jing*, which they interpreted to suit their own ends, as a part of their construction of an organized Daoist religion.

Music, Literature, and Art

By the late Zhou dynasty, the same rich intellectual life that had given rise to Confucius, Mencius, Zhuangzi, and the *Dao de jing* had also produced distinct ways of thinking about music, art, and literature. The late Zhou elite understood music, literature, and art as important instruments by which rulers and their officials could exercise a transformative moral influence over those below them and thereby bring about social order and stability. However, the worlds of Chinese music, art, and literature were not homogeneous. Within the elite culture of the late Zhou, there existed already a creative tension between the aesthetic ideals associated with the ideas articulated by Confucius and similar thinkers on the one hand, and in texts like the *Zhuangzi* and the *Dao de jing* on the other. Beyond this, the culture of the late Zhou elite existed in a world of diverse regional languages and cultures. Sometimes this cultural diversity is positively visible in the archeological record or in the continued existence of distinct regional variants of the Chinese language. At other times, we see negative evidence of diversity when elite authors condemn “immoral” varieties of art, literature, or music as they assert the rectitude of their culture, the culture of Zhou, to which modern Han Chinese trace their cultural roots.

Music was central to Zhou ideas of morality and kingship. As a Chinese author of the Zhou period wrote:

In music the Holy Sages took delight, because music can improve the heart of the people. Music has a profound influence on man; it can improve customs and ameliorate morals. Therefore the kings of olden times promoted the teaching of music.³⁰

The performance of pleasant, harmonious music was considered to have a positive effect on the morality of those who listened. In contrast, one should avoid music that was disharmonious, expressed feelings of lust, or lured men into wasteful indulgence of the senses.

We cannot know what the morally upright music of ancient China sounded like: we have prehistoric, Shang, and Zhou instruments, but no records of the tunes which were played on them. The instruments themselves range from the simple whistles and flutes of prehistoric times to full sets of carefully tuned stone chimes and bronze bells, which were clearly used in court ceremonies.

Chinese music was based on a pentatonic scale (five notes), although a heptatonic (seven-note) scale was created in the late Zhou by adding two halves into the pentatonic scale. By at least the Shang period, there is evidence for stringed instruments, the most notable of which is the *qin* (variously translated as “lute” or “zither”). The *qin* is a wooden instrument with seven silk strings. The musician depresses the strings with the fingers of the left hand while plucking with the right. This instrument, said to have been played by Confucius, was much admired by Chinese literati for over two thousand years. Few mastered the complexities of playing the *qin*, but all acknowledged the beauty of its tones. The *qin* was associated with many noted authors over the millennia, including Tao Qian (372?–427 CE, also known as Tao Yuanming), whose *qin* had no strings because, he said, “I have acquired the deeper significance of the *qin*; why should I strive after the sound of the strings?”³¹

It is from literature that we learn most about the music of the Zhou, and about the lives and aesthetic ideals of the men who made the music. Literature also reveals to us the creative tensions within the Chinese literary tradition and hints at the extent to which the written language of the elite concealed the diversity of regional cultures.

The written Chinese of the late Zhou had developed from the writing that we see on the Shang dynasty oracle bones. The Chinese writing system uses symbols—we call them “characters”—to represent sounds and meanings. Each character stands for a single syllable: words may be one syllable, or may be composed of several syllables, each represented by a separate character. Some characters have their origins as pictures of the thing which they represent, but most characters are composed of two or more constituent parts, with one part giving a rough indication of the meaning of the character, while the other may contain a hint as to the character’s pronunciation.

Aside from their function as carriers of meaning, Chinese characters have an inherent beauty, which led to

calligraphy becoming one of the most respected art forms in the Chinese world. To gain appointment as an official and rise through the ranks, a man would (in most cases) have to excel in both calligraphy and in the composition of prose and poetry. Basic literacy required the memorization of around a thousand characters, while a highly educated person would be familiar with four to six thousand. As in most early civilizations, the written language developed grammar, vocabulary, and styles of expression very different from the spoken word, and though functional literacy on some level was probably greater, the number of people who were proficient in the written language was around two percent of the population.³²

In imperial times, those Chinese who were highly educated looked to a number of books attributed to the Zhou period as the earliest sources of literary style and themes. Although parts or all of some of those texts may have been written sometime after the Zhou, it is appropriate to consider the major works traditionally attributed to the Zhou period here. We have already referred to the *Analects*, the *Dao de jing*, and the books of Mencius and Zhuangzi. Also of importance are the so-called “Five Classics”: the *Book of Changes* (the *Yi jing*), the *Book of History*, the *Book of Odes*, the *Record of Ritual*, and the *Springs and Autumns Annals*.

The *Record of Ritual* purports to be an account of the various court and family rituals that guided the lives of the Zhou elite. The *Book of History* and the *Springs and Autumns Annals* are historical records (some forged, some genuine). The *Book of Odes* is a collection of court songs and some popular songs from the Zhou period. Until the mid-19th century, educated Chinese believed that Confucius wrote the *Springs and Autumns Annals* and edited the *Book of Odes*, choosing his words carefully to indicate his moral judgment on the historical characters and events and choosing songs that carried moral lessons concerning the responsibilities of rulers, subjects, husbands, and wives.³³

Standing in contrast to the *Book of Odes* is the *Songs of Chu*, a collection of poetry from the Yangzi Valley state of Chu, at that time regarded as the semibarbaric southern extremity of the Chinese world. The *Songs of Chu* employs graphic accounts of shamanistic journeys and rich references to the plants of the south, which underline their exotic contrast to the more straitlaced and drier world of the Central Plains. However, the *Songs of Chu* share with the northern literature strong concerns about the morality of officials and the search for an enlightened ruler who will treat his people and officials with justice and benevolence. In the most famous example, “Encountering Sorrow,” the poet Qu Yuan, lamenting the corruption at court and unable to find a moral ruler, drowns himself rather than compromising his integrity.

The *Book of Changes* is a divination text from which philosophers associated with both Confucius and the *Dao de jing* drew inspiration. The text includes sixty-four hexagrams—combinations of six broken or unbroken parallel lines. A diviner chooses one hexagram through a process of chance. The text attached to the hexagram is then interpreted as an answer to a question or a guide to action. The structure and content of the *Book of Changes* suggest that it can be regarded as a model of the universe—a universe that is in constant change, but change that follows particular patterns, and that if one knows the patterns of change and adapts one’s actions accordingly, one will be successful.

The presence of “Daoist” and “Confucian” themes in the corpus of late Zhou literature (sometimes even within the same text) brought a creative tension to high culture. Over the next two thousand years, both the ideals of naturalness, simplicity, and withdrawal from a dangerous society associated with Laozi and Zhuangzi and ideals of fulfilling one’s roles in the family and the state so closely identified with Confucius would deeply influence the lives and literature of the Chinese elite.



A painting of Confucius from the Ming dynasty.

In the long term, the creative tension between the “Daoist” and “Confucian” outlooks on life would be played out in the area of art. However, the record of art in the Shang and Zhou periods most dramatically demonstrates another tension: that between the various regional cultures of what we now call “China” and the process by which the elite culture of the Central Plains came to assert hegemony over regional cultures. As we have seen in the previous chapters, the archeological record indicates a variety of different cultures, whose unique styles are reflected in those objects that have survived until today: pottery, jade carvings, and, especially, bronzes. The discovery of artifacts such as the great bronze drums of the Yangzi Valley cultures or the remarkable bronze statue and other bronzes at Sanxingdui in Sichuan, both contemporaneous with the Shang, testify to the cultural diversity of early China. However, as we move into the period of Zhou unification, bronze vessels become more standardized and homogeneous. During the Warring States period, variety reasserts itself, but what we see is variety within a common style, with some of the variety being due to the influence of neighboring cultures. The naturalistic birds and animals, and possibly the inlaying of turquoise, malachite, and lapis, are thought to indicate the influence of the art of the nomadic peoples to the north, in present-day Mongolia.³⁴

Throughout the elite music, art, and literature of the Eastern Zhou period, we see some common concerns: culture as a mark of rulership and as an instrument through which rulers and the educated elite manifest and communicate morality. We also see tensions within the world of culture: the creative tension between “Daoist” and “Confucian” attitudes toward life and the tension between a unifying elite high culture and a variety of elite and popular regional cultures. The creation of a common culture, one that would be shared by a larger educated elite and, ultimately, by the common people as well, would be a long-term project during which the developing culture would be deeply influenced and changed by contact with the civilizations of India, Central Asia, Persia, and, eventually, western Europe and the Americas. In the short term, however, the further imposition of cultural unity would be accomplished only by the creation of a strong, unified government. That task was conceived of and carried out by men who placed a higher value on power than on culture or morality.

Legalist Thinkers

Texts like the *Analects*, the *Zhuangzi*, and the *Dao de jing* taught people how to live and (sometimes) instructed rulers in morality. Military strategists taught how to deal with one’s enemies. Another group of loosely related thinkers taught rulers how to manage people and resources. As with the terms “Daoist” and “Confucian,” the term “Legalist” was coined by Han dynasty historians as a category into which they could put a variety of political theorists and practitioners who were not seen as representing a coherent “school of thought” at the time when they were alive. The theoretical ideas behind Legalism are best expressed in the writings attributed to Han Fei (?–233 BCE), most of which are probably his own work or very accurate representations of his teaching.

Legalism was pragmatic and strongly oriented toward the present and the future. To make the point, Han Fei tells the story of a farmer in the state of Song. While plowing, the farmer of Song saw a rabbit run down the field, run smack into a stump, and break its neck. Delighted to be eating rabbit for dinner without having gone to any effort himself, the farmer of Song laid down his plow, waited, and watched for a second rabbit to hit the stump. "Those who think they can take the ways of the ancient kings and use them to govern the people of today," said Han Fei, are all "stump-watchers."³⁵ Instead of looking to the past for solutions to contemporary problems, the Legalists argued in favor of rational (including quantitative) analysis of problems and innovative, realistic solutions.

Legalist solutions for the problems of governance were part of the general trend of the Springs and Autumns and Warring States periods: the trend away from hereditary kinship feudalism and toward a centralized bureaucracy staffed by officials appointed to functionally defined posts on the basis of an evaluation of their competence. Along with this trend came a host of policies intended to strengthen the state: organization of families into groups in multiples of five and ten for mutual surveillance, corvée labor, and taxation; private ownership of agricultural land rather than enfeoffment and subenfeoffment; and organization of territory into prefectures run by appointed officials. Another part of the change taking place was a movement away from reliance on wise and moral leaders to define and mediate social and political relations. Instead of elders who were presumably wise and familiar with ritual, rulers began to favor written laws enforced by clearly prescribed rewards and punishments.

Much of this was anathema to followers of Confucius, who said so quite clearly. Written laws were especially upsetting to them: they argued that the use of laws and punishments would only lead to more social unrest. It would make people sly and litigious as they searched for loopholes. The Legalists, however, had faith in their ability to use the "two handles" of reward and punishment to build strong, stable kingdoms and to restore peace and stability to their world.

At the center of the Legalist government was the ruler himself. As the Legalists pointed out, simply occupying the position of ruler confers authority on a man who, in fact, may not be the most intelligent or talented of his generation. But rulers were not to micromanage or meddle, nor could they be successful if they indulged their whims or acted out of favoritism. His officials manage the affairs of state according to the laws, using the "two handles." The ruler himself, then, does nothing other than to keep the system running and to respect its operation.

The laws, the Legalists said, should be clear, and should prescribe severe punishments even for minor offenses. In this way, few people would dare to commit any offense at all, and the ruler would have succeeded in "using punishments to do away with punishing." When offenses were committed, punishment should be rapid and inevitable: it should be applied to all offenders alike, without reference to their official rank or social status.

With the laws established and enforced uniformly, the affairs of state would run smoothly. Legalists designed their laws not only to discourage criminal behavior, but also to encourage the two types of enterprise most essential to the state: agriculture and war. The state would accordingly be stable, safe, wealthy, and strong, in a position to defend itself against aggressors and to conquer more land from its neighbors when it so desired.

Toward Unification

One can see why the advice of the Legalists would be more attractive to Warring States rulers than the moral platitudes of the by now eight different schools associated with Confucius, Mencius, and Xunzi and their teachings about humaneness and ritual. As the seven great states vied with each other for territory, and ultimately for control of "all under Heaven," rulers were likely to agree with another Legalist, Lord Shang: "rites and music, odes and history, cultivation and goodness, filial devotion and brotherly love, sincerity and trustworthiness, uprightness and integrity, humaneness and rightness, criticism of the army and being ashamed of fighting" were all parasites to be firmly eliminated.³⁶

With the harsh realism of the Legalists, the simplicity and humor of the Daoists, the utilitarian dictatorship of the Mohists, and the hierarchical ritual humanism of the "Confucians," it would seem that the spiritual world of the Eastern Zhou was dominated by philosophers. Nothing could be further from the truth. Confucius, it is true, displayed little interest in discussing ghosts and spirits, and the Legalists had no time for anything other than the affairs of this world. Nonetheless, both elite and commoner held a variety of religious beliefs. Astrologers studied the night skies not only to devise calendars, but also to understand the significance of astrological phenomena for the affairs of men. Men, including rulers and officials of states, performed divination with turtle shells and with the *Book of Changes*, seeking guidance as they pondered political and military decisions. People believed that Heaven

ruled an animistic pantheon of spirits which needed to be placated and respected. Medicine combined herbal and other remedies with magic and shamanism to treat disease.

No amount of shamanism or ritual could prevent the overall historical trend of the Eastern Zhou: the increasing irrelevance and powerlessness of the Zhou kings and the kinship feudalism that had linked the Zhou kingdom together. The very system that had brought increased levels of cultural unity to the Central Plains and their periphery had led to political fragmentation. Technological advances, increased production, a cash economy, and growing trade all brought benefits to individual states, not to the Zhou kings.

The world of fiefs gave way to a world of fewer and fewer states. Those that achieved greater degrees of centralization and which were able to conquer more productive agricultural land gained the most power. As the rulers of the various states sought officials and advisors, the *shi* class gained power and philosophy flourished, laying the foundations of what later became Confucianism, Daoism, and Legalism: three schools of philosophy that would inform Chinese moral ideals and political practice for the next two thousand years. Warfare, once the affair of nobles riding chariots, became the business of plebian infantry supported by cavalry. These trends were shared, more or less, by all seven of the powers of the Warring States period. They are best exemplified in the state that eventually unified all under Heaven: Qin.

Notes

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3. Mark Edward Lewis, "Warring States Political History," in Loewe and Shaughnessy, eds., *Cambridge History of Ancient China*, 598; Burton Watson, introduction to *The Tso Chuan: Selections from China's Oldest Narrative History*, Burton Watson, trans. (New York: Columbia University Press, 1989), xxxi.
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6. Li Xueqin, *Eastern Zhou and Qin Civilizations* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1985), 315.
7. *Ibid.*, 479–81; Paul Wheatley, *Pivot of the Four Quarters: A Preliminary Enquiry into the Origins and Character of the Ancient Chinese City* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing Co., 1971), 130–1.
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0. Wheatley, *Pivot*, 133.
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4. Albert E. Dien, "Armor in China Before the Tang Dynasty," *Journal of East Asian Archeology* 2.3–4 (2000): 26; Li, *Eastern Zhou Civilization*, 326.
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9. Confucius, *Analects* 14:23, translated by Edward Slingerland (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Company, 2003), 163.
0. Ibid., 12:19, in Slingerland, op. cit., 134.
1. Ibid., 12:11, in Slingerland, op. cit., 130.
2. Ibid., 12:1, in Slingerland, op. cit., 125.
3. Benjamin I. Schwartz, *The World of Thought in Ancient China* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1985), 134–51.
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5. (Mencius) *Mengzi*, 5B9.1, translated by Bryan W. Van Norden (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Company, 2008), 142.
6. (Mencius) *Mengzi*, 1B8.3, in Van Norden, op. cit., 26.
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The Chinese have regarded the origins of a unified, centralized Chinese state with a mixture of pride and revulsion. In 221 BCE, the feudal state of Qin wrapped up its violent conquest of all the various warring states when it defeated Qi. After eleven years of allegedly bloody autocratic rule, Qin fell and was replaced in 202 BCE after years of civil warfare by the Han dynasty, whose founder, Liu Bang, had risen from a humble farming background to become emperor. Building on the Qin accomplishment, Liu Bang and his heirs constructed a centralized bureaucratic state that ruled over most of China Proper and extended its military might into Central Asia, Korea, and Annam.

Together, the Qin and Han firmly established the principle of unified rule over the “mountains and rivers” of the people who, to this day, call themselves “people of Han,” and are known in European languages as “Chinese” after the Qin dynasty. By the end of the Han dynasty, the Han (Chinese) people’s pride in their culture and their identity with their imperial territory (still, at the time, centered on the Central Plains) ran deep—but so, too, did doubts and questions that are still relevant today: Just how do we define the Han (Chinese) people and delimit their territory? How is violently imposed unification to be squared with Confucius’ ideal of rule through virtue? How important is political unity, and what degree of violence and suffering is justified in achieving it?

Han-dynasty and later historians resolved the moral dilemma of the forceful foundation of the Chinese imperial state by casting the first emperor of the Qin dynasty as a villain and the founding emperor of Han as a moral exemplar in the mode of Confucius. We need not take these images seriously as history, but we should take them seriously as long-lasting images of two styles of power. In this chapter, we will look at how the Qin and Western Han emperors built the centralized state and territory that subsequent generations of Chinese came to regard as a model. In the following chapter, we will consider the weaknesses which led to the ultimate downfall of the dynasty in the Eastern Han period and at the cultural legacy which inspired the continued identification of the Chinese as “people of Han.” The story begins in the waning years of the Warring States period in that most warlike of states, the state of Qin.

The State of Qin

Qin lay in the area of the old homeland of the Zhou before they conquered the Shang: territory which the Qin had recovered from the nomadic Rong invaders and made into their own state. The center that they established in the Wei Valley was one of Qin’s sources of strength. They were protected from the Central Plains states by the Yellow River and by mountain ranges pierced by only a few easily defensible passes. Qin was close enough to the Central Plains to be part of the Huaxia culture, yet removed enough to preserve its independence.

The Wei Valley was a productive area. The land was fertile and could be made more so by diverting water from the Wei River for irrigation. Its location on the periphery of the Zhou world also meant that it had a hinterland into which to expand: the even more productive kingdoms of Shu and Ba in Sichuan.

As a part of the Huaxia cultural world, Qin shared in the broad trends of the Eastern Zhou: the introduction of iron farm tools, the decline of feudalism, the developing commandery-prefecture system of territorial administration, the cash economy, the growth of centralized bureaucracy, and the proliferation of moral and political philosophies. As we have discussed, all the Warring States adopted the Legalist style of government. The man responsible for Qin’s Legalist system was Shang Yang, also known as Lord Shang or Gongsun Yang. Originally from the neighboring state of Wei, he went to find his fortune in Qin in 361 BCE. As an advisor to Duke Xiao of Qin, Lord Shang

recommended revising the law, arguing that “Wise men make laws, stupid men are constrained by them.”¹ His reforms, initiated in 359 BCE, remade Qin and contributed substantially to its strength.

Under Shang Yang’s new laws, Qin’s families were registered in groups of ten for mutual surveillance and mutual responsibility. Commoner families with more than two sons had to send the other sons off to establish independent, taxable households. Feudal estates were not completely eliminated (Shang Yang was himself granted a fief, Shang, thus becoming ennobled as Lord Shang), but the power of the nobility was severely limited by dividing the bulk of the land into prefectures administered by appointed officials.

One of Lord Shang’s purposes was to stimulate agricultural productivity. Therefore, the laws required local officials to file regular reports on rainfall and the state of the harvest and to maintain huge granaries in which tax grain was stored. Merchants and artisans were viewed with suspicion and relegated to the lower rungs of the social hierarchy. Like families, merchants were organized into groups for mutual surveillance, with the chief of each group required to inform the authorities of any illegal acts committed by group members. Special officials managed markets and inspected weights and measures to make sure that they conformed to government standards. All this did not prevent the growth of a cash economy, nor did it prevent some merchants from becoming rich and, occasionally, gaining political power.

Were the laws of Qin unusually severe? Historians differ on this question. Some say that Lord Shang carried out the Legalist agenda more thoroughly and more brutally than had been done anywhere else.² Others find nothing exceptionally cruel about the Qin laws. They certainly did use judicial mutilation (cutting off of feet and noses) and capital punishment. Torture was employed to gain confessions, although confessions obtained without torture were considered to be more reliable. Heads of families could ask the state to punish obstreperous slaves or disobedient sons. Whether this was unusually cruel for the times is debatable; and the laws may have had good as well as bad effects for commoners. The Han-dynasty historian Sima Qian suggests that the cruelty of the laws was the cause of Qin’s downfall in 206 BCE, but he has this to say about the immediate effects of Lord Shang’s reforms:

By the time the laws had been in effect for ten years, the people of Qin were delighted. No one picked up objects dropped on the road, the mountains were free of robbers and bandits, and each family had enough of what it needed. The people were brave in public warfare and fearful of private vendettas. Profound order prevailed in the hamlets and towns.³

When Duke Xiao died in 338 BCE, Lord Shang’s enemies at court accused him of plotting rebellion. With his patron dead and nowhere to turn, Lord Shang had no choice: he did rebel and was killed in battle; his body was then torn apart by chariots, and his family exterminated. Although he died a rebel against Qin, Lord Shang left a significant legacy. The new ruler and all subsequent rulers of Qin continued to administer the state with his laws.

The Legalist system was designed to make efficient use of people, land, and other resources, to put them in the service of a strong state and a strong army. To make the most of the system’s potential, Qin would have to acquire more land and more people. The easiest and most rewarding direction in which Qin could expand its territory was toward the south, into Sichuan.

Sichuan was the home of two independent kingdoms, Shu and Ba. The Central Plains culture of Shang and Zhou had certainly influenced these civilizations, but they remained distinct from the Huaxia culture, as can be seen in their art, in the great, tiger-decorated bronze drums of Ba, and in their rudimentary writing systems, which were entirely different from the writing system of the Central Plains.⁴

The state of Chu had been expanding up the Yangzi and Han River Valleys, encroaching on the territory of Ba in modern Sichuan. Qin, in the meantime, cut a road through the precipitous mountains that separated Qin from Sichuan. Then, in 316 BCE, Qin used this road to capture Shu and, soon afterwards, much of Ba. It took decades for Qin to consolidate its control over these territories, to build more roads linking them to Qin, and so to bring them more firmly into the sphere of the Huaxia culture. The investment paid off handsomely. Shu and Ba were a productive rear area supporting Qin’s ongoing wars with its neighbors on the Central Plains. Possession of Shu and Ba put Qin in an especially advantageous position vis-à-vis its major competitor for power, the Yangzi Valley state of Chu. Qin could now deprive Chu of the resources of Sichuan and was poised to float down the Han and Yangzi Rivers to drive Chu out of the middle Yangzi Valley, which it did in 278 BCE.

Possession of prime agricultural land in its home territory and in Sichuan gave Qin the resources needed to build a stronger state and army. Those resources were further enhanced by two irrigation systems. Between 277 and 267 BCE, Qin engineers diverted the Min River in Shu to irrigate farmland on the Chengdu Plain. This project, the Dujiangyan Diversion, was maintained and upgraded all the way through the 20th century and remains in use to

this day.⁵ In 246 BCE, work was begun on the Zheng Guo Canal, which irrigated around 465,000 acres (185,000 ha) of farmland in Qin's homeland, the Wei Valley.⁶

These, then, were the advantages of Qin: an efficient administration, an enviable geo-strategic location, and a lot of very productive irrigated agricultural land. Little wonder that the armies of Qin ate away steadily at the lands of their neighbors, even sweeping aside the last Zhou king in 256 BCE. Such was the inheritance of the man who would preside over Qin's unification of all the feudal states, and more: Ying Zheng, better known as Qin Shi Huangdi, First Emperor of the country of Qin.

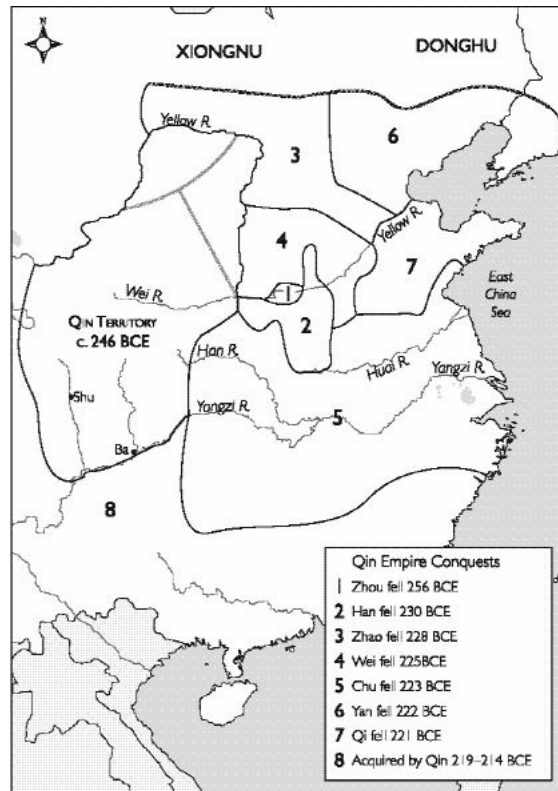
The Qin Empire and Qin Shi Huangdi

Ying Zheng inherited the throne of Qin at the age of fourteen in 246 BCE. His regent and prime minister, Lü Buwei, a former merchant, led the government, planning and executing a series of wars in which Qin took more and more territory from its neighbors. Lü also invited a number of scholars from the various states to serve on his staff and to compile a collection of writing representing the best of all the learning of the time. The work remains extant and is translated as the *Annals of Lü Buwei*.⁷

In 240 BCE King Zheng turned twenty and took control of his kingdom. Lü Buwei and his supporters were shunted aside, Lü committing suicide in 235 BCE. King Zheng appointed a man from Lü's staff to the post of chancellor: Li Si. Li Si and King Zheng created a unified realm bearing many of the characteristics that later dynastic states inherited: a centralized bureaucracy, led by a hereditary emperor, covering a territory roughly equivalent to China Proper and occasionally expanding into various parts of the Inner Asian periphery. Under their leadership, the remaining states of the Eastern Zhou world fell, one after the other: Han in 230 BCE, Zhao in 228 BCE, Wei in 225 BCE, Chu in 223 BCE, Yan in 222 BCE, and Qi in 221 BCE. In recognition of the significance of unification, King Zheng devised a new title that would reflect his status as a ruler more powerful than a mere king: Huangdi, emperor. He would be the First Emperor of Qin, Qin Shi Huangdi, with his successors as Second, Third, and so on for ten thousand generations.

Qin Shi Huangdi reigned as emperor for eleven years until his death in 210 BCE. The effects of those eleven years are still felt today. They include territorial expansion, measures designed to achieve cultural and economic as well as political unification, and a theatrical (not to mention expensive) style of rulership.

Qin's territorial expansion did not stop at the borders of the various Warring States. In the south, Qin Shi Huangdi's interest in opportunities for trade drove him to extend his rule into Guangdong and Guangxi and part of Fujian province. These were potentially productive areas, but it would be many centuries before they would realize their potential and become completely integrated into the Chinese economic and cultural world. In the north, General Meng Tian spent ten years (221–211 BCE) conquering the Ordos (the land within the great loop of the Yellow River), northwestern territories out to the Lanzhou region of Gansu province, and parts of Inner Mongolia.



[The expansion of the Qin Empire.](#)

These conquests in the north eliminated buffer zones between the world of settled Chinese agriculture and the pastoral nomads of the steppes. This would have serious consequences for future dynasties.⁸ On the emperor's orders, Meng Tian linked already existing fortifications on the northern borders together into a 3,000 mile (5,000 km) "Long Wall." This barrier later fell into disrepair, but it is the basis for the myth that the Chinese have always lived settled agricultural lives behind the Great Wall and taken a passive, defensive attitude toward their northern neighbors. As we shall see, some dynastic governments used walls in the defense of their northern borders, some did not, and many struck aggressively north and northwest beyond the limits of the agricultural world. The Great Wall that exists today, a Ming fortification, is constructed along a different route from the Qin wall.

Li Si and Qin Shi Huangdi realized that this huge empire could easily fall into pieces as the Zhou kingdom had. They took steps to prevent that from happening. Weapons (other than those of the imperial armies) were collected and melted down to cast huge bronze statues. The walls of the capital cities of the former feudal states were torn down. The empire was divided up into commanderies and prefectures, the people organized into groups for mutual surveillance and mutual responsibility.⁹ New roads and canals knit the empire together; colonists were moved to open up newly acquired, underpopulated land. If there was a single theme to Qin policy, it was standardization. Orders were issued requiring standardization of weights and measures, currency, and even the axle-gauge of carts. Qin also simplified and standardized the written language, establishing a single official system of Chinese characters for the empire.

In addition to the writing system, of course, Qin Shi Huangdi was interested in regulating what was written. In response to a Confucian scholar's recommendation that the First Emperor enfeoff his brothers and sons as the Zhou kings had done, Li Si is said to have responded with a vehement rejection of the idea and a critique of scholars who "study antiquity in order to criticize their own age" and who use their "private theories" to "criticize the laws and directives" and to mislead the common people with their teachings. His solution: destroy publicly circulating copies of the various philosophical writings, the texts that later generations called Confucian classics, and the histories of all the feudal states other than Qin. Books on useful topics such as divination, forestry, agriculture, and medicine were exempt from destruction, and even copies of the forbidden books were kept in the imperial archives so that the emperor's own scholars could read them.¹⁰

Qin Shi Huangdi acted on this recommendation. He is also said to have become so angry with some scholars who were criticizing him that he had 470 of them killed (some say buried alive). This is probably a story concocted in the Han dynasty as a part of Han historians' denigration of the Qin. Nonetheless, this story, along with the more reliable account of the destruction of the books, gave the First Emperor the reputation of a ruthless dictator who especially hated scholars and scholarship.

It is impossible to argue that the ruler who created a huge empire through a series of bloody wars was a kindly gentleman who practiced the virtues praised by Confucius. However, the First Emperor did support an "academy" of seventy scholars, some of whom were traditionalists. His laws were certainly not anything that Confucius would have approved of, but they were no harsher than those of the other states had been. The Qin laws—of which we have only piecemeal records—were actually a body of imperial statutes (*lǚ*) and ordinances (*ling*).¹¹ The Qin rulers issued these statutes and ordinances over a period of many decades as guidelines for local officials dealing with everything from agriculture and war to basic law and order. The laws reinforced the structure of the patriarchal family and extended privilege (such as the substitution of fines for corporal punishment) to the upper strata of Qin society. And because they were issued to deal with concrete problems as they occurred, the ordinances and statutes were marked by a high degree of precision. For example, the statutes concerning the Controller of Works stipulate:

When government storehouses loan government carts and oxen ... in case the borrower perhaps privately uses the government carts and oxen, as well as when the borrower does not feed the oxen well, and the oxen grow thin; if he does not repair the cart, or the cart is neglected, if the cart's shafts are crooked, as well as when the cart has not been covered, or of the carriage's hood or canopy has been violently broken or torn, the person in charge of the carriage as well as the official and the head of the office will have committed a crime.¹²

Violations of the statutes and ordinances were subject to punishments including death, hard labor (sometimes accompanied by mutilation such as amputation of the nose or of one or both feet), banishment, castration, and fines. Nonetheless, records of Qin Shi Huangdi's proclamations show that he represented himself as a ruler of virtue, one who supported filial piety, humaneness, righteousness, and good faith. In an interesting combination of Legalist severity and Confucian concern for the people, one inscription credited to Qin Shi Huangdi boasts: "The powerful and overbearing he boiled and exterminated; the ordinary folk he lifted and saved."¹³

Extermination of the powerful and the overbearing left Qin Shi Huangdi the most powerful and overbearing man in the empire. Vast amounts of resources and labor were spent on constructing his tomb, a lavish underground chamber with a model of the empire and the universe, flanked by enormous pits holding the famous ranks of terracotta warriors and other pits holding bronze acrobats and entertainers, boatmen and water birds. His capital city had palaces for the ruling families of the states that he had conquered (to keep them under guard) and his own palace complexes. He is said to have ruled from the shadows, secretly moving from one palace to another. Perhaps he feared assassination. He certainly had reason to: he had survived several attempts on his life during his years as king and emperor.



Detail of a terracotta warrior's head.

Qin Shi Huangdi died, apparently of natural causes (one theory has it that his taste for elixirs of immortality—which may have contained mercury—were the cause of his demise), at the age of forty-nine in 210 BCE while on the last of five extensive inspection tours of the empire. Already, cracks were beginning to appear in the imperial

edifice that he and Li Si had constructed. Social order was not good. Bandits had troubled even Qin Shi Huangdi on one of his tours in 218 BCE. In 216 BCE, it was said that robbers made it dangerous for him to move around the capital city at night. The price of grain in 216 BCE was at a shocking high of 1,600 cash coins for one *shi* (around half a bushel, or 19 liters).¹⁴ Perhaps the ambitious territorial expansion, construction projects, and imperial tours had overextended the empire's resources and put a strain on the economy.¹⁵

Whatever the underlying structural weaknesses of the still-young empire may have been, they were exacerbated by factional struggle at court. In the four years after Qin Shi Huangdi's death, bloody political struggles claimed the lives of his heirs, Prime Minister Li Si, and eunuch official Zhao Gao (d. 207 BCE) (none of whom were blameless in these sad events). As the drama of factional struggle unfolded at court (211–207 BCE), rebel forces arose and swept across the empire. The strongest of them closed in on the capital itself. It is to those rebels who we now turn, in the realization that “rebels who succeed are emperors; rebels who fail are bandits.”



Terracotta warriors.

From Qin to Han

As the *Annals of Lü Buwei* observe, “Those who conquer their enemies create great animosity.”¹⁶ It is hardly surprising that Qin faced numerous rebellions after scarcely a decade. Members of the ruling houses and other powerful old families of the feudal states that Qin had so recently defeated emerged as leaders of rebel forces.¹⁷ Of the rebel groups, the strongest were those of Xiang Yu and Liu Bang, both nominally under the leadership of the king of the newly resurrected state of Chu.

Xiang Yu and Liu Bang came from very different backgrounds. Many generations of the Xiang family had served the state of Chu as generals. Xiang Yu was a big, powerful aristocrat, trained in the art of war. Liu Bang was a poor, low-ranking Qin official, a village headman, with a fondness for drink and women. As village headman, Liu Bang was once assigned to take a group of men for forced labor on the First Emperor's tomb. So many men escaped en route that Liu Bang gave up, let the rest go as well, and fled into the swamps, where some of the men joined him. When rebellions broke out a year or so later, Liu and his followers joined forces with Xiang Yu, already asserting his claims to leadership.



Terracotta warriors.

Theoretically speaking, Liu Bang and Xiang Yu were both fighting on behalf of King Huai of Chu. In fact, they were competitors for power. Each man wanted to be the first to break through the passes into the Wei Valley and take the Qin capital of Xianyang. Liu Bang got there first. According to the histories (written during the Han, and thus biased against Xiang Yu), Liu Bang treated the people and the pitiful third ruler of Qin with kindness and courtesy. When Xiang Yu arrived with a much larger army, he was livid with anger. Liu Bang survived only by apologizing and turning the Qin capital and the Wei Valley over to Xiang Yu. Xiang Yu promptly killed the Qin king and slaughtered the people of the capital. He is said to have looted the First Emperor's tomb and burned the palaces (including the imperial library).

Xiang Yu divided up the empire into nineteen kingdoms, enfeoffing relatives and followers as kings and styling himself "overlord." Liu Bang, who was too powerful to ignore and too dangerous to trust, was enfeoffed as King of Han with the Han Valley and Sichuan as his kingdom. From his base in the Han Valley and with the men and grain of Ba and Shu behind him (as Qin had had in its conquering days), Liu Bang struck back at Xiang Yu. First he recovered the Wei Valley. Then he pursued and defeated his enemy on the Central Plains in 202 BCE. With only one brief interruption (9–24 CE), his descendants reigned as emperors of the Han dynasty until 220 CE.

As founder of the Han dynasty, Liu Bang—or Gaodi, as we shall now call him—followed the institutions of Qin. His capital, Chang'an, was in the Wei Valley near the ruined Qin capital of Xianyang. The laws and structure of his government were based on those of Qin, although the laws may have been applied in a less draconian fashion.¹⁸

Only in the matter of territorial administration did Gaodi depart significantly from the Qin model. Qin Shi Huangdi had divided the entire empire into commanderies and prefectures. Han Gaodi was inclined to do the same, but he owed too many favors. Some of his key allies were already in control of substantial territories that they ruled as kingdoms. Accordingly, in perhaps two-thirds of the empire (in the eastern side) Gaodi instituted eleven kingdoms ruled by family members. Lesser allies and Liu family members were enfeoffed as marquises with smaller territories. Gaodi and his successors progressively reduced the autonomy and number of these kingdoms and marquisates, but they remained a part of the Han system until the end of the dynasty.

In foreign affairs, the new Han Empire acquired Qin's border problems along with its territory. In the far south (Guangdong and Guangxi), a local leader named Zhao Tuo took over and ruled as King of Nanyue. Gaodi recognized Nanyue as an independent state. In the north (modern Mongolia), the nomadic Xiongnu were unified under a new leader, or *shanyu*, Maodun. To prevent attacks, Han sent Maodun a Chinese princess and began to give the Xiongnu regular gifts.¹⁹

Gaodi died from a wound received in battle in 195 BCE. He had established an empire that was to be ruled by his clan, the Liu. However, for the next fifteen years, his heirs reigned, but did not rule. The empire was in the hands of Gaodi's wife, Empress Dowager Lü.

Women and Power

China's official historians traditionally portrayed women in politics as wicked creatures. In doing so, they encourage us to think of women as either submissive victims of patriarchy or as cunning, merciless rebels against it. The truth is more complicated and more interesting. Certainly, by our standards, Han men were privileged and women subordinate. The Chinese of the time were strictly monogamous, for example, but this meant that a man could have only one official wife at a time (usually chosen by his parents), but he could also have as many concubines as he could afford. As for the one wife, the marriage was arranged, the wife generally left her natal family to live with her husband's family, she was only to have one husband at a time, and she certainly was expected to obey her mother-in-law!

However, as the power of the mother-in-law suggests, women were not simply women: they were daughters, sisters, wives, concubines, daughters-in-law, mothers, mothers-in-law, and so on. Their behavior was conditioned by the roles that they were expected to play within the family, just as men's choices were conditioned by their roles as sons, husbands, brothers, and fathers. Three aspects of women's roles are important in helping us to understand how Empress Lü exercised the powers of an emperor. First, marriage did not cut off a woman from her natal family. Marriage was a contract between two clans, and the wife was the living connection between them. Wives could mobilize the resources of their natal family to assist their husbands' families or vice versa. Second, mothers

commanded a great deal of respect and obedience from their sons. Third, when a man died and there was no male heir of adult age, the wife could take on the decision-making role of the male head of the household and was the natural person to choose who the heir would be, if that choice had not already been made.

Empress Lü's roles as wife of the late emperor and mother of the heir gave her tremendous power. She dominated her son, Emperor Hui (r. 195–188 BCE). After he died, she put first one, then a second infant on the throne. For fifteen years, until her death in 180 BCE, Empress Lü exercised the powers of an emperor. She appeared openly in court, had imperial seals carved for herself, and issued decrees in her own name. She used her power to place men of her Lü clan in important positions in the government and the army and as enfeoffed kings. She also forced several enfeoffed kings of the Liu clan to take Lü women as their wives. She is said, perhaps untruthfully, to have advanced the interests of the Lü not only by such peaceful means, but also by arranging the assassinations of a number of men, women, and children of the Liu and other clans who stood in her way.

Many men gained power through their family connections or were cut off from it by having no connections, but within family and political institutions, the only way women could gain power was through their roles as wives and mothers, and the only way they could hold onto power was to bring reliable men from their own clan into the government, especially as military commanders, a role that women could only rarely play. As for assassinations, history holds many examples of men as well as women killing rivals and potential rivals in order to get and hold power. The real question is not whether or not Empress Lü gained and held power by being cruel and stacking the government with her clansmen, but what kind of a ruler she was.

In foreign affairs, Empress Lü was not successful. During her years in power the empire suffered invasions from the Xiongnu in the north and the kingdom of Nanyue in the south. In domestic affairs, however, the Han historian Sima Qian, who records Empress Lü's alleged brutality in excruciating detail, has this to say:

Empress Lü, although a woman ruling in the manner of an emperor, conducted the business of government without ever leaving her private chambers, and the world was at peace. Punishments were seldom meted out and evildoers grew rare, while the people applied themselves to the tasks of farming, and food and clothing became abundant.²⁰

Empress Lü had put many members of her clan into power, but in the final analysis, she was their patron and protector. When she died, members of the Liu clan and their supporters in the bureaucracy and the military ousted the Lü from power, dethroned and killed the infant emperor whom Empress Lü had appointed, and installed an adult son of Gaodi as emperor in his place. The reign of Empress Lü was over, but it became a standard example of the power that a consort and her clan could acquire and was long cited as a case of an evil state of affairs that should be avoided. It also demonstrates a simple fact about emperors: they reigned, but there was no need for them to rule. A male of the Liu clan needed only to play the ceremonial role of emperor. His high-ranking officials, or his mother, grandmother, aunt, elder sister, or an appointed regent, could make the major decisions of state.

Emperor Wu, the Xiongnu, and the Silk Road

Emperor Wu (or Han Wudi) ascended the throne in 141 BCE. His two predecessors had strengthened the central government, weakened the kings and marquises, and accumulated a healthy surplus of grain and cash. This set the stage for Wudi's reign, which was characterized by territorial expansion, activist government, and intellectual creativity. Wudi himself never led troops in battle, and it is an open question as to what role, if any, he played in devising and carrying out the policies for which his fifty-four-year reign is famous.²¹ Whatever the case, Emperor Wu's government pursued a strong forward policy with regard to border affairs and the development of overland trade to Central Asia along the Silk Road.

The Xiongnu were the central problem of the time. These nomadic pastoralists in Mongolia stood astride the trade route to Central Asia and were a constant threat to the peace and security of the northern frontier. In 209 BCE, three years before the founding of the Han dynasty, a Xiongnu leader or *shanyu* named Maodun brought the fractious Xiongnu tribes together in a confederacy. As the Han consolidated their empire, so too did the Xiongnu, advancing into the Gansu corridor and Central Asia.

From the time of the founder Gaodi up until Wudi's reign, the Han had tried to pursue a policy of "harmonious kinship" toward the Xiongnu. Han princesses were given to the Xiongnu ruler, or *shanyu*. Treaties were signed

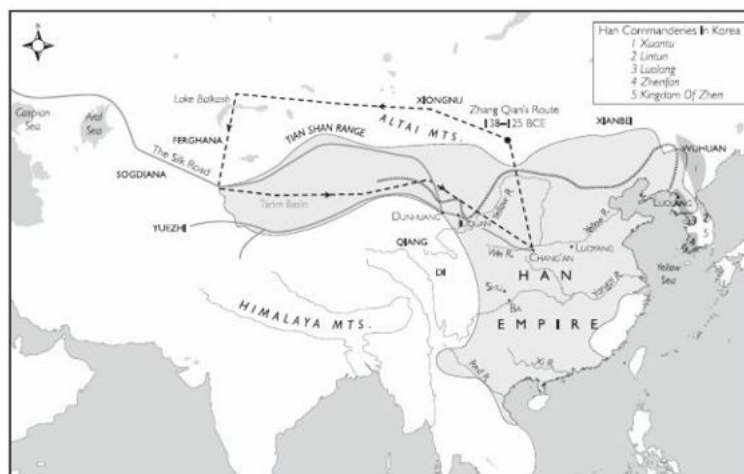
requiring the Han to give the Xiongnu lavish gifts of silk, alcoholic beverages, rice, food, and other goods several times a year. In return, the Xiongnu were supposed to stay on their side of the Qin Long Wall. It did not work. Relations along the frontier veered between trade (in which the Xiongnu were very interested) and invasions (which the Xiongnu mounted when they couldn't get what they wanted by trading). The "harmonious kinship" policy was "both costly and ineffective."²²

Under Emperor Wu, the Han pursued an aggressive policy toward the Xiongnu. An emissary, Zhang Qian, was sent in 139 BCE to the Central Asian kingdoms lying to the west of Han and Xiongnu territory in an attempt to win allies. Zhang returned around 126 BCE, reporting that none of the kingdoms were interested in an alliance against the Xiongnu. However, he did bring back a wealth of information about the trade routes, products, and political situation of the Central Asian kingdoms, which would prove useful later. Military victories over the Xiongnu between 127 and 119 BCE prepared the way for Han expansion into the Western Regions. A second mission by Zhang Qian, probably starting around 115 BCE, and both diplomatic initiatives and military campaigns in the area allowed Han to bring its presence and strength to bear far into the Western Regions.



Zhang Qian leaving Emperor Wu (Han Wudi) for an expedition to Central Asia. Detail of a wall painting in the Dunhuang caves.

It is hard to overstate the significance of Han expansion into Central Asia that begun during Wudi's reign. Chinese merchants followed Zhang Qian's lead and began to ply the trade routes to the Western Regions, exporting silk and other Chinese goods, which they exchanged for horses, other livestock, and luxury goods. This traffic along the Silk Road ultimately brought some Chinese silks from one trader to the next until they reached the Roman Empire, where it is said that they were so popular that bankruptcy threatened the capital. As for the defeated Xiongnu, their unity was shattered, and they were brought into a new framework of foreign relations: the tribute system. Under this system, Xiongnu emissaries would be sent on regular missions bearing tribute to Han emperors. The emperor would in turn bestow gifts to be taken back to the Xiongnu leaders. The highest point of Han-Xiongnu relations came in 51 BCE with a state visit that the *shanyu* paid as an honored guest of Xuandi (r. 74–48 BCE).



[The Western Han Empire.](#)

Territorial expansion and trade were not confined to the Western Regions. Under Emperor Wu, Han administrative organs were established to the south in Guangdong, Guangxi, and Annam (northern Vietnam); to the southwest (Yunnan); and to the northeast (the Korean peninsula). As with the Western Regions, trade was a major impetus for expansion into the south. Overseas trade centering on a port near modern Guangzhou brought Chinese silk to India, from where some of it reached the Roman Empire. Slaves were imported from overseas to Guangdong, and there was a brisk trade in enslaved women and boys on the overland routes from the southwest.²³

Economics and Philosophy

Chinese and Central Asian merchants profited enormously from Emperor Wu's extension of Han territory and control of trade routes. However, wars, the tributary system, and the need to defend distant frontiers put a serious strain on government finances. The surplus that Wudi inherited was quickly exhausted, and tax revenue fell short of expenses. The leading officials and scholars of the empire offered different approaches to the administrative and fiscal challenges facing an overextended government. Officials including Sang Hongyang (152–80 BCE) advocated policies inspired by the Legalist example of Qin. Scholars such as Dong Zhongshu (179–104 BCE) argued in favor of a moral restoration based on the teachings of Confucius, although their views were modified by the acceptance of many Legalist and Daoist ideas.

Sang Hongyang's approach to government owed much to his merchant family background.²⁴ Instead of simply raising taxes, Sang got the imperial government into business. He set up profitable state monopolies on salt and iron, staffed them with experienced merchants, and used conscript and convict labor in order to cut costs.²⁵ He established an "equitable marketing system" in which the government would stabilize prices by purchasing basic commodities such as grain when the price was low and selling when the price was high.²⁶ In these respects, Sang Hongyang's approach called for active state intervention in the marketplace. One area in which he did not favor government intervention was in the matter of land ownership. Land was privately owned. Wealthy families tended to accumulate large landholdings at the expense of poorer people. As far as Sang and other officials were concerned, it did not matter how much land a family owned as long as they paid taxes on it.²⁷

Scholars like Dong Zhongshu had both moral and practical objections to Sang Hongyang's economic activism and his tolerance for a free market in land. In a memorial to Emperor Wu, Dong drew on an idealized vision of the Zhou dynasty to argue that when the "well-field" system was in place, taxes were low, the people only had to do one day's corvée labor a year, there was plenty of food, and thus everyone "took delight in obeying their rulers." All that changed, Dong said, when Qin allowed people to buy and sell land: "The rich bought up great connecting tracts of ground, and the poor were left without enough land to stick the point of an awl into."²⁸ Accusing Han of having followed the bad example of Qin, Dong suggested limits on land ownership,²⁹ an end to the iron and salt monopolies, abolition of slavery, tax reduction, and a return to peaceful relations with the Xiongnu.³⁰

Dong Zhongshu's political position was part of a larger syncretism which combined the moral philosophy associated with Confucius, the laws and bureaucratic management techniques of the Legalist scholars, and some elements of Daoist correlative thinking. Chinese had long seen correlations between natural phenomena and human society. Dong took this a step further to construct a theoretical understanding of the universe in terms of correlative pairs such as Heaven and Earth and yang and yin. One work attributed to Dong Zhongshu draws a series of correlations between the state and the human body. Just as the body derives its energy from the circulation of *qi* (energy or vital essence), so the state owes its vitality to the worthy men who serve as its officials. Just as the blood and *qi* support each other in the body, so the superiors and inferiors support each other in the state, each taking their respective places. Thus: "Those who regulate the state endeavor fully to develop their humility and thereby accumulate worthy and competent men."³¹

Dong placed special emphasis on the emperor's relationship to Heaven and his role as the one man who links Heaven, Earth, and Man. Clearly rejecting the Qin example and alluding to the Zhou, he explained that Heaven warns a ruler by sending forth unnatural phenomena as portents. "The source of all portents," he wrote, "lies in faults that exist within the state."³² Dong's theory of portents gave officials in the Han and later dynasties a powerful tool: they could point to disasters or flukes of nature (such as the birth of a two-headed sheep) in order to justify their criticisms of government policy or of the emperor himself.

Dong's correlative cosmology also had long-term implications for the status of women. He portrayed Heaven,

yang, and male as strong and exalted; Earth, yin, and female as base, humble, and yielding. The hierarchy of yang and yin, the hierarchy of male and female, and the hierarchy of husband and wife were seen as a natural part of the Way of Heaven. This helped to strengthen gender hierarchy by making it natural, and thus unquestionable.³³

During Emperor Wu's reign, a few steps were taken to choose officials trained in the ethical precepts of Confucius, as Dong Zhongshu and some others recommended. Certainly, the court preferred to base government on texts associated with Confucius rather than on the writings of the realistic and perhaps materialistic men on whose principles the Qin Empire had been based, or on the mystical ideals associated with Laozi (and much appreciated by Wudi's own grandmother). But it was only after Emperor Wu's death that protests such as those that Dong Zhongshu and others made against Wudi and Sang Hongyang's activist domestic and foreign policies began to take effect. The most notable record of these criticisms, and of the court's response, is the record of a debate between government officials and critical scholars held at court in 81 BCE.

In this "Debate on Salt and Iron," the government spokesman (probably Sang Hongyang) laid forth justifications for the state monopolies and the equitable marketing system: The government needs to protect the people from the Xiongnu. Defense requires resources, and the state monopolies generate those resources. The equitable marketing system prevents merchants from hoarding goods and gouging the public by evening out prices and gives the government a reasonable profit as well. To discontinue these measures would leave Chinese soldiers cold and starving and put the people at the mercy of rapacious merchants.³⁴

The scholars responded that the Han Empire should live at peace with its neighbors and remain within its traditional boundaries. By being involved in monopolies and trade, the imperial government was lowering itself to the level of a petty merchant, pursuing profit and setting a bad example for the people. The people would abandon agriculture to seek their fortunes in trade, thus causing a decline in grain production, which would lead to a decline in national wealth. The scholars added that the iron tools produced by state ironworks were of poor quality, that the officials managing the equitable marketing system connived with dishonest businessmen to exploit the people, and that the government was following the same immoral Legalist ideas that had led Qin to ruin.³⁵

Although there was little change in economic policies, the scholarly reformists seem to have won the debate and exercised increasing influence in government. In foreign affairs the Han pursued a cautious policy of consolidation and retrenchment from perhaps 80 BCE onward. The breakup of the Xiongnu confederacy into two feuding branches, north and south, was a boon to the Han. The southern Xiongnu, in Inner Mongolia, pursued peaceful relations with the Han Empire in order to strengthen their position against the northern Xiongnu. This made the policy of retrenchment and peaceful relations possible. Huhanye, the southern Xiongnu *shanyu*, came to the Han court to pay tribute in 51 BCE and was treated with the honors due to a king.³⁶

In domestic policy, the reformists drew ostentatiously on the Zhou classics. Han emperors abandoned Qin rituals and worshipped Heaven and Earth in the style of Zhou.³⁷ Officials reduced punishments, simplified the laws, and urged emperors (with some success) to set a good moral example by cutting back on court luxuries. In a celebrated victory, the scholarly reformers, who revered Confucius, abolished the Office of Music, which, they said, performed base and licentious tunes. The reformers could not, however, do away with the salt and iron monopolies: the loss of revenue was too much to bear.³⁸

Rural Poverty, Great Houses, and Court Politics

The reformers had gained a strong voice in government, but theirs was not the only voice, nor were they able to make Western Han society or the imperial family conform to their moral standards. In criticizing the social reality of their times, however, the scholars articulated ideals that would become influential in later generations.

As the traditional-minded scholars saw it, the ideal society was composed of extended patriarchal families (clans) in which each individual fulfilled his or her role within hierarchies of age and gender that put unquestionable authority in the hands of elder males. The empire as a whole was seen in similar hierarchical terms: the imperial family, officials, and commoners each had their roles to play. Commoners were further divided into four categories: scholars, farmers, artisans, and merchants.

There were some fundamental clashes between these ideals and Western Han reality. The reformers, for example, were against widows remarrying, women engaging in commerce, women initiating divorce, and women being involved in government. Nonetheless, all those things were widely accepted parts of life in the Western Han.³⁹ The four categories were recognized as such in theory, but to list them in hierarchical order as scholar, farmer, artisan,

merchant was a pious hope and moral judgment, but not an accurate description of society. Han society was a good deal more complicated than the four-category system would have it. Imperial officials and scholarly reformers were aware of this discrepancy between ideals and reality and regretted it deeply.

In theory, the scholars and officials themselves were the highest ranking of the four categories. In practice, scholars could be rich or of modest means, but no matter what their financial assets, they were legally the superiors of merchants and could become officials.

Merchants stood at the bottom of the moralistic hierarchy because they neither produced food nor made useful items, but simply bought and sold. Despite suffering moral disapprobation, merchants could be men of great wealth and influence. Of course, not all merchants were rich, but in general, they were better off than artisans, and artisans were better off than farmers. Men of merchant families were legally barred from holding office. This law was, of course, violated from time to time. In any event, merchant houses could overcome their political weakness by making mutually profitable alliances with scholars and officials.

Scholars and officials often expressed resentment at the wealth and power of the merchants and lamented the poverty of the farmers. Righteous anger in the face of social injustice was a stock theme in prose and poetry. For example, the official Chao Cuo, writing in 178 BCE, expressed his concerns this way:

[E]ven though their [the merchants'] men neither till nor weed, and their women neither rear silkworms nor weave, they wear only variegated silk and eat only good grain and meat. They do not suffer the hardships of the peasant, but they enjoy the products of the land. By means of their wealth they associate with kings and marquises. Their power surpasses that of the officials. They compete with each other in wealth.⁴⁰

It is notable that during the Western Han, farmers may have sunk into poverty just as agriculture was becoming more efficient and productive. During the Western Han (and continuing into the Eastern Han period), Chinese agriculture became more intensive. There was no more broadcasting of seed, for example. Fields were now planted in patterns to make irrigation and weeding more efficient. Farmers selected seed to produce better crops, improved the soil through crop rotations, manures, and leguminous cover crops, and used more and better iron tools. They used land more efficiently by multicropping, mixing crops, and growing vegetables on marginal land.⁴¹ Increased yields supported an estimated 1.6 percent annual population growth as well as supporting the officials, merchants, scholars, soldiers, and other non-food producers.

With increasing production, why did more and more farmers fall into poverty and lose their land? The average independent farming family cultivated about 33 acres (13 ha) of land. In theory, they paid about one-thirtieth of the average estimated yield of their land in land tax every year, no matter what the actual crop was, but often the tax was much more. They were also responsible for poll taxes, miscellaneous taxes, and corvée labor.⁴² If anything went wrong—a bad year, illness, death in the family, natural disaster—they would be forced to borrow money or grain at high interest with their land as security, or to sell their land outright. They would then become tenants paying fifty percent of their crop as rent.⁴³ In theory, farmers could become officials, but in practice, they had no access to education. The only escape from rural poverty was to become a bandit, a thief, an artisan, or a merchant.

The distress of the farmers represented economic opportunity to the great houses of the land: descendants of the pre-Qin feudal aristocracy, Han imperial relatives enfeoffed as kings or marquises, and high-ranking officials. These were all families who had parlayed political connections into material wealth in the form of landed estates. They also invested in business enterprises. Wealthy merchants joined the ranks of the landed elite by investing their business profits in property. These powerful families had access to education, officeholding, and even to the emperor himself.

The emperor was theoretically at the apex of all hierarchies: the “solitary man,” the Son of Heaven, pivot of Heaven, Earth, and Man, the high priest of the empire. Anyone who showed disrespect or disobedience could be punished, as in the case of a drunken marquis who sang during a sacrifice at the imperial temple and was sentenced to commit suicide for the offense of “great disrespect.”⁴⁴ Emperors did not, of course, run the empire by themselves. They were assisted and in some ways restricted by a whole body of officials who controlled the administration.



Detail from a silk banner with a painted design of a sacrificial offering to the deceased, excavated from a tomb at Changsha, Hunan Province.

These included some thirty thousand officials in the central government: the chancellor and ministers with specialist responsibilities, and some hundred thousand in the commanderies and fifteen hundred counties of the empire. These men had earned their positions in the civil service on the strength of their scholarship or their moral reputation and had either been recommended by other scholars or officials or (in a minority of cases) had passed some form of testing. In their roles as advisors, policymakers, and administrators, highranking imperial officials could and often did exercise significant influence and control over the actions of emperors.

These officials bore the titles of their respective offices in the duly established organs of government, such as “Director of the Great Granary” and “Chancellor,” and enjoyed the salaries appropriate to their ranks. In addition, there were those men who had been given honorary titles such as “Palace Attendant” or “Marshal of State” who served as personal assistants and advisors to an emperor. In time their position was regularized and they became members of a “Secretariat” which could at times make decisions independently of the established officials, including the chancellor. In addition, the emperor was often advised or overridden by empresses, empresses dowager, and, in time, eunuchs. None of these people could perform a mature emperor’s ritual functions for him: there could be only one Son of Heaven, one man playing the role of emperor, from whom all authority flowed. Often enough, the most powerful people in Chang’an were the imperial consorts and their families.

There was, of course, considerable competition among imperial women for the position of empress and mother to the heir apparent. Like any husband, the emperor could have only one official wife or empress at a time, but he could demote his empress and promote another consort to that post if he chose to do so. In some notorious instances, serving empresses were known to assassinate or arrange for the assassination of rivals and of the male children of rivals in order to maintain their position.⁴⁵ As we have seen in the case of Empress Lü, imperial consorts also worked to get the men of their natal families ennobled and appointed to key posts in the bureaucracy and the military. Empresses dowager were able to choose the next emperor from the many sons, brothers, nephews, and cousins of the Liu imperial clan. They often chose men (or better yet children) who could be easily controlled. Powerful men who were not heirs to the throne but desired to manipulate imperial power used the same techniques. In addition, as we shall see, heirs and also the uncles or brothers of heirs could use illegitimate and bloody means to gain the throne.

The manipulation of emperors was a dangerous game. If a consort fell out of favor with an emperor, her family would be thrown out of power. When a powerful woman such as Empress Lü died, rivals would quickly attack her family members. Later on, competition between Wudi’s Empress Wei and her rival, the concubine Lady Li, led to five days of pitched battles in the streets of Chang’an. Thousands were killed, and in the end both the Wei and Li clans were nearly wiped out. Emperor Wu himself stayed safely out of the city in his summer retreat until the violence was over.⁴⁶

The powerful great houses of the Western Han participated in these struggles to control the throne, often marrying daughters into the imperial family as an investment. And so it was that in the ninety-two years following Emperor Wu’s death, the great families accumulated more and more land and more and more power. Overextended and short of resources, the imperial government pulled back from the dizzying heights of Emperor Wu’s activist and expansionist policies. Empresses dowager and men of their families managed the empire and enriched themselves in the process. Finally, in 9 CE, the inevitable happened. The leading members and supporters of an empress dowager’s clan decided that there was no need for the Liu imperial house at all. In a simple coup, Wang Mang, a

nephew of the Grand Empress Dowager Wang Zhengjun, took the throne as the first and only emperor of the Xin dynasty. The name itself, “Xin,” Chinese for “new,” represented new hopes for a new beginning.

Notes

1. Sima Qian, “The Biography of Lord Shang,” in Burton Watson, trans., *Records of the Grand Historian: Qin Dynasty* (Hong Kong: The Research Centre for Translation, Chinese University of Hong Kong, 1993), 92.
2. Steven F. Sage, *Ancient Sichuan and the Unification of China* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1992), 103.
3. Qian, “The Biography of Lord Shang,” 93.
4. Sage, *Ancient Sichuan*, 74–5.
5. Ibid., 148; Joseph Needham, *Science and Civilisation in China, Vol. 4: Physics and Physical Technology, Part III: Civil Engineering and Nautics* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1971), 288–9.
6. Derk Bodde, “The State and Empire of Ch’in,” in Denis Twitchett and Michael Loewe, eds., *The Cambridge History of China, Vol. 1: The Ch’in and Han Empires, 221 B.C.–A.D. 220* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1986), 46.
7. John Knoblock and Jeffrey Riegel, *The Annals of Lü Buwei* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2000).
8. Nicola Di Cosimo, “The Northern Frontier in Pre-Imperial China,” in Michael Loewe and Edward L. Shaughnessy, eds., *The Cambridge History of Ancient China: From the Origins of Civilization to 221 B.C.* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 892–3.
9. Bodde, “State and Empire of Ch’in,” 56.
0. Qian, *Records of the Grand Historian: Qin Dynasty*, 55.
1. The following draws on Michael Loewe, *The Government of the Qin and Han Empires, 221 BCE–220 CE* (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Company, 2006), 119–33; and Yongping Liu, *Origins of Chinese Law: Penal and Administrative Law in Its Early Development* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998), 202–7.
2. “Eighteen Ch’in Statutes,” A 74, in A. F. P. Hulsewé, *Remnants of Ch’in Law* (Leiden: Brill, 1985), 74.
3. Quoted in Bodde, “The State and Empire of Ch’in,” 76.
4. Bodde, “The State and Empire of Ch’in,” 89–90.
5. Ibid., 89; Sage, *Ancient Sichuan*, 155–6.
6. Knoblock and Riegel, *The Annals of Lü Buwei*, 337.
7. T’ung-tsu Ch’ü, *Han Social Structure* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1972), 162.
8. Michael Loewe, “The Former Han Dynasty,” in Twitchett and Loewe, eds., *Cambridge History of China, Vol. 1*, 123.
9. Loewe, “The Former Han Dynasty,” 127–8.
0. Sima Qian, “The Basic Annals of Empress Lü,” in Burton Watson, trans., *Records of the Grand Historian: Han Dynasty I* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1993), 284.
1. Loewe, “The Former Han Dynasty,” 153.
2. Ying-shi Yü, “Han Foreign Relations,” in Twitchett and Loewe, eds., *Cambridge History of China, Vol. 1*, 389.
3. Ying-shih Yü, *Trade and Expansion in Han China: A Study in the Structure of Sino-Barbarian Relations* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1967), 111.
4. Michael Loewe, *A Biographical Dictionary of the Qin, Former Han, and Xin Periods (221 BC–AD 24)* (Leiden: Brill, 2000), 462–3.
5. Michael Loewe, “Attempts at Economic Coordination,” in Stuart Schram, ed., *The Scope of State Power in China* (London: School of Oriental and African Studies, 1985), 253–6.
6. Loewe, *Biographical Dictionary*, 463.
7. Loewe, “Attempts at Economic Coordination,” 250.

8. Dong Zhongshu, quoted in William Theodore de Bary et al., eds., *Sources of Chinese Tradition, Vol. 1: From Earliest Times to 1600* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1999), 357–8.
9. Ibid., 358.
0. Loewe, *Biographical Dictionary*, 72.
1. Dong Zhongshu, “Chunqiu fanlu,” quoted in de Bary et al., eds., *Sources of Chinese Tradition, Vol. 1*, 297.
2. Dong Zhongshu, quoted *ibid.*, 305.
3. Bret Hinsch, *Women in Early Imperial China* (Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield, 2002), 157.
4. “Debate on Salt and Iron,” in de Bary et al., eds., *Sources of Chinese Civilization, Vol. 1*, 360–3.
5. Ibid.
6. Yü, *Trade and Expansion in Han China*, 44–5.
7. Loewe, “The Former Han Dynasty,” 207–8.
8. Ibid., 193–211.
9. Hinsch, *Women in Early Imperial China*, 43, 74, 86, 161.
0. Chao Cuo, quoted in Ch’ü, *Han Social Structure*, 339.
1. Cho-yun Hsu, *Han Agriculture: The Formation of Early Chinese Agrarian Economy (206 B.C.–A.D. 220)* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1980), 151.
2. Ibid., 152–3.
3. Ch’ü, *Han Social Structure*, 110.
4. Ibid., 69.
5. Hinsch, *Women in Early Imperial China*, 95.
6. Loewe, “The Former Han Dynasty,” 177–8.

Wang Mang's pious hope that his Xin dynasty would represent a new beginning was soon dashed. Within fifteen years, the Xin had fallen into a morass of famine, banditry, and rebellion. Liu Xiu, a scion of the old Han dynasty's ruling house, emerged from the chaos to establish the Eastern Han dynasty, which ruled from 25 to 220 CE.

Both Wang Mang and the rulers of the Eastern Han faced the same problems as the Western Han. Nonetheless, the Eastern Han saw considerable periods of peace and prosperity. The expanding agricultural economy supported a scholar-official elite whose accomplishments in literature, art, philosophy, and music built upon the achievements of their Western Han predecessors to produce cultural achievements that were so important in defining an elite cultural identity that the Chinese later came to refer to themselves as "Han people."

The cultural identity of the Han dynasty elite should not be taken to imply cultural homogeneity within the area that we refer to as China, or even in those parts of it that were incorporated into the imperial administrative structure or came under Han military influence. The southern, southwestern, western, and northwestern areas of the empire included vast regions inhabited by various ethnic groups who did not partake of the elite culture of the empire's political and economic center in the Yellow River Valley.

Nor did Han high culture or the Han economy develop in isolation from other parts of the world. Merchants plying the overland trade routes linking China with Central Asia, India, and the Mediterranean world exchanged Chinese silk and lacquer products for foreign art objects and other luxuries. By the late Eastern Han period, foreign influences and foreign religions, particularly Buddhism, had begun to enrich and transform Chinese culture—a process which would continue and strengthen in the centuries after the Han dynasty finally collapsed in 220 CE.

Wang Mang's Xin Dynasty

The fact that Wang Mang (45 BCE–23 CE) was able to take possession of the throne demonstrates both the power of imperial wives and mothers in the Han court and the limited roles within which they could wield power. Wang Mang was a nephew of the Grand Empress Dowager Wang Zhengjun. She appointed him to serve as regent for the last two Western Han emperors—both children whom she had placed on the throne. A woman like the grand empress dowager could be a kingmaker, but she could not be a king. Thus, imperial women entrusted the public roles of power-wielding to males of their own clan while they exercised power from behind the scenes. Members of the ruling Liu clan were not unaware of this, and struck twice against the Wang clan's arrogant manipulation of the throne. They were easily defeated both times, which seems to have persuaded Wang Mang and his supporters that the time had come to simply shove the Liu clan aside. Wang Mang took the throne as First Emperor of the Xin dynasty in 9 CE.

Although he had displaced the ruling family, Wang Mang largely followed patterns of government established in the Western Han.¹ His government faced the same problems as had the Western Han: the Xiongnu and other neighboring peoples, concentration of land ownership, rural poverty, and natural disasters. Wang Mang responded, on the whole, with policies modeled on those of the Western Han, while claiming that he was re-instituting the practices of the kings of Zhou.

Wang Mang was relatively successful at dealing with border problems. He mobilized over three hundred thousand men in the winter of 10–11 CE to prevent the Xiongnu from launching a major attack. In this instance and later, Wang Mang used a combination of defensive military actions and diplomacy to keep Xiongnu raids to a minimum and to maintain influence in the Western Regions. In the far west, he extended the realm at the expense of the Qiang

(Tibetan) people. In the east, he forced Koguryo in present-day Korea to acknowledge his authority.

In the domestic arena, Wang Mang was a failure. His goals were to use economic policies to address the interrelated problems of rural poverty, banditry, concentration of land ownership, and insufficient tax revenue. Wang Mang tried a number of initiatives to solve these economic problems. Currency reforms, three of which were essentially currency debasement, were carried out in 7, 9, 10, and 14 CE. He re-established state monopolies on salt, iron, and alcohol and introduced a state marketing system intended to stabilize the price of grain, silk, and fabric. As for land reform, Wang Mang tried to break the power of the great families. He ordered (in 9 CE):

Now at this time, let the land throughout the empire be designated “king’s fields” and slaves be called “private retainers.” Neither land nor slaves are to be bought or sold. Those families whose adult males do not number eight, but whose fields amount to more than one “well-unit” [in the “well-field” system described by Mencius] shall divide the surplus lands among their near relatives of the nine generations and the people of their townships and boroughs. Thus those who are without lands shall justly receive them according to this system.²

This edict on redistributing land and prohibiting slavery is the only instance in which Wang Mang’s policies depart significantly from the Western Han model. It met with strong resistance from the great houses and was cancelled in 12 CE. Wang Mang’s other reform policies also failed. The monopolies were ended in 22 CE because they were too difficult to administer in the midst of massive rebellions. The currency reforms were unpopular: counterfeiting and use of the older currency continued uncontrolled.

The Xin dynasty fell after fifteen years, not because of resistance to Wang Mang’s reforms, but for environmental reasons. The Yellow River changed its course somewhere around 3, 4, or 5 CE, and again in 11 CE. Both instances were major catastrophes in which large areas of land on the Central Plains, particularly around Shandong province, were flooded. Many farmers drowned. Many, many more lost their crops and homes. Famine, banditry, refugee migrations, and rebellions followed.

One of the rebellions began when a woman called Mother Lü sought revenge against a county official who had executed her son. Leading thousands of supporters, Mother Lü “stormed the county capital and beheaded the hated administrator.”³ Mother Lü soon died, but her rebels joined with others to challenge Wang Mang’s government. To identify themselves in battle, the rebels painted their foreheads red, and thus became known as the Red Eyebrows. As is so often the case in Chinese history, uneducated rural rebels like the Red Eyebrows brought a dynastic government to its knees, but it was members of the wealthy, educated elite who rode the wave of rural rebellion to power and established a new dynasty.

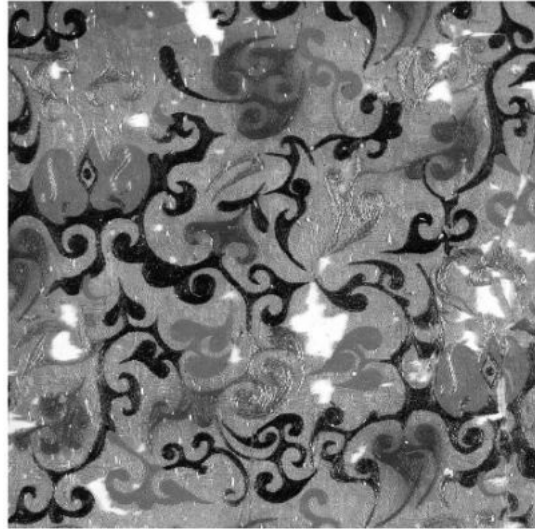
The Liu Clan’s Eastern Han Dynasty

As the Xin dynasty’s armies crumbled before the Red Eyebrows and other rebels, wealthy landowning families (who had their own armed retainers) saw an opportunity to re-establish social and political order on their own terms. A number of great families rallied around one Liu Xiu, a descendant of the Western Han emperor Jingdi (r. 157–141 BCE). As one powerful general from the northwest told Liu Xiu when joining him: “In present times, it is not only the sovereign who selects his subjects. The subjects also select their sovereign.”⁴ Liu Xiu, known as Guangwudi, took the throne of the restored Han dynasty on 5 August 25 CE.⁵ He and his supporters spent the next several years consolidating Han control over the empire.

Guangwudi chose the eastern city of Luoyang as his capital because of its access to the resources of the Central Plains and because when he first became emperor, he did not have enough military force to defend the Wei River Valley area where the old capital was located. Thus, his dynasty is conventionally referred to as the Eastern Han. Luoyang was a rectangular walled city almost 4 square miles (10 sq km) in area. Including the suburban districts outside the walls, the city was 9.5 square miles (24.5 sq km) with a population of around five hundred thousand. Within the walled city were two palace complexes, north and south, the imperial altar to the gods of soil and grain, government offices, granaries, storehouses, and a market. In the suburban areas were more markets, the altars of Heaven and Earth (south and north of the walled city, respectively), and other religious buildings.⁶

From Luoyang, the imperial government administered the realm through a centralized bureaucracy much the same as that of the Western Han. Around ninety-nine commanderies and kingdoms (both administered about the same

way) were subdivided into some fifteen hundred counties. Each county was run by a magistrate who, from his offices in the walled county seat, was responsible for all aspects of government. Government below the level of the county magistrate was in the hands of local officials who were appointed, or sometimes merely confirmed in their posts, by the county or provincial authorities.⁷



Detail of a Han dynasty silk brocade embroidered with the design of a phoenix among the clouds.

For ordinary farming folk, life went on without rapid changes in productive technology, food, clothing, or shelter. Technological change occurred throughout the Western and Eastern Han periods as a slow evolutionary process. Innovations such as iron tools, iron ox-drawn plows, brick-lined wells, and the seeding, weeding, fertilizing, and irrigation techniques of intensive agriculture spread slowly and steadily and became much more common by the mid- to late Eastern Han than they had been in early Western Han times. The iron plowshare was modified to have a smaller point and longer blade area in order to plow deeper and turn and break up the soil more thoroughly. New techniques for moving water from lower to higher fields included an endless chain of containers, driven by footpower, and a device using the siphon principle. These innovations appear to have contributed to increases in agricultural production.

In practice, it was the great landowning families, not the imperial government, who enjoyed the wealth created by China's increasingly productive farmers. As we have seen, great families emerged during the Western Han period. Great families were even more important in national and local affairs in the Eastern Han. Initially, this was because certain families helped Liu Xiu to take power and secure the empire. Later, their importance was linked to a decline in the power and effectiveness of the imperial government.

These "great families" were extended families of several generations living with hundreds or even thousands of retainers and slaves in compounds of many buildings on large estates worked by tenants from whom they collected rent. The most powerful of them were actors on the national stage. Most only dominated political life at the county or commandery level. Such families bribed or intimidated local officials to keep as much of their land as possible off the tax registers. It was great families, for example, who led resistance to the first Eastern Han emperor's attempt to survey all agricultural land. When repeated attempts to suppress resistance failed, Guangwudi was forced to compromise with the great houses—essentially suspending the effort to measure their property.⁸

Extensive (and lightly taxed) landholdings cultivated by dependent farming families made it possible for the great houses to support retainers, invest in commercial enterprises and moneylending, and educate their children. In the second century, as the imperial government lost its ability to provide disaster relief and maintain social order, local elites performed the role of government: "For the bulk of the population, local elites were the only significant wielders of power."⁹ We catch glimpses of the life and power of the great families of Han from the terracotta models of houses, watchtowers, and other buildings excavated from the graves of elite Han men and women.

The imperial government was aware of the problems posed by the power of the great families and their control of

land. The Eastern Han was characterized by technological innovation and increasing production on the one hand, and rural immiseration and central government weakness on the other. Technological innovation had increased agricultural productivity and led to an expansion of the cash economy. In industry, waterpower was harnessed to run bellows for metalworking and hammers for husking rice. Eastern Han craftsmen invented paper, made advances in the application of the Pythagorean theorem (which Western Han mathematicians had previously worked out) to astronomical problems, and invented a seismograph that showed the direction from which seismic tremors originated.¹⁰



Pottery palace of the Han dynasty, created for an elite burial.

While there is evidence of technological innovation and increasing wealth, it appears that many ordinary farming families were unable to afford the iron tools and other new techniques. For families who lived from harvest to harvest, natural disasters that wealthier folk could withstand brought poverty or death. The government tried to alleviate poverty by lowering taxes, by resettling landless farmers on state-owned land, providing grain to disasterstricken areas, and cancelling debts. Such measures were inadequate, especially in the second and third centuries, when the government simply did not have enough resources to provide relief for the victims of an increasing number of natural disasters.

Borders and Migration in the Eastern Han

The Eastern Han ruled over an empire which was retreating in the north, northwest, and west. At the same time, Chinese migration into the Yangzi Valley was beginning to transform the ethnic composition, the culture, and the economy of the south, incorporating it more firmly into the world of the empires ruled from the Central Plains.

In the far northwest along the Silk Road, the kingdoms of the Western Regions had slipped out of Chinese influence as the Xin dynasty collapsed. The Eastern Han general Ban Biao re-established such influence in 92 CE, bringing more than fifty states into the tributary system, but by the midsecond century, the area was again free of any form of Han domination.¹¹



Two gentlemen engaged in conversation while two others stand by. A painting on ceramic tile from a tomb near Luoyang, Henan Province, dated to the Eastern Han dynasty.

Closer to home, around 50 CE the Southern Xiongnu were allowed to settle permanently south of the Qin “Long Wall” in the Ordos region and bordering parts of Gansu and northern Shanxi. There, they became a semi-independent state within Han territory. They were incorporated into the tributary system, sending tribute missions and hostage princes to Luoyang. In return, the Eastern Han gave the Southern Xiongnu regular gifts of cattle, sheep, silk, rice, and other goods. The purpose of these subsidies was to secure Southern Xiongnu support in wars against the Northern Xiongnu.

This strategy succeeded for forty years: campaigns were indeed carried out against the Northern Xiongnu in 73 and 89 CE, and the borders were relatively peaceful. In the long term, however, defeat of the Northern Xiongnu freed two tribes they had dominated, the Wuhuan and Xianbei in the north and northeast, to become strong enough to pose a threat to the Eastern Han Empire. Indeed, during the reign of Han Emperor He (r. 89–106 CE), the Xianbei moved into Northern Xiongnu territory on the Mongolian plateau and absorbed over a hundred thousand Northern Xiongnu households.¹²

The western frontier was as unstable as the northern and northwestern areas. In the west, Han expansionism had brought the Chinese into direct contact, and conflict, with the Qiang, a people related to the later Tibetans. A Chinese official writing in 33 CE described the situation as follows:

Since the two peoples are different in social customs and cannot communicate in language, very often the petty Chinese officials and crafty people take the advantage to rob the Qiang of their belongings.

Extremely enraged and yet helpless, they thus rise to revolt. We can almost say that this is the cause of all barbarian rebellions.¹³

In fact, Qiang actions went beyond localized warfare. The Qiang fought extended wars with the Han from 107 to around 119 CE, 136 to 145 CE, and 159 to 161 CE. Qiang raids hit the Wei Valley and occasionally even parts of the Central Plains.¹⁴ The impetus for war was not merely “petty Chinese officials and crafty people” taking advantage of non-Chinese ethnic groups. The so-called “Qiang uprisings” in 185 and 187 CE, which threatened the old western capital of Chang’an, included disgruntled Han Chinese as well as ethnic Qiang people.¹⁵ Suppressing these uprisings was very costly, requiring the mobilization of hundreds of thousands of troops, which we can assume put additional pressure on farming families.¹⁶

Tension on the northwestern frontiers and the flooding of the Yellow River during the Xin and Eastern Han led to migration away from the northwest and the Central Plains as Han Chinese farmers left for the south, particularly Hunan, Jiangxi, and Guangdong.¹⁷ At first not many people migrated, but this was the beginning of a long process that by about 1000 CE would shift China’s population distribution and its economic center of gravity to the south, particularly to the Yangzi Valley and Guangdong.¹⁸ During the Eastern Han migration brought Chinese settlement to the river valleys of the south and caused non-Han people such as the Yue to fight against Han domination.¹⁹

History, Philosophy, and Morality

The scholars and officials of the Eastern Han period sought to explain the causes of instability and to point the way to better rulership and better public morals. Their writings on history and philosophy built on the foundations laid by their Western Han forebears while developing new insights in response to the issues of their day.

In a sense, the writing of Chinese history has its roots in the Shang oracle bone inscriptions, which recorded not merely questions and predictions, but also the outcomes of events. Some of these inscriptions reveal the kings’ failures, which suggests “a commitment ... to both genuine divinatory acts and genuine historical records.”²⁰ Eastern Han historians, of course, did not know about the long-buried Shang oracle bones. Instead, their models were the *Springs and Autumns Annals* and the Western Han historian Sima Qian’s *Records of the Grand Historian*. As discussed in Chapter 2, the *Springs and Autumns Annals* was a terse record of events taking place in the state of Lu. It was traditionally ascribed to Confucius, who was thought to have recorded events accurately and to have chosen his words carefully in order to indicate his moral judgment of the men, decisions, and events of the past. Writers of history were expected to record events faithfully, without trying to please the powerful; for only if

accurate could a record of events offer practical moral instruction to the rulers and ministers of present and future generations.

Sima Qian (145?–86? BCE) was the first great exemplar of the Chinese historical tradition. Sima's father, the court astrologer (whose duties included keeping a record of events), had begun writing a history of civilization from the times of the legendary Yellow Emperor. Sima Qian inherited both his father's position at the court of Wudi and his father's unfinished historical project. Before he finished, he angered the emperor by writing a memorial (a report to the emperor) in defense of a general who had been defeated and surrendered to the Xiongnu. Sentenced to commit suicide or submit to castration, Sima chose castration so that he could finish writing his historical work and thus fulfill his filial obligation to his father.

The completed *Records of the Grand Historian* is composed of five sections: "Basic Annals," "Chronological Tables," "Treatises," "Hereditary Houses," and "Memoirs." The "Treatises" covered subjects such as rites, music, the calendar, astronomy/astrology, state sacrifices, the Yellow River and canals, and the "Balance of Commerce" (economics).²¹ The "Memoirs" are short biographies of a variety of people, such as statesmen and officials, merchants, notable assassins, generals, and evil officials. The style of Sima Qian's work was didactic, its purpose to communicate the moral lessons of the past. In both its organization and its approach to history, the *Records of the Grand Historian* served as a model for all subsequent officially sanctioned Chinese historical writing.

The most notable historian living in the Eastern Han period was Ban Gu (32–92 CE). Ban's father had begun to write a continuation of Sima Qian's work, which had ended at 90 CE, intending to bring it up to the end of the Western Han. When he inherited this project, Ban Gu decided instead to write a separate complete history of the Western Han dynasty. At first, Ban Gu was briefly imprisoned for attempting, as a private person, to write an unauthorized history of the Han emperor's illustrious forebears. However, the emperor, impressed with the samples of Ban's writing submitted for his perusal, soon freed the historian and gave him an official appointment.

With imperial sponsorship and access to the imperial library, Ban Gu worked for twenty years on his history of the Western Han which was completed by his sister, Ban Zhao. The book remains a valuable source of information about the period. It was also a model for future historians: it became standard practice for each Chinese dynasty to employ scholars to compile and write a standard history of the previous dynasty. These dynastic histories, twenty-five in all, followed Ban Gu's example in taking their organizational structure from the *Records of the Grand Historian* and in combining historical records with Confucian moral judgment. Ban Gu, for example, offered the following critical assessment of Emperor Wu:

The expense of [Emperor Wu's] armies was measureless. [It was] so great that [the state's] income was insufficient, so [the emperor] monopolized [the manufacture] of intoxicating liquors, monopolized salt and iron, cast white metal [fiat money], created leather currency, exacted poll taxes even upon carts and boats, and taxed even domestic animals, so that the strength of the common people was used up and their wealth and supplies exhausted.²²

Writers like Ban Gu and his sister drew their philosophical position from the views expressed by the reformists of the late Western Han: the same tradition which, drawing on the scholarly example of Dong Zhongshu, had criticized Wudi's activist economic and foreign policies. Leaning on the idealistic concepts of the Western Han, Eastern Han scholars sought for ways to understand and live through what they perceived as unstable, dangerous, and morally bankrupt times: the contradictions between their ideals and the world in which they lived left them dissatisfied, bewildered, and disillusioned.²³

No Eastern Han philosopher was more disillusioned with and openly critical of the common beliefs of his time than Wang Chong (27–100? CE). Taking the position that the Way of Heaven is to act naturally and spontaneously, Wang Chong disparaged the notion that there is some mysterious relationship between the actions of emperors and natural phenomena.

Man holds a place in the universe like that of a flea or a louse under a jacket or robe, or of a cricket or ant within a hole or crevice. Can the flea, louse, cricket, or ant, by conducting themselves either properly or improperly, effect changes or movements in the ether that lies under the jacket or robe or in the hole or crevice?²⁴

In the case of strange phenomenon interpreted as omens and portents, which Dong Zhongshu had explained as messages from Heaven to the ruler, and in the case of the nearly universal belief in the existence of souls and ghosts,

Wang Chong rejected popular beliefs for which he saw no objective evidence. To those who idealized the Zhou, he responded that the Han Empire was bigger and better. He did believe in fate, but here too, his cynicism was evident. A man of relatively poor background who served only in a few low-ranking posts, Wang Chong declared that wealth, fame, success, and high official position had nothing to do with an individual's intelligence or morality: all such things were a matter of fate.

Wang Chong's writings are a striking example of the variety of opinions one can find in Eastern Han thought, but he is not representative of the intellectual mainstream. That mainstream (which ignored Wang Chong's polemics) drew eclectically on systems of thought known later under the very general terms of Confucianism, Daoism, yin-yang thought, and Legalism. Some men tended more toward the conservative Confucian side, others were more Daoist or Legalist in their orientation, but they all shared a moral position grounded in the Five Classics and the teachings of Confucius and enhanced by beliefs about the way of government and the Way of the universe derived from Legalism and Daoism.²⁵

Conservative Confucianism in the Eastern Han was very much a continuation of the trend established in the Western Han period. Moralists articulated ideals of proper thinking and behavior that were inspired by Confucius and stood in contrast and in reaction to the political and social realities of the times. There was certainly a lot for Confucians to react against in a dynasty in which women and eunuchs played leading roles in government. The reaction was to place great emphasis on strict observation of family morality as prescribed by Confucian ritual texts. The three years of mourning for a parent, for example, was re-emphasized, and great attention paid to the prescriptions for proper female behavior. The most famous Eastern Han scholar to write on the expected roles of women was Ban Zhao (48?–116? CE), sister of the historian Ban Gu, who finished his history at the emperor's request when Ban Gu died.

Ban Zhao was a highly educated widow from an elite family. At court, she not only worked on history, but also tutored a consort who later ruled as a regent, Empress Dowager Deng. Among Ban Zhao's writings was an essay entitled *Admonitions to My Daughters*, addressed to her daughters but perhaps meant for a wider audience of elite women. *Admonitions to My Daughters* is a prescription of women's subordinate roles in the family combined with an argument for female literacy. The text was written while Ban Zhao, as matriarch, was managing the careers and marriages of her husband's clan. A contemporary wrote that in the midst of one court controversy, "at word from Mother Ban, the whole family resigned."²⁶ Ban Zhao says that the husband's role is to control and the wife's to serve, and that as there can only be one Heaven, so a woman can only have one husband, who is to her as Heaven is to humankind. At the same time, she sees marriage as a complementary relationship in which there must be harmony. Man and wife must each play their roles, but men, she says, understand only their responsibility to control and to have authority. If women are to understand and perform their expected roles, then they must learn to read so that they can learn from the same ritual texts as men do.²⁷

In the first century, conservative followers of Confucius had at least some reason to hope that moral instruction could make the world a better place. The realm was relatively peaceful from 30 through 90 CE, and the emperors Guangwudi, Mingdi, and Zhangdi were praised for their moral cultivation. But as the century drew to a close, things began to fall apart. Educated gentlemen of the second and third centuries moved more and more in the direction of Legalist and Daoist approaches to government and life.

Some scholars and officials called for more rigorous use of laws and punishments to restore basic order and morality—which, from a Confucian point of view, could be justified on the grounds that social order benefits the common people.²⁸ In practice, local officials had little concern for imperial edicts, interpreting them and enforcing (or not enforcing) them as they wished.

Where some continued to preach Confucian moralism or advocated the use of Legalist rewards and punishments to reach Confucian moral goals, others adopted a so-called "Daoist" attitude. This included calls for moderate reforms that would have the emperor employing Daoist recluses in court or ask everyone to follow the dao and cultivate their moral virtue. Others simply decided not to meddle in the affairs of government. Toward the end of the Eastern Han, it became common for scholars to decline official posts and instead to remain quietly on their provincial estates minding their own, local affairs.²⁹

Daoist Thought, Religion, and Rebellion

While scholars took refuge in Daoist quietism, and some Han empresses energetically promoted Daoist texts as an

antidote to increasingly sexist Confucianism, ordinary people turned to a mix of religious beliefs inspired by the Daoist philosophers. Religious Daoism emphasized longevity, healing, and preserving the body and its vital essence (*qi*) through a combination of austerity, self-discipline, and meditative and calisthenic practices. Popular religious Daoism also incorporated many beliefs that were also part of elite culture: Heaven, filial piety, yin-yang, portents, and belief in Daoist sages who had become “immortals.” One particularly significant belief shared by elite philosophy and popular religion was the idea that change in the universe—and in human history—could be explained by the theory of the Five Phases.

Five Phases theory dates back to pre-Qin days. It holds that time is divided into eras, each dominated by one of five “phases” symbolized by wood, fire, earth, metal, and water. These phases were conceived of as following on and transforming one into the other, not as static elements. The Five Phases were correlated with other sets of (usually) five: seasons, colors, tastes, smells, directions, and many more. A few of the correlations are as follows:

Phase	Season	Color	Taste	Direction	Smell
Wood	Spring	Green	Sour	East	Goatish
Fire	Summer	Red	Bitter	South	Burning
Earth		Yellow	Sweet	Center	Fragrant
Metal	Autumn	White	Acrid	West	Rank
Water	Winter	Black	Salty	North	Rotten

During the Qin and Western Han, each Phase was thought to be defeated by the next in the cycle: fire-water-earth-wood-metal. The Xin and Eastern Han adopted the more humane belief that each Phase generates the next in the cycle as follows: wood-fire-earth-metal-water. Dynastic governments identified themselves with a Phase thought to represent their era. Qin may have been identified with water (color black). At first, the Western Han also took water as their Phase, then changed to earth (color yellow) in 104 BCE, only to decide later that Han had actually corresponded to fire (red) all along.

No matter what the choice, Five Phases theory suggests a cyclical view of history in which every dynasty will give way to another when its Phase generates the next Phase in the cycle. When this will happen is open to question, and thus subject to interpretation not only by government scholars, but more dangerously, by charismatic religious leaders.

Two charismatic Daoist religious movements troubled Lingdi’s reign (168–89 CE): the Yellow Turbans and the Five Pecks of Grain. The Yellow Turbans grew out of a Daoist healing tradition in the Central Plains. The leader, Zhang Jue (d. 184 CE), cured illnesses with a mysterious medicine that he dispensed from a gourd and by requiring the ill to confess their misdeeds. He built a following of hundreds of thousands in the 170s and early 180s CE, organized them into thirty-five units, and taught them that in 184 CE the world would enter a new historical era of Great Peace as the Phase of earth (color yellow) gained ascendancy. His followers included many local officials and scholars as well as farmers. As with many charismatic leaders, Zhang planned for a rebellion to help usher in the new era. The rebellion broke out simultaneously in sixteen commanderies south, east, and northeast of Luoyang in 184 CE.³⁰

During the same years, a man named Zhang Lu (unrelated to Zhang Jue) took control of the Five Pecks of Grain movement in the Hanzhong and northern Sichuan (Ba) areas. This organization required every member to donate “five pecks of grain or rice to his religious superiors, who in turn provided safety and cured disease by making the patient confess his sins.”³¹ Zhang Lu added Daoist religious teachings and used the movement to construct an administrative hierarchy with which he controlled Hanzhong and Ba.³²

These Daoist rebellions, particularly the Yellow Turbans, were too great a challenge for the incompetent regular imperial forces. (Zhang Lu, in Hanzhong, seemed content to simply run his own area and did not try to topple the dynasty.) The government organized new armies, new military commands, and new regional commissioners. These new forces defeated the Yellow Turbans in February 185 CE. A number of other rebel groups, inspired by and some even taking the name of the Yellow Turbans, sprang up over the next seven years, but all were suppressed. As they crushed these Daoist rebellions, the commanders of these new armies built their own independent power bases in the provinces. The imperial government had exchanged one threat for another. The provincial strongmen protested their loyalty to the dynasty, but they would be sorely tempted to intervene if they sensed any weakness, confusion, or factional struggle among the ruling elite in the capital.

Eunuchs and Warlords

Weakness, confusion, and factional struggle were the rule in Luoyang. Officials, eunuchs, the imperial clan, empresses and empresses dowager, and the men of their clans and military men all sought power: all understood that by controlling the person of the emperor himself, they would enhance and legitimize their power. Most of the Eastern Han emperors, accordingly, were pawns: only three (including the dynastic founder) took the throne as adult men; ten were chosen by empresses, empresses dowager, and their clans; and only six of the eleven child emperors of Eastern Han lived to adulthood.

One of the main themes of factional struggle was that of officials against eunuchs, but in fact, factions among the officials themselves contributed as much to the overall instability. The educated men of the great families and of lesser local elite clans competed with each other for a limited number of official posts. The most common routes to appointment and promotion were recommendation and patronage. Members of patron–client networks helped to promote each others’ moral ideals and practical interests at all levels of government. These patron–client networks easily developed into factions which competed for power and influence at the highest levels of government. Competing for power, the officials had to work cannily in the context of shifting alliances of various eunuch factions as well as generals, empresses, and empresses dowager and their families. One of the major lines of factional struggle was between eunuchs and the imperial family on the one hand and officials on the other.

Emperors, empresses, and empresses dowager were often on the side of eunuchs in their struggles against the civilian officials. At times, this was because emperors trusted eunuchs—their personal servants—more than they trusted officials, whose deep involvement with personal, family, and patronclient networks seemed to compromise their loyalty to the throne. Sometimes it was simply because eunuchs controlled the persons of the emperor and his family. In 125 CE, for example, a faction among the eunuchs placed the eleven-year-old Shundi on the throne, thus foiling the plans of Empress Dowager Yan and her clan, who had planned to install a different child. The leading men of the Yan clan were duly executed. Shundi rewarded the eunuchs who had helped him by granting them marquisates and allowing them to pass their noble titles and fiefs on to their adopted heirs.³³ In 159 CE, Huandi desired to eliminate the powerful Liang consort family, who had made him emperor at the age of fourteen and dominated him ever since. He turned to his eunuchs, who coordinated the capture and execution of the leading Liang clan members and their supporters.³⁴

During the reigns of Huandi (r. 146–168 CE) and Lingdi (r. 168–189 CE), the power of the throne and the eunuchs increased at the expense of the power of the officials, whom the emperors distrusted. The officials, who despised and feared the eunuchs, fought back. In 168 CE, a loose coalition of officials and military officers led by the empress dowager’s father, Dou Wu, planned to kill all the eunuchs. The eunuch leaders discovered the plot and moved with alacrity, mobilizing military forces loyal to the throne, whose interests they represented. Men originally on the side of the Dou clan surrendered, leaving Dou Wu no alternative but to commit suicide. Thousands of arrests and executions followed, and scholars even remotely connected with anyone involved in the plot were branded as “Partisans” and banned from public office. This in turn made it possible for the most powerful of the over two thousand eunuchs (whose ranks were also split into several competing factions) to fill administrative positions with their family members and friends.³⁵



Han dynasty pottery watchtower, made for placement in the tomb of a wealthy person whose family estate may have featured similar towers.

When Lingdi died in 189 CE, leaving two sons of thirteen and eight years of age, the predictable conflict broke out. Empress Dowager He placed the thirteen-year-old on the throne, but she and her half-brother, General-in-Chief He Jin, disagreed on what to do about the eunuchs. The empress dowager found them useful: they had supported her loyally in the past. He Jin and the other military commanders wanted to execute all the eunuchs—and there were thousands of them.

The eunuchs discovered He Jin's plot, trapped him, and cut his head off. Unfortunately for them, however, they had no support other than that of the empress dowager. Two generals from the field—regional strongmen—marched into Luoyang and slaughtered the eunuchs. Another general, Dong Zhuo, captured the thirteen-year-old emperor, deposed and killed him, and put the eight-year-old on the throne instead. This boy, Xiandi, was the last Han emperor, reigning from 189 to 220 CE. He spent the whole time under the control of various generals and rebels and abdicated his throne in 220 CE, thus bringing a formal end to the Han dynasty.

Culture and Han Chinese Identity

At the height of the Western Han, the poet Sima Xiangru (d. 117 BCE) described his patron, Wudi:

In this world there lives a Mighty One
Who dwells in the Middle Continent.³⁶

Long before, the Zhou had created the myth that the Central States, whose ruler held the Mandate of Heaven, extended their civilizing influence to the world. The Han, building on the brief but important legacy of the Qin, gave the myth of the Central States flesh and bone, extending their influence into Inner Asia, Korea, and south of the Yangzi even to Annam. In doing so, the Western and Eastern Han emperors presided over the development of a stronger and more unified elite cultural identity in China Proper than had existed in the Zhou. The very idea of a central government ruling over a unified empire had become an essential part of this culture and persisted even after the political institutions of the Han Empire had collapsed. This culture of the Han people was, of course, much more than just politics: it was expressions of laughter and love, friendship and enmity, wealth, status, and life and death. It was expressed and conveyed to future generations (and to foreign places) in poetry and prose, music, calligraphy, textiles, lacquerware, and sculpture.

One of the fundamental cultural acts of the Han dynasty was to reconstruct the classical texts of the Zhou period. The basic texts of scholarly tradition had been banned and destroyed during the Qin dynasty and—perhaps even more completely—in the wars between the fall of Qin and the founding of the Han. During the Western Han,

scholars wrote down the classics as recited from memory by older scholars. These versions came to be referred to as the “New Text” versions of the classics because they were written in the style of Chinese character current during the Han. In the late Western Han, alternative versions of a number of the classics appeared. These versions, said to have been discovered hidden in the walls of houses (including the walls of Confucius’ old home in Shandong province), were written in the archaic Chinese characters of the late Zhou, and thus were called the “Old Text” versions.

There were significant discrepancies between the New Text and Old Text versions of the Zhou classical texts, as well as differences between alternative New Text versions of the same classic. No matter what the version, the texts themselves were now ancient and their meaning often unclear. Questions and disagreements on the meaning of texts led to the development of an important new form of literature: commentaries on the classics. Commentaries and debates on the classics throughout the Western and Eastern Han resulted in an orthodox version of the Confucian classics, one based largely on the Old Text versions, but incorporating elements of the New Text school as well. The New Text/Old Text controversy remained below the surface, to be resurrected again, for political purposes, toward the end of the Qing dynasty in the late 19th century.

Debates over the authenticity and meaning of classical works of history and philosophy were generally tied to debates about imperial policy. Commentaries were written to defend or justify political positions or to gain appointment or promotion by demonstrating one’s literary prowess. For the most part, Han scholars saw literature as a way to communicate moral and political positions and to impress patrons and emperors. This was the case not only for classical exegesis and the writing of history and philosophy, but also for poetry, whose imagery, themes, and structure had a major influence on the poetry of later dynastic periods.

Han poetry is most noted for rhapsody or “rhyme-prose” (*fu*), the relatively short, structured “ancient poems” (*gu shi*), and folk songs (*yuefu*). Rhapsodies combined prose (particularly for the introduction) with freeflowing description, full of rhetorical flourishes and rich natural and supernatural imagery, which clearly drew on the example of the *Songs of Chu*, particularly Qu Yuan’s “Encountering Sorrow.” Sima Xiangru, quoted above, was one of the acknowledged masters of the form. “The Beautiful Person,” attributed to him, describes an encounter with a woman:

I pushed my way in through the shuttered door,
Found my way into the hall;
Exotic perfumes and fine scents hovered in the air,
Rich screens and tapestries furnished it.
And there in this room a lady waited alone:
Curvaceously beautiful, reclining on the bed
In sweetly perfumed and languid charm,
Her skin clear, her features vivid.³⁷

Critics (including some practitioners) condemned the rhapsody for its self-indulgence and lack of serious moral purpose. They preferred the folk song and the short poem. The Han government collected folk songs in order to gauge the feelings of the common people, just as scholars believed had been done by the Zhou in their *Book of Odes*. Some are likely written or revised by scholars using the folk song form for their own purposes. Han folk songs range from complaints about the hardships of poverty and military service to the lament of an orphan oppressed by his elder brother to songs of love and seduction (successful and otherwise).

Han short poems (*shi*) include a collection called the “Nineteen Poems” as well as a number of poems that used, for the first time, lines of five syllables (five Chinese characters) each. Popular themes included absence, longing, war, the bleakness of the frontier, the fleeting nature of life:³⁸

Yin and yang turn round in ceaseless flow
Spans of years like morning dew
Men’s lives go fast like stops overnight
Old age lacks the fixity of iron or stone
Eons on end we saw them off
No saint or sage that found escape
Some took drugs to find the potions were wrong
Better to drink good wine

And clothe yourself in satins and silks.³⁹

Because it was preserved and passed on to future generations of scholars, we know more about literature than other aspects of Western and Eastern Han culture. Nonetheless, it is clear that in art as well as in literature, the achievements of the Han period formed a cultural heritage that the elite of later periods drew on as they constructed a sense of Chinese identity. Both calligraphy and painting developed as art forms during the Han, but little remains of either of these perishable art forms. Palaces, temples, and tombs were decorated with wall paintings, and we have at least one example of Han calligraphy, a carved inscription recording the life and times of an Eastern Han official who, among other things, led what may have been the last military expedition to the far western area of Sule (modern Kashgar). Tombs and shrines were also decorated with stone bas reliefs, imitations of wall paintings.

The most famous example of Han bas relief is the shrine constructed in 151 CE for Wu Liang, a wealthy man of the Eastern Han period. The carved walls of the shrine depict the universe in miniature. Depictions of Heavenly omens appear on the ceiling. On the gables are scenes of the mythical Queen Mother of the West reigning over the land of the immortals. On the walls are scenes from human history, including images of moral exemplars, male and female, and short inscriptions.

The literature, calligraphy, painting, and shrine carvings of the Han period draw on the symbolic and moral themes of governance, history, Confucian moral philosophy, and Daoist philosophy and religion. They were produced for the Han people themselves, and show little if any foreign influence. Other forms of art, however, point directly to cultural exchanges with the civilizations of Central Asia and perhaps South Asia. The actions of Wudi in the Western Han marked the beginning of a long period of extensive trade between the Han Empire and the states of Central Asia. Han silk was a major commodity in this trade along the fabled Silk Road. Han welcomed horses from the north.

These imports brought new themes to the Chinese arts: a design evidently derived from the Mesopotamian “Tree of Life” on a Han silk discovered in Mongolia, a painting of an archer executing the “Parthian shot” (turning on his horse to shoot a target behind him) on a lacquer box, and mythical beasts (chimera, Ch. *bixie*) in stone, bronze, jade, and gold may have derived from Mesopotamian art by way of Persia and Bactria. Jade and glass, too, were evidence of foreign influence. Jade, imported from the far west, was used extensively in the Han (as it had been since the Neolithic period), especially for symbolic discs (*bi*) and for mortuary items. Jade was believed to preserve the body, and so members of the imperial clan and some favorites were buried with jade items, jade plugs for their bodily orifices, and even entire suits made from small plates of jade. Some Han bodies have been found in such suits, so well preserved that their flesh bounced back when pressed. Those who could not afford mortuary items made from jade sometimes used substitutes made of glass.

Together, the rulers and officials, the armies, the authors, and the artists of the Han created institutions and works that defined the elite civilization of their time. But even before the Han dynasty weakened and the empire descended into chaos, this culture was open to influence from abroad. But Han art, literature, music, religion, and philosophy had been transformed, not only by the passage of time, but also by interaction with foreign people and ideas. This interaction with Central, West, South, and Southeast Asia would continue into the future, both in times of chaos and in times of political stability.

Notes

1. The following interpretation of Wang Mang’s reign follows that of Hans Bielenstein, “Wang Mang, the Restoration of the Han Dynasty, and the Later Han,” in Denis Twitchett and Michael Loewe, eds., *The Cambridge History of China, Vol. 1: The Ch’in and Han Empires, 221 B.C.–A.D. 220* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1986), 232–40.
2. William Theodore de Bary et al., eds., *Sources of Chinese Tradition, Vol. 1: From Earliest Times to 1600* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1999), 364.
3. Bret Hinsch, *Women in Early Imperial China* (Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield, 2002), 98.
4. Quoted in Bielenstein, “Wang Mang [and] the Restoration,” 275–6.
5. Bielenstein, “Wang Mang [and] the Restoration,” 277.
6. *Ibid.*, 262–4.

7. Bielenstein, "The Institutions of Later Han," in Twitchett and Loewe, ed., *Cambridge History of China*, Vol. 1, 507–9; Michael Loewe, *Everyday Life in Imperial China During the Han Period, 202 BC–AD 220* (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Company, 2005), 36.
8. Zhang Chuanxi, ed., *Zhongguo gudai shi gang (shang)* (Outline of ancient Chinese history, vol. 1) (Beijing: Beijing daxue chubanshe, 2004), 240. Zhang's source for this affair is the *Hou Han Shu*, "Guangwudi ji (xia)."
9. Patricia Ebrey, "Economic and Social History of Later Han," in Twitchett and Loewe, eds., *The Cambridge History of China*, Vol. 1, 637.
0. Cho-yun Hsu, *Han Agriculture: The Formation of Early Chinese Agrarian Economy (206 B.C.–A.D. 220)* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1980), 127–8; Loewe, *Everyday Life*, 106–7, 169, 175; Zhang, ed., *Zhongguo gudai shi gang (shang)*, 245, 247, 288; Zhang Qizhi, ed., *Zhongguo lishi: Qin Han Wei Jin Nanbeichao juan* (Chinese history: Qin, Han, Wei, Jin, Northern and Southern Dynasties volume) (Beijing: Gaodeng jiaoyu chubanshe, 2001), 191.
1. Ying-shih Yü, *Trade and Expansion in Han China: A Study in the Structure of Sino-Barbarian Relations* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1967), 140; Bielenstein, "Wang Mang [and] the Restoration," 269.
2. Yü, *Trade and Expansion*, 49–51; Bielenstein, "Wang Mang [and] the Restoration," 266–8; Zhang, ed., *Zhongguo gudai shi gang (shang)*, 257.
3. Quoted in Yü, *Trade and Expansion*, 53.
4. Bielenstein, "Wang Mang [and] the Restoration," 270.
5. B. J. Mansvelt-Beck, "The Fall of Han," in Twitchett and Loewe, eds., *The Cambridge History of China*, Vol. 1, 335–6.
6. Zhang, ed. *Zhongguo lishi: Qin Han Wei Jin Nanbeichao juan*, 129.
7. Mansvelt-Beck, "The Fall of Han," 240–2.
8. Caroline Blunden and Mark Elvin, *Cultural Atlas of China*, rev. ed. (New York: Checkmark Books, 1998), 37.
9. Bielenstein, "Wang Mang [and] the Restoration," 271.
0. David N. Keightley, "The Oracle Bone Inscriptions of the Late Shang Dynasty," in de Bary et al., eds., *Sources of Chinese Tradition*, Vol. 1, 19–20.
1. de Bary et al., eds., *Sources of Chinese Tradition*, Vol. 1, 369.
2. Ban Gu, *Han shu* (Book of Han), quoted in Homer H. Dubs, "The Reliability of Chinese Histories," *The Far Eastern Quarterly* 6.1 (Nov. 1946): 37.
3. Ch'en Ch'i-yün, "Confucian, Legalist, and Taoist Thought in Later Han," in Twitchett and Loewe, eds., *The Cambridge History of China*, Vol. 1, 772.
4. Wang Chong, *Lun heng [Critical Essays]*, quoted in Fung Yu-lan, *History of Chinese Philosophy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1953), 154–5.
5. Ch'en, "Confucian, Legalist, and Taoist Thought," 783.
6. Nancy Lee Swann, *Pan Chao: Foremost Woman Scholar of China*. (Ann Arbor: Center for Chinese Studies, University of Michigan, 2001), 236.
7. Ban Zhao, "Admonitions for Women," in Swann, *Pan Chao*, 82–90.
8. Ch'en, "Confucian, Legalist, and Taoist Thought," 789.
9. *Ibid.*, 786–7, 795.
0. Mansvelt-Beck, "The Fall of Han," 338.
1. *Ibid.*, 349.
2. *Ibid.*, 350.
3. Bielenstein, "Wang Mang [and] the Restoration," 285.
4. *Ibid.*, 286.
5. *Ibid.*, 289; Mansvelt-Beck, "The Fall of Han," 328.
6. Sima Xiangru, "The Mighty One," in John Minford and Joseph S. M. Lau, eds., *Classical Chinese Literature: An*

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7. Sima Xiangru, "The Beautiful Person," trans. John Scott, in Minford and Lau, eds., *Classical Chinese Literature*, 293.
8. Robert Joe Cutter, "Poetry from 200 B.C.E. to 600 C.E." in Victor H. Mair, ed., *The Columbia History of Chinese Literature* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2001), 250–1; Wai-lim Yip, *Chinese Poetry: An Anthology of Major Modes and Genres* (Durham: Duke University Press, 1997), 67.
9. Trans. Charles Hartman, in Wu-chi Liu and Irving Yucheng Lo, eds., *Sunflower Splendor: Three Thousand Years of Chinese Poetry* (Garden City: Anchor Press/ Doubleday, 1975), 32–3.

Part II

CULTURAL
INTERACTION AND
TRANSFORMATION,
220–1368

大有

*The Three Kingdoms,
Western Jin,
and the Period of
North-South Division*

They say the momentum of history was ever thus: the empire, long divided, must unite; long united, must divide. Thus the House of Zhou reached its end and the empire was partitioned into seven warring kingdoms. Thus these seven were absorbed into the House of Qin. Then Han and Chu destroyed Qin and waged war on each other until the empire was reunited under the House of Han, reinvigorated by Guangwudi and passed down the generations to Xiandi, the last of the Han, after whose generation the land was partitioned into the three kingdoms.¹

So read the opening lines of the *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*, a 14th-century historical novel based on the events following the fall of the Eastern Han dynasty. We conventionally think of China as being one country. But Qin–Han unity, overturning a thousand years of variety and division, was not permanent. For most of the period from the end of the Eastern Han dynasty in 220 until the Sui dynasty conquered the south in 589, China Proper was divided into two or more kingdoms. The basic division was between north and south, roughly along the Huai River. At times, independent kingdoms ruled the area of modern Sichuan province. The north was often divided into two or more rival kingdoms, most of them ruled by non-Chinese ethnic groups whose origins lay among the nomadic clans of Mongolia, Manchuria, and Tibet.

Foreign rule and endemic warfare in the north and between north and south did not prevent overland and maritime foreign trade, which brought Central Asian and Indian influence, including Buddhism. Many elements of culture—politics, religion, philosophy, economy, art, and literature—changed significantly during the three centuries in which nomadic warriors and Buddhist teachers played an unprecedented role in public and private life. When reunification of north and south finally came under the Sui and Tang dynasties, the Chinese world was very different from what it had been during the reign of the last emperor of the Eastern Han.

The Fall of the Eastern Han

The Eastern Han dynasty officially came to an end on 11 December 220 when the last Han emperor abdicated and Cao Pi (187–226), son of the strongman Cao Cao, took the throne as the first emperor of the new Cao Wei dynasty. In fact, the Eastern Han government had effectively ceased to function in 189. It was in that year that, following the death of the Han emperor Ling, General Dong Zhuo captured Luoyang and installed an eight-year-old child as Xiandi, the last emperor of the Eastern Han. But control of the emperor no longer guaranteed control of the government, much less the territory of the Han. Various factions including eunuchs, the empress dowager, and various generals competed with Dong Zhuo for power.

There is never a single neat and clean explanation as to why a particular dynastic family loses control of an empire. Still less is there a simple way of explaining why, in this case, the territory of the Eastern Han should come to be divided among multiple states, many of them ruled by non-Chinese pastoral clans, for over three hundred and fifty years. There may be some relationship between climate change and the long-term pattern of political fragmentation. In the years from the late Eastern Han to the Sui, China experienced below-average temperatures. The cooler climate, which would have brought harsher conditions and reduced pasturage to the Mongolian steppe, may have been one factor in bringing nomadic Inner Asian peoples into the northern parts of China Proper.²

As for the ruling Liu family's loss of power and the collapse of their Eastern Han Empire in the years following Emperor Ling's death, we can point to several factors. The first is simply bad luck: both Emperor Ling's sons were children when he died. Perhaps a mature man of strong will would have handled things differently. But whoever was in control would still have had to contend with the cumulative results of the natural disasters, epidemics, and peasant rebellions which had brought suffering, death to ordinary people, and a decline in tax revenue to the Eastern Han government.

The process by which the economy and central control broke down in the last decades of the Eastern Han is unclear. It seems that key areas of the empire, including the Central Plains and the Taiyuan area in the northwest, were hit by a series of floods and droughts from the 120s through the 180s.³ The flow of refugees to areas unaffected by natural disaster strained their resources in turn, causing a kind of chain reaction of starvation and social unrest. Natural disasters may also have contributed to the nine epidemics recorded between 151 and 217.⁴ Rural poverty and epidemics contributed to massive peasant rebellions: the Five Pecks of Grain uprising in Sichuan and the Yellow Turban rebellion in the Central Plains. As noted in Chapter 4, the leaders of these two popular rebellions were Daoist healers. A generation of military strongmen began their careers in the fighting against these Daoist rebels. The most famous were Cao Cao (155–220), Liu Bei (161–223), and Sun Jian (155–191).

Cao Cao's father was the adopted son of Emperor Ling's chief eunuch. Cao Cao was thus part of the Eastern Han elite, but not quite respectable. He served as an official and then made his mark leading troops against the Yellow Turbans. Liu Bei was a distant but poor relation of the imperial clan. In his youth, he and his mother sold shoes and wove mats to make a living. Liu joined the fighting against the Yellow Turbans, attracted the attention and support of some of the strongest generals of the time, and rose to prominence. Sun Jian, a southerner from modern Zhejiang province, served as a minor official until rising to power as leader of another army against the Yellow Turbans.

These three men went on to play major parts in the fighting, which eventually resolved itself into the establishment of three independent kingdoms on the territory of the Eastern Han Empire.

The Three Kingdoms

After Emperor Ling's death and the extermination of the eunuchs, over a dozen generals (including Dong Zhuo, who controlled the boy emperor) emerged as warlords, each controlling some part of the empire and all fighting each other in a shifting pattern of alliances and enmities. It was Cao Cao who gradually gained control over all of north China.

Cao Cao is portrayed in history and especially in historical fiction as a brilliant but cruel, short-tempered man, an effective commander, and one of the most talented poets of his time. Tradition has it that a soothsayer once told Cao, in his youth: "You would be a capable official in times of peace, but a treacherous man in a chaotic age." If Cao Cao was guilty of treachery, he was certainly not alone. A coalition of Dong Zhuo's fellow generals, including Cao Cao, drove Dong out of Luoyang in 191, and celebrated when Dong died in 192 at the hands of one of his own generals. The allies then turned on one another. Cao Cao defeated them all in turn, including a celebrated victory over Yuan Shao, his boyhood friend and former ally, at Guandu on the Yellow River in 200. With further victories over other warlords, Cao Cao took full control of northern China in 207. The Han emperor Xiandi, whom Cao Cao had taken in as a refugee, was a mere puppet: the veneer of dynastic rule was maintained, but Cao Cao was in charge.

While Cao Cao was unchallenged in the north, he still faced the Sun clan and their ally Liu Bei in the south. Liu Bei had a checkered career. Often victorious in battle, but just as often defeated, he had been a subordinate ally of many of the major warlords of the time, including Cao Cao himself and, shortly before the Guandu battle, Cao Cao's friend and victim, Yuan Shao. In 207, Liu was a minor ally of the southern strongman Sun Quan, the second son of Sun Jian.

Sun Jian had died in 191 in the bloody battles for control of the Central Plains, but not before building a sizable army. In 194 his eldest son, Sun Ce, eighteen years of age, took control of a part of the Sun army and used it to carve out his own territory in the lower Yangzi Valley—in modern terms, southern Jiangsu, southern Anhui, and northern Jiangxi. When Sun Ce was assassinated by a local enemy in 200, his younger brother inherited the family enterprise—coincidentally also at the age of eighteen—and expanded the Sun territory. Nonetheless, Sun Quan was not, at least on paper, a match for the overwhelming force that Cao Cao could bring to bear. Cao Cao had every reason to be confident. In early November 208, he advanced to the north bank of the Yangzi River at Red Cliffs (somewhere between Wuhan and Yueyang).

Two of Sun Quan's generals and Liu Bei, now a minor ally of Sun, went upriver to prevent Cao's northerners from crossing. Initial engagements were indecisive. Cao Cao's forces prepared a large number of boats, which they had lashed together and joined with catwalks. Sun Quan's general used fireboats, destroying Cao's ships and causing tremendous loss of life. Sun's forces followed up by crossing the Yangzi and chasing down Cao's troops, now in disorderly retreat. Cao Cao himself fled, ignominiously, and struggled back to Luoyang, his dream of uniting the empire dashed. For his part, Sun Quan was strong enough to have repelled Cao Cao's attack, but he did not have the resources to follow up with a campaign to take over the north. Liu Bei, taking advantage of the limitations of both Sun and Cao, took territory for himself, ultimately controlling the area of modern Sichuan and Hanzhong.



Confucius presenting the baby Buddha to Laozi. This painting, done in the Qing period, represents a Daoist perspective on the relationship between the “Three Teachings” of Daoism, Confucianism, and Buddhism.

The territory of the Eastern Han was now effectively divided among three independent kingdoms. In the north, Cao Cao's area took the name Wei, after one of the ancient kingdoms of Confucius' day. For convenience, we label Cao Cao's kingdom the Cao Wei. In the south, Sun Quan's area took another ancient name, Wu, conventionally called Sun Wu. In the west, Liu Bei, being a relation of the imperial household of the Han dynasty, claimed that his kingdom was the extension of Han and took that name. Because it was centered in the part of Sichuan called Shu, we label Liu Bei's kingdom Shu Han. All three kingdoms faced similar tasks: restore order, increase agricultural production, establish a government bureaucracy, and set up a system of taxation to support the bureaucracy and the military. The kingdom of Cao Wei pursued the most innovative policies.

The Cao family's kingdom of Wei had inherited the most productive, populous area of the Eastern Han Empire: northern China's Central Plains. Cao Cao described the area after years of war:

Their armor was alive with breeding lice,
Ten thousand families were wiped out.
Their white bones lay and bleached in the wilderness,
For a thousand leagues not a cock was heard to crow.
Of the people, barely one in a hundred survived,
Remembering this is enough to break your heart.⁵



The Three Kingdoms.

War had brought death and destruction to the countryside: many families had fled to the south. Great families in their large fortified compounds dominated the countryside. Together with their retainers, dependent peasants, and slaves, they were largely self-sufficient and not amenable to government control or taxation.

Cao Cao's policies were very Legalist in inspiration, which is to say that he favored a high degree of government action, particularly in economic matters. For all the damage done to the Central Plains, Cao Cao was still in a strong position: he had the heartland of the Han Empire and seventy percent of its formerly registered population.⁶ Cao Cao faced three main problems: restoring agricultural productivity and in-kind state tax revenue, settling refugees, and re-establishing central and local government authority. His government was most noted for its use of agricultural colonies as a source of government grain.

The Han dynasty had formerly established self-supplying agricultural military garrisons on the northwestern frontiers. Cao Cao now used the same model to set up both military and civil agricultural colonies at strategic points on the borders and within the kingdom. The state supplied land, seed, tools, and sometimes draft animals to get the colonies started. The colonies paid fifty percent of their produce annually to the state (sixty percent if they used state-owned oxen). These became an important source of grain for the Cao Wei armies, and thus a foundation of the state's military strength. But most land in the Cao Wei kingdom was still privately owned, so the state could share its grain only through taxation. To collect taxes, Cao Cao needed to rebuild the bureaucracy.

The central problem of bureaucracy was recruitment. Cao Cao took an innovative approach. In a society that had come over the course of the Eastern Han to once more, as in Zhou times, put great emphasis on elite pedigree, Cao Cao insisted that—as in the Qin and early Han—officials should be appointed on the basis of talent, not heredity. In order to locate men of talent, he set up a system of local officials called “Rectifiers.” These men were to rank the scholars of their areas into one of nine categories from highest to lowest, based on an assessment of their talents and moral character. These recommendations would be sent to the central government, which would choose officials from among the men recommended in this nine-rank system. In practice, men of elite families occupied the position of rectifier, and such men had more chance to study anyway, so it should come as no surprise that they were inevitably placed in the upper three ranks of the nine-rank system, while men of lesser pedigree were relegated to the lowest ranks. Cao Cao's meritocratic intent was undermined, but the practice did build a common identity between his government and the elite families.

With peace and innovative effective policies, the Cao Wei kingdom grew in power. Cao Cao's son, Cao Pi (187–226), inherited the throne on his father's death. Cao Pi continued his father's policies. He also formally accepted the Han emperor Xiandi's abdication and took the throne as emperor of Cao Wei, considering himself as the legitimate successor of Han, and thus bound to conquer and incorporate his neighbors to the south, Sun Wu and Shu Han. On Cao Pi's death in 226, men of the martial Sima clan took over effective power while leaving puppet Cao emperors on the throne. Sima Yan finally brought the Cao Wei dynasty to an end in 265 and founded his own dynasty, the

Western Jin. The Cao Wei annexed Shu Han in 263, but neither Cao Cao nor Cao Pi, nor the Sima prime ministers, were able to subdue Sun Quan's Wu kingdom in the south until the Western Jin conquered it in 280.

In the south, Sun Quan was just as interested in uniting "all under Heaven" as was Cao Cao in the north. However, he and his heirs in Wu were unable to take even peripheral territories from the Wei. On paper, the kingdom of Wu looks huge: southern China including the fertile Yangzi Valley, Hunan, Guangdong, Guangxi, Vietnam's Red River Valley, and the Vietnamese coast to Hue. The area had great potential, but it was as yet undeveloped. When it was established, Wu had only one-sixth of the population of the Eastern Han Empire (Cao Wei held over two-thirds of the Han population).⁷ Non-Chinese ethnic groups such as the Mountain Yue occupied much of Wu territory. These people were not registered households and did not pay taxes.

Even in more developed areas, entrenched great families held sway: indeed, the Sun clan relied on and intermarried with the great land-owning families of the south. This made it very difficult for the Sun Wu government to concentrate resources in support of building the bureaucracy and army. The Sun Wu government did expand the area of land cultivated by taxpaying farmers by conquering and forcibly "civilizing" some of the Mountain Yue people. This long-term project laid the basis for south China's later economic strength, but not in time to save the Wu kingdom from falling victim to their much bigger neighbor to the north, the Western Jin, in 280.

Of all the Three Kingdoms, Shu Han had the greatest claim to be heirs to the Eastern Han Empire: the founder, Liu Bei, was, after all, a distant relation of the Han imperial house. Nonetheless, Shu Han was the smallest and shortest-lived of the Three Kingdoms period. Like the Sun Wu kingdom, Shu Han had extensive southern territories that were the home of non-Han, nontaxpaying ethnic groups. Unlike the Wu, Shu Han was not able to incorporate these people into the bureaucratic structure of the kingdom, and take their surplus product as tax revenue. At the same time, Shu Han was determined—even more so than Wu—to conquer the land of the Cao Wei. Multiple attacks on the Wei sapped Shu Han's strength and made it an easy target for Cao Wei forces, under the leadership of Sima Yan, to conquer Shu Han in 263.

A Brief Reunification: The Western Jin

The Three Kingdoms coexisted not because they wanted to live together in peace, but because no one of them was able to conquer the other two. The common goal of reunification was to be achieved by the Sima family, but only briefly. The Sima were one of the powerful elite clans of the Cao Wei kingdom. At first, they controlled the Wei from within, leaving Cao men on the throne. In 265 Sima Yan, the third generation of Sima leaders to run the show, decided to put the Cao Wei out of existence. He had recently conquered Shu, and presumably felt in a position to be emperor. Taking the throne as the first emperor of the Western Jin dynasty, Sima Yan enfeoffed his sons as princes, giving them territory, complete with tax revenue and real power. His intention was to make sure that the Sima clan would have multiple centers of power so that no usurper could push the family out of power—as his clan had deposed the Cao clan.

In 280, Sima Yan defeated the southern kingdom of Wu. The Three Kingdoms period was over. Unity had been restored to all under Heaven—but only for thirty-seven years, until 317. In that year, rebels under non-Han leaders took over and drove the Jin court south to the Yangzi Valley, where it continued to rule as the Eastern Jin. Once again, north and south were under separate governments. What went wrong?

Shortly after his dynasty had lost the north, a Jin intellectual, Bian Kun (281–328) blamed the spiritual atmosphere: "To oppose the rites and injure the teachings [of Confucius]—there is no crime greater than this. The downfall of the central court was really because of this."⁸ Bian Kun was referring to the vogue for the "Learning of the Mysterious" (*xuanxue*) and to the generally freethinking, spontaneous-acting libertine attitude of some of the most famous scholars of the third century.

At first glance, the Learning of the Mysterious looks inoffensive. By the late Eastern Han, the amalgamation of Confucian, Daoist, and Legalist ideas on which government was based had reached a state in which powerful men (such as Cao Cao) made patently cynical use of "portents" and fortunetelling to legitimize their bids for political power. Under the Three Kingdoms period, Cao Shuang, King of Wei, sponsored men like He Yan (?–249) and Wang Bi (226–249) who drew on the Daoist texts—the *Dao de jing*, the *Zhuangzi*, and the *Book of Changes*—to suggest new understandings of the Way of the universe.

He Yan and Wang Bi argued that Nonbeing (*wu*) is the *dao* (the Way) and the source of all things, including the moral teachings associated with Confucius (*mingjiao*), which had been the center of Han thought—and still were the

center of the moral philosophy of the more conservative scholars of their era. This kind of thinking, which sought to explain the origins of all things in Daoist terms but to link this theory of origins to morality and ritual, was a new departure for Chinese thought, and particularly for traditionalist scholars, who had not been particularly concerned with the mystery of how the universe and all within it came to be.

Although they were original thinkers, He Yan and Wang Bi were hardly political radicals—they both held office, as a good scholar would. In doing so, He Yan, Wang Bi, and like-minded scholars created and embodied a new concept in which the ideas of the Daoists and of Confucius could be combined in one's own life: following Daoist naturalness and freedom while remaining engaged with the world. It was an ideal to which Chinese scholars would return time and again over the centuries, and it was the ideal that lay behind the tendency of Chinese scholarly men to create extravagant but rustic gardens which were intended to recreate, in safely tamed miniature, the wild and natural environment in which one would imagine a Daoist recluse.⁹

Both He Yan and Wang Bi upheld the Confucian moral principles and rituals which lay at the center of Chinese family and political life. But when the Sima clan wrested power from the Cao rulers of Wei in 249, they found He Yan and Wang Bi's philosophy unacceptable. Upholders of the conservative Confucian position, the Sima leaders rejected any philosophy which would subordinate the Confucian moral teachings and rituals to Nonbeing. He Yan was executed. Wang Bi was thrown out of office and died a natural death later the same year.

The Sima clan's Confucian dictatorship did not bring the entire Chinese intellectual world into conformity. The next stage of the Learning of the Mysterious was dominated by a group of famously freewheeling libertines and shocking nonconformists, the Seven Sages of the Bamboo Grove. The best-remembered of the Seven Sages were Xi Kang (223–262), Ruan Ji (210–263), Shan Tao (205–283), Xiang Xiu (c. 221–300), Liu Ling (c. 225–280), Wang Rong (234–305), and Ruan Xian (fl. third century). Some of them agreed that Confucian moral teachings and the natural Way of Daoism were more or less the same, while others did not. All were known for their unorthodox thinking and behavior. Perhaps the most notable was Xi Kang. Xi Kang had been an official when the Cao family still controlled the kingdom of Wei, but he resigned in protest when the Sima clan deprived the Cao of political power.

In philosophical terms, Xi Kang went beyond, and opposed the more conservative Learning of the Mysterious of Wang Bi and He Yan. He Yan and Wang Bi had explained all things as being naturally produced from Nonbeing, which was the *dao*. Confucian moral teaching, which they honored, was simply one natural manifestation of the *dao*. Xi Kang explained everything in the universe as being a product of “Primal Force” (*yuan qi*). This in itself might not seem so bad, but Xi Kang completely rejected the idea that Confucian morality could be natural or even desirable: “The Six [Confucian] Classics take repressing temptations as their main theme; human nature takes fulfillment of desire as its happiness.”¹⁰ As far as Xi Kang was concerned, people should step beyond the bounds of Confucian moral teaching and give free rein to their natural inclinations. A rival scholar of the Learning of the Mysterious denounced Xi Kang to the Sima strongman of the day on charges that “he despises the times, is arrogant toward the world, and is of no use to his fellows. ... If Xi Kang is not executed, there will be no means of purifying the Royal Way.”¹¹

Xi Kang (who carried his coffin around with him) was executed, a victim of political infighting, but the freewheeling lifestyle that he and the other “Sages” embodied continued to influence a certain unruly element in the late Wei kingdom and in the Western Jin dynasty. These men were known for drunkenness, violating mourning ritual by eating meat and drinking wine, and sitting around together, naked, drinking and dallying with concubines.

Such conduct may have outraged conservatives (of whom there were plenty), but the fall of the dynasty was not due to the moral improprieties of a particular group of elite men. There were more fundamental reasons why the ethnic Han Chinese rulers of the Western Jin dynasty should have lost the northern portion of their empire to various kingdoms led by rulers of pastoral, non-Han origin.

First, neither the Cao Wei kingdom nor the Western Jin ever had good control over the northern, northeastern, and northwestern frontier areas. A variety of nomadic peoples, all speaking Turkic or Tibetan languages, were creating their own tribal areas and kingdoms in what are modern Tibet, Inner and Outer Mongolia, and Manchuria. Some, particularly certain Xiongnu tribes, had been settled within China Proper for generations. However, relations between Han Chinese and nomadic peoples were generally poor: even Chinese records attest to the exploitation and harsh policies which engendered resentment against the Han Chinese.

At the same time, the first Sima Jin emperor's technique of enfeoffing his relatives as princes in order to defend the interests of the clan came back to haunt his successors. When an empress dowager attempted to assert control over the government, some of the Eight Princes of Sima blood did come to the rescue of their clan, eliminating the

empress. But in the aftermath, the Eight Princes fought a bloody twelve-year war among themselves for control of the throne. As the War of the Eight Princes sapped the Jin government's strength, non-Han rebel leaders arose and overthrew Chinese rule in the periphery, then in the Central Plains, and all over northern China. The remnants of the Western Jin court fled south of the Yangzi, along with many wealthy northern Chinese families and their retainers. There, they continued under the name of the Eastern Jin dynasty. In the north, chaos prevailed as numerous tribal groups carved out small kingdoms for themselves, only to be conquered by larger kingdoms, which in turn split up again into smaller ones. China was once more divided.

The Multi-Ethnic States of the North

At first glance, the nearly three centuries from the fall of the Western Jin (317) until the Sui reunification (589) are a hopelessly confusing mess, fully deserving the Chinese adjective *luan* ("chaotic"). The north was broken up among multiple, short-lived kingdoms, most of them established by Turkic or Tibetan strongmen. The south, though ruled by a single dynastic government at a time, saw the rise and fall of five different dynasties and numerous peasant rebellions. Despite the chaos of these centuries, there are some underlying themes that can help us to understand what life was like and the directions in which China and Chinese civilization were changing. Chinese historians separate these years into two distinct periods: first, the period of the Sixteen Kingdoms (in the north) and Eastern Jin (in the south); and second, the period of the Northern and Southern Dynasties, with the Northern Wei and its successor states in the north and four Chinese dynasties ruling in succession in the south.

The stories of two men, Liu Yuan (?–310) and Shi Le (274–333), illustrate some of the characteristics of the north under the Sixteen Kingdoms. Liu Yuan was a Xiongnu noble. His particular branch of the Xiongnu had been settled in modern Shanxi province, south of the Qin wall, for generations as a buffer against their nomadic cousins to the north. Liu was educated in the Chinese classics, histories, and philosophy (he was particularly fond of Sunzi's *Art of War*), and he inherited his father's official post in the Western Jin capital city of Luoyang.

However, as the Western Jin tore itself to pieces in the War of the Eight Princes, Liu Yuan returned to Shanxi and led his Xiongnu in revolt against Chinese rule. Liu Yuan's goal was not merely Xiongnu independence: he wanted to rule the Chinese heartland, the Central Plains. Accordingly, he appealed successfully to a variety of ethnicities, including Han Chinese, to join him in expelling the corrupt and failing Sima ruling clique. His kingdom, known as the Former Zhao, only lasted from 317 to 329, when one of his former generals, Shi Le, conquered and absorbed it.

Shi Le was a man of the formerly pastoral Jie people, who had also settled in modern Shanxi province. Shi was from a poor background. He had been a trader in Luoyang, worked as an agricultural laborer, and, at the age of twenty, was taken prisoner by a Chinese Western Jin official who sold him as a slave in Shandong. There, Shi Le led a rebellion, built an army, and then joined forces with Liu Yuan, thus participating in the downfall of the Eastern Jin. Though a Jie and a former slave of a Chinese official, Shi Le made a point of incorporating unhappy Chinese Eastern Jin officials into his army and of gaining the support of the highly militarized Chinese elite families of the Central Plains. This was what enabled Shi Le to control his own territory, declare himself king, and defeat and absorb the Xiongnu Former Zhao kingdom. Shi Le's Later Zhao kingdom lasted for all of thirty-one years.

What we learn from the stories of Liu Yuan and Shi Le is, first, that ethnic identity and culture were both important and complicated in northern China. The repressive policies of the Chinese rulers—Eastern Han, Wei, and Western Jin alike—had bred resentment on the part of non-Chinese peoples, both outside and within the borders of the Chinese-administered territory. Furthermore, like Liu Yuan, many of the leaders of the Sixteen Kingdoms, though ethnically Xiongnu, Jie, Di, Qiang, or Xianbei, were to one degree or another educated in the Chinese cultural tradition. Third, ethnic resentment operated between different non-Chinese ethnic groups as well as between the Chinese and those whom they regarded generally as "the Five Barbarians." Finally, ethnic identity was shifting, rather than fixed. The Xiongnu and Xianbei, for example, comprised a number of clans, each having the potential to develop its own separate identity as a different people. The reverse also occurred when the nobility of one ethnic group absorbed wholesale members of another. For example, as the Western Jin collapsed into chaos, a number of Chinese officials, landholders, and their dependent commoners joined the Murong Xianbei.¹²

The fact of an overwhelmingly Han Chinese population being ruled by military strongmen of various Turkic and Tibetan ethnic groups is a second characteristic of this period. The ethnic origins of the rulers of the Sixteen Kingdoms may have been in the nomadic regions of the north and west, but their cultural background and sometimes their family background was increasingly a mixture of Turkic or Tibetan and Chinese. In general, the

non-Chinese rulers governed their own people according to their own custom, but to govern their Chinese population, they used Chinese administrative structures and Chinese culture. Accordingly, these non-Chinese rulers respected and employed Chinese scholar-officials. Confucian philosophy remained a mainstay of northern Chinese political culture and family life despite Turkic or Tibetan rule.

Finally, the northern kingdoms—including the few that were ruled by ethnic Chinese—were highly militarized and inherently unstable. On average, a kingdom lasted for thirty-one years. Nearly every one of these kingdoms was weakened, generally within a generation of its founding, by internal fights over control of the throne. Tensions within the ruling ethnic group and between the ruling group and other non-Han ethnicities easily broke out into rebellion. In the meantime, in the rural areas, elite families built self-sufficient fortified compounds, supported armed retainers, and defended their own small territories and dependent farmers. The only regime able to bring unity and peace to the north for a longer time was the Northern Wei.

The Northern Wei

While competing kingdoms came, fought, and departed from the stage of the Chinese heartland, new confederations of pastoral people were forming in the steppes of Inner and Outer Mongolia. Where once the Xiongnu had reigned, the Tuoba branch of the Turkic Xianbei people now held sway. First taking control of the steppe area itself, the Tuoba Xianbei turned their attention to China Proper only in the beginning of the fifth century. Soon, they had established a Chinese-style capital near the modern city of Datong—in north China, but close enough to the steppe to straddle the pastoral and the agricultural worlds. The strength and stability of the Tuoba Xianbei state and their interest in Chinese-style government attracted Confucian scholars from the great Chinese families of the Central Plains. Confucian concepts were incorporated into Tuoba law, and the Tuoba Xianbei government became more and more “Chinese.”

The Tuoba elite’s adaptation of Chinese elite culture and techniques of government proceeded at a faster pace when Empress Dowager Feng (442–490) took over political power in 466. The empress dowager—a Han Chinese aristocrat originally brought into the palace as a slave—ruled on behalf of boy emperors. Her government’s policies were clearly modeled on those of Qin and Han, centering on household registration in order to build up the tax base and assure a supply of corvée labor. In an innovative twist, however, Empress Dowager Feng’s advisors devised a policy called the Equal Fields System.

Under the Equal Fields System, the state owned agricultural land and assigned it to individual families. Land assignments were based on the number of adult males, females, and slaves in a family and were to be revised on a regular basis. Each family was responsible for paying tax in the form of grain and cloth on the land assigned to them. In addition to their temporary land allotment, each family was also assigned a permanent plot on which to grow fruit and mulberry trees. This plot was permanent in order to assure that trees would be planted and cared for. The Equal Fields System was a highly regarded model for land management. Later, the Tang dynasty and the early Japanese state both used it to assure a steady flow of tax revenue.



[The period of division: Northern Wei and Southern Qi, c. 480.](#)

Influential though they were, Empress Dowager Feng's policies struck at the interests of both Han Chinese and Tuoba Xianbei elite households—large landholders for whom a more efficient tax-collection system meant nothing but a loss of local control over local resources. Furthermore, the Tuoba nobility were becoming concerned that the Tuoba people were losing their identity (and, perhaps more to the point, that the Tuoba nobles themselves were losing power to Chinese-style bureaucrats). There was good reason for them to be concerned. As rulers of a sedentary Chinese agricultural population, the Tuoba Wei emperors and their advisors were increasingly aware of the advantages to be gained by using tried-and-true Chinese bureaucratic techniques to extract surplus wealth from the vast rural economy based on small landholders, and to use that wealth in order to support a strong army, foreign trade, and a suitably luxurious imperial lifestyle.

The Tuoba Northern Wei emperor Xianwendi (r. 471–500) took the adoption of Chinese techniques of government to its logical extreme. In 494, he moved the capital of the Northern Wei to the old Chinese capital city of Luoyang, right in the heart of the Chinese cultural (and agricultural) area, and far from the steppes from which the Tuoba Xianbei had so recently come. Some of the Tuoba elite rebelled in protest. They were crushed. In Luoyang, the emperor forced the Tuoba elite to intermarry with Chinese elite families, to adopt Chinese surnames, to wear Chinese clothing, to speak the Chinese language, and, when they died, to be buried in the Chinese city of Luoyang.

Eventually, the Tuoba Northern Wei, too, broke up into smaller successor states (partly due to internal resistance to sinicization), but the legacy of the Tuoba sinicization policies would remain for many generations. Northern China now had a new elite: families of mixed Tuoba Xianbei–Chinese ancestry, some of them Tuoba families that had taken Chinese surnames. Their culture, too, was mixed: they partook both of the Confucian legacy of China and the horse-riding warrior legacy of their Turkic ancestors of the steppes. In addition they, along with their neighbors to the south, shared Buddhist and Daoist beliefs that had developed during the period of disunity.

The Eastern Jin and Southern Dynasties

In 317 the Xiongnu completely overran the Central Plains, captured the Western Jin emperor Mindi, and killed him. Of the enfeoffed Sima princes only Sima Rui (276–322) was in a position to re-establish the Jin dynasty in the south. Fleeing his base area in Shandong, Sima Rui led his army south to take the strategically located city of Jiankang (modern Nanjing) on the Yangzi River. With the help of powerful émigré clans from the north and a few important southern clans, Sima Rui was able to control the lower and middle Yangzi areas and the Pearl River Basin in Guangdong.

The role of elite clans in Sima Rui's ascent to power is the key to understanding both the strengths and the weaknesses of the Eastern Jin and its four successors in the south. Without the support of the great families of the realm, neither Sima Rui nor the founders of the subsequent four Southern Dynasties (the Song, Qi, Liang, and Chen

dynasties) would have been able to take power. But at the same time, the strength of these elite families severely limited any emperor's ability to govern.

During the Eastern Jin, the elite clans who had fled the north dominated political life. These large extended families, their retainers, dependent farmers and slaves were resettled in the south. Though a minority of the southern Chinese population (perhaps seventeen percent), the northern clans wielded power by virtue of their connections with the Eastern Jin ruling clan, the Sima, who were themselves refugees from the north. Over time, however, many of the northern elite families declined, while some of the wealthy but, in terms of pedigree, "humble" clans of the south rose to power, often because clan leaders were military commanders—a role which the men of the established elite clans had avoided. The founders of both the Song (470–479) and the Qi (479–502) dynasties, for example, were men who had risen through the army.

Neither the Eastern Jin nor any of the four Southern Dynasties were able to effectively curb the power of the great families. This was not for lack of trying. Unfortunately, the southern imperial governments were all trapped in the same vicious circle: they could not put the clans in their place without having superior military and economic power, but the fact that the clans controlled local resources and evaded and resisted taxation meant that the imperial governments would never acquire superior military and economic power. Much of the territory of the south was still sparsely populated by non-Chinese ethnic groups such as the Mountain Yue, who, despite the initial efforts of the Sun Wu regime, were not registered taxpaying households and had no desire to become such. Great families—both northern and southern—controlled much land and population themselves, and they, their retainers, and the families who farmed their land also had no desire to pay taxes or render corvée labor to the emperor, whom they saw as socially no better than themselves.

Numerous attempts to broaden the tax base met with limited success. There were successful campaigns against the Mountain Yue, including mass relocations to settle them on productive valley land as registered taxpayers. On the other hand, other attempts to survey land and register households met with broad resistance from both ordinary people and elite clans. For example, the Qi dynasty tried to carry out a very aggressive household registration program. It ended when a Daoist rebel named Tang Yuzhi tapped into popular discontent to raise an army of over thirty thousand in 484–85 in support of his unsuccessful but violent attempt to become emperor of the south.¹³

An inefficient tax system, military weakness, numerous popular rebellions, and the inevitable infighting among enfeoffed relatives of the imperial clans meant that the Eastern Jin and the four Southern Dynasties had little drive to reconquer the north. Leading generals of the Eastern Jin and the Liang made attempts to recover the northern lands from the "barbarians," but even when parts of northern territory were temporarily recovered, the southern emperors and their courtiers had neither the will nor the resources to follow up. The only way the south could possibly have taken over the north was by concentrating all possible resources through superefficient government policies to increase production, collect taxes, conscript soldiers, and impress corvée laborers. Even if the fractious aristocrats had permitted that, the south faced a fundamental obstacle: it had a far lower population of registered taxpaying families (and probably a lower population overall) than the north.

The Three Teachings: Confucianism, Daoism, and Buddhism

Turkic and Tibetan elites ruled northern China during the period of division, while Han Chinese clans held the throne in the south. Nonetheless, major historical trends of the third, fourth, and fifth centuries cut across the shifting border between north and south. One of the most significant among these was the way in which elites and commoners, north and south, incorporated Confucianism, Daoism, and Buddhism into their lives. People came to regard these "Three Teachings" as being more or less mutually compatible, although some, of course, preferred one over the others. A minority of individuals firmly identified with one or another set of beliefs, and even they did not entirely exclude the others from consideration. It is only for simplicity, then, that we treat Confucianism, Daoism, and Buddhism as separate categories.

Confucian philosophy (in fact, as we have seen, itself already an amalgam of Confucian, Legalist, and Daoist ideas, texts, and practices developed in the Han dynasty) remained the moral basis of family life, state organization, and state legitimization. In both the north and the south, Confucian philosophy moved away from the freewheeling ways of the Learning of the Mysterious and reverted to a more conservative emphasis on moral teaching and ritual. Northern and southern emperors alike used Confucian concepts such as the ruler's function as moral exemplar and

the proper performance of ritual as tools to legitimize their positions.

In the north, even a relatively uneducated man of pastoral background like Shi Le established schools for the purpose of teaching the Confucian classics. Turkic rulers who had been educated in the Chinese cultural tradition were quite enthusiastic patrons of Confucian scholarship. Fu Jian, a strongman of Di ethnicity who founded the Former Qin dynasty, not only established an imperial college for Confucian studies, but was said to visit the college every day. Confucian learning was particularly well preserved in Dunhuang in the northwest—an area relatively untouched by the frequent warfare of the Sixteen Kingdoms period.¹⁴ In both the north and the south, central and local governments continued to be organized along the principles developed in the Qin and Han dynasties, and an assessment of moral character was still the basic publicly stated criterion for recommending men for public office (although personal connections and membership in an elite family were the unspoken but more realistic criteria).

While Confucianism remained fundamental to Chinese identity and to non-Chinese claims to hold political power, Daoism also played an important role in religious life. For analytical purposes, we can distinguish between three different facets of religious Daoism: the institutional, the personal, and the political.

Like the Learning of the Mysterious, religious Daoism offered something that Confucianism had not been interested in: an explanation of the origins of the universe and all things. For Daoism, all things arise naturally from the dao (the Way) discussed by Laozi and Zhuangzi. Daoists also believed that certain highly developed human beings had become immortals and continued to play a role in the universe and in the human realm. Under the influence and stimulation of Buddhism (which the Daoists saw as a rival religion, a feeling which the Buddhists reciprocated), Daoism also developed an institutional apparatus: a very large set of scriptures, rituals, and deities; a priesthood; and temples.

For the individual, the Daoist scriptures and priests established rules of behavior, rituals, and techniques that promised longevity or even immortality and other special powers. The use of alchemy to produce elixirs of immortality (mercury was often a key ingredient!) was a practice that went back at least to the Qin dynasty, but during the period of division, Daoism came to put more emphasis on diet, exercises, and moral discipline as techniques for preserving the body and its primal energy (*qi*) and thus achieving longevity. In addition, popular Daoist healers, like the leaders of the Yellow Turbans, promised to cure diseases by administering mysterious medicines and/or receiving confessions of sin and donations.

Religious Daoism was not necessarily political, but some Daoist texts and Daoist leaders offered their followers a millenarian vision of cataclysmic events in which the evil (nonbelievers) would be punished, the good would be saved, and a new, better, egalitarian world would be born. Sometimes these events were to be helped along by divine beings or ghosts. At other times, Daoist leaders, such as Tang Yuzhi mentioned above, tapping into the frustration or desperation of the poor, would lead an uprising to help usher in the new Daoist world order.

Over time the more peaceful and less politicized versions of religious Daoism entered the state-sponsored mainstream of Chinese life in both the north and the south. Ge Hong (283–343), an alchemist and Daoist philosopher, set the tone in his well-known book entitled *The Master Who Embraces Simplicity*. He expounded on the dao and described his failed attempts to manufacture the elixir of immortality, but condemned those anti-Confucian and rebellious Daoist leaders and their followers as false Daoists. He asserted that anyone who desired to achieve longevity and immortality must not only practice Daoist techniques and discipline, but must also live in accordance with Confucian moral principles which, he was sure, were in no way contradictory to the dao. Nonetheless, popular Daoism of the sort that Ge Hong deplored continued to exist as a substrate of Chinese religious beliefs, and as an inspiration for rebellions. Daoism had, however, also become an institutionalized religion. Daoist institutions and scriptures were established in response to, and in imitation of, the institutional structure of Buddhism.

Buddhism, the third of the Three Teachings, came from outside of China. The historical Buddha, Siddhartha Gautama, was a prince, born and raised in the area of modern Nepal and northern India. Leaving the princely life behind to seek spiritual enlightenment, the Buddha (literally, “the enlightened one”), drawing on already existing Hindu beliefs, taught that all things are impermanent and that all sentient beings are caught in a cycle of birth, death, and rebirth, with the circumstances of each rebirth being determined by the karma (the energy created by good and bad actions) generated in the previous life. The only escape from this unending cycle of suffering was to achieve enlightenment through a process of correct living and meditation, and thus to enter Nirvana.

The Buddha’s teachings are summed up in the Four Noble Truths:

1. All things are impermanent, and thus life is filled with sorrow.

2. The cause of sorrow is desire.
3. Sorrow can be stopped only by ending desire.
4. Desire can be ended through a life of discipline and meditation as a monk.

Several hundred years after the Buddha's death, the Buddhist religion had developed into two major sects. Theravada Buddhism was closest to the Buddha's original teachings. It maintained that the only way to reach salvation was through the disciplined life and meditation of a monk. Mahayana Buddhism offered a more richly varied panoply of religious practice and devotional acts for both the monk and the layperson. Mahayana postulated the existence of bodhisattvas—generous spiritual beings who have vowed not to enter Nirvana until they have assisted all sentient beings to achieve enlightenment. The concept of the bodhisattva introduced the possibility that even laypeople could achieve salvation (or at least rebirth into a Heavenly realm in which a meditative life would be easier to achieve) by appealing to the grace of a bodhisattva. Since their teachings offered everyone a ride to salvation, followers of Mahayana (literally “Greater Vehicle”) Buddhism dubbed Theravada teachings “Hinayana,” that is, the “Lesser Vehicle.” Both Theravada and Mahayana Buddhism were brought to China by trade routes, overland and maritime, but it was Mahayana Buddhism, traveling predominantly along the overland trade routes from India through Central Asia that became the dominant form of Buddhism in China.

Buddhism came to China at least as early as the Eastern Han dynasty, but it did not gain broad popularity, even among the elite, until after the fall of Han. When the Han dynasty collapsed, so did Confucian teachings' monopoly on the spiritual and philosophical lives of the Chinese. As we have seen, Confucian philosophy, ethics, and ritual were still fundamental to Chinese family life and political organization, but without the strong alliance between orthodox scholarship and a powerful imperial government, many Chinese thinkers were open to exploring alternative philosophical and religious ideas. The Learning of the Mysterious and the rise of religious Daoism are both part of the more diverse religious and philosophical world from the late Han through the period of division. So too was the rise of Buddhism.

Buddhism grew to importance slowly because it took time to bring the texts and teachings of this very different religion to China and to translate them into Chinese. Translators like Kumarajiva, an Indian monk who led a massive translation bureau in Chang'an (where he was active from 402 to 413), struggled to find appropriate Chinese equivalents for Indian religious concepts that were quite unfamiliar, and sometimes repugnant to, the Chinese. One fruitful approach was to use Daoist and Confucian terms, some of them taken from the Learning of the Mysterious. For instance, the Buddhist concept of Emptiness (the idea that all things are temporary combinations of elements and have no permanent nature or existence of themselves) could be captured by using the Learning of the Mysterious concept of Nonbeing (*wu*). The use of Daoist terms, bad translations (particularly at the beginning), and the fact that religious Daoism was simultaneously borrowing ideas and institutional structures from Buddhism led many Chinese in the Three Kingdoms and Western Jin to regard Buddhism as a variety of Daoism.

As Buddhism came to be better translated it attracted more followers, both elite and commoner, with its promise of release from suffering (of which there was no shortage). Emperors and elite families in both the Turkic/ Tibetan-dominated north and the Chinese-ruled south patronized Buddhist temples and monasteries. At the same time, however, many Chinese, including rulers (north and south), had reservations about the influence of the Buddhist religion and, perhaps even more so, feared the growing economic power of Buddhist monasteries, temples, and monks.

Many Buddhist teachings (such as Emptiness) were merely strange. Others violated cherished Chinese family and political values. Advocates of Buddhism had to argue that the Chinese classics did not have a monopoly on wisdom, that Confucius would not have objected to monks shaving their heads (despite the passage in the *Analec*s which calls on men not to injure the body, limbs, hair, or skin, as they are gifts from one's parents), and that it was reasonable for a monk to “accumulate goodness and wisdom in exchange for the joys of wife and children,” despite traditional emphasis on the importance of bearing sons to continue the family line.¹⁵

Perhaps even more serious were questions involving the relations between Buddhism and the state. In the Eastern Jin the monk Huiyuan (334–416) argued that because a monk has stepped outside the world of ordinary men, he is not obliged to bow down before a king. The authorities of the day accepted this argument, but relations between imperial governments on the one hand and monks, monasteries, and temples on the other were often difficult. Emperors north and south did patronize Buddhism, sometimes to the point of extravagance. Emperor Wu of Liang (in the south, r. 502–549) gave himself as a hostage to a monastery three times, each time requiring his government to redeem him with a generous ransom. This sort of generous imperial support, the tax-free status of Buddhist

establishments, and their substantial business interests and landholdings were matters of concern to insecure states.

In both the north and the south, imperial governments cracked down on monasteries when they felt threatened by monastic power. When this happened, thousands or tens of thousands of monks and nuns would be defrocked and returned to lay life, wealth would be confiscated, and monastic land and monastic tenants would be returned to the tax rolls. Such crackdowns were more thorough and more effective in the north, where Buddhism was more dependent on imperial sponsorship. In the south, elite family sponsorship of Buddhism and elite family independence from the state combined to limit the state's ability to control and punish Buddhist institutions.

The Three Teachings were only part of the religious landscape. The working belief systems of commoners and of the elite combined elements of Confucian ethics and ritual, beliefs and practices related to Daoism and Buddhism, and a variety of other beliefs and practices. There were funeral and memorial services for the dead, rituals to express reverence for one's ancestors, and the belief that the ancestors were an active presence in the world of the living. There were festivals, most notably the lunar New Year's festivities, which marked the passage of time, kept the cosmos running, ensured and gave thanks for the harvest, and safe-guarded the community. There were practices meant to establish communication with the spirit realm: consultations with spirit mediums, prayers and offerings to spirits, and rituals to communicate with the Jade Emperor in Heaven and the bureaucracy of gods under his command.¹⁶

The Transformation of Culture

The north and the south also shared broad trends in the transformation of Chinese culture. The elite of the Qin and Han dynasties had overwhelmingly regarded literature, art, and music as ways to convey moral teaching and government policy. What the Han dynasty "Great Preface" to the *Book of Songs* (also called the *Classics of Poetry*, or the *Odes*) said about poetry could, by extension, be applied to prose, calligraphy, painting, sculpture, and music:

To correct achievements and failures, to move Heaven and Earth, to stir the gods and spirits, there is nothing more apposite than poetry. By it the former kings managed the relations between husbands and wives, perfected the respect due to parents and superiors, gave depth to human relations, beautifully taught and transformed the people, and changed local customs.¹⁷

This state-centered moral didacticism informed understanding of the arts. With the fall of the Eastern Han, the horizons of art, music, and literature broadened to give greater scope to individual expression. Some resisted these changes. State patronage (and control) of art and literature remained strong. So too did moral didacticism, which could be used both by and against the government. Nonetheless, the change was significant enough that even state-sponsored culture of the period of north-south division looked very different from that of the Qin and Han periods.

Daoism and Buddhism were particularly important for Chinese art, music, and literature. Daoist aesthetics, for example, transformed calligraphy. Qin and Han calligraphers executed Chinese characters in the seal and clerical scripts (*zhuan* and *li*), forms whose right angles and unmodulated strokes symbolized power as they communicated the policies of the state.¹⁸ Beginning in the late Han, calligraphers began to treat writing as an art in itself and to develop forms of script which allowed expression of the calligrapher's character and aesthetic sensibilities: the regular script (*kaishu*), cursive script (*xingshu*), and especially the drafting script (*caoshu*).

The cursive and drafting scripts allowed the calligrapher to treat the writing of Chinese characters more as an artistic process. They modified and connected the strokes or even omitted them, sometimes to the point at which the character becomes virtually unrecognizable to any but a highly trained observer. Naturalness, individuality, and eccentricity were highly admired. The pioneers of calligraphy as an art form include Lady Wei (272–349), her student Wang Xizhi (303–361), and Wang's son, Wang Xianzhi (344–388). Wang Xizhi's most famous piece, the "Preface to the Poems Composed at the Orchid Pavilion" written in 353, survives only in copies of copies, but is regarded as having initiated a revolution in Chinese calligraphy.

Just as calligraphy became an art for its own sake, so poetry and prose literature moved away from moral didacticism.¹⁹ Here, not only Daoism, but also Buddhism, are as significant as the collapse of state-sponsored orthodoxy. Translating Buddhist sutras from Indian languages into Chinese introduced the idea of writing prose tales in a semivernacular style instead of in the purposely archaic formal style and grammar used for official documents. Buddhism and Daoism also contributed to the development of genres devoted to tales of the strange and supernatural

and to pseudo-biographies of Daoist immortals.



A copy of Wang Xizhi's most famous piece of calligraphy, "Preface to the Poems Composed at the Orchid Pavilion."

In poetry, the development of literature for its own sake began in the Cao Wei kingdom. Cao Cao and his sons Cao Pi and Cao Zhi were notable patrons and practitioners of poetry. Cao Wei poets wrote intensely personal work on their experiences and observations of a society suffering through innumerable wars, as well as occasional poetry meant to flatter their patrons. Five-syllable (pentasyllabic) poetry, which would become one of the most important poetic forms of the Tang period, received its first major development. With the rise of the Sima clan and the founding of the Western Jin, the lives of poets became quite dangerous. Poetry accordingly became less personal and political. The poet Tao Qian (372?–427) expressed the escapist attitude of the times in his celebrated story of the Peach Blossom Spring, a pastoral hidden land which had remained untouched by the travails of the real world since the Qin dynasty. Tao himself, unwilling to engage in a corrupt and dangerous public life, had chosen to really live the Daoist ideals celebrated in the abstract by many of his contemporaries: he had withdrawn for thirteen years to the countryside to become a farmer—probably meaning that he occasionally oversaw the labor of his serfs, who he describes in another text as coming out to welcome him.²⁰

Moralistic poetry with strong Confucian themes was not by any means dead: Xiao Tong (501–31), a prince of the southern Liang dynasty, sponsored the poetry anthology *Literary Selections*. While including works of personal expression, the compilation is generally informed by a conservative concern with taking one's stand on moral principle. Still, Xiao Tong's younger brother, Prince Xiao Gang (503–51), is more representative of the spirit of the age. Xiao Gang was an ardent lay Buddhist and the author of numerous writings on Buddhism. He was also a poet-prince who fully enjoyed the pleasures of his many concubines and who sponsored the *New Songs from a Jade Terrace*—a collection of poems that celebrate the pleasures of love and life in the palace.²¹ In some of his poems, Xiao Gang manages to combine the themes of palace poetry with the Buddhist theme of the transitory nature of life:

She who was once like a pink lotus,
Moving gently on green water's margin,
Today seems like a tree of white flowers,
Full of sadness, in front of her mirror.²²

The synthesis of (and sometimes conflict between) staid Confucian morality, unrestrained Daoist naturalness, and South and Central Asian cultural influence is also evident in the art and music of the centuries of division. The most notable developments in painting came in the south. The paintings of human subjects and of landscapes by Gu Kaizhi (c.345–c.406), of the Eastern Jin period, had a strong influence on future generations. Landscape painting in particular became a genre associated with the painters of the Southern Dynasties. Artists in both the north and the south, however, also painted scenes depicting the stories of Confucian moral exemplars and, increasingly, of Buddhas and bodhisattvas.

South Asian influence was evident in the art and even the art theory of both the north and the south during the period of division. Xie He (fl. 500) was the first to systematically discuss the theory of painting in China. His "Six Laws" summarize the essence of painting in terms of movement, the use of the brush, the imaging of form, application of color, positioning and placement, and modeling and depiction. They are clearly drawn from a Sanskrit text on painting, the *Six Limbs*.²³ In the practice of art, however, the most striking evidence of South and Central Asian influence comes in the form of monumental Buddhist statuary created under the patronage of the Northern Dynasties. Chinese Buddhist statuary received and adapted the Gandharan and Mathura styles of Buddhist sculpture,

which themselves had incorporated elements such as the high aquiline nose and portrayal of the folds of the statues' draped robes from the Hellenistic tradition.



Two Buddhist statues, visible through the collapsed front of one of the caves at Yungang Grottoes near Datong, Shanxi province.

The Yungang caves near Datong in the northwest hold the most famous Chinese Buddhist sculpture of the Northern Dynasties. These statues were carved between 451 and 494 CE when Datong was the site of the Northern Tuoba Wei court. The sponsors included not only the court, but also monks, nuns, and lay men and women, including common folk who pooled their money in order to be able to generate blessings for themselves and their families by employing craftsmen to carve these Buddhas and bodhisattvas. Northern Dynasties Buddhist art is also preserved at the Mogao caves in Dunhuang, a caravan city on the far northwestern edge of the Chinese world, where statues and murals vividly attest to the way in which South and Central Asian art styles and themes were brought into and adapted to the Chinese world.

Toward Reunification

The various ethnic groups of the north and the south shared many cultural elements: Confucianism, Buddhism, and Daoism, agriculture and bureaucracy, Sunzi's *Art of War* and Zhuangzi's pacifism, patriarchal family structure and a leading role in government for aristocratic clans. In the long term, these shared characteristics, in combination with the sheer numerical superiority of the Han Chinese population, led to a mixing of ethnic groups. Styles of painting, poetry, and literature—and sometimes the artists and poets themselves—moved across the shifting boundaries between the territories of the Northern and Southern Dynasties. The Xiongnu, Di, Jie, Qiang, and Xianbei of the north and the Mountain Yue of the south gradually lost their distinct languages and identities. As they merged with the larger Han Chinese population, these non-Han people changed Chinese culture as well. The changes were especially noticeable in the north, where the blending of Turkic and Chinese elites over time produced a new aristocratic society. The new aristocratic families of the north owed much of their martial, horseriding, Buddhist identity to their Turkic Central Asian heritage.

Central Asian musical instruments, notably the *pipa* (a lute-like plucked string instrument) and the *huqin* (a two-stringed fiddle) entered the mainstream of Chinese musical culture. Northern music and poetry absorbed the cadences of Central Asian folk music, and northern women were more independent and played a greater role in public than their sisters in the south. An unknown poet of the fifth or sixth century celebrated, or perhaps exaggerated, this female independence in the “Song of Mulan,” which later writers expanded into a play, and, ultimately, a Disney movie. The original poem tells of a daughter who disguises herself as a man in order to take her father's place in the army of the khan, the Son of Heaven. As one passage put it:

She goes ten thousand miles on the business of war,
She crosses passes and mountains like flying.
Northern gusts carry the rattle of army pots,

Chilly light shines on iron armor.
Generals die in a hundred battles,
Stout soldiers return after ten years.²⁴

Scholars in both the north and the south were conscious of the cultural styles that distinguished them from each other. Southerners regarded the forwardness of northern women as a strange characteristic and speculated that it might be a relic of earlier Tuoba Xianbei culture.²⁵ While southerners saw themselves as the heirs of the Han dynasty and the guardians of orthodox Chinese culture, northerners characterized the south as an unhealthy swampland and declaimed:

Your rulers wear their hair short and never have long heads. The people decorate their bodies. You float on the three rivers or row on the five lakes, but have never been steeped in rites or music or reformed by laws. Even though some Qin and Han convicts have brought the true Chinese pronunciation, the unpleasant tongues of Min and Chu have not been transformed.²⁶

The shared cultural and linguistic characteristics were more significant than the differences between north and south. Debates about who was more cultured rested on shared cultural assumptions. Shared interests and characteristics went deeper than high culture to include basic elements of the economy and trade. Both northern and southern governments were centralized bureaucratic states struggling to administer—and to tax—agricultural economies. Northern and southern imperial governments shared the same basic structure inherited from the Qin and Han dynasties. Both faced similar challenges: how to keep agricultural land and farming families on the tax and corvée labor rolls when great families, high-ranking officials, monasteries, and temples all conspire to accumulate land, pay reduced or no taxes, and shelter their tenants from taxation and corvée labor. The Northern Wei and one of its successor states, the Northern Zhou (557–581), managed to increase both production and tax revenue by implementing the Equal Fields System. The Southern Dynasties, hamstrung by powerful elite families, did not do so well in this regard.

The Southern Dynasties were less well funded and less powerful than the northern imperial governments, but the southern economy was more highly commercialized. The south had more highly developed riverine and maritime trade than the north. The Northern Dynasties, on the other hand, were focused on the caravan trade, which linked China to Central Asia and beyond. Both the caravan trade and internal trade fluctuated with the violence and instability of the Sixteen Kingdoms period. The relative stability of Tuoba rule during the Northern Wei brought a strong recovery of domestic and long-distance commerce. The Northern Wei capital of Luoyang was the terminus of the caravan trade to Central Asia. Central Asian silverwork, Roman glass, and Buddhist sculptural styles derived ultimately from Greece all became parts of the Chinese world, while Chinese silk fabrics and silk technology traveled the other way.

A common culture and economic ties help to explain why the north and the south, under separate political rule for most of the time since the Eastern Han collapsed in the early 200s, should have been reunified in 589. The question was simply: Would the north conquer the south, or vice versa? In the south, the Chen dynasty (557–589) could claim to be the direct and legitimate heir of the Qin and Han—after all, the Qin royal seals were in the south, and the south had not been conquered by “Five Barbarians.” On the other hand, the north had some distinct advantages.

The economic and population center was still in the Central Plains, north of the Huai River. Estimates are that Northern (Tuoba) Wei had five million registered households. Even after Northern Wei had broken up, the Northern Qi had over three million households (for a population of approximately twenty million), while Northern Zhou had at least one million registered households. In the south, by contrast, the Liu dynasty at its strongest had nine hundred thousand registered households (for a population of about 5,170,000), and the Chen dynasty, when it was conquered by the Sui in 589, had a mere five hundred thousand registered households.²⁷ The demographic and economic and, therefore, military advantage lay firmly in the north.

Notes

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The Sui and Tang Dynasties

When the Roman Empire fell, it receded into myth, its many constituent parts never to be reunited; the Han dynasty, however, was the first in a line of empires which lasted until the 20th century and, in some respects, to the present. After nearly three centuries of creative disunity, the new empires of the Sui (581–618) and Tang (619–907) combined the Han model with new ideas and techniques developed during the centuries of division. The shortlived Sui dynasty reunited north and south, bringing all of China Proper once again under a single imperial government. The Tang dynasty then built an empire whose territory and protectorates extended from northern Vietnam to northern Korea, and northwest to Samarkand and Bukhara (in modern Uzbekistan) and Herat (in modern Afghanistan). At home, a strong agricultural economy and international trade allowed the Tang to create a sophisticated bureaucracy, a legal system, and a vibrant, creative, and eclectic religious and cultural life which would influence all the neighboring civilizations and remain an inspiration and example to future Chinese dynastic rulers, officials, scholars, writers, and artists.

The Sui Dynasty

Yang Jian (r. 581–604), the founder of the Sui dynasty, was a member of the ethnically mixed, militaristic northwestern Chinese aristocracy that had developed during the period of division. The Yang clan had served and intermarried with the Xianbei for generations. Yang Jian was a general under the Northern Zhou, the last of the Xianbei dynasties of northern China. He served briefly as regent for his grandson, the last emperor of the Northern Zhou, before establishing himself as founding emperor of the Sui dynasty in 581.

Yang Jian came to power intending to conquer the south, but his first challenge would come from the north, where the Turks had built a sprawling empire from Zungharia in the west across Mongolia to Manchuria in the east. The Sui needed to neutralize the Turkish threat before they could send their armies south. Yang Jian achieved this through an aggressive counterattack against the Turkish offensive of 582. The Sui also benefited from the Turks' bad luck: an epidemic hit the Turks in that year, and in 583, internal fighting split the Turks into two competing empires, the Western Turks and the Eastern Turks. Yang Jian then turned his attention to the south, which he easily conquered in 589.

Although he was a product of the mixed-ethnicity northern aristocracy, Yang Jian made a point of emphasizing Han Chinese cultural identity. He encouraged everyone to adopt Chinese surnames, purged court music of "barbarian" tunes, and built a bureaucracy modeled on Qin and Han practice. Yang Jian also constructed a square-grid capital at the site of the old Han capital, Chang'an. At the same time, he consolidated the political and military power of both the northwestern aristocracy and the central government. One way he accomplished this was to bring agricultural land and farming families into the Equal Fields System—the same system devised by the Tuoba Wei dynasty. By bringing land under government control and assigning it to registered farming families, the Sui government limited the power of elite families—whose strength was ultimately based on their ability to acquire more and more agricultural land for themselves.

When he died, Yang Jian had built a strong empire that covered both northern and southern China. He had constructed the capital at Chang'an and had begun several more ambitious projects: a canal to connect the Yangzi Valley to the Yellow River area, a second capital at Luoyang, and the conquest of the Korean kingdom of Koguryo. It fell to his son, Yangdi, to carry these projects forward.

Yangdi's life stands in sharp contrast to that of his father. As crown prince, the future Yangdi had lived a simple life as long as his domineering father was alive. With Yang Jian dead, he revelled in luxury, built many palaces for

himself and took expensive pleasure trips to the Yangzi Valley, having fallen in love with the mild climate, beautiful scenery, cuisine, and culture of the area. His decision to build a secondary capital at Luoyang and to construct a canal linking the Yangzi Valley to the new city were partly due to his liking for luxury and for the south. However, there were also very practical reasons for these expensive projects.



Rebellions in the late Sui.

The imperial capital of Chang'an was a glorious city, the largest in the world at the time, but it held too many people to be fed by grain produced nearby. Chang'an's inhabitants and visitors had to pay high prices for grain and sometimes could not get it at all. Luoyang was on the other side of the passes and at the confluence of the Luo and the Yellow Rivers, so it had access to the grain-producing areas of the Central Plains. If linked to the south by canal, Luoyang would also have access to the potentially even more productive rice basket of the Yangzi Valley. Furthermore, control of Luoyang would prevent any potential rival from taking this key area.

Yangdi was also determined to fulfill his father's ambition of subjugating the Korean kingdom of Koguryo. The Sui rulers saw Koguryo—which held parts of present-day Manchuria and the northern part of the Korean peninsula—as a part of the former Han and Jin Empires: territory that the Sui needed to recover, just as they had recovered the south. The Sui also feared an alliance between Koguryo and the Eastern Turks.¹ Four attacks on Koguryo in 598, 612, 613, and 614 all ended in defeat and tremendous losses for the Sui.

At the same time that he was conducting the failed campaigns against Koguryo, Yangdi ordered the construction of a network of canals to link Luoyang, the Central Plains, the Huai Valley, and the increasingly important and productive Jiangnan (lower Yangzi) region, the old kingdom of Sun Wu. Hundreds of thousands of men and women were taken from their fields to work on the canals. Hundreds of thousands more were mobilized for the armies, only to lose their lives in the failed invasions of Koguryo. Then the Yellow River flooded disastrously in 611. Farmers, powerful local families, scholars, and even officers of the Sui armies rebelled beginning in 613, reaching an empirewide crescendo by 617. Yangdi, whose officials often feared to communicate bad news lest they be punished, fled to his beloved south, where he was murdered by a descendant of the Northern Zhou ruling house from which his father, Yang Jian, had taken the throne in 581.

Foundations and Structure of the Tang Empire

Suffering commoners fleeing from taxation, forced labor, and starvation filled the ranks of the many armies rebelling against the Sui. Their leaders, however, were prominent and powerful men, most of them generals or high-ranking officials of the Sui itself. As they contended with each other to found the next dynasty, the Eastern

Turks looked on with interest and offered their support to whichever leaders seemed most likely to weaken the Sui or each other. The ultimate beneficiary of this situation was Li Yuan (566–635).

Li Yuan was a Sui general stationed in the northwestern garrison town of Taiyuan, where he was to defend the realm against the Eastern Turks. As the Sui fell to pieces, Li Yuan made peace with the Turkish khan (thus securing his rear) and sallied forth to compete with tens of other rebel leaders for control of the capital and the Sui territory. His daughter (later ennobled as Princess Pingyang, ?–623) raised a substantial army by distributing property from her estates near the Sui capital and by making alliances with local rebel and bandit groups.² Li Yuan, assisted by his sons Li Jiancheng and Li Shimin, took the Sui capital at Chang'an in 617 and declared himself founder and first emperor of the Tang dynasty. With that declaration began the history of one of China's most fabled and glorious dynastic periods, which would last nearly as long as the period of division that had preceded it—almost three hundred years.

Li Yuan (r. as Tang emperor Gaozu 618–27) and his son Li Shimin, or Emperor Taizong (r. 627–50), between them secured all of the territory of the Sui and established the institutions of the Tang state. Many of the smaller contenders for power willingly surrendered to the Tang; they, their armies, and their territories were duly incorporated into the empire. The more serious rivals—those who thought they had a chance of defeating the Tang—were defeated in battle. In Chang'an, Li Yuan and his officials rebuilt civil government and law, taking the Sui institutions as their pattern—institutions that had in turn been based on Qin and Han models, as modified by the Northern Tuoba Wei. The Tang model of government, which Korea and Japan imported and adapted, was the culmination of techniques developed beginning with the breakdown of feudalism in the late Zhou and legitimated by layered sets of ideologies, the earliest layer being the Zhou myths about the conquest of Shang.

In this government structure the emperor stood as the unchallenged head of the bureaucracy, assisted by a Secretariat (which drafted edicts) and a Chancellery (which reviewed the edicts and made suggestions). The Department of State was charged with putting edicts into effect through its Six Ministries: Personnel, Revenue, Rites, War, Punishments, and Works. The empire itself was divided into prefectures, with each prefecture subdivided into counties for a total of about fifteen hundred local governments. The Tang did establish an examination system for talented men who sought public office, but the vast majority of government posts were filled by hereditary privilege, with the top posts going to men whose clans had a personal, often a family, relationship to the ruling Li clan. Tang China was still very much an aristocratic empire, run by northwestern clans who, like the Li clan, had one foot in the Turkic world of the steppes and one in the sedentary Chinese world. Indeed, men like Tang Taizong (Li Shimin), who had grown up on the frontiers, spoke both Turkish and Chinese and drew on both cultural traditions.

Li Shimin was a gifted strategist and fighter who personally led his cavalry troops into many a battle. But he was not the crown prince. That honor belonged to his elder brother Li Jiancheng. The two brothers clearly regarded each other with the deepest suspicion, and with reason, as each was actively plotting the other's downfall. As it happened, Li Shimin and twelve handpicked men ambushed Jiancheng and younger brother Li Yuanji as they approached Chang'an's Xuanwu Gate. Li Shimin slaughtered his brother, the crown prince. He then arranged his father's abdication and took power himself. The act was brutal, but it assured a smooth transition and the continued consolidation of Tang rule under Shimin's very capable leadership. Recognizing that the imperial government was, as the saying had it, supported by the people as a boat is supported by the water—and that the people can overturn the government just as the water can overturn a boat—Li Shimin gave great attention to the most basic of economic issues: grain, labor, and armies.

Grain, Labor, and Armies

The Tang dynasty is famous for its territorial expansion, its great cities and palaces, its flourishing foreign trade, its art, literature, and religious life, and for the luxurious lives of its aristocrats. This power and glory was possible only because the imperial government controlled grain production, labor, and armies. When the Tang state lost control of these things its power declined and it was less able to deal with internal and external crises.

The early Tang emperors adopted the institutions of the Northern Dynasties and the Sui: the Equal Fields System, grain and silk taxes, and compulsory labor service. Under the Equal Fields System, the state assigned a set amount of land to each adult male in a family, with smaller assignments for women, the elderly, and slaves. All land assignments were reviewed every three years and the allocations adjusted to reflect changes in the composition of

each family. In addition, each family received a small plot of heritable land. The purpose of the Equal Fields System was to build an economy of individual farming families who would pay annual taxes: 3 bushels (100 liters) of grain, 40 (later 20) feet (12 and 6 m) of silk or linen cloth, and 3 ounces (85 g) of silk floss or 3 pounds (1.4 kg) of hemp thread. Each adult male also had to work at tasks such as wall-building or grain transport for the government for twenty days a year (or find a substitute to take his place).

This was an unwieldy system. Bulky taxes collected in kind had to be transported to where they were needed, at great expense. Since some areas had less farmland than others, or land that was less fertile, the allocations had to be varied to accommodate local circumstances. In the long run, the bureaucratic task of registering and repeatedly re-registering the population and adjusting the land allocations accordingly proved to be impossible. From the beginning, there were also exemptions: the imperial family, northern and southern aristocrats, high-ranking officials, and Buddhist and Daoist institutions owned large estates that were entirely outside the Equal Fields System.

Although it lasted for nearly a hundred years, the Equal Fields System slowly declined and collapsed by around 756, when the state recognized that in fact land had reverted to private ownership. In a major change, beginning in 780, the Tang collected a twice-a-year tax calculated on the basis of how much land a family held, not on how many people were in the family, and the tax was assessed in cash (although it was payable mostly in grain and silk). The twice-a-year tax served the same purpose as the Equal Fields System: to transfer grain from the farmer to the government.

The average Tang farming family grew wheat, millet, or barley in the north, rice in the south. The diet was supplemented by vegetables, game, fish, and occasionally the meat of domesticated animals. The women wove cloth of ramie (a plant of the nettle family cultivated for its fiber), hemp, or silk. Tang peasants, particularly those in the north (closer to the capital) were hardpressed by regular Equal Fields or twice-a-year taxes, various surtaxes and local taxes, twenty days (per adult male per year) of compulsory labor for the imperial government, and additional compulsory labor for the local government. On top of that, men faced the prospect of serving in the local government's militia or being drafted into an expeditionary army for three years or more. Many northern peasants voted with their feet, absconding from their assigned lands and fleeing to the south, where they might rent land from big landlords (tenants did not pay taxes) or settle on newly opened land on the southern frontiers, where incomplete control meant that they were less likely to face taxation, compulsory labor, and conscription.

As the Tang Empire expanded, conscription became a heavy burden, especially in areas near the capital. The early Tang emperors maintained standing armies and rotating militias (manned by peasant conscripts) to guard the capital cities and to maintain light garrisons on the frontier. Large expeditionary forces were organized on an ad hoc basis from the militias and from conscripts. As the empire conquered new territory in the mid- to late seventh century, the Tang created permanent garrison armies strung out along the northern frontier and all the way into Central Asia. By 722, the Tang had armies totaling over six hundred thousand men, including foreign commanders and troops (particularly cavalry) in the service of the Tang.³ These armies, their men drawn from the farming families and their food, clothing, and equipment produced by the Tang people, created and guarded one of the largest empires of the time.

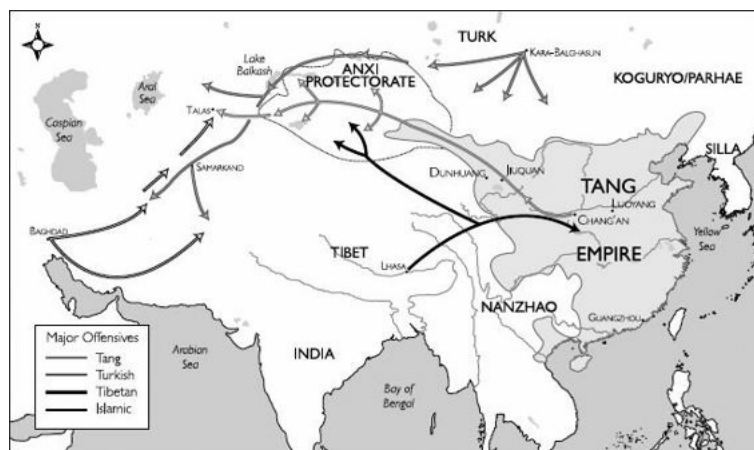
Borders and Trade

Tang military expansion was directed first and foremost toward the north and northwest, where the empire's needs for defense against nomads (particularly the Turks) coincided with its interest in controlling the Central Asian trade routes—the Silk Road. Campaigns in this direction brought the Tang into contact and conflict with the Turkish (and later Uighur) Empire in Mongolia, with the Tibetan Empire, and even with the Muslim Abbasid Caliphate as it expanded from Persia into Central Asia. In addition, the Tang established a short-lived commandery in northern Korea, defended its southwestern borders against the independent state of Nanzhao (in modern Yunnan province), and asserted colonial control over Annam (northern Vietnam). However, it was the north that occupied the Tang government's greatest attention.

At first, the Tang dynasty's policy toward its neighbors to the north was cautious. The Eastern Turks were stronger than the newly-established Tang in 618. Li Yuan and Li Shimin were initially unprepared to fight the Turks, and instead bought peace by periodically presenting them with generous gifts of silk and other luxury goods. In a famous incident of September 626, the newly enthroned Li Shimin himself, in a show of deference, left the walled city of Chang'an to give gold and silk to the Turkish khan, who had led an army of one hundred thousand to

within twelve miles of the city. Such indulgent tactics were, however, a temporary expedient. In the long run, Li Shimin's goal was to defeat the Eastern Turks and to send his forces into Central Asia. In 629–30, he sent six expeditionary armies totaling around one hundred thousand men against the Turkish khan. In imitation of the Turks, with whose culture he was quite familiar, Li Shimin had built his own Turkish-style light, mobile cavalry. The Turks, weakened by the loss of massive numbers of livestock due to heavy snows in Mongolia in the winter of 627 and wracked by internal rebellions, were no match for the Tang forces. The Eastern Turkish khan was defeated, and his empire collapsed.⁴ The way was open for further Tang expansion into the northwest.

Li Shimin and his successors sent their armies deep into Central Asia in order to control the trade routes. At its greatest extent, the might of the Tang Empire extended into modern Afghanistan and Uzbekistan, and to the borders of Iran, even clashing with (and losing to) the Abbasid Caliphate at the Talas River in modern Kyrgyzstan in 751. These far-flung territories were not under direct Tang civil administration, but Tang armies guaranteed that local rulers acknowledged the Tang as their master and thus supported Tang interests in the trade routes passing through such fabled cities as Khotan, Kashgar, Samarkand, and Tashkent: cities almost as exotic to Tang subjects in the east as they were to Europeans.



[The Tang Empire.](#)

In theory, the Tang government regarded merchants with disdain. The law certainly discriminated against them, and men of merchant background were not supposed to become officials. Despite the laws, merchants gained significant power as trade, including foreign trade, flourished. Increased agricultural productivity throughout the empire, the road and canal systems centering on Luoyang and Chang'an, the popularity of the southern ports among Arab, Indian, and Persian mariners, and Tang control of the Silk Road all contributed to the making of great merchant fortunes. The poet Yuan Zhen (779–831) described a merchant as follows:

Traversing the oceans in search of pearls, gathering jade on Chu's Mount Heng,
North to buy Tangut horses, west to capture parrots in Tibet.
The fireproof cloth of the south, and Sichuan's woven brocades,
Slave girls of Yue, plump and smooth, bright-faced Tatar slave boys.
Calculating the cost of food and clothing, caring nothing for the distance of the journey,
Traversing all under Heaven, to then arrive in the city of Chang'an.⁵

One could see and hear the results of trade on the streets and in the inns and taverns of Chang'an and Luoyang, and even in the fields and homes of the common farmers of the Yangzi Valley.

The Tang's main export was silk. However, silk—woven by the women of hundreds of thousands of farming families and tendered to the government as taxes—was a tremendously profitable commodity. It was silk, more than anything else, that paid for a tremendous variety of imports which could be found in the markets of Luoyang and Chang'an.

Tang cities were cosmopolitan centers for trade and consumption of all goods, from luxuries to everyday

commodities. In the great West Market of Chang'an, Sogdian merchants rubbed elbows with Turkish or Uighur horsetraders and moneylenders. Foreign communities in Chinese cities had their Manichean temples, Nestorian Christian churches, Zoroastrian shrines, and Muslim mosques. In the southern port cities of Guangzhou and Jiaozhou (modern Hanoi), Arab and Persian seafarers congregated by the thousands. Peas, spinach, and garlic from the west enhanced Tang cuisine and came to be locally grown, as did pistachios and sesame from Persia, sugar and black pepper from India, and almonds from Turkestan. Coriander from the Mediterranean, and grape wine from Tashkent could be had in Chang'an.⁶ Glassware and the delicate work of Persian silversmiths and goldsmiths were popular among the wealthy households. Oven-baked breads and even the wok (Chinese cooking pan) were also imports from Central Asia.



Tang aristocratic women riding on horseback. Painted by Li Kung-lin, a 12th-century reproduction of a hand-scroll painted in the Tang dynasty by Zhang Xuan.

Arts, food, and cooking techniques from abroad had a long-term influence on Chinese culture. But for the Tang government, the most valuable import was horses. The pasturelands of the Turks provided the most convenient access to horses, while Central Asia, particularly Sogdiana, was as famous in the Tang as it had been in the Han for the quality of its horses. The heartland of China Proper had neither the climate nor the pasturage for horse-breeding—yet the Tang armies relied on horses. Control of the pasturelands was a crucial matter for imperial military preparedness, and thus as important as control of the trade in luxury goods. The infatuation with horses is amply illustrated by the prominence of horses in Tang art: the most famous are earthenware horses finished in a unique three-colored glaze.

Buddhism and Buddhist Monasteries

As in the period of north-south division, Buddhist monks also traveled the overland and maritime routes from China to India. In 629 the monk Xuanzang (c. 600–664) left the Tang Empire secretly and illegally (the emperor feared any possible collusion with the Turks or other Central Asian powers) in order to study and purchase Buddhist scriptures (sutras) in India. Xuanzang's long and dangerous travels took him ten thousand miles across mountains, down rivers, through the Buddhist kingdoms of Central Asia and modern Afghanistan, Pakistan, and India, and finally, in 645, back to Chang'an. On his return, Xuanzang was welcomed by Emperor Taizong, who debriefed him thoroughly about the political and military situations of the kingdoms through which he had passed. Xuanzang, in turn, is credited with having won Taizong's support for Buddhism—a religion about which the emperor, as a Daoist and purported descendant of Laozi, had rather mixed feelings. Taizong and his successor, Gaozong, supported Xuanzang, who devoted the rest of his life to translating and explicating the many Buddhist texts that he had brought back with him.⁷

Buddhists from India and Central Asia also came to the Tang Empire to teach and to translate, while Japanese

monks came to learn from Chinese and Indian masters. However, the major developments in Chinese Buddhism during the Tang were internal, as Chinese further adapted the Buddhist religion both at the level of popular practice and learned theology, and as Buddhist institutions and the clerical community of monks and nuns grew in size and power.

Most Tang people were illiterate. For them, Buddhism was a matter of simple beliefs and practices that supplemented their dealings with local gods, ghosts, demons, and ancestral spirits. Even educated people who could read difficult Buddhist texts combined Buddhist and Daoist beliefs and practices into their lives with, in general, no concern as to conflicting loyalties. The religious rituals, teachings, and personnel of the Daoist temples and Buddhist monasteries intersected with the everyday lives of the emperors, the aristocrats, and the ordinary people in many ways. Buddhist monks, for example, introduced the chair (a standard item of Indian monastic furniture) to the Chinese, and it was Buddhist monks in China who developed and popularized the drinking of tea in the Tang dynasty.⁸

For the common folk, festivals were the major occasions for the display of Buddhist devotion. There were Buddhist festivals held on the occasion of imperial birthdays, and Buddhist memorial services for deceased emperors. There was the three-day Lantern Festival in the middle of the first lunar month of the year, when the curfew was waived so that people could stay up and participate in processions, feasting, music, and revelry all night. There were special events such as the ceremonies to receive a relic of the Buddha (a putative finger bone) in Chang'an. The processions and ceremonies surrounding this event included commoners making such extreme manifestations of devoutness as burning or biting off their own fingers as offerings to the Buddha. Above all, on the fifteenth day of the seventh lunar month, commoners, aristocrats, and monks celebrated the Ghost Festival, at which they combined Confucian filial piety with Buddhist devotion by offering food and other goods to the souls of their ancestors in hopes of speeding their way out of the Buddhist hell realms and on to new incarnations in better worlds.⁹

Art was an important vehicle for both the expression and transmission of Buddhist belief. Sculpture gives us the best insights into the Buddhist art of the Tang, both because it was important at the time and because it has simply outlasted smaller and more perishable items such as embroidery, vestments, and ritual paraphernalia. The territorial unity of Tang China and its trade and cultural exchange with the civilizations of South, Southeast, and Central Asia gave Tang Buddhist sculpture a confident and cosmopolitan feel and a natural, realistic style.¹⁰ Like people during the period of division, Tang rulers and aristocratic patrons paid for beautiful statues carved into the rocks of the Longmen caves outside of Luoyang. These carvings, the first dating from 494 during the period of division, were done over a period of four hundred years. The statues indicate shifts in aesthetic tastes over time, and in the popularity of different objects of Buddhist devotion. Reverence for Sakyamuni (the historical Buddha) gives way first to worship of Maitreya (the Buddha of the future), then Amitabha (the Buddha of the Western Paradise or Pure Land), and Avalokitesvara (Chinese name, Guanyin, the bodhisattva of compassion).

In terms of monastic discipline and lay practice, Tang China saw the development of two major schools of Buddhism: Pure Land and Chan. Pure Land Buddhism was a devotional sect which focused on the Amitabha Buddha. According to Pure Land beliefs, Amitabha reigned over a "Pure Land" or "Western Paradise." He had vowed that anyone who dies while calling upon him, with devotion, would be reborn in the "Pure Land," from which it would be easier to achieve Nirvana. This provided a simple devotional practice that anyone—monk, nun, or layperson, educated or uneducated—could perform, and chants calling on "Amituofuo" became one of the most common Buddhist practices in East Asia.

The second school, Chan, became best known in the West under its Japanese name, Zen. While Pure Land Buddhism held forth the possibility of salvation by faith, the Chan, or Meditation, school taught that all people have the Buddha nature, but that they must realize it through meditation. There were two competing variations of Chan Buddhism, but that which became most popular held that the techniques of enlightenment must be passed directly from master to disciple and that enlightenment is realized suddenly, "in a flash." Some Chan masters were famous for shocking their disciples by striking them suddenly at just the right moment to precipitate that insight into their true, Buddha nature that Chan regards as enlightenment.

Flourishing under imperial patronage and with generous donations of goods, money, and land from devout people of all classes, Buddhist monasteries were not simply places of religious study and practice: they were also wealthy, diversified business enterprises. As such, monasteries and monks often came into conflict with the imperial government and were criticized by some Tang officials who believed that the Buddhist clergy—who neither farmed nor wove—were a financial burden on the government and on the hard-pressed taxpayers. Furthermore, there was

the serious problem of common folks pretending to be monks, or buying ordination certificates that legally identified one as a cleric (which the central and local governments sometimes sold in order to raise money) simply to enjoy the tax-free status of a monk.

The ambivalent government attitude toward the Buddhist establishment led to periodic anti-Buddhist campaigns. Tang Taizong, who sponsored Buddhist institutions, castigated some Buddhist monks for deceiving the people with false claims of magical healing powers, and he also prohibited the fabrication and sale of Buddhist and Daoist statues. Emperors Xuanzong (r. 712–56) and Wuzong (r. 840–46) both took measures to defrock spurious monks and to confiscate the wealth of large monasteries. The impetus for these measures was not a hatred for Buddhism: the real motives were financial. The imperial government was short of cash and concerned about the wealth of the Buddhist monasteries and the numbers of monks, spurious monks, and tenants and slaves of Buddhist monasteries who were off the tax rolls. Tens of thousands of monks and others were returned to the status of taxpaying citizens, while in some cases, able-bodied monks or monastery slaves were conscripted into the Tang armies.

The anti-Buddhist campaign of 842 destroyed as many as four thousand monasteries and temples and confiscated large amounts of monastic land. From then onward, the imperial government exerted stronger secular control over the religious establishment and did not allow monasteries again to accumulate such tremendous amounts of wealth and land. As a consequence, the Buddhist establishment never recovered the degree of power and respect that it had achieved at the height of the Tang.¹¹ Buddhism, to be sure, continued to permeate every aspect of life. But by regulating property and limiting ordination, Chinese imperial governments prevented institutional Buddhism from becoming a significant rival of the state. In Europe, a pope could sometimes bring a sovereign to his knees. In China, the emperors made a point of weakening established religion while at the same time drawing on its prestige and spiritual power to legitimate their own positions of authority.

Women in Tang China

Prior to the Sui reunification, a southern Chinese observer opined that northern women were inclined to “take charge of family affairs, entering into lawsuits, straightening out disagreements, and paying calls to seek favor.”¹² The Tang dynasty did indeed have a number of prominent women, including the only woman in Chinese history to take the throne and rule in her own name.

Ordinary Tang women wove cloth and worked in the fields. They were not publicly or legally regarded as the equals of men. For instance, women could not serve as witnesses, nor were their accomplishments or family backgrounds given much note in public writings such as epitaphs.¹³ However, as in earlier periods, women acted as household managers, generally when they were widowed, or when a husband or adult son was absent due to corvée labor or military service. In such circumstances, women controlled economic resources, made pious donations to Buddhist temples, paid taxes, took out loans, and entered into contracts. Women knew their legal rights, and would bring suit before the local magistrate for violation of contract. For example, sometime between the years 714 and 741, a woman named A’Liang in the northwestern city of Turfan contracted with a man, Bu Anbao, to care for her vineyard. When Bu failed to cover the vines in time, A’Liang filed a complaint with the local authorities.

We know very little about common women such as A’Liang, or about common men, for that matter. The women about whom we know the most are those who are least typical: the politically active wives and daughters of the imperial family. The most famous of those powerful women is Wu Zhao (623?–705), better known as Empress Wu Zetian.

Wu Zetian’s father, a lumber merchant in Shaanxi, had been an early supporter of Li Yuan’s uprising, and consequently became a high-ranking official in the Tang government. As a concubine of Tang Taizong and, after his death (and in violation of a taboo on cross-generational incest), of his son, Emperor Gaozong, Wu Zetian both symbolized and put into action the ties between the Wu and Li clans. Only one of many imperial concubines, she was ambitious, intelligent, and as ruthless as her first husband, Taizong, who had killed his brother: arranging the demotion of the reigning Empress Wang, Wu Zetian became empress in her place in 755. As with the competition among consorts and their children in the Han, this was more than simply the replacement of one woman by another: Gaozong’s court was divided into pro-Wang and pro-Wu factions, and when Wu ascended to power, so did those officials associated with her.

Gaozong was in poor health and, after 666, often incapacitated by the effects of a stroke that left him partially paralyzed. Empress Wu was, in effect, co-emperor, sharing and even taking entirely upon herself the emperor’s

responsibility to make decisions concerning everything from rituals to war and taxes. She used her power to elevate not only her own status but also the status of the palace women generally, by taking part in public ritual ceremonies. When her husband died in 683, Empress Wu put first one son, and then another, on the throne while acting as regent. Then, in 690, having forced both sons into “retirement,” Wu Zetian took an unprecedented step: she declared herself to be *huangdi* (the gender-neutral term the Qin founder had invented, and which we translate as “emperor”) and established her own dynasty, which she called the Zhou.

As a ruler, both before and after 690, Empress Wu followed much the same policies as other Tang emperors, except in her efforts to promote gender equality among the elite by receiving officials’ wives, arranging sericultural rituals at the imperial level, giving palace women official titles equivalent to those of male officials, and other such activities.¹⁴ Imperial expansion in the northwest continued, armies were sent to secure the frontiers when necessary, taxes and punishments were tempered by generous acts of grace in which the empress waived tax payments and released prisoners. The record indicates that she generally chose her officials wisely and used them well. Empress Wu was an avid patron of Daoism and, especially, of Buddhism. A remarkable statue of the Buddha Vairocana, Lord of the Universe, was carved at the Longmen cave-temple complex at her command. Empress Wu’s patronage of Buddhism was very much bound up with her use of Buddhism to claim legitimacy for her rule just as rulers during the period of division had done.¹⁵

On the other hand, even allowing for some exaggeration by later Confucian historians who disapproved of women in politics, Wu Zetian appears to have been one of the more mercilessly violent rulers in an era when cruelty was standard procedure. She arranged the slaughter of Gaozong’s children by other palace women and consolidated her regime by exercising a reign of terror over her political rivals. Her taking of lovers, including a former cosmetics salesman whom she ordained as abbot of the Buddhist White Horse Monastery (located outside of Luoyang), raised some eyebrows. (She later found another lover and arranged to have the monk assassinated.) None-theless, Empress Wu reigned secure into her old age: her son, Zhongzong, peacefully removed his elderly mother from the throne in 705 and restored the Tang.

Empress Wu was neither the first nor the last imperial woman to achieve political power. Empress Lü of the Han had seals carved in the imperial style with her name. Empress Deng, Ban Zhao’s pupil, and other Han empresses ruled as regents. Empress Wu’s daughter-in-law, Empress Wei (d. 710), and her daughter, Princess Taiping (d. 713), made bids for power, both of which ended in unhappy and untimely death for these women. Empress Wu’s reign and the ambitions of Empress Wei and Princess Taiping seem to have confirmed orthodox historians’ already strong prejudice against powerful women: the imperial histories are generally very critical of Empress Wu and her Zhou dynasty. Nonetheless, male aristocrats and officials would serve a powerful woman (as they would a weak man) if they thought it would benefit their careers. Few aristocratic women could aspire to be as powerful as Empress Wu. But the wives of the Tang elite did take an active role in running the family, educating the next generation, arranging marriages, and managing household industries (which could employ hundreds of people). Wives, and also concubines and female entertainers, could be as educated and sophisticated as elite Tang men. But no matter what their accomplishments, access to legitimate participation in the government bureaucracy was impossible for aristocratic women. As the renowned women poet Yu Xuanji put it when looking at the public list of successful civil service examination candidates posted on a wall in Chang’an:



Statue of the Vairocana Buddha, flanked by a disciple, at the Longmen grottoes near Luoyang. These statues were

carved for Empress Wu Zetian. According to some accounts, the Vairocana Buddha's face is that of the empress herself.

I wish my woman's clothing didn't obscure my poems,
Raising my head in vain, admiring the names on the honor rolls.¹⁶

Calligraphy, Poetry, Painting, and Music

For many of the aristocratic men who filled the bureaucratic posts of the Tang government, as much as for the aristocratic women like Yu Xuanji who were excluded from office, poetry, calligraphy, painting, and music were the essence of life. It was not merely that they enjoyed these things (though they certainly did); a man's career depended on his talents in the arts, particularly poetry and calligraphy. There were three main routes to government office: to be from a clan with a close relationship to the imperial house, to gain office by hereditary privilege, or (and this was a minority) to pass the civil service examinations. These examinations included both poetry and calligraphy sections as well as essays on philosophical and political issues. Furthermore, in order to do well on the examination, it was essential first to submit samples of one's poetry to the chief examiner and generally to impress him and other influential people with one's poetic and musical talents and with one's sociability and elegant manners.

Sui and Tang imperial patronage played a significant role in the development of calligraphy. Sui and early Tang calligraphers followed the example of Wang Xizhi (see above). The Sui dynasty Buddhist monk Zhiyong, a seventh-generation descendant of Wang Xizhi perpetuated the style of his illustrious ancestor. Demand for his work was so great, it was said, that guests wore out his doorsill, which he had to repair with iron.¹⁷ Tang Taizong, too, was a great admirer of Wang Xizhi: he is said to have ordered Wang's masterwork, the "Preface to the Poems Composed at the Orchid Pavilion," to be placed in his tomb when he died. Taizong's own excellent calligraphy and his patronage ensured that other calligraphers continued to work in the style of Wang Xizhi while each adding his own unique variation.

The Tang also saw many influential innovative calligraphic styles. Zhang Xu, or "Crazy Zhang" (active 710–750), and the "Drunken Monk" Huaisu (735?–800?) were both known for spontaneous, energetic, very abstract, and allegedly alcohol-fueled cursive, or drafting style, script. Both Huaisu and the Tang general and calligrapher Yan Zhenqing were students of "Crazy Zhang." Huaisu is best known for his expressive cursive "Autobiography." Yan Zhenqing, on the other hand, was famous for his *kaishu*, which showed the influence both of Wang Xizhi and of the monumental stele inscriptions of the Northern Dynasties. Admirers praised the bold, energetic, yet relaxed masculinity of his work. Detractors suggested that his characters looked like big peasant men standing in a field.

Although few became noted calligraphers, every educated man and woman had to practice calligraphy on some level. So too did every educated man and woman write prose and poetry. Much formal writing (including examination essays) was done in the highly allusive and carefully structured "parallel prose" style that had developed during the centuries of division. In the late Tang, scholars including Han Yu (768–824) attacked the rigid structure of parallel prose, advocating a return to a more straightforward style modeled on that of Han writers like the great historian Sima Qian. Han Yu's "revive antiquity" movement opened new possibilities, but parallel prose remained popular and was the required style for examination essays from the Tang all the way through to the Qing dynasty (1644–1911).¹⁸

Parallel prose and the "ancient" style favored by Han Yu were formal writing. There were also less formal styles of literature which entertained the people of Tang and influenced the development of Chinese fiction in later periods. "Transformation texts" (*bianwen*) began when Buddhist monks composed entertaining tales to communicate Buddhist beliefs to common folk. The "transformation text" style, which combined prose and poetry, colloquial and classical language, was soon adapted to nonreligious literature intended for the less educated reader.¹⁹

Another literary genre, the "marvel tale" (*chuanqi*), developed out of the tradition of biographical writing begun by Sima Qian. Tang marvel tales told of things like the exploits of martial heroes; dream visits to utopian societies; a woman and her lover who kill her husband and conceal the body, only to be reported to the authorities by the green parrot who witnessed the crime; or a man who marries the Dragon King's daughter (a character taken from Indian literature). In one tale, a young man who falls in love with a courtesan is rejected by his family, and then saved from poverty by the same courtesan, whose earnings put him through the civil service examinations and set him on the road to a brilliant career.²⁰ Many Tang tales were written by scholars for presentation to the chief examiner as a way

of giving a good impression of their literary abilities.²¹

The same men who were writing tales to impress examiners and parallel prose on the examinations themselves were also writing poetry. Poetry was, in fact, one of the required sections of the examination, as well as a social ability expected of any educated person. The Tang dynasty is accordingly famous for the quantity and the quality of its poetry. Though the *fu* (rhapsody) style of the Han dynasty remained popular, Tang poets particularly favored the *shi* (lyric) form, which called for anywhere from four to (rarely) as many as two hundred pentasyllabic lines.²² The works of an accomplished poet were characterized by careful attention to form and rich cultural allusions. As a result, translations into English tend to be pale and heavily-footnoted reflections of the originals.

The two most famous Tang poets are Li Bo (701–762) and Du Fu (712–770). Li Bo’s family was from modern Gansu, but he was born on the edges of the empire, near Lake Balkhash in modern Kazakhstan. The Xuanzong emperor invited him to court on the strength of his poetry, but Li Bo was unable to cultivate the right connections and thus never had a civil service career. He is known for his spirited poetry and his individualistic, free-wheeling persona. Du Fu was born into an aristocratic family that had come down in the world. His father was a minor official, and Du Fu himself held some minor court posts, but was disappointed with his career. His poetry is, on the whole, more sober and concerned with social justice than that of Li Bo.

It is in the work of these and many other Tang poets that we experience most directly life in Tang China as we read their descriptions of home and family, landscapes, palaces, and war, and as they speak out on behalf of the poor and the oppressed.

Li Bo and the late Tang official Bo Juyi (772–846) give striking descriptions of their everyday lives. Li Bo, for example, on a drinking party (and on the failure of his attempts to be an official):

Heaven gave me talent—it must be used!
I can spend a thousand pieces of gold, it will all come back to me
So stew a sheep, slaughter an ox, and we’ll have a ball
A drinking bout of at least three hundred cups!
Master Cen, esteemed scholar Danjiu
Bring wine without end,
And for you I’ll sing a song
So be pleased to bend your ears and hear!
Bells, drums, food lovely as jade, they’re nothing.
All I want is to be forever drunk, never sober
The sages and immortals of antiquity are all struck silent
Only the drinkers have left their names to posterity.²³

Bo Juyi, writing with more restraint, describes “Enjoying a Party on a Rainy Night Together with the Courtesans of the Niu Household” thus:

Jade pipes and clear strings: their sounds flourishing;
Kingfisher hairpins and red sleeves: they sit entangled.
Two households perform together in the inner chambers,
In the eighth month, the time of continuous shade and autumn rain.
On singers’ faces, feelings freeze and stares last a long time,
Dancers’ waists powerless, turning their skirts slowly.
No pleasure can surpass this,
The Western Paradise in the upper realms simply has no idea!²⁴

On a more serious note, many of the Tang poets, moved by Confucian morality, Buddhist compassion, Daoist reverence for simplicity, or all of these simultaneously, spoke out against the corruption of high officials, the rapacity of tax collectors, and the self-indulgence of the rich and powerful, and lamented the suffering of the poor and the depredations of the seemingly endless wars. Du Fu, for example, on the effects of military service on the villages of the Chinese countryside:

Do you know that, east of China’s mountains, in two hundred districts,
And in thousands of villages, nothing grows but weeds,

And though strong women have bent to the plowing,
East and west the furrows all are broken down?

.....

Men of China are able to face the stiffest battle,
But their officers drive them like chickens and dogs.
Whatever is asked of them,
Dare they complain?
For example, this winter
Held west of the gate,
Challenged for taxes,
How could they pay?

.....

We have learned that to have a son is bad luck—
It is much better to have a daughter
Who can marry and live in the house of a neighbor,
While under the sod we bury our boys.²⁵

Description of landscape and the placement of houses and people within landscape is one of the most striking characteristics of Tang poetry. Of the many poets who described landscapes, none surpasses Wang Wei (701–761), a painter, poet, and sometime official. Here, he describes an imperial palace in the mountains, to which his patron, the heir apparent, had moved to escape the summer heat:

Through the window, clouds and mist rise from one's clothing;
When curtains are rolled up, mountains and springs appear in the mirrors.
Beneath the trees the sound of water conceals talking and laughing,
Among the crags, the color of trees shades the window railings.²⁶

Wang Wei was not only a poet, but also an accomplished painter. Some said that his paintings entered his poetry, and his poems were suffused with the images of his paintings. Wang Wei and other artists of his generation are credited with making landscape painting a genre in its own right—a claim that is difficult to assess, since few Tang landscapes survive, and none by Wang Wei himself. Wang Wei and other Tang painters also painted portraits and portrayals of ceremonies and other aspects of life at court. These were often painted on hand-scrolls that were meant to be viewed section by section by small groups of people, and perhaps only on particular occasions linked with the theme of the scroll itself.

Although hand-scroll landscapes painted on silk or paper became a major part of the scholar-amateur art tradition of the literati in the Song (as we will see below), the dominant forms of artistic expression in the Sui and Tang periods were murals painted on the walls of tombs, palaces, and temples, and Buddhist decorative art and sculpture. Wall painting dominated in the Sui and early Tang: teams of artists, most of them anonymous, painted scenes of aristocratic life, hunting, and sports on the walls of imperial tombs. Buddhist monasteries and temples were decorated with murals illustrating tales from the sutras and with statues depicting the historical Buddha and other Buddhist deities. Much of the best Buddhist work was destroyed in the government's periodic attacks on Buddhism. The impressive Buddhist murals and sculptures preserved in the cave-temples of Dunhuang in the northwest area remain as a fascinating glimpse of the richness of Tang Buddhist painting and sculpture.

One of the themes to appear most strongly in the art of the Sui and Tang is the presence of Indian, Central Asian, Persian, and even Mediterranean influence. One sees it in the depictions of Iranians, Sogdians, and Arabs in sarcophagi of merchants, in the Central Asian clothing and floral designs of statues of tomb attendants, and in Buddha statues whose draped robes and even facial features speak silently but clearly of Hellenistic influence. It can be seen in the earthenware camels and horses, some bearing male and female riders, and in gold and silver bowls and ewers, some Chinese, some imported from Central Asia, bearing Central Asian floral and grapevine motifs.²⁷



Female polo player. Remnants of the original paint are still visible.

Central Asian influence was also a prominent feature of Tang music, both at court and in society. To be sure, the traditional *qin* music, with its roots in the age of Confucius, continued to flourish and develop. But the liturgical music of Buddhism and new instruments from Central and West Asia transformed the musical world of the Sui-Tang period. Chinese Buddhists adapted Chinese tunes to the chanting of Buddhist sutras, in which a choir of monks or nuns would be accompanied by percussion instruments, and occasionally woodwinds or strings. Musicians specializing in entertainment brought new instruments, including several new types of drum from India and Central Asia, and brass cymbals from India. The most famous of the new instruments was undoubtedly the *pipa*, a four-stringed lute with a pear-shaped body which came from Central Asia. The *pipa* was associated with Buddhist deities and used in court music. It was also played by courtesans and popular entertainers; merchants were even known to sponsor *pipa* contests.²⁸

Tang entertainment included not only music, but also festivals and carnivals of a seasonal nature, dwarves, jugglers, acrobats (including Daoists who would climb a ladder of swords in their bare feet), wrestlers, and illusionists. Dance was a major component of Tang music and Tang entertainment. There were refined court dances and vigorous military sword dances, including one performed by women.²⁹ But perhaps the most famous of all the Tang dancers were the Xuanzong emperor's dancing horses. There were said to be a hundred of them "dressed in rich embroideries, fringed with gold and silver. ... [T]hey danced in intricate maneuvers, with tossing heads and beating tails. ... [T]hey could dance on three-tiered benches, and would stand stock still when their benches were heaved up by athletes."³⁰

The An Lushan Rebellion

Dancing horses were only the beginning of the splendors of Xuanzong's reign, which extended from 713 to 756. This was the age of Li Bo, Du Fu, and Wang Wei, and of calligraphers like "Drunken Monk" Huaisu and General Yan Zhenqing. In the great city of Chang'an, the Tang court would subsidize three-, five-, seven-, even nine-day grand carnivals in which the streets were given over to marathons of eating, drinking, entertainment, and parades of horse and ox-drawn floats.³¹ On the face of it, Xuanzong should be revered as a brilliant emperor. Instead, he is notorious for his infatuation with a concubine, and his reign is remembered chiefly for a rebellion from which the imperial government never recovered.

Xuanzong took the throne in 713; an attempted coup by his aunt the Princess Taiping was quashed in the same year, as mentioned above. After six coups and five emperors in eight years, the empire finally achieved a degree of political stability during what would become a forty-four-year reign. In many ways, this was the height of Tang power and glory. Xuanzong presided over a much-needed revision of the administrative law and took measures

against the economic power of the Buddhist monasteries and the public preaching of Buddhist monks, some of whom were connected to religious rebellions. He accumulated large supplies of emergency grain in the empire's granaries and greatly improved the organization and efficiency of grain transport by canal and Yellow River from the Central Plains and the south to Luoyang and Chang'an. Personally, Xuanzong was known as a pleasant man; a talented administrator; a patron of Buddhism, Daoism, literature, and the arts; and as a reasonably good poet and calligrapher.

Imperial overreach was the ultimate cause of Xuanzong's downfall. His predecessors, including Empress Wu, had conquered vast territories, particularly in the northwest.³² This brought the Tang Empire's borders up against some formidable and well-organized neighbors. To the southwest, the independent kingdom of Nanzhao, at times allied with Tibet, threatened Sichuan and Tang control over Annam (north Vietnam). In the west, the expansionist Tibetan Empire challenged the Tang for control of the horse pastures of Qinghai and the routes to Central Asia. In Mongolia, the Eastern Turks, once defeated by Li Shimin, posed a threat until the Eastern Turkish khanate disintegrated in 741, and was replaced by the more friendly Uighur Empire.

To defend their distant borders from these and other enemies, the Tang needed something more permanent than the ad hoc expeditionary armies with which they had built their empire. To meet this need Xuanzong, continuing the work of his predecessors, established ten regional frontier commands with permanent, professional garrison troops. By contrast, the imperial government had very few troops at the heart of the empire, and those were unseasoned and poorly trained. The emperor and his advisors realized the danger of allowing regional commanders to become too strong, and had established checks, including command rotation, to decrease the possibility of the frontier commanders becoming a threat to the central government, but these measures were not enforced.

In 755, General An Lushan (Roxan in Persian) had been commander of two large frontier commands in the north, in the area of modern Beijing, for twelve years. An was one of the many non-Chinese generals who held regional frontier commands. His mother was Turkish, his father a Sogdian. An owed his good fortune both to his military prowess and to the patronage of Xuanzong's chief minister, one Li Linfu, who had dominated Xuanzong's court from 736 until his death in 752. However, the new chief minister, Yang Guozhong, regarded An Lushan as a dangerous rival. Yang Guozhong himself owed his position to the fact that he was second cousin of the Xuanzong emperor's favorite consort, Yang Guifei. Xuanzong, on the throne since 712, had tired of ruling and spent inordinate amounts of time (or so his officials thought) dallying with the pleasantly plump Yang Guifei at the ornate Floriate Clear Palace, which was built around the hot springs outside of Chang'an.

Disaster struck when Yang Guozhong began to arrest and execute An Lushan's supporters in Chang'an. In December 755 An Lushan led the main force of his northern frontier troops, perhaps one hundred fifty thousand men, swept down through the Central Plains, and easily took the secondary capital of Luoyang. A hastily-arranged defense of the Tong Pass, the invasion route from Luoyang to Chang'an, stopped An Lushan temporarily. But, when Xuanzong (acting on Yang Guozhong's immature advice) ordered the numerically inferior troops at Tong Pass to sally forth and do battle with the rebels, the game was over: An Lushan's forces cut the defenders to bits, and advanced on Chang'an. The emperor, with Yang Guifei and Yang Guozhong in his entourage, fled in one direction, his heir apparent in another. The emperor's bodyguard blamed the whole debacle on the Yangs. In a move that became famous in stories, songs, plays, and television drama, they forced Xuanzong to approve the execution of both his chief minister and his beloved concubine. Shortly afterwards, Xuanzong's son, Suzong (r. 756–762), forced him to abdicate and addressed himself to the task of saving the Tang Empire.

An Lushan had imperial pretensions, but he was killed by his own officers in 757. The subsequent leaders of the rebellion were unable to establish stable control or internal discipline, and thus failed to become emperors themselves. For their part, Suzong and the loyal troops of the Tang dynasty struggled against the rebels until 763. In the final analysis, their victory was due to three strategies, all of which had serious long-term consequences for the empire. First, the Tang had to withdraw frontier garrison troops from their distant northwestern posts in order to fight against the rebels. The Tibetans moved into the vacuum, cutting the Tang off from the Central Asian trade routes and taking control of the grasslands on which the Tang relied for their horses. Chinese rule would not return to the area now known as Xinjiang until the 18th century. Second, Suzong literally begged support from the Uighur Empire, which had replaced the Turks as the dominant power in Mongolia. The Uighurs were glad to help, but for a price: they were allowed to sack Luoyang when they recovered the city from the rebels, and they demanded highly preferential trade agreements with the Tang for decades afterward.

Victory in battle, with the help of the Uighurs, enabled Suzong to defeat the rebel leaders. When that was accomplished, the Tang, its resources exhausted, resorted to the third strategy: it negotiated peace with the

remaining rebel commanders. In return for pledging loyalty to the Tang, the former rebels were confirmed as governors of the northeastern provinces that were their power bases, and were allowed to keep their military forces intact.

The Late Tang

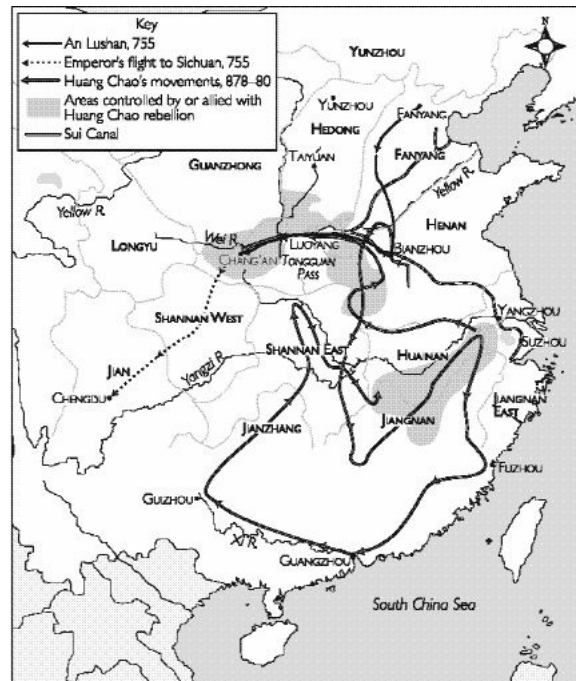
The An Lushan rebellion brought the Tang government to its knees, but we cannot draw a simple, straight line from this rebellion in 756–63 to the ultimate collapse of the Tang imperial government in 907. The rebellion weakened the imperial government significantly, but the Tang Empire remained in many ways a strong and vital place for much of the time between 763 and 907.

The An Lushan rebellion did lead to the permanent loss of the far western regions, a situation which the growing Tibetan kingdom took full advantage of. In 791, the Tibetans brought a complete end to any Tang control of modern Xinjiang. This weakness in the north and northwest meant the loss of trade, of horse pasturage, and of strategic depth.

Without control of the overland trade in luxury goods from Central Asia and beyond, Chang'an and Luoyang became less cosmopolitan in their tastes and their consumption patterns. This was not, however, a significant blow to the imperial purse: commercial taxes had never been a significant source of revenue for the Tang state.

The loss of horse pasturage and of strategic depth had a more detrimental immediate and long-term effect on the dynasty. The Tibetans now controlled pastures immediately adjacent to Tang territory, as well as access to the horse trade with Central Asia. The Tang thus relied on their fractious allies, the Uighurs, for horses. The Uighurs, aided and abetted by Sogdian merchants, took full advantage of this situation. Each year, they forced the Chinese to purchase thousands of horses, purposely bringing inferior animals and demanding exorbitant payments—up to forty rolls of silk per horse. Much of the tax silk collected from countless Chinese farming families was going directly into the hands of Uighur and Sogdian merchants, who used some of the silk themselves, but sold more of it for export farther west. This trade, and the arrogant, sometimes violent, behavior of Uighur and Sogdian merchants in Chang'an and Luoyang, contributed to growing anti-foreign fears and prejudices among the people of the Tang capital cities.

The Tang's loss of territory also meant that Chang'an was now a mere 200-some miles (about 350 km) from the border, making defense a more pressing and difficult task. The Tibetans invaded the border areas regularly between 763 and the 840s. They occupied some border areas, made, broke, and remade treaties with the clearly weakened Tang, and even occupied and looted Chang'an for twelve days in 763. As we have seen, the Uighurs were content to exploit the Tang in a more civil, businesslike fashion. Tibetan pressure came to an end when the Tibetan kingdom fell apart in the 840s. The Kirghiz destroyed the Uighur Empire in 840. The decline of these fractious neighboring states must have been celebrated in Chang'an, and it is noteworthy that the Tang, even in its weakened state, should have outlasted these rivals. However, in the long term, the military weakness and lack of horses, both attributable to the loss of the western regions, left the Chinese unable to defend the Yellow River and the Central Plains from any well-organized, well-armed power to the northeast, north, or northwest. This would become painfully evident in the histories of the Song, Yuan, and Ming dynasties.



[The An Lushan and Huang Chao rebellions.](#)

Internally, the An Lushan rebellion and the way in which it was finally “defeated” led to the de facto independence of provincial governors, who as in the late Han became warlords, each with his own army and territory. This situation was particularly serious in the northeast, where the governors were former rebels. The provincial regimes continued to acknowledge the Tang emperor as their sovereign, but they collected and retained their own tax revenue. This had the effect of throwing the Tang house into greater reliance on the more loyal southern Yangzi Valley provinces. By the late Tang, population shifts and increasing Chinese colonization of the far south (Guangdong, Guangxi, and Annam) had incorporated the south more firmly into the Chinese world and opened up more land to highly productive rice agriculture.

Provincial independence also inspired Tang emperors and their officials to come up with innovative ways to reduce provincial autonomy. In one such move, the Dezong emperor (r. 779–805) approved a new tax system: the “Twice-a-Year Tax” or “Two-Tax System.” As described above, this tax combined all previous taxes into a single annual tax calculated on how much land a family owned, and payable in two installments. At first, this system increased state revenue. As a result, the Xianzong emperor (r. 806–821) had enough strength to exert a degree of central control over the provincial administrations—sometimes by threats, sometimes by defeating provincial militaries in battle.

Xianzong’s reign is sometimes seen as the high point of the late Tang. The assertion of control over the provinces, the return of fiscal health, and victories over the Tibetans seemed to indicate to the people of the time that this was the period in which the Tang had an opportunity to recover its greatness. It was not to be. By the mid-ninth century, the provinces were again throwing off the control of the imperial government. The emperors, highly distrustful of professional army commanders since the An Lushan uprising, relied more and more on eunuch servants to act as their agents and as supervisors of whatever military forces the imperial government still controlled. As a result, factions led by high-ranking eunuch officials came to control the court.

Furthermore, the An Lushan rebellion and the government’s inability to control the provinces afterward coincided with the complete collapse of the Equal Fields System of land allocation. In its place, agricultural land had become a commodity to be purchased by the highest bidder. This led to the development of a whole new class of landholding families in the provinces—families whose pedigree could not be traced either to the old mixed-race northwestern aristocracy who had founded the Tang, nor to the long-established Confucian aristocratic families who had supported the Tang. This new land-owning elite played an important role in the Song period and beyond as they sent their educated sons to compete for official appointments via the civil service examination system.

Concentration of land ownership also generated large numbers of landless people whose men swelled the ranks of the provincial armies and of bandit gangs. Droughts and famine in the Central Plains during the 860s and early 870s contributed to the misery and poverty that fed the ranks of bandits, since the central government no longer had the means to provide public security or famine relief. Between 874 and 878, numerous bandit gangs were operating in the Central Plains. In 878, many of them coalesced under the leadership of one Huang Chao (?–884). Huang Chao's family had become wealthy in the salt business, and Huang himself had taken the civil service examinations several times, but with no success. It is significant, however, that this rebel leader was not a poor peasant, but, rather, a man who had sought fame and power through legitimate channels before rising in rebellion.

Huang Chao, leading tens of thousands of followers, swept through Shandong in 878, taking cities and declaring himself to be the “Heaven-storming generalissimo.” Then, fleeing government forces, he led his followers to the south, reaching the international port city of Guangzhou in the summer of 879. Angry at the imperial government's refusal to appoint him governor of the port (they offered him a lesser position), Huang Chao turned his troops loose to loot, pillage, and kill. Estimates are that as many as one hundred twenty thousand of Guangzhou's two hundred thousand people (many, perhaps most, were Arab, Indian, Persian, and Southeast Asian merchants) were killed.³³

At that point, Huang Chao, his armies suffering severely from tropical disease, turned north. His progress was aided when incompetent and cowardly Tang commanders refused to fight his forces, but simply allowed them to continue on their way, looting as they went. As his forces approached Chang'an, Huang Chao drew closer and closer to proclaiming himself the founder of a new dynasty. In 880, he defeated the Xizong emperor's hopelessly unprepared, eunuch-commanded “Divine Strategy Army” and captured the capital, the emperor having fled under eunuch “protection.” This was not, however, the start of a new dynasty. Huang Chao's men, who were beyond his control, mercilessly looted and destroyed Chang'an—precisely the opposite of what should happen when a military leader seeks to achieve legitimacy with the people and (more importantly) with the officials whom he will need to set up a new imperial government. Huang Chao, himself a man with a reputation for extreme cruelty toward those who crossed him, found himself in possession of the capital city, but without support from the provinces and without an adequate supply of grain. Unable to defeat the rebellion, the Tang called in the cavalry: Li Keyong, leader of the Shatuo Turks—a nomadic group who had previously both helped and invaded the Tang from their base in the north. Li drove Huang Chao out of Chang'an, chased him down, and, after several battles, finally defeated him in 884.

Huang Chao was finished—but so too was the Tang. The capital lay in ruins, the emperor was a puppet of the eunuchs, and the provinces were under the control of whoever had the most troops on the ground. Foreign troops—the Shatuo and others—dominated the area north of the Yellow River. Later generations of Chinese admired the cultural vitality and military power of the Tang. But when a strongman forced the abdication of the last Tang emperor in 907, the once-great empire had already long-since disintegrated.

Notes

1. Disputes over the historical status of Koguryo continue into the 21st century. In 2004, Chinese and South Korean scholars and diplomats clashed over the question of whether the history of Koguryo is a part of the history of China or a part of the history of Korea. Chinese scholars argued that two-thirds of Koguryo territory lies within the national territory of the current People's Republic of China. Koreans argued that Koguryo was essentially Korean and that Chinese attempts to control history are related to Chinese attempts to control, in the future, all areas where ethnic Koreans reside. Mongolian and Turkish scholars chimed in to argue that as the Chinese present the histories of the Mongols and the Turks as parts of Chinese history, the contemporary Mongols and Turks should stand by the side of the Koreans in resisting Chinese claims. James Brooke, “Reviving a Korean Kingdom,” *International Herald Tribune*, August 25, 2004; “Academic Conference Reveals Continuing Chinese Distortions of Koguryo History,” *Chosunilbo* (English), September 16, 2004, also available online at <http://english.chosun.com/w21data/html/news/200409/200409160039.html>.
2. Howard J. Wechsler, “The Founding of the T'ang Dynasty: Kao-tsu (reign 618–626),” in Denis Twitchett and John K. Fairbank, eds., *The Cambridge History of China, Vol. 3: Sui and T'ang China, 589–906, Part I* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1979), 159–60.
3. Denis Twitchett, “Hsüan-tsung (r. 712–56)” in Twitchett and Fairbank, eds., *Cambridge History of China, Vol. 3*, 365.

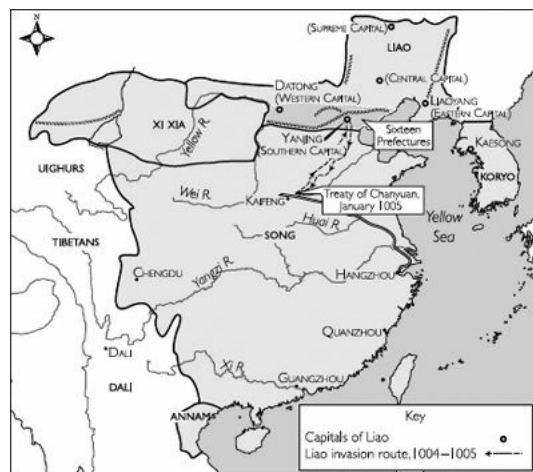
4. David A. Graff, *Medieval Chinese Warfare, 300–900* (London: Routledge, 2002), 186–8.
5. “Song of the Merchant,” in *Yuan Zhen ji, juan 23* (Collected works of Yuan Zhen, vol. 23), quoted in Zhang Qizhi, ed., *Zhongguo lishi: Sui Tang Liao Song Jin juan* (Chinese history: Sui, Tang, Liao, and Jin volume) (Beijing: Gaodeng jiaoyu chubanshe, 2001), 94. Translation by the author.
6. Edward H. Schafer, “T’ang,” in K.C. Chang, ed., *Food in Chinese Culture: Anthropological and Historical Perspectives* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1977), 88–126.
7. Sally Hovey Wriggins, *Xuanzang: A Buddhist Pilgrim on the Silk Road* (Boulder: Westview Press, 1996), 182, 191–4.
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[The Song and Its Neighbors](#)

Confucius is said to have remarked: “There are not two suns in the sky, nor two sovereigns over the people.”¹ But following the Tang Empire’s final collapse in 907, China Proper and the adjacent areas of Inner Asia (Manchuria, Mongolia, Xinjiang, and the area around the Ordos) after a period of fighting and multiple regimes saw the coexistence of several empires whose ruling houses were of distinctly different ethnic identities: the Khitan Liao Empire, the Tangut Xi Xia Empire, the Jurchen Jin Empire, as well as the Chinese Song state. The Song coexisted with these neighboring states, reluctantly treating them as equals and negotiating agreements on borders and trade. But relations between the Song and its neighbors were not always peaceful. The Jurchen Jin Empire, established in Manchuria in 1117, conquered the Liao and then went on to take northern China from the Song in 1127. Because the Song continued to control the south, we divide the Song into two periods: Northern Song (960–1127) and Southern Song (1128–1276).

The three and a half centuries in which the Liao, Xi Xia, Jin, and Song coexisted and competed with one another saw tremendous economic and social changes, ways of thought, and new techniques of rulership and statecraft that make the late imperial period of Chinese history (Song through Qing) very different from the middle period (late Han through the fall of Tang). Many of these changes had their origins in the late Tang/Five Dynasties/Ten Kingdoms decades, thus underlining again the sometimes arbitrary nature of dynastic regimes as “dividing lines” in history. The highly commercialized Song economy, the rise of Chinese shipbuilding and navigation, tea-drinking, the intellectual movement that we call “Neo-Confucianism,” landscape paintings, and poetry, all of which are so representative of the Song, had their roots in the late Tang, Five Dynasties, and Ten Kingdoms. So too did the need of the Song Chinese to live with strong non-Chinese neighboring states—and the need of the ruling elite of those states to adapt useful elements of Chinese civilization and to find effective ways of ruling Chinese subjects while retaining their own identity.



[The Song, Liao, and Xi Xia Empires.](#)

The Khitan Liao

The Liao dynasty was established in 916 when the Khitan khan Abaoji (872–926) declared himself emperor. Abaoji had already transformed a loosely knit confederacy of the nine Khitan tribes in the Western Liao River region (eastern Inner Mongolia) into a unified regional power and begun to absorb neighboring Inner Asian tribes and peoples.² Where Abaoji departed from conventional Inner Asian confederation-building was in his combination of Khitan and Chinese techniques to create a strong central government. His campaigns brought large swaths of modern Mongolia and Manchuria under his domination. Among the conquered was Bohai, whose kings had already adapted many elements of Chinese civilization and bureaucracy to manage the farming population of their kingdom, which straddled the border of modern Manchuria and North Korea. When he died unexpectedly in 926, Abaoji was already planning to acquire Chinese territory to his south. Like many other Inner Asian leaders before and after him, Abaoji understood that the apparently endless wealth of China could be used to build ever larger Inner Asian confederations.³

Abaoji's heirs continued to expand the Khitan Empire and to construct a Khitan-centered system of international relations and trade.⁴ At its height in the tenth and early 11th centuries the Liao Empire stretched from Manchuria in the east across Mongolia to Xinjiang in the west. To Central Asians and Russians, the Khitan Empire (*Khitai*, English "Cathay") was "China." Chinese trade goods, including silk, flowed through Liao to Central Asia and the West. The Khitan elite, enthusiastic consumers of Chinese goods themselves, were patrons and practitioners of Buddhism. Among the few remaining artifacts of Liao material culture are huge wooden pagodas and tomb murals showing the elaborate wedding of a wealthy Liao couple. Both indicate the influence of Chinese culture along with the presence of distinctive Khitan features: the unique timber construction of the wooden pagodas, the combination of shamanistic animal sacrifice, Buddhist iconography, and Chinese-style tombs, and the Khitan male hairstyle—the head shaved on top, with a fringe of long hair across the forehead from the left to right temple.⁵

The influence of Chinese civilization on the Khitan elite was partly due to the fact that Liao territory included areas that were populated by sedentary farmers and local elites who followed Chinese customs and who were best managed through Chinese bureaucratic practices. These included not only the Chinese-influenced Bohai kingdom, but also the "Sixteen Prefectures"—a slice of territory in northern China stretching from Datong to the area of modern Beijing and on to the coast. The Liao had acquired the Sixteen Prefectures in 937 from a client kingdom in north China. Control of this area gave the Liao a large Chinese population and, more importantly, control of the key mountain passes that any army would need to cross to mount invasions from north to south (or vice versa).



First known illustration of a fire lance and a grenade, in a tenth-century Buddhist painting in Dunhuang, on the Silk Road.

Because they ruled both nomadic pastoral people and sedentary farmers, the Liao established a dual administration: a Northern Court to rule their Inner Asian subjects according to tribal practice, and a Southern Court to manage their Chinese population according to Chinese custom. Khitan rulers were khans to their pastoral subjects and emperors to the farming people. They had five capitals: the Supreme Capital in Mongolia and the Central, Eastern, Western, and Southern Capitals, the latter on the site of modern Beijing. Each capital was the center of administration for its own area. The Liao emperors and their court moved regularly among the capitals, their

baggage carried in ox-drawn carts. Rather than build palaces, they lived in luxurious tents.

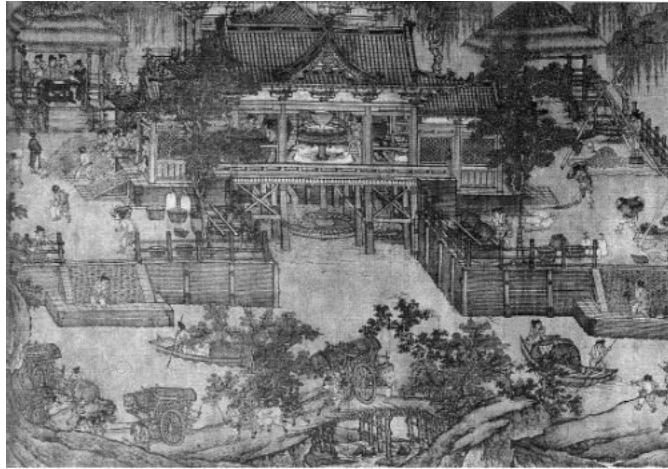
Their peripatetic lifestyle, the continued use of the Khitan language, and a passion for hunting all helped Liao rulers to preserve an identity that was distinctly not “Chinese.” But beginning with Abaoji himself, the Khitan khans’ efforts to play the part of Chinese emperor involved them and their families in cultural and political contradictions that occasionally led to violence. Khitan khans were generally chosen and regularly re-confirmed in their positions by meetings of the leading men of the tribe or confederation. A leader’s successor was often one of his brothers. In order to increase the power of the Liao central government, Abaoji held onto power without submitting to regular re-election and designated his son as his heir. His younger brothers responded with several unsuccessful rebellions and assassination attempts.⁶

Contention over succession and related disagreements about the extent to which the Khitan should adopt Chinese ways occurred repeatedly. When Abaoji died (apparently peacefully), his very refined and civilized (by Chinese standards) eldest son Pei should have inherited the throne. But real power was in the hands of Abaoji’s widow, Empress Dowager Yingtian. Like many aristocratic Liao women, the empress dowager was an independent-minded and powerful person. She was also a commander quite capable of leading her two-hundred-thousand-strong cavalry into battle. Pei wisely stepped aside. Yingtian placed a younger, more martial son on the throne and continued to play a role in Liao court politics. She was the first of several powerful empresses and empresses dowager in Liao history.

Before the founding of the Song in 960, the Liao had manipulated and occasionally invaded the smaller kingdoms of northern China. In 947 the Khitan had even invaded the Central Plains and occupied the city of Kaifeng, only to withdraw in the face of relentless attacks which left the Liao Taizong emperor lamenting that he had never expected the “soft and timid” Chinese to be so hard to govern.⁷ With the establishment of the Song in 960, the Khitan had to deal with a powerful Chinese state whose leaders were determined, for reasons of strategy and sentiment, to regain the Sixteen Prefectures. Twice (in 979 and 985) the Song tried to recover this territory, and twice they were thoroughly defeated.

In 1004, Khitan forces led by the Liao Shengzong emperor and his mother, Empress Dowager Chengtian, attacked the Song and advanced to Chanyuan (also called Shanyuan), just north of the Yellow River and a mere 60 miles (100 km) from the Song capital of Kaifeng. Peace negotiations between the weakened Song and the Khitan (themselves overextended and ready to return home) resulted in a treaty: mutual recognition, demarcation of borders, trade, and, from the Song, annual gifts to the Liao of 100,000 ounces of silver and 200,000 bolts of silk.

The Treaty of Chanyuan and the payments made to Liao were a political embarrassment, but not an economic burden: they amounted to only a small fraction of the Song’s huge economy. With only minor exceptions, this agreement enabled the Liao and the Song to maintain peaceful relations and mutually beneficial trade (in which the Song economy regained most of the silver given to the Liao in exchange for Chinese goods) for more than a century. The two imperial courts communicated regularly with each other on a basis of equality. This appears to have been particularly difficult for some Song officials and emperors to stomach: the Song court’s formal communications and public documents dealing with Song-Liao relations used the language of equality. Internal documents continued to refer to the Khitan as barbarians.⁸ Many Song officials and emperors keenly felt the shame of having to compromise with the Liao and yearned to recover the Sixteen Prefectures, which the Treaty of Chanyuan had placed firmly on the Khitan side of a clearly drawn and mutually recognized border.



A Northern Song dynasty painting on silk of a water-powered grain mill.

The drawing of that boundary line seems to have heightened the awareness of exclusive identities and loyalties on either side of the border. Song emperors and officials emphasized their identity as civilized men. Han Chinese had previously crossed back and forth between Chinese- and Khitan-controlled territory, sometimes because territory itself and its people changed hands, sometimes as captives, but sometimes voluntarily. Such crossings and changes of allegiance were now less practical and morally indefensible as the stronger definition of borders was accompanied by new definitions of loyalty that bound men more exclusively to a single ruler.⁹

Despite the difficulty of border crossings, the Khitan elite (and the Han Chinese who served them) still lived in both the Khitan and Chinese worlds. While in no way losing their identity as Khitan, the Liao used a Tang-style code of law and employed Chinese officials, whom they recruited both through the *yin* system (recommendation) and through limited civil service examinations. Many Chinese were quite willing to serve the Liao: some even adopted Khitan names.¹⁰ The cultural dualism of the Liao elite (both Khitan rulers and Han officials) and the Liao state stood as examples when other hunting and pastoral people like the Jurchen or the Mongols sought to build and sustain large steppe confederations by ruling and drawing on the wealth of the sedentary farmers of China.

The Tangut Xi Xia

Like the Khitan, the Tanguts rose to power in the tenth century after their stronger neighbors had declined. The Tanguts had been nomads in the Qinghai-Sichuan area until the expanding Tibetan Empire pushed them out in 680. The Tang then settled the Tanguts in the Ordos, the area within the loop of the Yellow River. In return, they were to help defend this border area, standing as a buffer between the Tang and the Tibetans. When both these empires collapsed, the Tangut leaders, though in effect independent, continued to acknowledge the superiority of whichever Chinese dynasty held the north. Then, in the late tenth century, the Tanguts saw an opportunity to play the Liao and the Song against each other.

The initial stages of Xi Xia expansion and consolidation took place during the reign of Weiming Yuanhao (r. 1032–1048). Like the Khitan Abaoji, Yuanhao drew selectively on Chinese political institutions such as centralized rule by a dynastic family in order to impose greater central authority over a decentralized tribal elite and to extend his control of people and territory farther into the pastoral world. Yuanhao enhanced his aura of independence by ostentatiously rejecting key elements of Chinese culture which the Tangut aristocracy had made their own. Yuanhao mandated Tangut clothing and Tangut (not Chinese) surnames. Men were ordered to shave the tops of their heads, leaving a fringe across the forehead and down the sides.¹¹ In 1036 he introduced a Tangut writing system: about six thousand characters, modeled on but purposely different from Chinese characters.¹²

Yuanhao's calculated rejection of Song Chinese superiority reached a climax in 1038, when he cast aside Song ceremonies and declared himself "Shizu, Originator of Literature, Rooted in Might, Giver of Law, Founder of Ritual, Humane and Filial Emperor" of the "Great Xia."¹³ While asserting Tangut cultural identity against both the

Song dynasty and the Tangut aristocracy (who had adopted many aspects of Chinese civilization) Yuanhao was himself making creative use of Chinese models of emperorship and centralized government. When the Song rejected his claim to emperorship, Weiming responded: “The Fan [the Tanguts] and the Han are each different countries, and their lands are vastly dissimilar. This is not a case of usurpation. Why is your resentment so deep? Moreover [I] was elevated by the throng and ... aspire to be emperor. What is wrong with that?”¹⁴

Apparently, quite a bit was wrong with it. Years of war and negotiations (in which Yuanhao cheekily referred to himself as the Song emperor’s “grandfather”) led to an agreement in 1044. To keep the peace, the Song would make annual payments to the Xi Xia: 72,000 ounces (about 6,000 modern pounds or 2,700 kg) of silver, 153,000 bolts of silk, and 30,000 *jin* (about 40,000 pounds or 18,000 kg) of tea. This arrangement did not hold as effectively as the Treaty of Chanyuan. The Song simply did not have the same respect for the relatively small Tangut Xi Xia as they had for the powerful Khitan.¹⁵ Relations often deteriorated, with the Song cutting off trade, failing to make the payments and attacking the Xi Xia.

Tangut emperors after Yuanhao were unable to exert the level of centralization that he had achieved. Rival factions at court often presented themselves as leaning either toward assertion of Tangut cultural identity or as advocates of further adoption of Chinese culture and institutions. The rise and fall of rival factions was reflected not only in changes in institutions, but also in court ritual and dress.¹⁶ But while steppe warrior practices and Chinese models both provided useful techniques for emperorship and government, the Xi Xia emperors, beginning with Weiming Yuanhao, also drew heavily on Buddhism to justify their rule. Xi Xia emperors presented themselves as great kings who ruled the world according to the Buddhist dharma and tried to establish a special relationship between themselves and “the potency of the Buddha, whose protective and salvific powers [they] could then channel on behalf of the state and the Tangut people.”¹⁷

Whether because of the powers of the Buddha or for more prosaic reasons, the Tanguts expanded from the Ordos westward across the Yellow River. At its height, the Xi Xia was a multinational state centered on modern Ningxia province in the Ordos area, but taking in parts of Shaanxi, Inner Mongolia, Gansu, and Qinghai provinces. Herding was the main form of productive activity. Nomads made up perhaps one-quarter of the Xi Xia’s population of around four million.¹⁸ The Xi Xia state organized nomads into decimal units based on groups of ten families, inventoried their livestock, taxed them, obliged them to guard the borders, and pressed them into service in its army.¹⁹ Agriculture, particularly in the irrigated areas along the Yellow River in modern Ningxia, also came to play a significant role in the Xi Xia economy.

The Xi Xia’s westward territorial expansion and its relations with the Liao, Song, Tibetans, and Uighurs contributed to the development of a thriving state and civilization. Artisans (Chinese, Tangut, Uighur, and others) in Xi Xia cities produced a wide variety of goods: camel’s hair carpets, wines and liquors, iron tools and weapons (Xi Xia swords were especially famous), statues, pagodas, tombs, and high-quality paper and books.²⁰

Trade with the Song centered on exchange of Song tea and silk for caravan goods, medicinal plants, salt, and horses. Xi Xia control of trade routes, and particularly of the horse trade, was a major problem for the Song court. Attempts to put pressure on the Xi Xia and to develop alternative trade routes, especially for horses, got the Song involved in both diplomatic and military adventures in the Tibetan areas of Qinghai, immediately south of the Xi Xia. For the Song, both the Tangut Xia and the Khitan Liao posed tough challenges. Debates about how to respond to those challenges played a major role in Song court politics and economic policy.

Politics and Economy in the Northern Song

The Song dynasty was established in the same chaotic conditions which had favored the rise of Khitan and Tangut power. General Zhao Kuangyin established the Song in 960 when he carried out a coup against the seven-year-old emperor of the Later Zhou (one of the several states of north China during the tenth century). Zhao then took the throne as Taizu, the founding emperor of the Song dynasty. Taizu and his successors saw their Song as the legitimate heir to the Tang Empire, but they were never able to match its greatness. Hemmed in by the independent kingdoms of Annam (formerly a Tang territory) and Dali (formerly Nanzhao) to the extreme south and southwest, various Tibetan tribes and kingdoms to the west, the Xi Xia to the northwest, and the Liao to the north, the Song controlled an area roughly corresponding to China Proper. This did not make the Song a poor or weak kingdom. The first three Song emperors (Taizu, Zhao Kuangyin, r. 960–976; Taizong, r. 976–997; and Zhenzong, r. 997–1022) consolidated control over north and south China and established stable military and civilian government institutions.

Song Taizu was keenly aware of the need for a strong army. He and his successors maintained a large standing army of professional soldiers. Over time, military preparedness deteriorated as officers failed to replace men who had grown older and made less effective soldiers. Nonetheless, the Song military was a force of considerable size and strength. Maintaining the army was a significant drain on resources: the Northern Song court may have spent as much as three-quarters of its annual tax revenue on military expenses.²¹ In addition to maintaining the troops, the court was also determined to keep them under close control. Taizu knew that independent regional military commanders had undermined the strength of the Tang court, destroying the dynasty. He and his successors tried to avoid this by dividing the central army into three units that balanced each other off, rotating troops and officers regularly, separating financial control from military command, establishing a centralized command structure, and firmly subordinating the military to civilian bureaucrats.²²

The first three Song emperors also designed the institutions of government to increase the emperor's control over his ministers and advisers. Song emperors reduced the power of their highest-ranking minister, the chief counselor, by appointing a vice-chief counselor to assist (and counterbalance) him. The chief counselor was responsible only for civilian issues: control of the military was placed in the Privy Council. Informally, too, Song emperors (and empresses dowager acting as regents) increased their control by playing rival factions against each other. An emperor or empress dowager blessed with a strong personality and an acute political sense could utterly dominate high-ranking officials. A strong chief counselor could still dominate a weaker or more impressionable emperor, but the general trend of the Song was toward an increase in the despotic power of the throne over the ministers at court.

While tightening control over the military and the civilian bureaucracy, the Song emperors also presided over significant changes in the techniques for recruiting officials. As in previous dynasties, there were several routes to government office in the Song. Government clerks, who worked in local and central offices but did not hold examination degrees, could now apply for promotion into the ranks of the regular bureaucracy. As in the Tang, high-ranking officials could recommend one or more (but not too many!) family members for official posts under the *yin* system. Those so recommended had to pass a relatively easy examination: pass rates were often above fifty percent. But neither of these routes led to real power. Those who aspired to a successful career and high office needed to take a series of highly competitive examinations: an initial examination at the local (prefectural) level, a "departmental examination" in the capital, and then a pro forma palace examination. Those passing the palace examination were awarded the *jinshi* (advanced scholar) degree and were eligible to serve as officials.²³

In conducting the examinations, techniques like the use of numbers instead of names on the examination papers assured more objectivity than in the Tang (when examination candidates often visited their examiners ahead of time in order to make a good impression). Rules prohibiting certain types of people (monks, artisans, merchants, clerks, and eunuchs, for example) were occasionally enacted, but soon lapsed. The examination system offered the appearance of a fair chance to everyone and the promise of upward social mobility. But in practice, only wealthy landholding families could normally afford the considerable investment in education that was required to prepare a young man for the examinations. Nonetheless, in the long term the Song examination system contributed significantly to an expansion of education and the development of a new class of educated men—a scholar elite—who derived their status, not from an aristocratic heritage or from officeholding, but from their command of the Confucian classics, dynastic histories, poetry, and a certain sense of moral superiority that came along with such an education.²⁴

Territorial consolidation and institution-building in the early Song were accompanied by an enviable degree of social stability and economic growth. But, as mentioned above, neither Song Taizu nor his successors had been able to recover the Sixteen Prefectures or bring the Xi Xia under submission. The Treaty of Chanyuan with the Liao, though not an economic burden, remained, for many, a sign of shame. For the Renzong emperor (r. 1023–1064) and his officials, Song weakness in the face of the Xi Xia and the Liao appeared to be linked to a series of domestic problems: a large, expensive, but weak military; an underfunded, overstaffed, and inefficient government; a civil service examination system that placed more emphasis on rote learning of philosophy and history than on practical administrative skills; and the plight of farmers struggling under heavy taxation, corvée labor, and high interest rates.

In the early 1040s, reeling from an ill-advised war against the Tanguts, the Renzong emperor saw all these problems as parts of a fundamental fiscal-military crisis.²⁵ In 1043 he appointed the noted scholar and official Fan Zhongyan (989–1052) to carry out thorough administrative reforms including organizing militia to support the army and more rigorous criteria for the evaluation and promotion of officials. Within two years, the reforms had encountered strong resistance in the bureaucracy. The emperor demoted Fan and other reformist officials in 1045.

The end of Fan Zhongyan's reform program did not mean the end of the problems that it was meant to address.

Rival groups of officials continued to debate the question of how to solve the Song's military, revenue, civil service staffing, and socioeconomic problems. Conservative officials like the historian Sima Guang (1019–86) argued for government budget-cutting and small, incremental reforms. They opposed war, both on grounds of expense and on the grounds that “barbarians” would respond positively to good government and negatively to military suppression.²⁶

Opposing Sima were advocates of reform led by a well-known, but eccentric official named Wang Anshi (1021–1086). Wang dismissed Sima Guang's proposals as a “petty reform that in the end offers no solutions to real problems. ...”²⁷ Wang pressed for a thorough reform of education and recruitment of officials and reorganization of institutions in order to increase government revenue and strengthen the military.

In the 1050s and early 1060s Wang Anshi could do no more than to make his case: he had relatively little influence at court. But in 1068, a new emperor changed the nature of the debate. Shenzong (r. 1068–1086) was twenty years old and determined to defeat the Liao and recover the Sixteen Prefectures. Convinced that radical reform would help him to achieve his goals, Shenzong put Wang Anshi in charge of the government in 1069. Wang Anshi, with the emperor's support, demoted opponents, put his own men in key government posts, and pushed through a whole series of aggressive reform measures known collectively as the New Policies.²⁸

The New Policies were a bundle of initiatives. A Finance Planning Commission and Administrative Regulations Commission drew up policy plans and restructured the bureaucracy. The Equitable Transport Policy had the government buying its own supplies and selling its own surplus goods (for a profit) according to need, instead of the old system in which localities supplied tribute in goods and amounts fixed long ago by custom. Under the Green Sprouts Law, the government used its granaries and treasuries to make spring loans of seed grain and food to farmers, repayable in the fall with a below-market interest rate of twenty to thirty percent over the six-month period of the loan. The Hired Service Law ended obligatory *corvée* labor, substituting a “service exemption tax” with which the state would hire laborers for government projects. Another set of reforms attempted to increase military effectiveness with such measures as building militia forces in the towns and villages, state supervision of weapons manufacture, layoffs of elderly and weak soldiers, and a restructuring that would give commanders and vice-commanders long-term postings to their units. In order to recruit the right men to serve as officials, Wang (who fundamentally distrusted the examination system) called for the establishment of a government school system and required all candidates for the civil service examinations to study Confucian classics with new commentaries written, or at least approved, by Wang himself.

Wang Anshi's goal in undertaking the reforms was to “enrich the country and strengthen the military” so that the Song would be able to deal with the Xi Xia and the Liao.²⁹ The New Policies increased government revenue and allowed Shenzong to accumulate an impressive budget surplus. The expansion of government-sponsored schools represented an attempt to unify the curriculum and standardize the thinking of the scholar-official class, and nearly doubled the size of the bureaucracy.³⁰ But the reforms did not make the Song any more militarily effective: Song forces continued to lose battles with the Xi Xia.³¹ Any attack on Liao was still unthinkable.

Whatever their achievements, Wang Anshi's reforms were very divisive. Wang's arrogance and his determination to transfer anyone who opposed him to a remote provincial post (virtual exile) earned him many powerful enemies. Opponents like Sima Guang, who preferred small, frugal government, argued that any increase in state revenue meant a decrease in the well being of taxpaying farmers. The fact that the imperial government was competing with merchants in the pursuit of profit (buying and selling goods, making loans at interest) simply compounded the immorality. Some local officials did in fact abuse the system, by forcing all farmers under their jurisdiction to take out loans, for example. Other, anti-reform officials refused to carry out the reform policies in their areas.

For forty years following Shenzong's death in 1085, successive rulers alternated between anti-reform and pro-reform policies. Each shift in policy was accompanied by increasingly ruthless purges as both sides engaged in all-or-nothing “ethical factionalism.”³² The reform policies themselves had become simply tools to collect more tax revenue. Still, Huizong, the last Northern Song emperor (r. 1101–1126) was determined to weaken the Xi Xia and recover the long-lost Sixteen Prefectures from the Liao. A successful, but expensive and ultimately meaningless campaign to annex Tibetan areas south of the Tangut Xia, a deterioration of military training and command systems, and almost complete intolerance of any dissenting opinion at court left the Northern Song “utterly unprepared to defend itself or its people at home.”³³ Huizong clearly thought otherwise. For to the northeast of the Liao, in Manchuria, a newly emerging kingdom offered the possibility of a mutual alliance in which the Song would finally recover the Sixteen Prefectures. That new state and potential ally was the Jin. Its people were the Jurchen.

The Jurchen Jin Empire and the Southern Song

The Jurchen consisted of a number of Tungusic tribes from the heavily forested mountains of modern-day eastern Manchuria and Russia. In the tenth century, some of them migrated south to the Manchurian plains.³⁴ The Chinese and Khitan called these “cooked” (i.e., civilized) Jurchen. Those who remained in the far north were called “raw Jurchen.” The Jurchen were a tribal people organized in patrilineal clans. Their economy combined hunting, fishing, farming, and livestock breeding. Although they lived in villages, they were known for their horses, horsemanship, and skill in archery.³⁵ “Cooked” and “raw” Jurchen were nominally subject to the Khitan Liao Empire.

In the winter of 1112, the Liao court held its annual First Fish Feast. Leaders of various subject peoples were in attendance, and were expected each to perform a dance for the entertainment of the Liao emperor. Aguda, chief of the “raw Jurchen,” gruffly refused to dance. The emperor’s advisors recommended immediate execution, but the emperor, who apparently regarded Aguda as a harmless bumpkin, allowed him to return home. Within two years, Aguda had united the Jurchen and was in open rebellion against the Jin. By 1117, he controlled much of Manchuria and had declared himself emperor, taking the dynastic name of Jin (“gold”).

Evidently convinced that “the enemy of my enemy is my friend,” the Song emperor Huizong and his advisers hoped to use the Jurchen to help regain their long-lost Sixteen Prefectures from the Khitan Liao. Beginning in 1118, Song emissaries traveled by sea to Jin to negotiate an alliance against the Liao. The alliance was shaky from the start. The Jurchen gave only vague assurances about the return of the Sixteen Prefectures, but demanded a clear understanding that the annual gifts of silk and silver now given to the Liao be given to the Jin once the Liao were gone.³⁶

By the time the Song-Jin alliance was signed in 1120, the Jurchen were already well on the way to conquering the Khitan. Song armies sent to attack Liao from the south and recover some of the Sixteen Prefectures proved completely useless. At the same time, Song weakness was compounded by rebellions, particularly in Zhejiang, where taxes and requisitions for the Huizong emperor’s palaces and gardens weighed heavily on local landlords and common farmers alike. The rebels and their leader, a local landowner named Fang La (?–1121), practiced a form of Manichean religion, from which they derived religious sanction for mass killings of government officials.³⁷ Song troops originally intended for operations against the Liao had to be transferred south to suppress the Fang La rebellion (1120–22).

While the Song struggled with Fang La and demonstrated their incompetence in battle against the Khitan, Jurchen forces defeated the Liao on their own in 1123. The remnants of the Liao court fled to Xinjiang, where they established the state of Qara-Khitai, which lasted until it fell to the Mongols in 1218. With Liao territory in Manchuria and north China under their control, the Jurchen renounced their useless Song allies and attacked. In 1127 they captured the Song capital of Kaifeng, the former Huizong emperor, his son the Qinzong emperor (to whom Huizong had ceded the throne in panic during an earlier Jurchen attack on Kaifeng), as well as their wives. The Song court fled south to the Yangzi Valley, where another of Huizong’s sons took the throne as Gaozong (r. 1127–1162), the first emperor of the Southern Song dynasty. Hard-pressed by the Jurchen, who crossed the Yangzi in 1129–1130 and forced him to escape into the East China Sea by ship, Gaozong and his court needed to decide how to deal with the loss of the north. Should they fight to regain lost land? Or should they be content to hold the south—which was far more populous and productive than the north—and come to terms with the enemy?

Of the advocates for war, none was more outspoken than General Yue Fei (1103–1142), an uneducated man who had risen through the ranks. Yue, like many of the generals of the war party, commanded an army that he had built himself (partly by granting amnesty to and absorbing bandit gangs) and that owed its loyalty primarily to him. To the court and to the advocates of peace including Chief Councilor Qin Gui (1090–1155), with An Lushan and the late Tang in mind, independent generals like Yue Fei were as much of a threat as the Jurchen. Qin Gui and the peace party also believed that the Song did not have the resources to recapture the north.³⁸

Yue Fei brought the issue to a head, campaigning vigorously against the Jin in the mid-1130s and then, in 1140, advancing to within striking distance of Kaifeng, deep inside Jurchen-occupied territory. Qin Gui, convinced that Yue Fei’s precarious advance into enemy territory had left the Southern Song vulnerable to devastating attack, preferred to carry out peace negotiations. Qin, who (with his emperor’s support) brooked absolutely no dissent, recalled Yue Fei, threw him in prison on trumped-up charges of treason, and then had him killed. Yue’s reputation as a loyal general, his advocacy of war, and the tragic circumstances of his death inspired later generations of Southern Song men to canonize him as an example of manly patriotism. Qin Gui, on the other hand, went down in history as the stereotypical “evil minister” who had arranged the assassination of a loyal general in order to negotiate

a humiliating peace treaty with a barbarous enemy.³⁹



[The Jin, Xi Xia, and Southern Song.](#)

The treaty that Qin Gui negotiated in 1141 was modeled on the Treaty of Chanyuan. The border between Jin and Song was set at the center of the Huai River. The Song were obliged to pay the Jin an annual tribute of silk and silver and to acknowledge the superior status of the Jin emperor, addressing the Jin as “your superior state” and referring to themselves as “our insignificant state.”⁴⁰ Although they crossed the Yangzi briefly in 1129–1130 and attacked again in 1161, the Jurchen were never able to conquer the Southern Song. The Jurchen excelled at cavalry operations, but they never mastered the art of naval warfare and so were always at a disadvantage in the watery south. For their part, the Southern Song, cut off from the trade with Central Asia, had no hope of gaining enough horses to meet the Jin as equals on the dry plains of the north. At an impasse, the two neighboring states lived in relative peace until the Mongol conquest.⁴¹

With the conquest of northern China, the Jurchen—who numbered a few thousand at best—had acquired a vastly larger Chinese population. They adopted the same technique that the Khitan had developed: a dual administrative system in which Jurchen and Chinese were each ruled according to their own customs. Like the Liao emperors, the Jin rulers were khans to their Jurchen subjects and emperors to the Chinese. Like the Liao, the Jin had five capital cities, the main capital being in Manchuria until the 1150s, when they moved it to Yanjing (at the site of present-day Beijing). Also like the Khitan (and the Tangut), the Jin rulers devised a Chinese-derived writing system for their language and used Chinese models of emperorship and bureaucratic government to increase their power and to make the position of emperor heritable within their own family.

Once the violence of conquest was over, the Chinese subjects of the Jurchen lived very much as they had under the Northern Song. The Chinese elite of the Jin regarded themselves as the heirs of the philosophical and literary giants of the Tang and Northern Song. An examination system and state schools (both greatly expanded in the 1190s) and trade with Southern Song, including trade in books, generated a vibrant intellectual atmosphere in the later decades of Jurchen rule over the north.⁴² Chinese scholars in the Jin Empire regarded the leading literati of the south as being too concerned with abstraction at the expense of the moral practice. One Jin dynasty Chinese scholar even referred to Southern Song men as “barbarians.”⁴³

Below the Huai River, the Southern Song rulers and literati harbored fond memories of the now “barbarian-occupied” north and saw themselves as the legitimate guardians and transmitters—like Confucius in his day—of “this culture of ours.” In fact, although Jin and Southern Song certainly differed in significant ways, both north and south had been deeply affected by a series of revolutionary changes that had their roots in the late Tang.

Modernization and the Song Dynasty

The Northern-Southern Song–Jin centuries saw a series of revolutionary developments: increased agricultural production, rapid, urbanizing population growth, a technological innovation, a growing commercial economy, a more despotic model of emperorship, a sophisticated civil service examination system, the growth of the literati elite, and new interpretations of Confucian philosophy. These changes have inspired some historians to argue that China's modern era begins in the Song. That argument relies on a simple definition of modernity as: "1. Power over other human beings, whether states, groups or individuals, according to the level of the system under consideration; 2. practical power over nature in terms of the capacity for economic production; 3. intellectual power over nature in the form of the capacity for prediction, and—more generally—of an accurate and compactly expressed understanding."⁴⁴ Whether or not one agrees with this definition of modernity and hence with the argument that China's "modern age" begins in the Song, the changes on which the argument rests still command our attention.

Increases in agricultural production were fundamental to those changes. Song farmers employed new tools and new techniques to produce greater amounts and a larger variety of crops than their ancestors had. Farmers terraced the hillsides, built dikes and canals to transform swamps into fields, created arable land at the edges of lakes by piling dredged mud on floating wooden platforms, used new and better iron tools and plows, and made human- and animal-powered waterwheels to lift water from lower to higher fields. The improvement of native strains of rice and the introduction of Champa rice from Vietnam both extended rice cultivation to the north and contributed to the long-term development of double-cropping on the productive fields of the south. A higher concentration of population in the fertile Jiangnan and Hunan regions and the development of more intensive (in contrast to pre-Tang extensive) agriculture also played a role in boosting agricultural production.⁴⁵

Demand from both farmers and from the Song army fed the growth of iron and steel production, and of coal mining. Iron production in Northern Song China around 1078 was at least 125,000 tons (113,000 tonnes) annually. By comparison, British iron production in 1788 was 76,000 tons (69,000 tonnes).⁴⁶ In some areas, farmers collectively ran small-scale mining and smelting operations in the agricultural off-season. There were also large mining and smelting enterprises owned by immensely wealthy households and employing hundreds of laborers. In the major iron-producing areas, deforestation had driven the ironworks to use coal and coke in blast furnaces in which they produced not only iron, but also high-quality steel, using a system related to the Bessemer process. As production of iron and steel skyrocketed in Song China, so too did other areas of mining and metallurgy: coal, copper, gold, and silver production all grew, spurred on by higher demand in a growing commercial economy.

In addition to metallurgy, the Song is also known for a revolutionary innovation in military technology: gunpowder. By the Tang period, the Chinese were already using incendiary weapons like "Greek fire" (a petroleum distillate), which they learned about from Arab traders. Daoist alchemists experimenting with saltpeter, sulfur, and charcoal came up with the formula for gunpowder. The Song made gunpowder bombs, using paper and bamboo casings, and eruptors, which emitted fire and, in some models, small projectiles. As explained by a Song author: "The eruptive incendiary spear employs a giant bamboo [section] as its tube, within which is emplaced a pellet basket. After igniting and the flames are exhausted, the basket of pellets bursts forth with a sound like a bomb that can be heard more than 150 paces away."⁴⁷

Advances in military technology were accompanied by new developments in shipbuilding and navigation. Song boatbuilders devised human-powered paddle wheel boats that plied the canals and rivers; Song oceangoing ships were built with iron nails, waterproofed with oil-based caulking, and equipped with the sternpost rudder and the compass (both Chinese inventions). Waterproof bulkheads subdivided the hulls of Chinese ships into multiple compartments to minimize the effects of leaks and to improve buoyancy. Song ships were among the best of their time and carried shipments of Chinese goods to Japan, Southeast Asia, and perhaps as far as East Africa.

Whether by river or canal, by sea or by land, Song merchants and the Song state shipped a wide variety of goods between different regions of Song territory, from Song to Liao, Xi Xia, and Jin, and to Japan, Korea, and other overseas markets. Bulk agricultural goods like rice and vegetable oils were generally traded only within Song territory. But manufactures and luxury goods were often shipped to foreign markets. Porcelain was one of the more important items for export. Large-scale porcelain kilns produced goods for domestic consumption and for export (bowls and food vessels, pillows, and decorative items), some of which were illustrated with pictures done in the style of book illustrations.⁴⁸

High-quality paper and books, too, were valued items on the domestic and international markets. Song woodblock printing techniques were highly efficient and contributed to a significant increase in the production of books—both

high-quality collectors' editions and much more: the classics, volumes of sample examination essays, books on agriculture, medicine, and technology, literature, and much more to serve the needs of a growing reading public, particularly the men of those literati families whose sons were educated with an eye to gaining official positions through the examination system.

Technological innovation and rising agricultural production were accompanied by population growth and urbanization. China's population roughly doubled from sixty to sixty-five million in the Tang to roughly 120 million for the Southern Song and Jin together around 1200.⁴⁹ The much larger population of the Song period was also distributed differently. In the Tang Empire, sixty percent of the population lived in northern China and forty percent in the south; in the Northern Song, around sixty-two percent of the population lived in the south. Between 742 and 1200, the population of the Southeast and the Middle Yangzi grew by 695 and 483 percent, respectively, with very high rates of growth also occurring in Guangdong and Jiangnan (the lower Yangzi area).⁵⁰ As the south accounted for a growing proportion of the population, so too did the cities. The capitals of the Northern Song (Kaifeng, population around one million) and Southern Song (Hangzhou, population around two million) were the centers of urban culture as well as political power. Urbanization also meant the growth of many smaller cities and towns: by the middle of the Song period, five percent of the population was urban.⁵¹

The growth of cities, increased agricultural production, technological innovation, and population growth all contributed to substantial changes in the way in which people in the Northern and Southern Song (and the Jin) lived and worked. Printing, gunpowder, the mariner's compass, and the use of sophisticated techniques and machinery in the large-scale production of iron, silk, and porcelain all point to the wealth and (by some definitions) modernity of the Song. All of these developments were closely intertwined with the daily lives of commoners and elites, with commerce, and with debates about the appropriate role of government in managing society and economic activity.

Daily Life, Commerce, and Government

Rural people, who certainly did not live comfortable lives, generated the wealth that supported the Song's large (and expensive) armies and fuelled the Song "commercial revolution." Although official tax rates were low (ten percent of the annual harvest in the early Northern Song), special taxes and surtaxes, many of them initially intended to support the military, brought the real tax rate up to onerous levels. Farmers paid their taxes and rents in silk and hempen cloth, grain, silver, and, increasingly, in money, both bronze coins and paper currency. Farmers also used money when they engaged with the commercial economy, which they did on a regular basis, traveling to nearby villages or small towns on market days (markets were generally held in the mornings on three- or six-day cycles) to sell produce and handicrafts and to purchase tools and items of daily use.

We know much more about the lives of urban people—artisans, merchants, the literati elite, and the imperial court—than we do about the farmers. One particularly fascinating resource, a hand-scroll painted in the 12th century, depicts urban scenes, perhaps in the Northern Song capital of Kaifeng.⁵² As the 18-foot-long (5.25 m) "Qingming Scroll" unrolls, we see fields and villages, donkeys bringing fuel to market, women on their way to the city (a wealthy woman in a sedan chair, women from somewhat less wealthy families riding donkeys). Then, following a bend in the river, we come to the city itself. Boats are laden with goods and passengers. The streets are lined with shops. Hawkers and peddlers sell tools, food, and drink from stalls in a bustling market area near (and on) a graceful wooden bridge. Buddhist monks, Daoist priests, and Confucian scholars share the streets with the merchants, artisans, and storytellers. The market has spilled outside the unguarded city gate, where a camel caravan approaches and a customer takes an experimental pull at a bow in a bowyer's shop.

The scroll and other Song paintings show us not only men, but also women and children. The roles of women and their place in the family and in society were the subjects of much debate and (among certain moralistic philosophers) consternation. Both Northern and Southern Song philosophers reemphasized the moral and intellectual inferiority of women and the importance of keeping them in their proper place, secluded within the walls of the family compound.⁵³ In a famous remark meant to underline the importance of female chastity (loyalty to one husband), the Northern Song philosopher Cheng Yi once remarked that: "to starve to death is a minor matter; to lose one's virtue [by remarrying] is a matter of the utmost importance."⁵⁴ The Song also saw the beginning of a practice that would become more common in the Ming and Qing: foot-binding. Perhaps originating with dancers around the end of the Tang, foot-binding required that a girl's feet be tightly bound, beginning around the age of six. Tight wrappings compressed the toes and forced the foot into a short, arched shape, ideally about three inches (eight cm) in length.⁵⁵

As significant as they became in the Ming and Qing dynasties, neither the fierce morality of Cheng Yi nor foot-binding (which was still limited to only a small portion of the elite in Southern Song) tell us of the breadth and variety of women's roles in Song China. Song women could own and inherit property and retained a high degree of control over property brought into their marriage as dowry.⁵⁶ Remarriage, though frowned upon by the moralists, was common. Many elite women were literate and responsible for the early education of their children, both girls and boys.⁵⁷ While their realm was within the family compound, elite women often managed household finances and servants.⁵⁸ Although arranged marriage was the rule, some elite men and women enjoyed "companionate marriage," the most famous example being the marriage of the poet Li Qingzhao (1084–c. 1151) and her scholar-official husband and companion in literary and antiquary scholarship, Zhao Mingcheng (1081–1129).



Detail from a copy of the 12th-century "Qingming Scroll."

Men and women, the wealthy and the poor, all lived with the reality of commercialization. The simple fact that an increasing percentage of tax revenue was collected in money brought more people into the cash economy. The Song minted many times more bronze coins than the Tang had: eight-hundred thousand in 997, over six million in 1085.⁵⁹ In the 1020s the Song government became the first in the world to print paper money. Merchants also used silk, silver, and other precious metals as media of exchange. Court cases show that Song men and women brought all manner of claims before the district magistrates: arguments over land, houses, and inheritances; problems with fraud, gambling, and violence; and disputes over money.⁶⁰

Song government officials relied on a written code of law to resolve these and other disputes. The law itself and the basic structure of the Song state were derived from Tang models. But there were some key differences. Tang emperors often found themselves hemmed in by powerful aristocratic military clans, whose men produced the lion's share of Tang officials. Song emperors drew their advisors from the literati elite, whose status was derived from a combination of wealth, education, and performance on the civil service examinations. As a result, Song emperors were more socially distant from their officials and exercised a greater degree of autocratic power.⁶¹ The autocratic power of the emperors vis-à-vis their officials increased over time, reaching even greater heights in the Ming and Qing periods.

But while the emperors became more autocratic, most Song people never saw an imperial official, let alone an emperor. Most of the details of people's lives were handled by family and clan. At the local level, the government organized households into decimal groups for mutual policing and tax collection. By producing far more educated men than could possibly earn examination degrees and more degreeholders than could be given government jobs, the schools and examination system generated a literati elite which increasingly (especially in the Southern Song) took responsibility for the affairs of their communities. As a result, the Song marks not only the beginning of an increase in autocracy, but also a decline in the power of central government vis-à-vis society and local administration. This made it more and more difficult for imperial governments to intervene in the economy and to pry tax revenue away from local and provincial administrators.⁶²

The Learning of the Way

The explosion of commerce and the rich variety of Song material life was accompanied by a similar (and related) variety and change in Song religion and philosophy. Buddhist institutions did not have the same degree of wealth

and power as in the Tang, but Buddhism still played an important role in the religious lives of elite and commoner. The most popular schools of Buddhism in the Song were Chan and Pure Land. Chan, known as Zen in Japan, placed its greatest emphasis on sudden enlightenment and on the transmission of the Buddhist teachings directly from master to disciple without the mediation of texts (a tradition that did not prevent the production of Chan sutras!). Pure Land devotees believed that the Amida Buddha would, through his grace, allow them to be reborn in his “Pure Land” or “Western Paradise” if they chanted his name with true devotion. Buddhism also continued to play a role in economic life: like the Tang, the Song sold ordination certificates to raise money; people bought ordination certificates because monk status brought exemption from taxes.⁶³

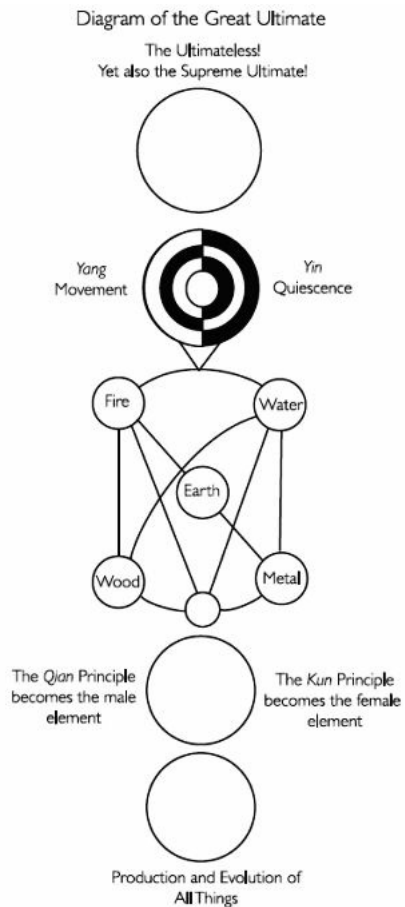
Religious Daoism remained tremendously popular in the Song, both among the imperial family (many of whom were liberal patrons of Daoism) and the elite, and among more humble people. So too did the worship of a variety of local gods: stove gods, earth gods, gods who were thought to have the power “to bring rain, to clear the skies, to drive out locusts, to expel bandits, to suppress uprisings, to cure illnesses, to enable couples to conceive, to prevent epidemics, and to help men pass the civil service examinations.”⁶⁴ Still other local gods came to the aid of merchants: for example, Lü Dongbin, a heavydrinking “immortal” who correctly predicts that a reed-mat merchant will turn a huge profit in Hangzhou (where a shortage of reed mats has led prices to skyrocket) and a god who enabled fish and salt merchants to increase their profits tenfold.⁶⁵ People served whichever gods seemed to be efficacious with offerings and prayers.

As more and more merchants, worshippers, and clergy traveled to and fro, they brought their gods with them to new places and brought the gods of other places back to their hometowns. Over time, some local gods developed regional or even national followings. In addition, the Song state, concerned about the chaotic nature of popular religion, tried to assert some control and order on the spiritual world by granting titles and recognition to some deities and denying recognition to others. Government intervention in the spiritual realm prompted wealthy men to lobby the government to recognize their gods. Other men likewise petitioned the government to proscribe the “licentious cults” of gods that they disapproved of.⁶⁶

Like the state, members of the literati elite (many of whom served as officials at some point in their career) were interested in establishing spiritual and cultural orthodoxy. A number of Northern and Southern Song men concerned themselves explicitly with the exposition and articulation of the true Way of Confucius—which they believed had been lost for many generations. These men, all of whom deeply believed that the Confucian Way must be reconstructed and used to achieve the moral transformation of the state and the people, differed among each other as to just what the Way was, how to know it, and how to practice it. In the West, their “Learning of the Way” is generally referred to as “Neo-Confucianism.”

Neo-Confucianism was an intellectual reaction to the challenges of Buddhist and Daoist philosophy. Buddhists suggested that all the “myriad things” of the universe, including human nature, were manifestations of the Buddha spirit. Daoism suggested that the universal “Way” (dao) generated all things. Neo-Confucians responded that the “Great Ultimate” generated yin and yang, which gave birth to the myriad things. And what was the “Great Ultimate”? Neo-Confucian thinkers identified it with “Principle”—a classical Confucian concept which implied universal moral values. By extension, if Buddhists argued that all people, being manifestations of the Buddha-spirit, share the Buddha nature, then the Neo-Confucians suggested that all people share the same moral human nature: therefore, when people understand the Principle that underlies the universe, they understand the moral principles that they must put into practice in order to achieve an ordered family, good government, and peace under heaven.

As the Learning of the Way developed, two major Neo-Confucian schools of thought emerged: the School of Principle and the School of the Heart/ Mind.⁶⁷ All understood Principle to be essentially moral. The two schools differed, however, on the way in which human beings are to understand Principle.



Taijitu, diagram of the “Great Ultimate.”

The main proponent of the School of the Heart/Mind was a Southern Song man named Lu Jiuyuan (also called Lu Xiangshan, 1139–1193). Lu held that “perfect truth is always a unity, the essential principle is never a duality. The mind and principle can never be separated into two.”⁶⁸ Accordingly, Lu maintained that to understand Principle, one need only look within one’s own heart-and-mind (the two western concepts are both implied in the single Chinese character *xin*, usually translated simply as “heart”). Lu’s thinking was strongly influenced by Chan (Zen) Buddhism and its teaching that one suddenly realizes one’s inherent Buddha nature.

The School of Principle is most often identified with Lu’s contemporary (and intellectual sparring partner) Zhu Xi (1130–1200). Zhu Xi argued that although all things—men and women, animals and plants, rocks and furniture—are manifestations of Principle, they are combined with “material force,” which gives them their different qualities—bright, clear, intelligent, murky, dull, or beastly, as the case may be. Although all people share the same essential Principle, it shines or is obscured to varying degrees depending on the quality of the material force in which it is made incarnate. Zhu Xi suggested that one may understand Principle (and therefore cultivate one’s inherent morality) by observing the natural world, human affairs, and history.

Each school of thought had different implications. Lu’s strategy of looking within to achieve enlightenment had the potential to lead to intellectual independence, but also to moral relativism. In later centuries, the School of the Heart/Mind came to be identified with heterodoxy, resistance to authority, and even rebellion. Zhu Xi’s insistence on finding truth by “investigating things”—that is, deriving standards by reference to external criteria—was attractive to rulers who were in a position to define the criteria of truth and falsehood by setting the curriculum and format for the civil service examinations. Although Zhu was a controversial man during his own life, later dynastic regimes established the School of Principle as orthodoxy.

While Neo-Confucian philosophy supplied answers to ontological questions, it also supplied the moral bases for practical political and social action. The Neo-Confucian thinkers argued that only by returning to the moral values of

the Confucian classics and living them through renewed emphasis on ritual and hierarchy could their empire become strong enough to defeat their enemies (Khitan, Tangut, and Jurchen) and recover lost Chinese territory. As far as international relations were concerned, the Neo-Confucians were, in general, in favor of bringing the fight to the “barbarians.”

In broader terms, the renaissance of Confucian philosophy informed a broad range of practical initiatives. Northern Song scholars, both those whom we think of as part of the Learning of the Way and others, were confident that the imperial government was capable of solving problems. It was this confidence that led Fan Zhongyan (989–1052) and Ouyang Xiu (1007–1072) to make their attempt at moderate administrative reform, and which formed the basis of Emperor Shenzong and Wang Anshi’s more radical belief that they could introduce new policies that would relieve the sufferings of the common people, enhance government revenue, and strengthen the military. The extent to which men of the Northern Song believed in and were tied to central government service is even evident in their lives and their marriage patterns. These men left their native villages and made careers and lives on the national stage. They married their children to the children of men like them, but from all parts of the empire, as a way of building useful long-term relationships.⁶⁹

By contrast, the men of the Southern Song, though similarly inspired by Confucian philosophy, tended to act locally. Much more so than their Northern Song forebears, the men of Southern Song turned their attention to their home counties and villages, organizing militias, managing granaries for famine relief, donating money to build bridges or renovate temples, and supporting schools for the boys of their lineage or their village. Lu Jiuyuan, for example, was, with other members of his elite family, active in organizing a militia. Zhu Xi drafted practical documents such as regulations for a school, the White Deer Grotto Academy (which he founded), and for community granaries. Southern Song men also married their children locally: alliances with other powerful families in one’s own or closely neighboring counties now seemed more useful than alliances with elite families from far-off provinces.

The increased localism of Southern Song men reflects a lack of confidence in the emperor’s bureaucracy. It also reflects the fact that in the Southern Song, the attention and the resources of the state were increasingly focused on the defense of the border against the Jurchen Jin and, later, the Mongols. The Southern Song rulers had little attention to spare for internal problems such as famine relief and banditry. As a result, the local elite, whose conduct was both inspired and justified by their re-invigorated Confucian moral philosophy, stepped into the breach, taking on the responsibilities that, in an earlier era, would naturally have been handled by the imperial government.

But the same concern with the local also carried with it a determination on the part of men like Zhu Xi and others to spread the values, practices, vocabulary, and texts associated with Confucius and Mencius to the people in general. Zhu, for example, produced edited and annotated versions of the Confucian classics and wrote a simplified manual of family ritual which later became widely circulated in the original and various revised editions.⁷⁰ Historians see this as the beginning the “Confucianization of the whole of Chinese society.”⁷¹ While the material circumstances of their lives were, and continued to be, very different from those of the literati elite, commoners were beginning to become more aware of and share in a cultural identity articulated by the literati and epitomized by idealized literati lifestyles.

The Cultural Marketplace

Urbanization, commercialization, the rise of the literati class, and their sense of national crisis contributed to significant developments in art and literature. The rise of markets made both art and literature into commodities to a larger degree than ever before. With a larger customer base, religious art entered the market in a big way: professional artists mass-produced images of Buddhas and bodhisattvas (Guanyin, the bodhisattva of compassion and mercy, was especially popular) and vivid paintings of the Buddhist hell realms. Advances in woodblock printing allowed the production for sale of collections of calligraphy and ink painting. Connoisseurship was now available not only to a small group of scholars, but also to anyone who had cash to spare.⁷²

For those who preferred entertainment to connoisseurship, theater and storytelling flourished in the great cities of Kaifeng and Hangzhou. *Zaju*, short farcical plays, incorporated elements of storytelling, singing, and dance. “Southern plays” based on the popular entertainment of Fujian province’s Wenzhou city adapted styles of song and poetry from around the Southern Song. “Medleys,” suites of songs, each in a different key, told a story. Love stories were popular, particularly those in which a dashing (and brilliant) young scholar rescues his lover, a courtesan, from

a forced marriage with a rich, but old and ugly merchant.⁷³ These theatrical forms, which developed most strongly in the later years of the Southern Song (and also in the Jurchen Jin), were the beginnings of what became, in the Yuan dynasty, a more fully developed style of writing for the theater.

While professional artists and writers created works for the market, it was still the imperial house and the literati elite who dominated artistic and literary production and who set standards both through their art and by defining aesthetics through works of theory and criticism.

The Song emperors led the way by patronizing and practicing the arts and literature as a way of underlining their own legitimacy. The dynastic founder Zhao Kuangyin claimed that he himself embodied “this culture of ours.”⁷⁴ He and his successors in the Northern and Southern Song periods collected and cataloged painting, calligraphy, antique bronzes, and literature on a greater scale and more systematically than had the emperors of Sui, Tang, or Han. The court patronized the kilns which produced luxury porcelain and made the court the center of production for painting. The court also set standards for prose and poetry by requiring certain styles to be used in the civil service examinations. In the early Song, for example, all examination essays had to be written in highly formalistic Tang-dynasty style of parallel prose.

But while they generally bowed to (and contributed to) the aesthetic influence of the court, groups of independent-minded Song literati often had tense relationships with the court, with their emperors, and with rival groups of scholar-officials. Their aesthetic preferences reflected dissatisfaction with the examination system, frustration with loss of territory to the Tangut, Khitan, and Jurchen, debates over government policy, factional struggles at court, and setbacks in their careers. Art and literature were, in short, often intertwined with politics and moral judgments. Song scholars who saw themselves as independent arbiters of morality, loyalty, and aesthetics had a significant long-term influence on the development of Chinese literature and art.

Some of the literati reactions against imperially sanctioned orthodoxy became very influential—and ultimately were established as orthodoxy themselves. This is what happened when Ouyang Xiu, Su Shi, and other Northern Song literati rebelled against the inflexible requirements of formal parallel prose. Ouyang and Su argued for a return to the “ancient style” of writing seen in the Confucian classics. In fact, they had no intention of literally returning to the style of the classics: they used the concept of a return to the “ancient style” as a way of creating their own more flexible and straightforward prose style, using more ordinary words, drawing on less formal styles of literature, and broadening their writing to address not only philosophy and affairs of state, but also less serious topics of daily life.⁷⁵ When Ouyang Xiu served as chief examiner, he required that examination essays be written in his “ancient style” prose. His victory was short-lived: parallel prose was later restored and remained the preferred style for the civil service examinations up through the late 19th century. The Song “ancient style” movement did, however, have a powerful influence over literati writing both in the Song and later dynasties.

Poetry, too, played a central role in the lives of the literati. While Tang styles of verse remained popular, the Song is best known for the lyric (*ci*). The lyric had its origins in the Central Asian songs performed by courtesans and other professional entertainers during the Tang dynasty. Poets would “fill in” new words to fit the established, but irregular, pattern of the original lyrics to a given song, thus creating a new song lyric. The lyric form developed through the interaction of professional entertainers and literati men in the entertainment districts of the great cities of late Tang and Northern Song.

The early lyric poetry reflected its origins: it was heavily concerned with love, and usually written in the voice of a woman (even if the author was a man). Li Qingzhao, one of the most famous writers of lyrics in her own time, was exceptional in directly expressing a woman’s perspective. Other poets, including the official Su Shi, began to use the lyric form to address more traditional male topics: affairs of state and the ideals of the scholar-official. Su Shi’s lyrics influenced subsequent generations in both the Southern Song and Jin dynasties.

Part of Su Shi’s appeal lies in his biting use of poetry in the factional struggles of the Northern Song. Su Shi and many, many less famous officials sacrificed many years of their careers when they opposed Wang Anshi’s New Policies. Su’s criticisms, voiced subtly (so he thought) in poems, would have earned him the death penalty had not the elderly empress dowager intervened on his behalf. Like so many other opponents of Wang Anshi, he was sent away into internal exile. This sort of experience led to a genre of poetry in which the authors complain, not without humor, about their failed careers, as Su did in these lines, written on the birth of his son:

Families, when a child is born
Want it to be intelligent.
I, through intelligence,

Having wrecked my whole life,
Only hope that the baby will prove
Ignorant and stupid.
Then he will crown a tranquil life
By becoming a cabinet minister.⁷⁶

In the early years of the Southern Song, angry literati used both the lyric and verse forms to lament the loss of the north to the Jurchen “barbarians” and to express their frustration at imperial policies that seemed more intent on appeasement than on retaking the lost territory. As Lu You (1125–1210) put it:

Rebel barbarians not slain, my heart not at peace,
A lonely sword clangs at my bedside.

As the decades rolled by, many Southern Song poets turned their attention to other aspects of life: plum blossoms, lyrics written to congratulate friends or powerful officials on their birthdays, and the contemplation of bucolic, peaceful scenery. Poetry, however, continued to play its well-established role as a polite (but still dangerous) way of criticizing the imperial government and its policies.

Like poetry, painting was a vehicle both for artistic self-expression and for political dissent. Just as Northern Song literati used the “ancient style” to reject the restrictive formality of parallel prose, they praised the ideal of the amateur in art in order to denigrate the technically better, but (they would argue) spiritless work of the professional artist.

This distinction between the amateur and the professional would remain central to the literati understanding of art until the literati themselves ceased to exist in the 20th century. Painting and calligraphy, they believed, must reflect the character of the artist and were best done spontaneously by gentlemen gathered together in amiable sociability; such work should capture the spirit, the essential principle of the subject—not merely reproduce a likeness with mechanical accuracy. Su Shi, who was a strong proponent of the ideal of amateurism, argued that art should express a poetic feeling: “In poetry, there should be painting, and in painting, poetry.” Nonetheless, the imperial Painting Academy and its professionals remained the main center of art in both Northern and Southern Song.

The paintings most representative of the Song period are ink, with or without color, on paper or silk. Landscapes were particularly popular. Many of the Song landscapes may be meant to represent the realms of the Daoist immortals rather than any real scenery. Northern Song landscape painting tended toward the full and monumental, with some works being large wall paintings. One particularly famous landscape, the court painter Guo Xi’s (after 1000–c. 1090) “Early Spring,” is thought to be a celebration of imperial rule, with the central peak in the mountain scene representing the emperor. Given the year in which it was painted (1072), it may also be viewed as an affirmation of Wang Anshi’s New Policies, which were bringing in new tax revenue (and causing much contention, as seen above).⁷⁷

Southern Song court painting moved away from the monumental style and confident fullness of the Northern Song toward a smaller, more personal perspective, with more painting done on hand-scrolls and fans, and landscapes painted in the “one-corner” style, in which the focus is on an intimate scene in a corner of the painting, with the rest of the landscape a vague and distant background. Southern Song painting also tended to focus more on single objects: a tree, a rock, a flower.

As in the Northern Song, much of Southern Song art was deeply related to political issues. Gaozong, the first Southern Song emperor and an avid patron of the arts, had his court painters produce a series of scenes based on the account of how the late Zhou dynasty Duke Wen of Jin, after a series of trials and tribulations, recovered his lost state—a story that carried deeply hopeful symbolism for the Southern Song, which had lost its northern territory to the Jin. Southern Song literati, whose lives were often more focused on local than national issues, also expressed their political opinions and hopes in their painting. The popularity of the “three friends of winter”—the early blossoming plum, the bamboo, and the pine—is indicative of their selfimage as lonely voices of moral rectitude living unappreciated in hard times. The plum, the first tree to bloom in the early spring, symbolizes hope for better times ahead; the bamboo, which bends but does not break, and the pine, which stays green throughout the winter, stand for the strength and constancy of the moral man’s convictions.

Conclusion

The centuries in which the Liao, Xi Xia, Jin, and Song ruled their various parts of China and Inner Asia saw a number of significant developments. The Liao, Xi Xia, and Jin rulers developed techniques by which non-Han rulers might adapt elements of Chinese culture and imperial rule in order to build larger, stronger tribal confederacies while effectively managing and taxing Chinese farmers, artisans, and merchants. The Liao and Jin systems of multiple capitals and rulers who acted as both khans and emperors proved to be useful to their successors, the Mongols.

In China Proper, the Northern and Southern Song and the Jin saw a number of developments, all of which had significant long-term implications: the disappearance of the martial aristocracy and the rise of the examination-generated literati elite; the subordination of martial virtue to civil virtue; the economic, commercial, and technological revolutions; the popularization of tea-drinking; and the beginnings of long-term trends including the rise of autocracy, the decline of the central government power and the rise of localism, foot-binding, and the scholar-amateur ideal in art and literature.

Loss of the Sixteen Prefectures, and then of the north, to non-Chinese regimes also seems to have inspired a distrust of foreigners and a “tendency to reject the foreign simply because it is foreign,” which contrasts sharply with the openness to foreign things that was so characteristic of the Tang.²⁸ Song emperors and generals, officials and artists all expressed concern about loss of territory and loss of honor. The late Southern Song literati painter Zhao Mengjian (1199–before 1267) chose to indicate the Southern Song dilemma in a 12-foot (3.5 m) hand-scroll monochrome painting of narcissus—a flower known as the water goddess, which made the painting an allusion to Qu Yuan, the loyal minister of Chu who drowned himself when his ruler, misled by corrupt men, failed to recognize his loyalty and talent.²⁹ Qu Yuan’s homeland, the state of Chu, fell to invaders from the north—the Qin. Although Zhao Mengjian did not live to see it happen, his Song, too, would soon fall to invaders from the north.

Notes

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3. *Ibid.*, 36.
4. Jing-shen Tao, *Two Sons of Heaven: Studies in Sung-Liao Relations* (Tucson: The University of Arizona Press, 1988), 79–81.
5. Valerie Hansen, *The Open Empire: A History of China to 1600* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2000), 309–13.
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9. Naomi Standen, *Unbounded Loyalty: Frontier Crossing in Liao China* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 2007), 96, 104.
0. Naomi Standen, “Review: Alien Regimes and Mental States,” *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 40.1 (1997): 76.
1. Ruth Dunnell, “The Hsi Hsia,” in Franke and Twitchett, *The Cambridge History of China, Vol. 6*, 181.
2. Mote, *Imperial China*, 180–1.
3. From Weiming Yuanhao’s letter to the Song court, trans. in Ruth W. Dunnell, *The Great State of White and High: Buddhism and State Formation in Eleventh-Century Xia* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 1996), 41.
4. Quoted in Dunnell, “The Hsi Hsia,” 187.
5. Jing-shen Tao, *Two Sons of Heaven*, 47, 64; Mote, *Imperial China*, 185.
6. Dunnell, “The Hsi Hsia,” 192.

7. Dunnell, "The Hsi Hsia," 203; Dunnell, *The Great State of White and High*, 38, 157.
8. E.J. Kychanov, "Nomads in the Tangut State of Hsi-Hsia (982–1227 AD)," in Anatoly M. Khazov and André Wink, eds., *Nomads in the Sedentary World* (Richmond, Surrey: Curzon Press, 2001), 207. Kychanov estimates a population of "about four or five million." Ruth Dunnell suggests a population of three million in the mid–12th century. Dunnell, "The Hsi Hsia," 154.
9. Kychanov, "Nomads in the Tangut State," 192–202.
0. Dunnell, "The Hsi Hsia," 196; Kychanov, "Nomads in the Tangut State," 201; Mote, *Imperial China*, 257; Nancy Shatzman Steinhardt, "The Tangut Royal Tombs Near Yinchuan," in *Muqarnas* 10, Essays in Honor of Oleg Grabar (1993): 369–81.
1. Mote, *Imperial China*, 115.
2. David A. Graff, *Medieval Chinese Warfare, 300–900* (London: Routledge, 2002), 244–6.
3. John W. Chaffee, *The Thorny Gates of Learning in Sung China: A Social History of Examinations* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1985), 23–4. Much of the following discussion of Song examinations draws on Chaffee.
4. For discussions of the Song literati elite, see Chaffee, *The Thorny Gates of Learning*, and also Richard L. Davis, *Court and Family in Sung China, 960–1279: Bureaucratic Success and Kinship Fortunes for the Shi of Ming-chou* (Durham: Duke University Press, 1986); Thomas H. C. Lee, *Government Education and Examinations in Sung China* (Boston: St. Martin's Press, 1985); Robert P. Hymes, *Statesmen and Gentlemen: The Elite of Fu-chou, Chiang-hsi, in Northern and Southern Sung* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1986); Beverly J. Bossler, *Powerful Relations: Kinship, Status and the State in Sung China (960–1279)* (Cambridge, Mass.: Council on East Asian Studies, Harvard University, 1998); Peter K. Bol, "This Culture of Ours": *Intellectual Transitions in T'ang and Sung China* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1992).
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6. Xiao-bin Ji, *Politics and Conservatism in Northern Song China: The Career and Thought of Sima Guang (A.D. 1019–1086)* (Hong Kong: The Chinese University Press, 2005).
7. Quoted in Bol, "This Culture of Ours" 215.
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0. Bol, "This Culture of Ours," 215, 218.
1. Paul Forage, "The Sino-Tangut War of 1081–85," *Journal of Asian History* 25.1 (1991): 1–28.
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7. Yu-Kung Kao, "A Study of the Fang La Rebellion," *Harvard Journal of Asiatic Studies* 24 (1962–1963): 27–38.
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2. Valerie Hansen, "The Beijing Qingming Scroll and Its Significance for the Study of Chinese History," *Journal of Sung-Yuan Studies* (1996): 1–5. The scroll itself may be viewed online at <http://afe.easia.columbia.edu/song/>, in Conrad Schirokauer, faculty consultant, *The Song Dynasty in China (960–1279)* (New York: Asia for Educators, Columbia University, 2008), and <http://www.yale.edu/history/faculty/materials/hansen-qingming-scroll.html>, in Hansen, *The Beijing Qingming Scroll* (New Haven: Yale University History Department, 2007). The following draws on the scroll as presented on these two Web sites and on Hansen's discussion.
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4. Wing Tsit-chan, trans., *Reflections on Things at Hand: The Neo-Confucian Anthology Compiled by Chu Hsi and Lü Tsuch'ien* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1967), 177.
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 4. Hansen, *Changing Gods*, 3.
 5. *Ibid.*, 77, 164.
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 7. This is, admittedly, a simplified way of characterizing a complex intellectual movement which included many men and many contradictory points of view.
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The Yuan Dynasty

The Song had coexisted unhappily with confederations of pastoral/hunting people on their northern and northwestern frontiers. Emperors had written poetic laments for their lost territories, armies had skirmished unsuccessfully on the borders. Southern Song scholars lamented the fact that they could not visit the homeland of Confucius and longed for someone to reunify north and south. In 1276, the long-hoped-for unification became a reality. But the unifier was not a brave scion of the Song imperial house or a spiritual heir of General Yue Fei: it was the hard-drinking Mongol warrior Qubilai Khan.

Qubilai was the grandson of Chinggis Khan, who, from his base in Mongolia, had created the core of what became a world empire which would ultimately stretch from Eastern Europe to China and the edges of southeast Asia. Qubilai's Yuan dynasty was established in northern China, which the Mongols had taken from the Jurchen Jin in 1272. His conquest of the Southern Song capital in 1276 incorporated South China into an empire which included not only China Proper, but also Yunnan, Tibet, and parts of Mongolia and Manchuria. The dynasty was relatively short: it fell in 1368, scarcely seventy-five years after Qubilai's death. But the decades of Mongol rule changed China in many ways, not least because China had been incorporated into the Mongol world empire. China's incorporation also changed the Mongol world empire, which was dismembered into separate and often warring khanates. This is a story of globalization and refragmentation that begins on the Mongolian steppe in the mid-12th century.



Chinggis Khan. Paint and ink on silk.

Chinggis Khan and the Rise of the Mongols

Around 1150, a small and not very powerful pastoral people called Mongols lived a nomadic life in the area between the Onon and Kerülen Rivers—an area where steppes and forest merge. While relying on their herds, they supplemented their diet with hunting and fishing. Around them were numerous other nomadic/hunting people. The Tatars to the east and southeast, the Merkid to the west, the Buriat to the north, the Qonggirad to the southeast, the Kereyid and Önggüd to the southwest, in the far west and northwest (western Mongolia and modern Xinjiang), the Oirad, Kirgiz, the Naimans, Uighurs, and that branch of the Khitans who had founded the Qara-Khitai. The ethnic and linguistic identities and relations of these various tribes remain unclear. Some (like the Önggüd) were Turkic-speaking. Others (like the Naiman and the Kereyid) were Mongolic speakers, though possibly of Turkic origin. All

of them had been parts of the great Inner Asian empires of the past—the Khitan, Turkish, and Uighur Empires which challenged and allied with the settled Chinese empires.

Unity was difficult to impose on these disparate tribes and their shifting confederations. What they had in common was the nomadic way of life. They lived in felt tents, or *ger*. They raised cattle, goats, and sheep, which they moved, following the seasons, among more or less well-defined pasturelands. They used camels to transport heavy loads and horses for mobility, hunting, and warfare. Nomadic societies were aristocratic, with the leading clans dominating the common herders. Raiding was a regular part of life. When driven by necessity or desire, nomads would raid the camps of other tribes, taking livestock, other goods, women, and even common men, whom they would incorporate into their own ranks.



[Central and East Asia on the eve of the Mongolian conquests.](#)

The Mongol tribes were particularly notorious for their constant fighting. This was the environment into which Temüjin, the boy who would become Chinggis Khan, was born, around 1165. Chinggis' shaman Teb-Tenggeri later described it:

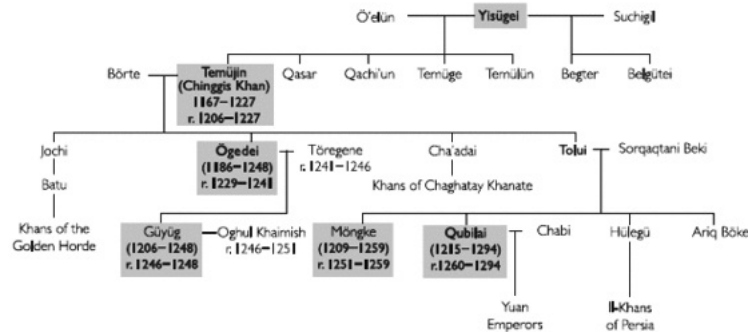
Everyone was feuding. Rather than sleep they robbed each other of their possessions. The earth and its crust had moved. The whole nation was in rebellion. Rather than rest, they fought each other. In such a world one did not live as one wished, but rather in constant conflict. There was no respite, only battle. There was no affection, only mutual slaughter.¹

The culture of inter-tribal enmity and raiding had a deep effect on Temüjin's life. His father Yisügei was a Mongol aristocrat of the Borjigid lineage whose followers, including members of the Tayachi'ud tribe. Yisügei frequently raided the Tatars and the Merkid, from whom he captured his primary wife Ö'elün (a Qonggirad). Ö'elün bore him a daughter and four sons, of whom Temüjin was the eldest. When Temüjin was around nine, Yisügei arranged his marriage to Börte, a ten-year-old Qonggirad girl. On the way home, Yisügei came across some Tatars who were having a feast. Following steppe custom, Yisügei joined them. The Tatars, who recognized him as the man who had raided them so often, poisoned his food. He died shortly after returning to his own camp.

Yisügei's death was devastating to his family. Because Ö'elün had no one to speak for her, the Tayachi'ud herders and the senior Borjigid clanswomen expelled her and her children, along with Yisügei's second wife and her children. Ignoring Ö'elün's pleas, the rest of the group rode off, leaving them to live or die on their own. Ö'elün is credited with keeping the family alive under the harshest of circumstances. As the *Secret History of the Mongols* tells it:

She nourished her small sons thus:
Pulling firmly her tall hat
Over her head,
Tying tightly her belt
To shorten her skirt,

Along the Onon River,
Running up and down,
She gathered crab apples and bird cherries,
Day and night she fed their hungry gullets.²



Chinggis Khan's family and heirs.

His family's desperate situation in the highly competitive world of the steppes may have contributed to Temüjin's later drive to dominate everything and everyone within reach. Within his family, the young Temüjin, the eldest son of his father's senior wife, Ö'elün, had a claim to the headship of the family. His elder half-brother Begter, the eldest son of Yisügei's secondary wife, was a competitor for leadership. Temüjin (then around fourteen years old) and his younger brother Qasar killed Begter on the grounds that he had taken a fish and a lark they had caught. Ö'elün scolded her sons for their murderous deed:

Like a jackal ganging up with its pack,
When one threatens its den;
Like a tiger never hesitant
When seizing its prey,
Like a brach attacking wildly,
You have destroyed!
Just when
We have no friend but our shadow,
We have no whip but our horse's tail,
And when, unable to put up with the outrage of our Tayachi'ud
kinsmen, we ask ourselves who shall take vengeance on them,
you behave [in this way] to each other.³

Ö'elün's worry about the Tayachi'ud was soon confirmed. Not long after the murder of Begter, the Tayachi'ud attacked and took Temüjin captive. After some days or weeks in captivity, he escaped with the help of a sympathetic Tayachi'ud tribesman. Temüjin may also have been captured and held for ransom by the Merkid. In 1178 he was formally married to Börte. Shortly afterwards, the Merkid raided Temüjin's camp and made off with her—their revenge for Temüjin's father's similar capture of Ö'elün from a Merkid.

Temüjin responded to the Merkid attack and kidnapping of his wife in the accustomed fashion of the steppe. Even before the raid, he had begun to make alliances with more powerful tribal leaders and to gather warrior followers, including his brothers and his half-brother Belgütei. Drawing on his connections, Temüjin raided the Merkid and recovered Börte. The successful operation made him a serious contender for power in the steppe. Over the next twenty-eight years, Temüjin brought more and more steppe tribes under his control, defeating some while making alliances with others. The process was difficult. Temüjin experienced defeats, some of them quite serious. After one defeat, around 1185, he fled for refuge to the territory of the Jurchen Jin dynasty, where, according to some records, he spent ten years as a slave.⁴

Back in Mongolia by 1195, Temüjin once again gathered followers to his side. Many of his followers were men of

the lower classes of the hierarchical, aristocratic Mongolian society—men who willingly joined him to fight the entrenched leaders. They first brought the various Mongol tribes under their control. Temüjin sealed his command of the Mongols by completely destroying his old enemies, the Tayachi'ud. That victory evidently convinced him that he could unify all the steppe people in one huge confederation.⁵ In a series of campaigns, Temüjin defeated the Tatars, the Kereyid, the Naiman, and others. With each victory, he distributed captured animals, goods, men, women, and children among his own followers. In 1205, he dominated the Mongolian plateau. At this point, he called a *quriltai*—that is, a meeting of the leaders of the various clans and tribes. Here, his followers acclaimed him as Chinggis Khan, meaning “Fierce Khan.”⁶ The leaders also discussed plans for their next military and diplomatic initiatives.⁷

From Steppe Confederacy to World Empire

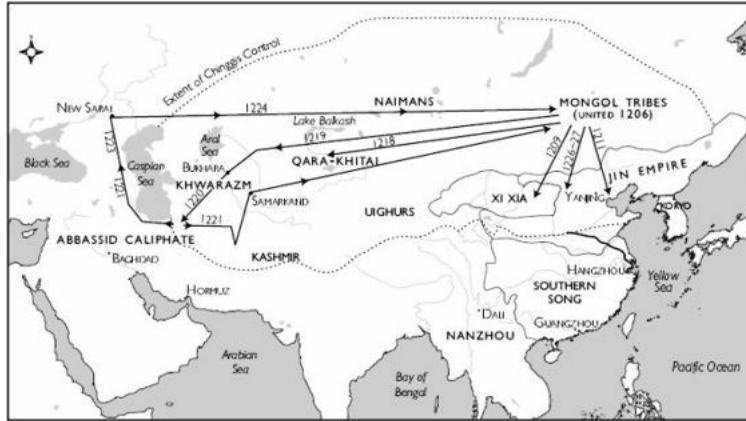
Chinggis Khan was now the acknowledged ruler of a multi-ethnic confederation which took on the name of his own particular tribe—Mongol. In order to keep that confederation together, he would need to impose discipline and organization and to reward his followers with the kind of material wealth that could be gained only by trading with or raiding the farmers and merchants of China to the south and Central Asia to the west.

Temüjin had begun the process of unifying and disciplining the Mongol warriors even before he was acclaimed as khan. He organized his troops into units of ten, one hundred, one thousand, and ten thousand.⁸ The khan himself was protected by the *kesalik*, a special bodyguard of ten thousand men who guarded Chinggis' person, supervised the preparation of his food and drink, and served in a variety of other capacities ranging from falconer to scribe. By breaking up larger tribal confederations into units of one thousand and introducing strict military discipline, Chinggis weakened the power of existing clan, tribal, and confederation leaders, ended the constant internal violence and revenge killings that had been a part of life on the steppe, and made the pastoral people into a unified, disciplined army.

The need to preserve his confederacy and maintain control over Mongolia drew Chinggis and his armies into contact with the neighboring regions and states. The first target of attack was the Tangut Xi Xia Empire. There are several reasons why Chinggis should have attacked the Xi Xia. One was revenge: the Xi Xia had offered refuge to Chinggis' enemies in the past. Economic and environmental factors may also have played a role. Years of warfare had taken their toll on the Mongols' animals. So too had changes in the climate: a decline in average annual temperatures in Mongolia between 1175 and 1260 reduced the height and extent of the grass on which both domesticated animals and game relied.⁹ The conquest of the Xi Xia began with raids (1205–1208) and then progressed to all-out attack. Mongol cavalry soon intimidated the Xi Xia emperor, who pledged loyalty to Chinggis in 1210. The Uighur Turks, impressed by the Mongols' operations against Xi Xia and hoping to escape the domination of the kingdom of Qara-Khitai, voluntarily submitted to Chinggis in 1209.

With the Tanguts and the Uighurs submitting to him, Chinggis' interests turned in two directions: south toward the Jurchen Jin dynasty, and west to Central Asia. Chinggis' invasions of Jin territories in northern China and Manchuria began as raids in 1211–1212. Over the next few years, Mongol attacks penetrated more deeply into China and Manchuria. In 1214 the Jin emperor, forced to make payoffs of gold, silver, and silk, abandoned his main capital city of Zhongdu (modern Beijing) and moved the court south to Kaifeng, in violation of his treaty with Chinggis. The next year an angry Chinggis captured Zhongdu. His men systematically sacked and burned the city and slaughtered its inhabitants. From 1214 to 1227, Mongol troops continued to capture Jin lands in China north of the Yellow River and in the Jurchen homeland of Manchuria.

The conquest of northern China proceeded relatively slowly because Chinggis had become embroiled on a second front in what became his Western Campaign. Pursuit of enemies who had fled Mongolia drew Chinggis into the Qara-Khitai kingdom (modern Xinjiang), which he absorbed in 1218. This, in turn, brought the Mongols into contact with the Khwarazm shah Muhammad II.¹⁰ Muhammad, a Muslim based in Central Asia, had built an empire corresponding roughly to modern Uzbekistan, Tajikistan, Iran, and parts of Afghanistan.



Chinggis Khan's military campaigns and the Mongol Empire, c. 1230.

Chinggis, eager to secure access to Central Asian trade routes, sent envoys to the Khwarazm shah. The two sides agreed to a treaty of trade and friendship in 1218. The next year, Chinggis sent a trade caravan (in which he had a personal investment) to the Khwarazmian Empire. Unfortunately, the governor of the city of Otrar, a vassal of Shah Muhammad II, slaughtered the members of the caravan (whom he suspected—not without reason—of spying) and confiscated all their goods. When envoys from Chinggis asked Muhammad to make amends and to turn the governor over to them for punishment, the Khwarazm shah refused. He also executed one of the khan's emissaries.

Chinggis' pride and his pocketbook had both been gravely insulted. He responded with a merciless attack. The disciplined, mobile, and expertly commanded Mongol forces defeated the numerically superior but badly divided Khwarazmian armies. Great trading cities like Otrar, Khwarazm, Samarkand, and Bukhara were put under siege, captured, and systematically looted. Towns that surrendered easily were spared; in places that resisted, the Mongols carried out mass executions of adult males and took women and craftsmen to serve as slaves. The Mongols used many captives as "arrow fodder," forcing them to do the deadly work of filling in moats and setting up and manning siege engines and rams when they attacked other Khwarazmian cities. The Khwarazm shah fled to the Caspian Sea, where he died of pneumonia in 1221. His mother, a skilled commander, was captured and humiliated. Chinggis and his army pursued the Khwarazm shah's son through Afghanistan to the Indus River where they destroyed the last of the Khwarazmian armies. Another part of the Mongol army continued west, making a 5,000-mile expedition across the Caucasus Mountains, through Georgia, up to the Crimean Peninsula, and then back into Central Asia, spreading fear and confusion and defeating Kipchak Turkish and Russian forces.

The campaigns in northern China and against the Khwarazm shah changed the way Chinggis and the Mongols thought about the goals of war. In the China campaign, Khitan and Jurchen turncoats encouraged Chinggis not merely to loot northern China, but to permanently acquire and administer Chinese land and its productive farmers. The Western Campaign opened the eyes of Chinggis and other Mongol leaders to the riches that could be gained by building an empire that would extend far beyond Mongolia. Before his clash with the Khwarazm shah, Chinggis' interests beyond the Mongolian steppe had been the same as those of earlier leaders of nomadic confederations: raiding and trading. Now, he expected permanent submission and a world empire.¹¹

Chinggis himself would not live to see the building of the Mongol world empire. His goals in the west achieved, he withdrew his overextended forces from the Indus River and appointed personal representatives, *darughachi*, to oversee native local officials in the eastern portions of the former Khwarazmian Empire. In 1225, he returned to Mongolia to attend to business there and in north China. The campaign against the Jin in north China had yet to be completed, and the Xi Xia emperor, having earlier pledged loyalty to Chinggis, had switched sides and was supporting the Jin. Chinggis, now around sixty-four years old, led the attack on the Xi Xia in 1226. He died, apparently of illness, in August 1227.¹² In accordance with his wishes, his generals completed the campaign, captured the Xi Xia capital, killed the Tangut emperor, and slaughtered the inhabitants of his city.

Chinggis left a tremendous legacy. He had unified the various Turkic and Mongolic tribes into a strong confederation and given them a common identity as Mongols. He had enforced discipline through draconian punishment and rewarded ability and loyalty with riches and promotion. Chinggis sponsored the adaptation of the Uighur script, which gave the Mongols a written language. One use of the new script was to write down the khan's

commands and decisions on disputes, matters pertaining to the army, discipline, and relations with foreign nations.¹³ These written records of Chinggis' decisions, became, along with Mongol customary law, a source of precedent which could be drawn upon when deciding legal cases.

Before his death, Chinggis had arranged for his empire to be divided among his four sons. Batu, the heir of Chinggis' eldest son, Jochi (d. 1227), received territory in north Central Asia, the Caucasus, Southern Siberia, and Russia (not all of which had been conquered). Cha'adai Khan, the second son, ruled parts of the former Khwarazmian Empire and adjoining lands in Central Asia. Chinggis' third son, Ögedei, had been chosen as the khan's political successor. Styling himself as *kaghan* (khan of khans, or emperor), Ögedei had territory in Zungharia (northern Xinjiang), but ruled in the Mongol capital of Karakorum as leader of all the four khanates. Tolui Khan, the fourth and youngest son, had the homeland of eastern Mongolia as his share. Northern China was to be administered as joint property, with appanages (fiefs) assigned to meritorious members of Chinggis' clan.¹⁴

Ögedei served as *kaghan* from 1229 until his death from alcoholism in 1241, when he was succeeded first by his son Güyük (r. 1241–1251) and then (after a brief struggle) by Möngke khan (r. 1251–1259), one of the four sons of Tolui. Under these men's leadership, and particularly during the reigns of Ögedei and Möngke, the Mongols created the huge world empire for which they are famous. In the far north Batu Khan's "Golden Horde" conquered Russia and inspired tremendous fear throughout Europe with the invasion of Poland and Hungary in 1241. Möngke's generals forced Korea to submit in 1259, after eight years of fighting; his younger brother Hülegü (1217–1265) extended Mongol control over modern Iran and Iraq, taking Baghdad in 1258. Both Ögedei and Möngke had a vision of a world empire and the determination and skill to translate that vision into reality. And both saw China as a part of their world empire.

China and the Rise of Qubilai Khan

Chinggis' campaigns against the Jurchen Jin had only begun the process of incorporating northern China into the Mongol Empire. Campaigns against the Jin from 1213 to 1220, causing tremendous death and destruction, had brought most of China north of the Yellow River under Mongol domination. Picking up where his father had left off, Ögedei attacked the Jin in 1230. In 1234, the Jin dynasty fell. China north of the Huai River belonged to the Mongols.

Although Ögedei completed the conquest of the Jin, it was the family of his younger brother Tolui who reaped the benefits. Tolui and his wife Sorqaqtani Beki had four sons: Möngke, Qubilai, Ariq Böke, and Hülegü. When Tolui died under mysterious circumstances in 1232, Sorqaqtani Beki, a Nestorian Christian, refused to remarry.¹⁵ Instead, she dedicated herself to raising her sons. All four young men learned the arts of war, in which their father had excelled. In addition, their mother retained an Uighur to teach them to read and write the Mongolian script.

Sorqaqtani Beki also played hardball politics to advance the family's interests. In 1236 she forced Ögedei Khan to grant her and her son Qubilai appanages (fiefs) in northern China. She kept a low profile when Ögedei's widow arranged to have their son Güyük become *kaghan*. But when Güyük Khan died, Sorqaqtani Beki conspired with Batu, leader of the Golden Horde, to wrest power from Güyük's widow by convening a *quriltai*, which chose her son Möngke as the third successor to Chinggis.



Yuan Shizu, also known as Qubilai Khan. Paint and ink on silk.

Sorqaqtani Beki, Möngke, and Qubilai were closely involved in the administration of former Jin lands in northern China. During Chinggis' time, when north China was a battleground, the Mongols requisitioned grain, other goods, and labor from the Chinese farming population in an ad hoc and highly confiscatory manner. But at the same time, Chinggis and his generals in north China understood the value of turncoats. In north China, a number of notable Liao, Song, and even some Jin commanders, officials, and scholars chose to serve the Mongol confederacy, and were welcomed for their skills and knowledge. Generals and soldiers who had defected from the Song played an essential role in the Mongol conquest and administration of Jin territory.¹⁶

Ögedei Khan made some moves toward adopting a more bureaucratic style of administration in northern China. When some of the Mongol generals wanted to convert northern Chinese farmland into pastures for their herds, Ögedei heeded the words of his Khitan adviser Yelü Chucai, who argued that it would be far more profitable to tax the farmers than to replace them with sheep, goats, and cattle. Ögedei did set up a tax system, and even allowed Yelü Chucai to hold civil service examinations, though few of the men who passed were assigned to important posts. Ögedei also assigned appanages—large chunks of land, with farmers and tax revenue—to influential members of the Mongol ruling class, including Sorqaqtani Beki and Qubilai.

Sorqaqtani Beki and Qubilai both learned how to be effective administrators. Using advisors who had worked for the Jin, Sorqaqtani Beki encouraged agriculture in order to build a strong and reliable population of taxpaying farmers. Although a Christian, she tolerated and supported Daoism, Buddhism, and Islam. Qubilai was, at first, an absentee landlord to his ten thousand farming households in modern Hebei province, his only concern being that he receive an ample income from his appanage. His officials and tax merchants, who had their own interests in mind as well, responded by imposing harsh taxes and heavy forced labor on the people. When he became aware of the situation, Qubilai followed his mother's example: he began employing officials within a bureaucratic framework that assessed regular taxes on his farming households.¹⁷

Qubilai's foothold in northern China and his willingness to adopt what was useful in the administrative practices of the Jin was directly related to his later dominance over all of the former Jin and Song territories and his founding of the Yuan dynasty. In 1251, Möngke Khan put Qubilai in charge of all the area north of the Huai River. He also appointed his brother Hülegü administrator of Iran. This represented a major change in the disposition of the lands of the Mongol Empire. Northern China and Iran had been shared lands in which all Mongol nobles had rights to appanages. Möngke was trying to increase the power of the Toluid line by appropriating these shared lands and putting his brothers in charge of them. In doing so, he had opened the way for the dissolution of the Mongol world empire and for Qubilai's rise to power as founder of the Yuan dynasty.¹⁸

Enabling his younger brother to become an emperor was not at all what Möngke had in mind.¹⁹ His intention was to solidify his own control over northern China and to conquer the south. Qubilai played a key role in campaigns in the southwest and south, capturing the independent kingdom of Dali (modern Yunnan province) in 1253–1254. In 1258 Möngke attacked the Song in Sichuan, Qubilai and another general attacked along the Yangzi, and a fourth Mongol army attacked from Dali. This multipronged attack strained Song resources, but in August 1259, Möngke died, either of illness or from wounds sustained in battle. With the Mongol leaders distracted by a bitter internal struggle for the position of *kaghan*, the Southern Song was spared, for the time being.

The struggle for succession revealed a major split in the Mongol Empire. On one side were the Mongols of the steppe, represented by Qubilai's younger brother Ariq Böke. On the other was Qubilai, who was already becoming identified economically, militarily, and (particularly in the eyes of his Mongol critics) culturally with China. Warned by his wife Chabi that Ariq Böke was about to declare himself successor to Möngke, Qubilai hastened to his stronghold at Kaiping in Inner Mongolia (17 miles [27.4 km] north of modern Beijing) and called a sparsely-attended *quriltai* which anointed him as *kaghan*. Ariq Böke held his own *quriltai* just weeks later in Mongolia.

In the civil war that followed, Ariq Böke had Mongolia and the support of most of the Mongols. But Qubilai had the human and material resources of the former Jin territory. In 1264 Ariq Böke surrendered to his brother. He died mysteriously in prison two years later. With the defeat of Ariq Böke, Qubilai had no serious challengers for the position of *kaghan*, but he was never as powerful as Möngke had been. Only the Il-khans, the Mongol rulers of Persia, accepted his authority—and they were far enough away to make their acceptance of Qubilai's leadership little more than a formality. The Golden Horde in Russia simply did not recognize Qubilai's leadership. Closer to home, in Central Asia, Ögedei's grandson Qaidu took up where Ariq Böke had left off. The Chaghatay and Ögedeid khanates in Central Asia fought Qubilai and his regime from 1268 until 1303.



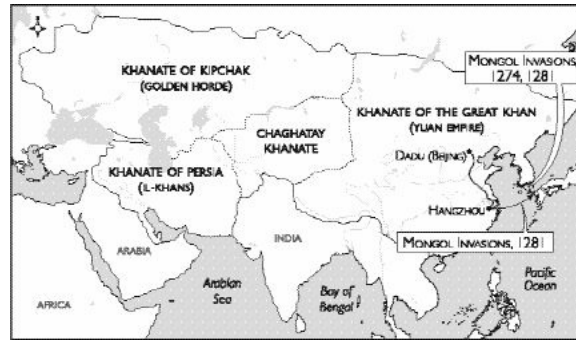
Empress Chabi, wife of Qubilai Khan.

The civil wars with Ariq Böke and with the Chaghadaid and Ögedeid forces underlined the extent to which Qubilai relied on the resources of China. Scholars, farmers, artisans and merchants, generals, and soldiers formerly of the Liao, Jin, and Song were crucial elements of Qubilai's power base. Their support could not be taken for granted. Li Tan, the powerful Shandong warlord who had pledged his loyalty to Qubilai, had rebelled during the war against Ariq Böke. Qubilai easily defeated Li Tan. But as long as the Southern Song existed, it would compete with Qubilai for the loyalty of his Chinese subjects and pose a threat to his southern border—a threat that he could ill afford with Qaidu threatening from the north. Unconquered, Southern Song was a threat. Conquered, its tremendous agricultural wealth and lucrative maritime trade would add to Qubilai's military power and to the income of the imperial house.

The new campaign against the Southern Song began in 1267. Facing the mountainous terrain of Sichuan and the great rivers of the south, Qubilai could not rely on Mongol cavalry forces. Instead, he invaded the Southern Song from the west, using the Yangzi River as a highway down which ships would carry his soldiers, horses, and siege machinery, to be landed when and where necessary to defeat the Southern Song forces and capture their cities. It was not an easy campaign. Song forces at the key cities of Xiangyang and Fancheng, twin cities on either side of the Han River—the best route of access to the Yangzi—held out for five years, from 1268 to 1273. Only then could Qubilai's forces—including thousands of ships—proceed down the Yangzi to defeat the Song main forces and capture the capital city of Hangzhou in February 1276.²⁰

The victory was complete: but it would not have been possible without the use of Persian and Uighur engineers whose catapults and mangonels battered the Song's heavily defended cities into submission. Nor could Qubilai have defeated the Song navy and sailed triumphantly down the Yangzi without Song soldiers and sailors, including many Southern Song officers who preferred to join the Mongols on their march to victory rather than die for the Song emperor.

Qubilai tried to expand his empire in other directions both during and after his long campaign against the Song. In 1268, 1271, and 1272, Qubilai sent emissaries to secure the subordination of Japan, whose merchants and pirates were active both along the coast of Korea (whose kings recognized Mongol authority) and southern China. When the Japanese Kamakura shogunate turned the Mongol envoys away discourteously, Qubilai responded with an invasion force of over twenty-one thousand soldiers and seven thousand sailors, who set sail from Korea in 1274. Landing at Hakata Bay on the island of Kyūshū, the invaders performed well on land, but were wiped out when a storm wrecked most of their ships. A second invasion of Japan, in 1281, similarly failed when a typhoon, hailed as the *kamikaze* or "divine wind," destroyed half the Mongol fleet as it lay off the coast of Kyūshū. The invasions of Japan revealed the limits of Qubilai's power. So too did expensive and ultimately fruitless attacks on Burma (1273, 1277, and 1278), Champa (1281), Annam (1286–87), and Java (1292).



[The Mongolian Empire, c. 1280.](#)

In Tibet, Qubilai was more successful. Tibet, much closer to the Mongol steppes, was easier to invade. And unlike Japan, Champa, Burma, and Annam, Tibet did not have a single ruler: ever since the fall of the Tibetan Empire in 842, it had been divided into numerous regions dominated by Buddhist monasteries and local clans. Tibet lay on Qubilai's western frontier, and to the south of modern Xinjiang, which was controlled by Qubilai's Central Asian enemies, the Ögedeids. If Qubilai did not gain control of Tibet, there was a good chance that his cousin Qaidu would.

Qubilai did not have to carry out a full-scale invasion to incorporate Tibet into the Yuan Empire. Exploratory Mongol invasions of Tibet in the 1240s had brought the young Pakpa lama (1235–1280), hereditary leader of the Sakya sect of Tibetan Buddhism, to Qubilai's court as a hostage. Much impressed with the brilliant young lama, Qubilai made him the political leader of Tibet. In 1268, six thousand Yuan troops accompanied Pakpa back to Tibet to carry out a census and to solidify his power. With Mongol backing the Pakpa lama and a civil administrator at Sakya established a regency over the thirteen other regions of central Tibet. Each of these regions was ruled by a powerful monastery, whose leadership was generally monopolized by a powerful local clan.²¹ As long as the Sakya (with Mongol backing) could command the respect and obedience of regional monastic leadership, a stable Tibet would flank Qubilai's western border.

Yuan Government

In 1272 the Mongol Qubilai Khan took on the role of a Chinese emperor. He had been moving toward this role for years. In 1267, he had begun the construction of Dadu, a new capital city on the same site as the old Khitan Liao and Jurchen Jin capitals—and the future site of Beijing, the capital of the Ming and Qing dynasties and of the People's Republic of China. Designed by a Chinese chief architect, Dadu was a roughly square, walled city, oriented to the north, containing walled imperial palaces, lakes, wide north-south and east-west streets. It had a Confucian temple, a temple to Qubilai's ancestors, altars of the soil and grain, Buddhist and Daoist temples and monasteries. The city plan, which clearly served as a model for Ming-Qing Beijing, was based on the classical description of the ideal capital city in the *Rites of Zhou*:

The builder constructs the City of the State. He makes a square nine *li* (one *li* = about half a kilometer) on each side; each side has three gates. Within the capital are nine north-south and nine east-west streets. ...

On the east is the Ancestral temple, on the West are the Altars of the Soil and Grain.²²

Like the design of the capital city, the name of Qubilai's dynasty, too, was drawn from ancient Chinese tradition. The word "Yuan" is associated with the first trigram of the Zhou dynasty divination text, the *Book of Changes*: it means "origins of the universe." But Qubilai was not simply a Chinese emperor. To the Mongols who recognized his rulership, he was *kaghan*, successor to Möngke, Ögedei, and Chinggis. For the Tibetans, the Pakpa lama described Qubilai as a Cakravartin king—a Buddhist universal emperor whose legitimacy is derived, not from the Mandate of Heaven, but from his role as protector and promoter of the Buddhist dharma.²³ But despite these other imperial faces, the former Jin and Song lands were the economic and political center of the Yuan Empire, and most of their subjects were farmers who spoke Chinese dialects and whose marriage and death rituals were based on the

Zhou dynasty classics.

Ruling an agricultural society with a complex economy presented the Mongol Yuan dynasty with some interesting challenges. Only bureaucratic administration could keep the agricultural economy healthy and generating a constant stream of tax revenue. But, as the Li Tan rebellion had shown, it was dangerous to repose too much power in the hands of Chinese officials. Qubilai and later Yuan emperors tried to maintain political control, social stability, and tax revenue by creating a balance of ethnic power in government and by combining Mongol and Chinese techniques of administration.

One of the Mongol innovations was to divide Yuan subjects into four legally defined hereditary categories. These categories, from the most to the least trustworthy (in their view), were: 1. Mongols; 2. *semu* or “diverse peoples” (Central and West Asians, among whom Tibetans, Uighurs, and Persians were prominent); 3. “Han people” (the people of the northern Chinese territories of the former Jin dynasty, including Chinese, Khitan, Jurchen, and Koreans); and 4. “Southern people” (the Chinese people of the former Southern Song territories).

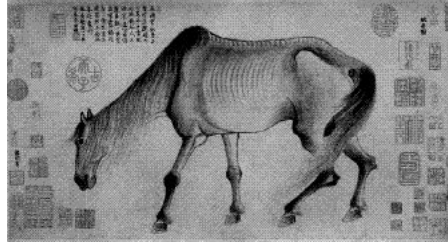
This “four-category” system was designed to maintain Mongol superiority. Mongols and “diverse peoples” (more trustworthy because they were far from home and dependant on the regime) enjoyed legal privileges, including lower tax rates. They had preferred access to government posts, most of which were assigned through the *yin* (recommendation) system during the Yuan. When civil service examinations were reinstated in some of the later Yuan reigns, a quota system guaranteed that Mongols and the *semu* people would get a disproportionate share of the degrees awarded. As a result, although they were each about 1.4 percent of the total population in 1290, Mongols and *semu* together held about thirty percent of all official positions and dominated the top government posts.²⁴

The structure of the Yuan state bore a superficial resemblance to that of previous dynastic regimes: an emperor and his court administered China Proper through subordinate provincial and country governments. But the Yuan introduced new elements into this structure. Some localities were administered as appanages (fiefs) assigned to Mongol aristocrats. Local and provincial governments were staffed by a polyglot hodgepodge of Chinese, Mongols, and West Asians. Decision-making followed a cumbersome conciliar model which had more in common with the collective decision-making traditions of the steppe than with Chinese bureaucratic practice.²⁵ In an effort to maintain control over the government and to collect taxes efficiently, the Yuan appointed *darughachi* (supervisors) to oversee the work of provincial and local governments. The *darughachi*’s approval was needed for any major decision. Most of the *darughachi* were Mongols and West Asian Muslims.²⁶

West Asian Muslims often held important positions in central and provincial government. Ahmad, a Muslim from Tashkent, served as Qubilai’s finance minister from 1262 to 1282. Ahmad’s job was to maximize government revenue. He regularized the land tax, enrolled untaxed households into updated tax registers, raised taxes on merchants, and enforced government monopolies on a variety of profitable goods: tea, liquor, vinegar, gold, silver, salt, iron, and copper tools. Ahmad’s policies greatly enriched the government. They also enriched Ahmad, his family, and his associates, whom he appointed to key offices. Influential officials in the category of “Han people” deeply resented Ahmad’s power and his policies. Some of them assassinated him in 1282.²⁷ Nonetheless, Muslims continued to occupy important official posts throughout the Yuan.

Tibetan Buddhist monks also played prominent and controversial roles. A Tibetan lama named Sangha became one of the most powerful men in Qubilai’s court in 1285. Like Ahmad’s, Sangha’s job was to generate revenue. He raised taxes on commerce, increased the price of state monopoly goods like salt, tea, and liquor, and introduced a paper currency reform, which required Chinese to exchange old banknotes for new at a rate of five to one. A Tibetan (or possibly Tangut) lama associated with Sangha further angered the wealthy people of Jiangnan when he confiscated land and buildings, including former Southern Song palaces and Daoist temples, to construct and support Buddhist temples, and when he raided the graves of the Song emperors for gold, silver, and building materials. In 1291 Qubilai, acting on the recommendation of outraged Han officials, ordered Sangha’s execution.²⁸

The Yuan surely had its share of corruption and cruelty. Yuan emperors famously had recalcitrant officials flogged, sometimes severely, in court. While the Mongols did not invent this practice (it goes back at least to the Han, and was particularly common in the Liao and Jin), the flogging of officials did stand in contrast with the more civil atmosphere of the Song court.²⁹ But while the Yuan emperors could be autocrats at court, they presided over a decentralized and not very efficient bureaucracy. The provinces of China Proper and the various appanages assigned to Mongol nobles had a high degree of independence. The important thing was that they continue to forward tax revenue and other goods and services to the imperial government. In a sense, this pattern—autocracy at court combined with looser control outside the capital—was a continuation of trends already in place in the Southern Song.



“Emaciated Horse,” by Gong Kai. This painting represents the poverty-stricken conditions that the painter, a “leftover subject” of the Song, imposed on himself when he refused to serve the Yuan as a government official. Ink on paper hand-scroll. Yuan dynasty.

The Mongols’ lack of interest in completely following the Jin and Song models of government extended to the matter of law. When Qubilai declared the founding of the Great Yuan, he aimed to use Mongolian customary law and the recorded decisions of Chinggis as sources of law. When principles of justice developed to rule a pastoral people proved unworkable in a settled agrarian society, the Yuan drafted various laws. But much to the frustration of Han officials, the dynasty never promulgated a complete code of law as the Tang, the Song, and even the Jurchen Jin had done. Yuan laws, collected in various compilations, were not particularly cruel. Yuan law included fewer capital crimes than had the laws of Song, and provided for multiple levels of appeal.³⁰ Chinese officials, indeed, complained that the laws were too lenient and that amnesties (issued under the influence of Tibetan Buddhist lamas) were too frequent.³¹ Chinese complaints about the incompleteness and laxity of Yuan law are yet another indication of how decentralized and inefficient Yuan government actually was.

Chinese Society and Economy Under the Mongols

Inefficient as they were, the Mongol rulers did have a vision of what Chinese society should look like. Their goal was to ensure that generation after generation of Chinese subjects would produce the food, crafts articles, tea, metals, and other goods that the Mongols desired. Qubilai tried to achieve this goal by classifying the entire population not only by ethnicity, but also according to hereditary occupational groups: farmers, soldiers, gold panners, fishermen, artisans of various kinds, and so on, more than eighty categories in all. The Mongol nobility had classified their commoners in Mongolia in a similar way, and were applying this model to the Chinese. It did not work: resentment and passive resistance made the rules unenforceable.³²

Although the Yuan emperors could not force Chinese society into a straitjacket of hereditary occupational groups, the interaction of Mongols, West Asians, Tibetans, and Chinese, along with trends already under way in the Liao-Jin-Song era did lead to new developments in Chinese society during the Yuan. Trade, daily life, and the lives of the literati elite all changed, sometimes because of Mongol policies, sometimes in spite of them, and sometimes without any particular reference to Mongol rule at all.

Trade is one area in which Yuan policies strengthened trends already present in the Song period. Qubilai’s conquest of the Southern Song made possible a strong growth in trade between north and south China—trade that had been developing more slowly under the constraints of the Southern Song’s troubled relations with the Jin and the early Yuan regimes. The Yuan government renovated the Tang canal system and extended it to Dadu to bring tax grain from Jiangnan to the capital. Not only grain, but other goods as well came up this “Grand Canal” from the Yangzi Valley to the north. Because the Grand Canal could not always deliver enough grain to the north, the Yuan government also contracted with maritime merchants and/or pirates (there was little distinction between the two) to develop the first regular, extensive system of coastal shipping from the mouth of the Yangzi to ports near modern Tianjin in the north.

The growth of domestic trade was accompanied by a resurgence of the Silk Road trade with Central and Western Asia. Mongol domination of Persia, Central Asia, and Russia allowed for the re-opening of a vigorous trade along the old overland Silk Road routes and the opening of new overland trade routes connecting China with the Middle East and Europe. Maritime trade with the kingdoms of Southeast and South Asia, already common in the Southern Song, continued under the Yuan. Exports of Chinese tea and porcelain were exchanged for gems, pearls, medicines,

aromatics, fabric, and other luxury goods. The Yuan had good reason to encourage trade: as with the Southern Song taxes collected on imports at the major ports of south China constituted a major part of the Yuan government's revenues. The government also profited by issuing the first standardized paper currency in Chinese history and requiring foreign merchants to exchange their gold and silver for paper currency as a condition of doing business.

Trade brought more than commodities. Crops and technology also traveled from south to north and from Central and West Asia to China. Cotton farming and weaving, first developed in south China, spread to the north, partly because the Yuan government collected some of its taxes in cotton cloth. Muslim mathematicians, astronomers, and medical practitioners brought Persian, Arab, and Greek learning in their fields (including Arabic numbers) to the Yuan Empire. Turkic foodways influenced Mongol and Chinese cooking. Watermelons, first grown in the northwest, were welcomed into Chinese cuisine, as were Muslim dishes, including the now ubiquitous wheat noodles and the *jiaozi* (small meat-filled dumplings).³³

People, too, traveled across the trade routes from Europe to the Mongol Empire. A variety of European merchants came across Central Asia to the Yuan Empire, among them the Venetian Marco Polo, whose travelogue, although considerably embroidered, remains a fascinating (though not always reliable) source of information about life in the Yuan period.³⁴ Catholic priests including John of Plano Carpini (1180–1252), William of Rubruck (c. 1220–c. 1293), and John of Montecorvino (1246–1328) also visited the Mongol realms, hoping to convert the *kaghans* and their courts. The priests made little progress in that regard, but they, too, left fascinating accounts of their journeys.³⁵

The fact that Catholic missionaries traveled to and within the Yuan Empire, proselytizing and even building churches, points to the indulgent religious policies of the Mongol rulers. Chinggis and his successors were tolerant of and even patronized any religion whose leaders promised to intervene with their gods to gain divine support for the continued prosperity of the state and the health and well-being of its leaders. This made it possible for a variety of religions to flourish under Mongol rule: Daoism, Chinese and Tibetan Buddhism, Islam, Manicheism, and Judaism were all represented in the Mongol Empire of Chinggis and in Qubilai's Yuan. Nestorian Christians, too, could be found among the Uighur and Mongol elites of Dadu and other cities. Religious leaders turned this openness to their own advantage. The elderly leader of the Chinese Quanzhen Daoist sect, who traveled across Central Asia to meet with Chinggis, obtained tax exemptions for himself and his followers in northern China. The Pakpa lama used his relationship with Qubilai to gain patronage for his Sakya sect of Tibetan Buddhism and to make the Sakya the rulers of Tibet.

Merchants and landowners also profited from Yuan rule. A resurgence of maritime trade and the government's weakness and even lack of interest in limiting private wealth contributed to the rise of tremendously wealthy landowners and to a boom in the construction of temples, monasteries, mansions, and gardens in already wealthy Jiangnan.³⁶ The book business flourished. Publishing houses catered to a large reading public with new editions of the Confucian classics, medical works, encyclopedias, agricultural handbooks, and popular works such as illustrated historical narratives and illustrated popular fiction.³⁷

But the Mongol rulers were not precocious multiculturalist liberals or Adam Smithian champions of free trade. Mongol leaders firmly suppressed any religious activities and organizations that threatened the state. They encouraged, sponsored, and monopolized trade because it generated income for the imperial government and the imperial household (the Yuan made very little distinction between these two). A Yuan government monopoly on maritime trade meant immense profits for merchants who had contracts with the government, while others had their cargoes seized and were driven out of business.³⁸

One of the ways in which Mongol leaders managed, and profited, from trade was through their partnerships with the *ortoq*—merchant companies run by Western Asian Muslims and Uighurs. The *ortoq* were active both along the overland caravan routes and in the maritime trade. In the days of Chinggis and Ögedei, the Mongol leaders had invested large amounts of silver (collected as taxes from the populace of northern China) with the *ortoq*. Both the *ortoq* merchants and the Mongol ruling house reaped tremendous profits from this partnership.

For common folk in northern China, the state-*ortoq* partnership meant something else entirely. The *ortoq* merchants engaged in extortion, tax farming, and high-interest loans (one hundred percent interest compounded annually was not unheard of).³⁹ Widespread resentment of the *ortoq*, and perhaps a desire to tax them more effectively, led Qubilai's government to impose some restrictions on the Muslim merchants. But the *ortoq*, their privilege, their power, and their partnership with the ruling house remained important features of the Yuan economy all the way through 1368.⁴⁰

Like merchants, literati sometimes benefited from Mongol rule. The Mongol *kaghans* (Yuan emperors to their Chinese subjects) won the loyalty of many literati by their patronage of painting and literature, by their performance

(if sometimes perfunctory) of Chinese imperial ritual, and by the simple fact of having unified the long-divided northern and southern regions of China Proper. Chinese did not generally view Mongols as “alien” rulers. Northern and even southern Chinese elite families were usually willing to work with and for Mongol patrons.⁴¹ And although it was not with intent, Mongol rule proved to be instrumental in advancing the moral-political agenda of those Chinese scholars who followed Zhu Xi’s “Learning of the Way.”

The Southern Song scholars associated with the Learning of the Way (or Neo-Confucianism) had been determined to enforce a vision of patrilineal society that they derived from their reading and interpretation of the corpus of classical texts associated with Confucius. In reality, neither Song law nor real life conformed to their ideals: Song daughters could inherit property, Song wives retained control of land that they had brought into their marriages as dowry, and Song widows retained ownership of their dowry property and even took it with them when they remarried.⁴²

During the Yuan, Mongol customs combined with Neo-Confucian ideals to push Chinese society closer to the patrilineal ideals associated with Zhu Xi and his followers. The Mongols, who had organized Chinese households into hereditary occupational categories, had a strong interest in seeing those households remain intact, with their property, generation after generation so that the supply of soldiers, artisans, farmers, and other occupations would remain stable. Furthermore, the Mongol inheritance practice of the levirate, under which a younger male relative of a deceased man inherited that man’s wives and property (excluding the younger man’s own mother), functioned to keep both widows and property within the patriline.

With the Yuan tax system structured around the continued existence of the patriline, with Yuan law overturning the principle that unmarried daughters had a right to a share of their father’s estate (or to the whole estate, if there were no male heirs), and with more Chinese families practicing the levirate, women’s property rights and the independence of widows were severely restricted as compared to the Song. When widow remarriage was no longer a viable option, female chastity or ritual suicide, both validated by Zhu Xi Neo-Confucianism, became the respectable alternatives.

These changes in the roles of women were accompanied by the spread of foot-binding from the elite to a much broader cross-section of society. The developments were not sudden or universal: a scholar (and descendant of Confucius) writing in the late Yuan still complained bitterly about “despicable” customs in which “wives and daughters manage property by themselves and even contend for property directly with their husbands . . .”⁴³ Still, the long-term trends established in the Yuan clearly fit in with, and were actively justified by, the moral ideals of the Neo-Confucian learners of “the Way.”

The rise of Zhu Xi Neo-Confucianism, so closely associated with this change in the status of women, also had long-term political implications. The Mongol conquest of the south made it possible for Zhu Xi’s teachings, already established as state orthodoxy under the Southern Song, to spread more widely throughout northern China and to the Yuan court. The result was a scholarly tradition based on Zhu Xi’s interpretation of the classical texts, but with an emphasis on practical implementation of morally-informed policy rather than on abstract doctrinal debate.⁴⁴

Mongol rulers contributed to this emphasis on the practical application of Neo-Confucian philosophy. They were far more interested in how to solve real problems than in understanding human nature and the origins of the universe. Thus Möngke, in response to an argument that Confucian scholars deserved exemption from corvée labor, asked: “How do the Confucians compare with the shamans and practitioners of medicine?”⁴⁵

Although some scholars (particularly those who felt bound by ties of loyalty to the Song) refused to serve the Mongols, others did. Yelü Chucai advised Ögedei on the wisdom of protecting and taxing the farming population of northern China. Xu Heng, a scholar from the former Jin Empire, advised Qubilai Khan and instructed a variety of young Chinese, Mongol, Khitan, and Muslim students in the intricacies of the Chinese classics and histories. Xu and other scholars introduced Zhu Xi’s teachings to the Mongol court. In 1313, when the Yuan emperor Ayurbarwada agreed to reinstate the civil service examinations, they were based on Zhu Xi’s teachings. Zhu Xi’s annotated versions of the Four Books (the *Analects*, *Mencius*, the *Great Learning*, and the *Mean*) and the Five Classics (the *Book of History*, the *Book of Changes*, the *Rites of Zhou*, the *Springs and Autumns Annals*, and the *Book of Poetry*) became the standard curriculum. Later dynasties followed the Yuan in officially recognizing the Zhu Xi “School of Principle” version of Neo-Confucianism as orthodoxy.

Literati Culture in Yuan China

Chinese men like Xu Heng, who served at the upper levels of Yuan government, were rare exceptions. The Yuan's "four-class system" (Mongols, *semu*, Han people, and Southern people) ensured that Han and "Southern" scholars, especially those from Jiangnan, had little opportunity for government service, and that those who did enter the bureaucracy would remain in low-ranking positions. Elite families reacted in a number of ways. Some chose to be involved in government service in some other way. One option (open to a very few) was to serve, like Xu Heng, as an advisor to an emperor or high-ranking official. Another option was to become a clerk. Service as a government clerk, looked down upon in the Song, became more desirable to elite men because the Mongols put greater value on clerical skill than had the Song rulers: unlike the Song, the Yuan recruited many of its officials from the ranks of the clerks.⁴⁶ In any event, being noticed and having a patron was essential. Many Chinese adopted Mongol names, clothing, and customs in order to improve their chances of employment and promotion.

But with the chances of becoming an official of any rank, high or low, substantially reduced, many men from scholarly families pursued other careers and identities. The Mongols had a great respect for medical doctors. In the Yuan, scholarly men who would have looked down their noses at such a common thing as treating illnesses chose to become doctors.⁴⁷ Many more, their incomes guaranteed by landholding and investments, chose to live the life of a cultured gentleman. Underemployed literati played leading roles in new developments in the thriving world of literature and art.

The blurring of boundaries was a major characteristic in the lives of the literati and the development of art, music, and literature in the Yuan. Social, political, and economic change threw people together into situations in which the distinctions between literati and merchants, amateurs and professionals, Chinese and foreign were challenged in ways that they had not been in the more insular Song. Men from literati families now rubbed elbows—and exchanged ideas—with educated men of merchant and landowner families and participated more openly in the world of popular literature and entertainment.⁴⁸

The interaction of Chinese, Mongol, Central Asian (particularly Muslim), and Tibetan culture is most evident in decorative art and music. Yuan court music used instruments, music, and musicians drawn from the courts of the Liao, the Jin, and the Southern Song. It also incorporated Muslim music performed by Central Asian and Persian musicians on their own instruments.⁴⁹ In popular music, Central Asian bowed lutes like the two-stringed *erhu*, already present in the Song period, were thoroughly assimilated.⁵⁰ Nepalese and Tibetan monks brought Tibetan styles of Buddhist art, including complex mandalas, both painted and woven in silk, which remained popular under later dynasties.⁵¹

Interaction between Mongols and Chinese and between different social classes led to the development of new styles of expression in literature as well as art. Educated men and women did still write large amounts of poetry in the now old regulated verse (*lushi*) and ballad (*yuefu*) forms. But they also wrote *sanqu*, literally, "separate songs." *Sanqu* developed out of the popular songs of northern China in the Jin and early Yuan periods. As with Song lyrics (*ci*), the poet had to fit his or her words into the structure of an existing tune. The *sanqu* were rooted in popular culture, used informal language in the northern Chinese dialect, and addressed popular topics: love (particularly common), social events, condemnation of social injustice, and fulsome praise for the Yuan dynasty were all common themes.

A number of tunes used for *sanqu* were also used in Yuan plays. *Zaju* (miscellaneous plays) were very popular in the early Yuan. These relatively short four-act plays incorporated dance and arias—all sung by the main character. Playwrights, some of whom were literati, addressed a number of themes: history, the successes and failures of kings and emperors, episodes in the lives of common folk, love stories, tales of Daoist immortals, and stories of crime and punishment. In the mid- to late Yuan, the center of *zaju* writing and performance shifted from the northern cities to Hangzhou in the south. Playwrights and actors began to incorporate elements from *zaju* into their own "southern play" (*nanxi*) tradition. The result was longer plays, more complex plots, and singing parts for a variety of characters.

Poetry and plays allowed Yuan literati to reflect on themes that were deeply informed by their Confucian philosophy: social injustice, weak and corrupt government, and a perceived decline in public morality (themes which, as we have seen already, were not unique to Yuan literature). Many plays and poems tackled issues of injustice. In *Selling Rice at Chenzhou*, for example, the incorruptible Judge Bao cleverly traps and executes two corrupt young aristocrats who had overcharged for famine relief grain and beaten a poor man to death when he dared complain. This socially engaged literature existed alongside of poetry in which elite men portrayed themselves as Daoist free spirits whose carefree lifestyles and drunkenness (whether literal or metaphorical) represented escape from the cares of the real world.

The literati also expressed their ideals, the contours of their everyday lives, and their ambivalence toward the Yuan dynasty in their paintings. As they worked to express individual feeling and experience, the literati painters of the Yuan transformed the practice and meaning of art.⁵² The Northern Song scholar Su Shi had emphasized the distinction between professional and amateur painters—making clear his preference for the amateur. Tension between the professional and the amateur ideals continued throughout the Northern and Southern Song, but as long as the court maintained its Painting Academy, it was the professionals, with the power of the court behind them, who defined the mainstream of Chinese painting and calligraphy.

In the Yuan, this was no longer the case. The Yuan court did patronize art, particularly ceramics, textiles, murals, and court portraiture in the Song style,⁵³ but there was no official Painting Academy through which the court could impose artistic orthodoxy. For the first time, it was possible for the amateur literati painters to define the mainstream. The process began with a generation of artists from Jiangnan (the lower Yangzi Valley) who had come of age under the Southern Song.

Some of these “leftover subjects” refused to serve the new dynasty and composed intensely personal paintings in which they subtly expressed their loyalty to the Song and their resistance to the Yuan. In 1306 Zheng Sixiao (1241–1318) painted two simple clumps of orchid leaves and a flower in ink on paper, accompanied by an enigmatic poem and two short texts imprinted by seals. A sensitive viewer would know that the orchid referred to Qu Yuan, the poet of ancient Chu, whose disgust with corruption at court led him to withdraw from the world. When asked why there was no dirt around the roots of his orchids, Zheng explained that the earth had been taken by the barbarians.⁵⁴

Zheng was uncompromising in his rejection of Mongol rule. Not every “leftover subject” was determined to express undying loyalty to the Song. Most were willing to serve the new dynasty. One such turncoat (much reviled by some of his contemporaries) was Zhao Mengfu (1254–1322), a descendant of the founder of the Song dynasty. In 1286 Qubilai invited Zhao to serve as a court official. Zhao served in a number of posts including secretary of the Board of War, provincial governor (twice), and director of the Hanlin Academy, a kind of “think-tank” for the court.⁵⁵

Like his fellow “leftover subjects,” Zhao Mengfu deliberately rejected the styles of calligraphy and painting typical of the Southern Song. Instead, he looked to the work of the Tang, Eastern and Western Jin, and Han masters for inspiration—work that he and other southerners could now see for themselves because the Mongols had unified China. Zhao emphasized the amateur ideal: painting was not an accurate representation of an external subject: it was a way of communicating an idea and in this sense was closely related to calligraphy and poetry. Zhao and other leading Yuan literati painters used calligraphic brush techniques in painting and wrote poems and other inscriptions (in excellent calligraphy) on the finished work.⁵⁶ Other men, too, would often add poetry or inscriptions to paintings by their friends, or to older paintings in their collections. To do so was to enter into the conversation that the painter himself had begun when he first set brush to paper.

Zhao’s style is representative of the beginnings of amateur “scholar” painting, a genre independent of court patronage or the taint of professionalism—this despite the fact that he owed his career and influence to his status as an official!⁵⁷ Over the course of the Yuan, Zhao and subsequent generations of literati painters developed their own highly individualistic style. But there was far more to paintings than merely the expression of an individual’s emotions or moral convictions. Paintings, like poems, functioned as tokens in the maintenance of networks of personal relations. When Zhao Mengfu’s wife Guan Daosheng (1262–1319), also a respected artist, painted clumps of bamboo (a symbol of female marital fidelity) to present to another elite woman, the painting and the act of presentation had a social meaning that only Guan and her friend would fully understand. Guan’s painting, and many others, were created as personal gifts for significant individuals, not as commodities or for display to the masses in a museum.⁵⁸

The highly social and personal nature of scholar-amateur painting in the Yuan gave rise to loosely delineated (often geographically based) groups of artists and to the appearance of some very colorful and eccentric characters. Among the latter was the collector and painter Ni Zan (1301–1374). Ni was the heir of a wealthy Wuxi family. He was an avid art collector as well as a painter. He is said to have been pathologically clean, compulsively washing his hands and avoiding contact with anyone who he felt was unclean, vulgar, or simply not sophisticated enough to deserve his company.⁵⁹ Ni Zan’s work exemplifies the simplicity, the calligraphic brushwork, and the melding of painting, poetry, and calligraphy typical of Yuan literati painting. His signature works were landscapes like those in his *Six Gentlemen* (1345) or *The Rongxi Studio* (1372). In both paintings, we see groups of skinny trees with sparse foliage (the “six gentlemen” are just such trees), a “great stretching of the interval between foreground and distance,”⁶⁰ and a complete absence of any human figures. In full accordance with the literati ideal, much of Ni’s

work was dashed off at social gatherings or on visits to friends. As he explained:

I use bamboo painting only to write out the exceptional exhilaration in my breast, that is all. Why should I worry whether it shows likeness or not, whether the leaves are too dense or too sparse, or whether the branches are slanted or upright?⁶¹



Autumn Wind Bamboo, by Ni Zan. Early Ming dynasty.

The Yuan Dynasty's 14th-Century Crisis

In the late 1340s, Ni Zan liquidated his huge estate (perhaps by giving land to relatives or friends, or by selling it). It was either that or face the exorbitant new taxes that the Yuan government was imposing on wealthy Jiangnan landowners. Ni spent the rest of his life in humble circumstances, first with his family in a small house, later wandering, sometimes living on a houseboat, or staying with friends or at Buddhist monasteries. Around 1362 he wrote:

When these troubled times have passed and I return,
It will not be to the world of affairs I knew—
My sons have reached their prime, have traveled;
Their minds have grown hardened and disobedient. ...
You, my lord, still possess your own land:
You can go home and cultivate it.
But what of me? From where shall I return,
And to what place?⁶²

Ni Zan was not the only one to fall on hard times in the mid-14th century. The whole empire had plunged deep into a crisis that stretched the state's capabilities and resources to the breaking point. The trouble was multifaceted: environmental catastrophe, epidemic disease, population decline, weak government, and massive rebellions combined to bring the Yuan dynasty to an end and drive the heirs of Chinggis and Qubilai out of China Proper and back to Mongolia.

The fundamental causes of the fall of the Yuan dynasty may have been environmental. China, like the rest of the Eurasian continent, experienced below-normal average temperatures during the 14th century. Harsh winters and shorter growing seasons meant fewer crops and harder times. Natural disasters, too, took a toll. Major floods and droughts struck the Yellow River region: the Yellow River itself flooded disastrously in the summer of 1344, flooding 6,000 square miles (15,500 sq km) and seventeen walled cities.⁶³ This was only one of numerous floods, droughts, plagues of insects, and famines that came one after the other during the first half of the 14th century.

Below-normal temperatures, floods, and droughts reduced agricultural production and generated tens of thousands of refugees. Epidemics, some of which may have been generated in the aftermath of flooding, may have destroyed a substantial part of the population during the Yuan. It was during the 14th century that the bubonic plague (or "Black Death"), which may have originated in Yunnan, spread from Central Asia to the Black Sea, where Italian trading vessels and their crews picked up the virus and brought it to the Middle East and Europe.⁶⁴ The subsequent history of the bubonic plague in Europe is well documented: the disease killed around one-third of Europe's population between 1348 and 1375 and had deep and far-reaching effects on European society, economy, and culture.⁶⁵

In China, the situation is much less clear. No historical records point clearly and specifically to the bubonic plague. Strong anecdotal evidence does indicate that unknown epidemic diseases ravaged parts of Yuan China during the first half of the 14th century. Population records, though incomplete, also suggest an episode or episodes of severe epidemic disease. The population of Southern Song–Jurchen Jin China was around 108 million in 1210. In 1351, the Yuan had only 87 million. The Ming dynasty census of 1381 suggests a population of 67 million. Population had declined by around thirty-eight percent over a period of only 170 years. Was bubonic plague one of the causes, or even the major cause, of this demographic disaster? It is possible, but the historical record simply does not give us conclusive evidence one way or another.⁶⁶

Whatever their ultimate causes, natural disasters, short growing seasons, epidemics, and significant loss of population together posed tremendous challenges for the Yuan government. A declining population, decreasing agricultural production, and natural disasters meant more poverty, more refugees, more difficulty in collecting taxes, and more rebellions.

Every dynastic regime had to deal with occasional local rebellions, fueled by some combination of natural disaster, official corruption or malfeasance, poverty, and charismatic leadership. A minimally efficient government could mobilize enough resources to suppress such disturbances without too much difficulty. But, as we have seen in the cases of the Eastern Han, the Sui, and the Tang, large-scale rebellions (the Yellow Turbans and Five Pecks of Grain in the Eastern Han, the An Lushan and Huang Chao uprisings in the Tang) could seriously weaken or even destroy a dynastic state. In the last decades of the Yuan, the empire was rocked by simultaneous (but separate) rebellions occurring, so it seemed, nearly *everywhere*. The rebellions were the people's response to natural disaster, epidemics, famine, harsh taxation, and heavyhanded attempts at restoring peace.⁶⁷

Many of the late Yuan rebel leaders drew their inspiration from one (or more) of the popular religious traditions of the times: Buddhist, Daoist, and Manichean teachings mingled in the popular imagination with the tales of historical heroes and local deities. Some, for example, were devotees of a popular form of Buddhism known as the White Lotus sect. Followers of the White Lotus sect believed that the Maitreya Buddha—the Buddha of the Future—was about to descend to earth incarnate and that he would usher in a new age of universal peace. Wearing red turbans (the symbolism being drawn from Manicheanism), White Lotus devotees rose up to overthrow all worldly authority in order to prepare the way for the Maitreya Buddha's inevitable arrival.

The late Yuan state's response to natural disaster and rebellion was complicated by its inherent weakness and disorganization (discussed above) and by factional struggles at court. The last Yuan emperor, Toghōn Temür (Yuan Shundi, r. 1333–1368) took the throne at the age of twelve. Toghōn Temür never became a strong ruler. Mongol nativists, reformist Confucians, and conservative Confucians competed with each other for control of the court. Government reaction to the multiple crises of the mid-14th century shifted back and forth with the rise and fall of factional leaders.

The first years of Toghōn Temür's reign were dominated by the Mongol nativist Bayan, who became chancellor in 1335. By this time, the Yuan dynasty was firmly centered on China. Mongolia had become a peripheral part of the empire, administered since 1307 as just another province. The herders of the steppe were impoverished and relied on relief grain from China. Ordinary Mongol troops stationed in China Proper had fallen on hard times: many had sold the land whose income was supposed to support them. They were no longer an effective military force.⁶⁸ Bayan thought that too much Chinese influence was the root of the Yuan dynasty's problems. His solution was to demand a return to an idealized vision of the “good old days” of Qubilai's reign.

There were two parts to Bayan's Mongol nativism. On the one hand, he railed against “Chinese-style” luxury, cut palace expenses, advised the emperor to suspend projects that would interfere with agriculture, and initiated effective famine and disaster relief programs in the countryside.⁶⁹ On the other hand, he tried to roll back the influence of Confucian philosophy and Chinese culture and to re-emphasize the leading roles of Mongols and the *semu* people. New regulations prohibited Chinese from carrying weapons, riding horses, or learning the Mongol language. In 1335, he cancelled the civil service examinations—much to the annoyance, not only of Chinese literati, but also Mongol and Turkic men who had become serious students of Chinese classical learning and regarded the examination system as their ticket to a successful government career. Rumors made Bayan's policies seem even more extreme: it was said that he would ban iron tools to keep the Chinese from making weapons and that he was going to reduce the Chinese population by killing everyone with the family names of Zhang, Wang, Liu, Li, or Zhao.

Opposition from Chinese, Mongol, and Turkic officials at court brought Bayan's chancellorship to an end. His own nephew, Toghto, engineered his overthrow and banishment in 1340. Toghto subscribed to the sort of muscular

reform Confucianism exemplified by the Northern Song statesman Wang Anshi. During his first stint as chancellor, from 1340 to 1344, he stacked the government with pro-Confucian officials, re-instated the civil service examinations, and restarted the long-delayed task of writing the official histories of the Liao, Jin, and Song dynasties—a project that offered glory (and employment) to Chinese scholars. But in 1344, with rebellions rising from Yunnan and Guangxi in the southwest to Manchuria in the northeast and even in Shandong and Hebei, Toghto resigned under pressure from more conservative Confucians who criticized him for “going back to Shang Yang and Wang Anshi and *their* methods.”⁷⁰

Toghto’s opponents were Mongol and Chinese officials who took a more conservative “small government” approach. They believed that strong local government and moral suasion by good men would bring peace to all under Heaven. They were mistaken. The rebellions continued unabated. The Yellow River flooded in 1344 and began to change course, making the Grand Canal impassable. This left the maritime route as the only way to deliver grain from Jiangnan to Dadu, which put the capital at the mercy of pirates. The most notable of these, an illiterate named Fang Guozhen (d. 1374) controlled a fleet of ships with which he engaged in trade, smuggling, and piracy along the Zhejiang coast. Yuan officials, unable to defeat Fang, simply granted him titles in order to gain his cooperation—which he gave to the extent that he found it profitable.

The failure of the conservative Confucians gave Toghto another chance to try his state-centered policies. Back in power in 1349, Toghto was determined to address the capital city’s chronic grain deficit. In an attempt to increase grain production in the north, he organized large state-run farms to introduce varieties of rice that were suited to the northern climate.⁷¹ He also undertook a major hydraulic engineering operation: in 1351 he mobilized over one hundred seventy thousand laborers and troops to reroute the Yellow River so that it would flow to the south, instead of the north, of the Shandong Peninsula. Successful completion of this project would make it possible to repair the Grand Canal. With the Grand Canal open for grain shipments to Dadu, the pirate Fang Guozhen would no longer be able to use his control of the maritime route in order to blackmail the court.⁷²

The Yellow River diversion was a great success. But in carrying out the massive engineering project, Toghto had created new problems. The imposition of heavy corvée labor responsibilities worsened the poverty and suffering of the people of the Central Plains, whose lives had already been devastated by flood and famine. The government further aggravated its economic problems when it issued a large amount of unbacked paper currency in order to pay for the Yellow River diversion. The resulting inflation made the paper money worthless. With widespread counterfeiting depressing the value of coin, people reverted to barter in the 1350s.⁷³ Inflation and corvée labor burdens contributed to the already growing problem of popular rebellions. By 1353 the Yuan faced rebellions spread over hundreds of thousands of square miles of the Huai and Yangzi River Valleys. One of the most powerful of the rebel leaders, a former salt smuggler named Zhang Shicheng, had occupied the walled city of Gaoyou, from which he controlled the Grand Canal.

Toghto organized a sophisticated response to the rebellions. He deployed army units to problem areas and constantly shifted commanders in order to prevent them from turning into rebels themselves. By 1354, his strategy was showing signs of success. Fang Guozhen and his pirate fleet still controlled the seas off of Zhejiang, but elsewhere on land, most of the rebel forces had been pushed back. Toghto himself had Zhang Shicheng under siege in the city of Gaoyou. But on 7 January 1355, with victory clearly within his grasp, Toghto received the Emperor Toghön Temür’s order dismissing him from his posts. A rival faction at court had convinced the emperor that Toghto, who controlled the government and its military response to the rebellions, was himself becoming too powerful and posing a danger to the throne.⁷⁴ Driven into exile, Toghto died a year later.

With Toghto gone, operations against the rebels fell apart. After 1355 Yuan armies controlled only Mongolia and a shrinking area around Dadu. Order broke down across northern China where independent warlords, some of them supporting the Yuan—at least for the moment—controlled their own territories. In the south, Fang Guozhen gained a foothold on land along the Zhejiang coast. Zhang Shicheng expanded his territory south from Gaoyou to Suzhou and Hangzhou, which gave him control over valuable agricultural land. Zhang, Fang, and dozens of other rebel leaders in the Huai and Yangzi Valley areas fought the Yuan and each other for power. One of those rebel leaders, Zhu Yuanzhang (1328–1398), emerged triumphant in 1368, founded a new dynasty (the Ming), and drove the remaining Mongol forces back to Mongolia.

Notes

1. Quoted in Paul Ratchnevsky, *Genghis Khan: His Life and Legacy* (Oxford: Blackwell Publishing, 1991), 12.
2. Igor de Rachewiltz, *The Secret History of the Mongols: A Mongolian Epic Chronicle of the Thirteenth Century* (Leiden: Brill, 2006), vol. 1, 18–9.
3. Ibid., 22.
4. Ratchnevsky, *Genghis Khan*, 49–50.
5. Ibid., 66.
6. de Rachewiltz, *The Secret History of the Mongols*, vol. 1, 460. The earlier interpretation of “Chinggis” as “Oceanic” or “Universal” is erroneous.
7. Thomas Allsen, “The Rise of the Mongolian Empire and Mongolian Rule in North China,” in Herbert Franke and Denis Twitchett, eds., *The Cambridge History of China, Vol. 6: Alien Regimes and Border States, 907–1368* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994), 342–3, 348.
8. Timothy May, *The Mongol Art of War: Chinggis Khan and the Mongol Military System* (Yardley: Westholme, 2007), 31. Subsequent discussion of the Mongol military system draws on May and on Ratchnevsky.
9. Joseph Fletcher, “The Mongols: Ecological and Social Perspectives,” *Harvard Journal of Asiatic Studies* 46.1 (June 1986): 33; Ratchnevsky, *Genghis Khan*, 103.
0. The following discussion of the campaign against Khwarazm draws on Ratchnevsky, *Genghis Khan*, 119–34; May, *The Mongol Art of War*, 1–4, 15–17; Allsen, “The Rise of the Mongolian Empire,” 354–7.
1. Ratchnevsky, *Genghis Khan*, 115; Thomas T. Allsen, “Mongolian Princes and Their Merchant Partners, 1200–1260,” *Asia Major*, Third Series, 2.2 (1989): 123.
2. The cause of Chinggis’ death is unknown: malaria is one possibility; injury sustained in a fall from a wild horse in winter 1226 is another. Ratchnevsky, *Genghis Khan*, 141–2.
3. Ratchnevsky, *Genghis Khan*, 188–9.
4. Thomas T. Allsen, “Sharing Out the Empire: Apportioned Lands Under the Mongols,” in Anatoly M. Khazanov and André Wink, eds., *Nomads in the Sedentary World* (Richmond, Surrey: Curzon, 2001), 173.
5. Morris Rossabi, *Khubilai Khan: His Life and Times* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1988), 11–4.
6. Igor de Rachewiltz, “Personnel and Personalities in North China in the Early Mongol Period,” *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 9.1/2 (Nov. 1966): 118–9.
7. Rossabi, *Khubilai Khan*, 15.
8. Allsen, “Apportioned Lands,” 175.
9. In fact, Möngke acted to reduce his brother’s power in north China in 1257 when Qubilai appeared to be building an independent power base there. Allsen, “The Rise of the Mongolian Empire,” 408–9.
0. Peter Lorge, “Water Forces and Naval Operations,” in David A. Graff and Robin Higham, eds., *A Military History of China* (Boulder: Westview Press, 2002), 89.
1. Turrell V. Wylie, “The First Mongol Conquest of Tibet Reinterpreted,” *Harvard Journal of Asiatic Studies* 37.1 (June 1977): 125–7.
2. Nancy Shatzman Steinhardt, “The Plan of Khubilai Khan’s Imperial City,” *Artibus Asiae* 44.2/3 (1983): 152. The description and interpretation of Dadu here follows Steinhardt.
3. Herbert Franke, “Tibetans in Yuan China,” in John D. Langlois, Jr., ed., *China Under Mongol Rule*. (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1981), 306–7.
4. Thomas J. Barfield, *The Perilous Frontier: Nomadic Empires and China, 221 BC to AD 1757* (Cambridge, Mass.: Blackwell Publishers, 1989), 220.
5. Elizabeth Endicott-West, “Imperial Governance in Yüan Times,” *Harvard Journal of Asiatic Studies* 46.2 (Dec. 1986): 535.
6. Elizabeth Endicott-West, *Mongolian Rule in China: Local Administration in the Yuan Dynasty* (Cambridge, Mass.: Council on East Asian Studies, Harvard University, 1989), 79. Chinese did serve as *darughachi* but in smaller numbers.
7. Morris Rossabi, “The Muslims in the Early Yüan Dynasty,” in Langlois, *China Under Mongol Rule*, 278–83.

8. Morris Rossabi, "The Reign of Khubilai Khan," in Franke and Twitchett, eds., *The Cambridge History of China*, Vol. 6, 478–80; Herbert Franke, "Tibetans in Yüan China," in Langlois, *China Under Mongol Rule*, 321–5.
9. Franke and Twitchett, introduction to *The Cambridge History of China*, Vol. 6, 29–30.
0. Paul Heng-Chao Ch'en, *Chinese Legal Tradition Under the Mongols* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1979).
1. Franke, "Tibetans in Yüan China," 316.
2. F. W. Mote, *Imperial China, 900–1800* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1999), 496–7.
3. Paul D. Buell, "Mongol Empire and Turkicization: The Evidence of Food and Foodways," in Reuven Amitai-Preiss and David O. Morgan, eds., *The Mongol Empire and Its Legacy* (Leiden: Brill, 1999), 205; Rossabi, "The Muslims in the Early Yüan Dynasty," 285–6.
4. There is considerable debate on whether or not Marco Polo really got to China. For the argument against Polo, see Frances Wood, *Did Marco Polo Go to China?* (Boulder: Westview Press, 1996).
5. Manuel Komroff, ed., *Contemporaries of Marco Polo* (New York: Boni and Liveright, 1928); Wood, *Did Marco Polo Go to China?* 16–22.
6. Richard von Glahn, "Towns and Temples: Urban Growth and Decline in the Yangzi Delta, 1100–1400," in Paul Jakov Smith and Richard von Glahn, eds., *The Song-Yuan-Ming Transition in Chinese History* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Asia Center, 2003), 187–9.
7. Lucille Chia, "Mashaben: Commercial Publishing in Jianyang from the Song to the Ming," in Smith and von Glahn, *The Song-Yuan-Ming Transition*, 296–302.
8. Jung-pang Lo, "Maritime Commerce and Its Relation to the Sung Navy," *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 12.1 (Jan. 1969): 98.
9. Allsen, "Mongolian Princes and Their Merchant Partners," 97.
0. Elizabeth Endicott-West, "Merchant Associations in Yuan China: The Ortoy," *Asia Major*, Third Series, 1.2 (1989): 127–54.
1. John D. Langlois, Jr., "Yü Chi and His Mongol Sovereign: The Scholar as Apologist," *Journal of Asian Studies* 38.1 (Nov. 1978): 99–100; Paul Jakov Smith, "Fear of Gynarchy in an Age of Chaos: Kong Qi's Reflections on Life in South China Under Mongol Rule," *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 41.1 (1998): 5–6.
2. This and the following discussion draw on Bettine Birge, *Women, Property, and Confucian Reaction in Sung and Yüan China (960–1368)* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2002); and Bettine Birge, "Women and Confucianism from Song to Ming: The Institutionalization of Patrilineality," in Smith and von Glahn, eds., *The Song-Yuan-Ming Transition*, 212–40.
3. Smith, "Fear of Gynarchy," 63.
4. John W. Dardess, "Confucianism, Local Reform, and Centralization in Late Yüan Chekiang, 1342–1359," in Hoklam Chan and Wm. Theodore de Bary, eds., *Yüan Thought: Chinese Thought and Religion Under the Mongols* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1982), 368.
5. Quoted in Liu Ts'un-yan and Judith Berling, "The 'Three Teachings' in the Mongol-Yüan Period," in Chan and de Bary, eds., *Yüan Thought*, 496.
6. Endicott-West, *Mongolian Rule in China*, 112–3; Chen, *Chinese Legal Tradition Under the Mongols*, 88–9.
7. Robert P. Hymes, "Not Quite Gentlemen? Doctors in Sung and Yuan," *Chinese Science* 8 (1987): 9–76.
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9. Rossabi, "The Muslims in the Early Yüan Dynasty," 285.
0. Robert C. Provine, Yosohiko Tokumaru, and J. Lawrence Witzleben, eds., *The Garland Encyclopedia of World Music*, Vol. 7, *East Asia: China, Japan and Korea* (New York: Routledge, 2002), 176; *The New Grove Dictionary of Music and Musicians* (London: Macmillan Publishers, 2001), vol. 5, 644.
1. Craig Clunas, *Art in China* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1997), 122–3.
2. The following discussion of Yuan painting follows the analysis in James Cahill, *Hills Beyond a River: Chinese*

- Painting of the Yüan Dynasty, 1279–1368* (New York: Weatherhill, 1976).
3. Clunas, *Art in China*, 63–4.
 4. Cahill, *Hills Beyond a River*, 16–7.
 5. *Ibid.*, 38.
 6. Wen C. Fong, *Beyond Representation: Chinese Painting and Calligraphy, 8th–14th Century* (New York: Metropolitan Museum of Art, 1992), 439–40.
 7. Clunas, *Art in China*, 147–8.
 8. *Ibid.*, 149–50.
 9. Cahill, *Hills Beyond a River*, 114. The following discussion of Ni draws on Cahill, 114–20, 166–76, and Fong, *Beyond Representation*, 475–97.
 0. *Ibid.*, 118.
 1. Quoted in Fong, *Beyond Representation*, 487.
 2. Quoted in Cahill, *Hills Beyond a River*, 116.
 3. John W. Dardess, *Conquerors and Confucians: Aspects of Political Change in Late Yüan China* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1973), 87.
 4. William H. Mc Neill, *Plagues and Peoples* (Garden City: Anchor Press, 1976), 162–4. The evidence for the Chinese origins of the medieval plague are, however, quite slim. See Carol Benedict, *Bubonic Plague in Nineteenth Century China* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1996), 10.
 5. Robert S. Gottfried, *The Black Death: Natural and Human Disaster in Medieval Europe* (New York: The Free Press, 1983).
 6. Robert Hymes, unpublished paper on the bubonic plague in Chinese history, 1997, cited with permission of the author.
 7. The following discussion of rebellions and the fall of the Yuan draws on John Dardess, “Shunti and the End of Yüan Rule in China,” in Franke and Twitchett, eds., *The Cambridge History of China, Vol. 6*, 572–80; Mote, *Imperial China*, 525–6; and on Dardess, *Conquerors and Confucians*.
 8. Barfield, *The Perilous Frontier*, 221–2.
 9. Dardess, “Shunti and the End of Yüan Rule,” 569; Dardess, *Conquerors and Confucians*, 61.
 0. Dardess, *Conquerors and Confucians*, 80–1.
 1. Dardess, “Shunti and the End of Yüan Rule in China,” 577.
 2. Dardess, *Conquerors and Confucians*, 99–103.
 3. Richard von Glahn, *Fountain of Fortune: Money and Monetary Policy in China, 1000–1700* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1996), 68–70.
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Part III

A NEW
CONFUCIAN
EMPIRE,
1368–1799



On 6 April 1398, in the last year of his thirty-one-year reign, Zhu Yuanzhang (1328–1398), the founding emperor of the Ming dynasty, reflected on his achievements:

Since the world was united I have set up the cardinal principles, promulgated laws and established offices according to ancient rules: in the capital, the six ministries and the Censorate; in the provinces, the provincial administrative commissions, the provincial surveillance commissions, prefectures, sub-prefectures, and districts.¹

Nevertheless, the emperor lamented that his system, so carefully (or so he boasted) modeled on the examples of the ancients, was not functioning as it should. The problem was his officials: “They often take bribes and break the law, turn benevolence and righteousness upside down, and injure good people.”² For decades, Zhu had tried to cure the problem of corruption by applying horrendous punishments: mass arrests, public beatings, torture, and tens of thousands of executions—but to no avail: “Although the corpses of the first [officials to be executed for corruption] have not been removed, already others follow in their path.”³

Despite Zhu’s frustration, his descendants ruled a large, prosperous empire until 1644. In order to give some structure to this span of 277 years, we can break it down into three periods: the early Ming (1368–1450); the mid-Ming (1450–1550); and the late Ming (1550–1644).⁴ The early Ming and the late Ming are times of fundamental transformations which had long-term significance. The mid-Ming can be thought of as a transitional period in which Ming economy, society, and politics grew away from the ideals articulated by the early Ming rulers and laid the basis for the very different world of the late Ming.

The first of the Ming transformations came as Zhu Yuanzhang articulated his ideals: a stable, harmonious, hierarchical, simple agrarian society, having a strong Han cultural identity, ruled by incorruptible officials and a wise emperor. Zhu used a variety of autocratic institutions and despotic, sometimes pathologically violent techniques as he tried to make Ming bureaucracy and society conform to his ideals. Though never fully realized in practice, his ideals would become points of reference for future generations of rulers, officials, and historians, who used them creatively for their own rhetorical purposes. Early Ming despotism, too, exercised a powerful influence: the later Ming and Qing emperors inherited an imperial government designed to facilitate autocratic rule and to accommodate the arbitrary abuse of imperial power. This also would become a point of reference: future officials, scholars, and historians who would point to Zhu Yuanzhang and the early Ming in order to explain or to criticize rulers ranging from the late Ming emperors to the 20th-century regimes of Chiang Kai-shek and Mao Zedong.⁵

The second Ming transformation has its beginnings in the mid-Ming period, but we see its full development in the late Ming years. Over these centuries, increased agricultural production drove a process of urbanization, commercialization, and demand for luxury goods, particularly in the capital city of Beijing, in the wealthy Jiangnan region, the southeastern coastal provinces, and the southern provinces of Hunan and Guangdong. This late Ming society greatly impressed the European merchants and missionaries who were drawn to the Ming by its wealth, but it was a far cry from Zhu Yuanzhang’s agrarian ideals.

Together, the political transformations of the early Ming and the economic transformations of the mid- to late Ming produced much of what we think of as typically “Chinese”: the strong emphasis on Han ethnic identity, the firm establishment of Zhu Xi Neo-Confucianism as orthodoxy, the late imperial government, legal system, and examination system, the imperial city of Beijing, the Great Wall, four of the great classic Chinese novels, the popularization of foot-binding, state sponsorship of the cult of female chastity, and blue-and-white porcelain are all Ming products. Ming government, philosophy, and culture served as models or points of reference for Korea,

Vietnam, and, by way of Jesuit descriptions, Voltaire and other luminaries of the European Enlightenment.

In this chapter, we will deal primarily with the political and economic developments of the early and mid-Ming, with occasional excursions into the later periods. In the next chapter, we will consider the foreign trade, the cultural achievements of the mid- and late Ming periods, and the dynasty's last, difficult decades.

Zhu Yuanzhang: Idealist and Autocrat

Zhu Yuanzhang's vision of society and the autocratic methods that he used when trying to realize his ideals have their roots in his early experiences, his rise to power, and the advice of Neo-Confucian scholars who flocked eagerly to his side when they saw that he might conquer "all under Heaven." For both Zhu himself and his Neo-Confucian advisors, autocracy was the instrument through which they hoped to make their ideals into political and social reality.

The future emperor, born in 1328 in Anhui province, began life in poverty.⁶ His father was a landless laborer; his maternal grandfather was a fortuneteller. Flood, famine, and disease raged throughout the 1340s. In Zhu's own rural community, drought, locusts, and an epidemic brought starvation and death in 1344. Zhu's parents were among the victims, leaving him an orphan at sixteen. To survive, the young Zhu Yuanzhang entered a local Buddhist monastery. Within weeks, the monastery ran out of food and turned the monks out to beg. Zhu lived for around three years as a wandering beggarmonk, returning to the monastery in 1348 to continue his monastic training.

While Zhu Yuanzhang lived precariously as a beggar-monk, the Yuan Empire was falling into chaos. The Yangzi and Huai River Valleys were home to countless bands of armed men: local militia trying to defend their communities, bandits, and rebels. Loosely coordinated rebel groups called the Red Turbans combined Daoist religion, millenarian Buddhist beliefs in the coming of the Maitreya Buddha (the Buddha of the Future) and Manichean beliefs in the coming of a "Prince of Light" who would defeat the forces of darkness. In 1352, Zhu left his monastery to join one of these vaguely Manichean rebel groups. No one could have predicted it at the time, but this was the barely literate monk's first step on the path toward military triumph and, ultimately, to the imperial throne.

Zhu Yuanzhang excelled at war. He recruited talented and brave men, won their loyalty, and led them to victory against other rebel groups, local strongmen, and the Yuan armies. By 1364, he controlled an extensive territory in the Yangzi Valley from his headquarters in the city of Nanjing. In 1368, Zhu ascended the throne as the Hongwu emperor, founder of the Ming dynasty, with its capital in Nanjing. His armies went on to defeat the remaining Yuan forces in the north, driving them back to the grasslands of Inner and Outer Mongolia (many Mongol officials and residents in the north and in the southwest, especially in Yunnan province, remained behind).



Official court painting of Zhu Yuanzhang, the Hongwu emperor, Ming dynasty.

The Hongwu emperor had already abandoned the Manichean beliefs of his rebel past.⁷ His policies and style of government developed in the context of his relations with a group of Neo-Confucian scholars who had served as his advisers since 1359.⁸ These men, from eastern Zhejiang province, believed that good, strong government would act

decisively to bring a chaotic, evil society into conformity with Confucian ritual, morality, and hierarchy as described by the Southern Song interpreter of Confucianism Zhu Xi. They were deeply disappointed in the weakness and incompetence of the Yuan dynasty. In Zhu Yuanzhang, they saw the powerful leader who could put their ideas into practice and reform society.

Zhu Yuanzhang was influenced by his Confucian advisors, but he was not their puppet. Although minimally educated, he was an intelligent, determined, opinionated, and ruthless man. His own ideals for government and society and his autocratic leadership style made him receptive to the advice that the Confucian scholars gave him. Together the Hongwu emperor, his advisers, and his high-ranking officials created a highly autocratic and centralized government apparatus in which harsh measures were often justified as being necessary to purge state and society of evil and thus to make the ideal, harmonious, benevolent Confucian society into a reality.

During the first eight years of his reign, from 1368 to 1375, the Hongwu emperor consolidated his control over Ming territory, restored order, and established the basic elements of the Ming state. In doing so, he was very conscious of his role as the man who had driven out the Mongols and restored Han Chinese rule. He made a point of reasserting Han Chinese cultural identity by banning Mongol names, ordering his people to wear clothing modeled on that of the Tang dynasty, and ostentatiously presenting his government and its institutions as the restoration of ancient Chinese models. In fact, the Hongwu emperor's government employed former Yuan officials and adopted its basic elements from the Yuan.⁹

The early Ming system departed most clearly from the Yuan model in the matter of religion, ritual, and education. These areas were at the core of the Ming claim to be restoring Han Chinese identity and were closely tied to the Hongwu emperor's goal of centralizing power and his advisers' ambition of creating an ideal Neo-Confucian state and society. The Ming state firmly suppressed "heterodox" religion and organized the approved local, provincial, and imperial deities into a hierarchy reflecting the administrative hierarchy of the empire.¹⁰ In order to standardize behavior, the emperor ordered that Zhu Xi's *Family Rituals* be adopted as the guide to ritual for elite and commoner families alike. This represents a further move toward the "Confucianization" of Chinese society. The Hongwu emperor also tried briefly to "Confucianize" his people by ordering each community to establish a community school at which the sons of commoners would be given lessons in morality and basic literacy—not to prepare them for further education or official careers, but simply to make them better, more obedient and reverent sons and subjects.¹¹

The Hongwu emperor had a clearly defined image of what the Ming Empire should be: a stable agricultural country, with scholar-officials, farmers, artisans, merchants, and military families all fulfilling their assigned roles, generation after generation, in a moral hierarchy headed by the emperors. Neither his people nor his officials conformed to the Hongwu emperor's expectations. Officials formed factions, took bribes, and preyed upon the people. Commoners persisted in worshipping the wrong gods, evaded taxes, and failed to establish community schools.

Never a patient man, the Hongwu emperor reacted not only by changing his policies,¹² but also by strengthening his autocratic power and by carrying out massive purges in which tens of thousands of people, from commoners to the highest-ranking officials of the realm, were denounced, cruelly tortured, and executed. Still, while huge numbers of officials fell victim, many other officials benefited by standing at the emperor's side and assisting in the slaughter.

The most significant of these purges was the emperor's attack on his prime minister, Hu Weiyong. Hu had served Zhu Yuanzhang for years. As prime minister, he was in charge of the daily operation of the government. He also had the opportunity to appoint numerous friends and men from his home community to positions throughout the bureaucracy. The Hongwu emperor feared that his old comrade was becoming too powerful. So in 1380, the emperor moved to destroy Hu and anyone associated with him.¹³

Over a period of years, tens of thousands of people connected or thought to be connected (whether closely or even remotely) to Hu Weiyong were arrested and executed. Hu Weiyong himself was one of the first to be killed. To make sure that no prime minister would ever again accumulate too much power, the Hongwu emperor abolished the position of Prime Minister entirely. Instead, he and his successors on the Ming throne would personally lead the imperial government in its daily business. This amounted to a significant increase in imperial power.

As he tried to bring his bureaucracy and society into conformity with his ideals, the Hongwu emperor used his immense power to introduce a series of new policies and institutions from 1375 until his death in 1398. To control his top-ranking officials, he established a palace security force, the Embroidered Uniform Guard. He also assigned more sensitive tasks, such as diplomacy, to the most trusted members of his personal household: his eunuch slaves.

In all that he did, the Hongwu emperor hoped to maintain social control while preventing his officials from becoming too powerful and limiting opportunities for corruption. However, as we have seen, in the year of his death, the Hongwu emperor was still unhappy with the state of affairs in his empire: neither the people nor his officials had fulfilled his ideals. He expected that his heirs would continue to carry out his policies and pursue his vision of a stable agrarian state. His imperial successors paid fervent lip service to the Hongwu emperor's ancestral injunctions, but, inevitably, they did things their own way. The first to violate the late Hongwu emperor's will were his grandson and heir, the Jianwen emperor, and his own son, Zhu Di, who usurped the throne from Jianwen to become the Yongle emperor.

The Yongle Emperor: Warrior and Patron of Culture

After he took the throne, Zhu Yuanzhang had enfeoffed twenty-three of his sons as princes and assigned them, with military forces of varying size, to strategically important locations across the empire. Those with the strongest armies were the nine princes assigned to guard the northern frontiers against the Mongols. The emperor's eldest son, the heir apparent, stayed in the capital with his father. When the heir died prematurely in 1392 his son, the imperial grandson, became heir apparent. In 1398 it was this young man, aged twenty-two, who took the throne as the Jianwen emperor.

Perhaps the Jianwen emperor would have been a more humane ruler than the Hongwu emperor had been. He and his advisers seem to have been more inclined toward moderation. However, their first challenge would be that posed by the Jianwen emperor's surviving uncles, the princes. Especially difficult would be Zhu Di, the Prince of Yan. Zhu Di was the eldest surviving son of Zhu Yuanzhang. His fief of Yan was the area of the old Yuan capital, Dadu. Zhu Di and his large army had been a key component of the Hongwu emperor's defense against the Mongols.

The Jianwen emperor began his campaign against the princes by bringing the weaker among them under control in order to deprive Zhu Di of allies. But when imperial armies then moved to attack Zhu Di himself, the Prince of Yan defeated them and struck south against Nanjing. By way of justification, Zhu Di announced that the Jianwen emperor had come under the influence of evil ministers and that it was his responsibility, as the eldest male of the imperial house, to come to the emperor's rescue.

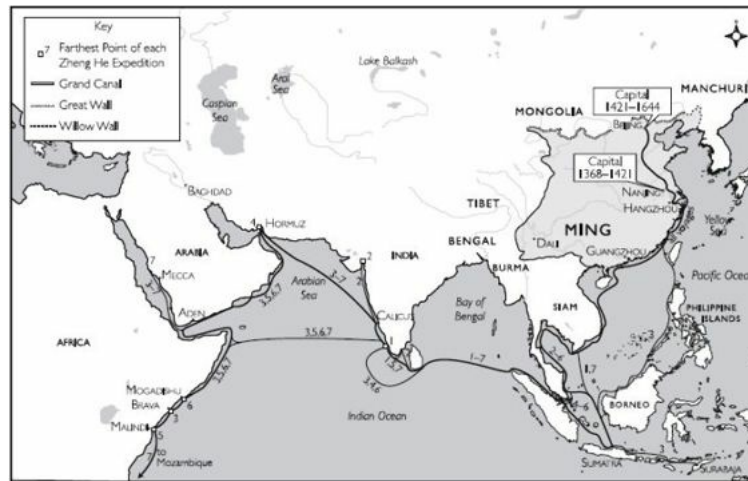


Official court painting of Yongle, the third emperor of the Ming dynasty.

During the attack on Nanjing, the imperial palace caught fire and burned to the ground. The Jianwen emperor and his consort were presumed dead—the bodies were never found. The victorious Prince of Yan took the throne as the Yongle emperor. He then did his best to erase the Jianwen emperor from the historical record: he changed the names of the three years of the Jianwen reign to make them appear as the last three years of the Hongwu reign, and he ordered the records of the Jianwen court so thoroughly revised that very little can be reliably known about the Jianwen emperor and his short reign.¹⁴

The Yongle emperor occupied the throne from 1402 to 1424.¹⁵ These were years of aggressive foreign policy, massive construction projects, and lavish support of scholarship and literature. Perhaps the Yongle emperor was trying to live up to his father's larger-than-life reputation, or to erase the stain of his usurpation from his, and the

historical memory. In any event, the accomplishments of his twenty-year reign changed the empire so significantly that it is reasonable to view Yongle, along with his father, as a co-founder of the Ming dynasty.



[The Ming Empire and the Zheng He voyages.](#)

The Yongle emperor is especially noted for his adventuresome foreign policy. Deploying his forces by land and by sea, the emperor expanded Ming territory, sent his armies north into Mongolia and south to Annam, and established diplomatic and trade relations with states from the frontiers of the far northeast to the islands of modern Indonesia to the shores of Africa. Whether or not the gains were worth the cost was, and is, highly debatable. The most notable, and perhaps most debated of these expensive projects was a series of voyages to Southeast Asia, the Indian Ocean, and the East African coast.

It is not entirely clear why the Yongle emperor decided to send a huge fleet to sail to the island kingdoms of Southeast Asia and into the Indian Ocean. Perhaps he was looking for news of the Jianwen emperor who, according to one rumor, had escaped the burning palace and fled to Southeast Asia. However, the more likely explanations for the voyage have to do with trade and prestige. By sending strongly armed imperial fleets to Southeast Asia and the Indian Ocean, the emperor may have hoped to gain recognition, enhance his status as “Son of Heaven” at home, and secure sea routes. He may also have wanted to bring existing maritime trade into the “tribute system,” in which representatives of foreign rulers came to the Ming court to present ceremonial tribute and to receive gifts from the Ming emperor in return.¹⁶ The tribute system benefited both the Ming and the “tributaries” by cementing military and political relations and by supplying a state-managed framework in which private trade (conducted by merchants accompanying the tribute mission and by the diplomats themselves) could be conducted. But not all trade was carried out within this system: unregulated private trade was often associated with corruption and piracy.

Yongle chose one of his eunuch slaves to lead the voyages. This man, Zheng He, was a child of a Muslim family who served the Yuan as officials in the southwestern province of Yunnan. A Ming general captured him while driving the Yuan out of the area in 1382.¹⁷ Zheng He, fourteen years old, was castrated and sent to serve the Prince of Yan, the future Yongle emperor, as a slave. Zheng He proved his bravery, intelligence, and capability in the prince’s campaigns against the Mongols and in the war against the Jianwen emperor. Zheng He’s status as a Muslim whose father and grandfather are thought to have made the pilgrimage to Mecca was undoubtedly a factor in his appointment. The voyage would be visiting a number of Muslim lands, and Arabic was the language of trade and navigation in the Indian Ocean and the South China Sea.¹⁸

Zheng He led a voyage to Southeast Asia, Sri Lanka, and the west coast of India in 1405–1407. This was the first of a total of seven expeditions which visited areas from Champa (a kingdom in modern southern Vietnam), Sumatra, Java, and Malacca to India, Sri Lanka, the Persian Gulf and Red Sea, the Arabian Peninsula, and the trading cities of the East African coast.

The voyages were generally peaceful (at least in comparison to the later Portuguese actions in the Indian Ocean), but the fleets of around two hundred to two hundred fifty ships and over twenty-seven thousand men, most of them Ming military personnel, armed with cold steel and gunpowder weapons, could overawe most potential rivals.¹⁹

Ming forces under Zheng He's command suppressed Chinese pirates around Java and landed thousands of troops to replace uncooperative local rulers in Sumatra and Sri Lanka. However, the main business of the fleets was to use the show of force to bring trade into the framework of the tributary system. The Ming exchanged porcelain for aromatics, medicinal herbs, ivory, rhinoceros horn, and exotic animals for the court (zebras and two very impressive giraffes). They also brought Southeast Asian, South Asian, Arab, and African emissaries, sometimes even rulers themselves, and merchants to the Ming capital, where their presence and tribute contributed to maritime trade and added luster and legitimacy to the Yongle emperor's claim to be Son of Heaven.

If they were successful (and they seem to have been so), then why did the voyages come to an end in 1433? Part of the reason is that the entire enterprise was so closely connected with the Yongle emperor himself and his eunuch servants. They brought little or no benefit to the government bureaucracy or to the Ming economy in general. Furthermore, the Confucian officials were able to make some cogent arguments against the voyages. The Zheng He voyages and their trade in luxury goods were a financial burden on the government. To understand the significance of that burden, we need to put it into the context of the Yongle emperor's other adventures.

At the same time as he built and sent forth his oceangoing fleets, the emperor struck out both to the north and south with his armies. In the south, Ming forces invaded and occupied Annam in 1407. The invasion quickly turned into a hopeless twenty-year struggle against Annamese resistance.

In the north, the Yongle emperor and his successors faced their most significant military threat, the Mongols. Yongle sent numerous diplomatic missions to Tibet, the Turkic kingdoms in modern Xinjiang and Central Asia, and to Manchuria in order to build a system of alliances to hem in the Mongols from the east and west. He clearly signaled his intention to bring the fight to the Mongols when he moved his capital from Nanjing, in the Yangzi Valley, to the old Yuan capital of Dadu, which became "Beijing," the Ming Empire's "northern capital."

Beijing's location put the imperial government close to the front line of the anticipated struggles against the Mongols. It also put the capital in a graindeficit area a long way from the rice supplies of the productive Yangzi Valley. It would be necessary to ship grain from the Yangzi Valley north to supply Beijing and the armies guarding the border. This could be done by sea or by canal. The Yongle emperor chose the canal route, which meant dredging and repairing the Grand Canal and building grain barges. The construction of Beijing and repairing and maintaining the Grand Canal were major new expenses for the Ming government. From his new capital the Yongle emperor again led expeditions against the Mongols, but with little success. The enemy could always flee into the vast interior of Mongolia, beyond the reach of the Ming emperor's fragile supply lines.

Taken together, the expenses of the Annam war and occupation, the construction of Beijing, the repair of the Grand Canal, campaigns against the Mongols, and the Zheng He expeditions consumed huge amounts of resources: wood for palaces, ships, and canal barges, grain to supply soldiers and workers, material for weapons, fittings for ships, and so on. It is little surprise that expenses outpaced revenue significantly during the Yongle reign.²⁰ In this context, it becomes understandable that the Yongle emperor's successors and their officials should decide that the empire could do without the expense of the very impressive, but economically and morally questionable Zheng He voyages.

While building his reputation as a warrior and seeking recognition from foreign chiefs and princes from Manchuria to East Africa, the Yongle emperor also cultivated the image of imperial patron of culture. He paid great attention to carrying out the Confucian rituals, made demonstrative examples of his filial piety (for instance, by following his father's instructions in matters of ritual, music, mourning, and funerals), and supported private academies and Confucian scholars.²¹

As a patron of culture, the emperor sponsored the compilation and editing of collections of important texts: the Four Books and Five Classics, as edited and annotated by Zhu Xi, other writings of Song and Yuan Neo-Confucians, and a massive collection, the *Yongle Encyclopedia*. This "encyclopedia" was a multivolume collection of all the worthwhile writings that could be found: Confucian classics, histories, philosophy, literature, poetry, astronomy, divination, religion, and art.²² By sponsoring scholarship, the emperor drew scholars into the service, and the control, of the imperial court. By publishing standard editions of the Confucian classics, handbooks of ritual, and other important texts, he further defined orthodoxy, proscribed heterodoxy, and strengthened the ideological basis of the imperial government.

The Hongwu and Yongle emperors, father and son, together reigned from 1368 to 1424 (with the brief Jianwen reign intervening). They founded and consolidated the Ming Empire, defined and reached (not always successfully) beyond its borders, and presided over the construction of an imperial bureaucracy. They also set a precedent of autocratic and often brutally violent personal rule. Ming emperors held the power of life and death over their

subjects, but were themselves simply one piece in what became a very complex system of imperial government—one that emperors worked within (to the extent that they were willing to work at all), but never completely controlled.

The Ming Bureaucracy

The Ming emperors were the chief executive officers of a complex bureaucratic government whose employees, like any bureaucrats, soon developed vested interests which, at times, clashed with the ideals and the interests of the emperors. Ming institutions of government developed and changed over the 276 years of dynastic rule. Nonetheless, the Ming system did have four basic elements throughout the dynasty, elements which the Manchu Qing emperors inherited in 1644. These were: the imperial government in the capital; a bureaucracy extending out to the provincial and sub-provincial levels across the empire; a set of institutions for managing people and resources; and the orthodox Neo-Confucian philosophy that served as the theoretical basis for the entire system and as an essential point of reference for policy proposals and debates.

The emperors were meant to be the leaders of the Ming system, both in a religious and in a practical sense. They were to carry out planting and harvest rituals, to worship Heaven and Earth, and to display filial piety toward their parents and ancestors. Since the Hongwu emperor had eliminated the post of Prime Minister, the emperors were also expected to be the hands-on chief administrators of the imperial government. The basic government structure was inherited from the Yuan dynasty. The ministers of the Six Ministries (Rites, Personnel, Revenue, Punishment, Works, and War) reported directly to the emperor (in the Yuan, they would have reported to the prime minister). The Censorate exercised independent investigation and oversight over all levels of the bureaucracy and reported directly to the emperor.

With talented and humane emperors, perhaps this system would have worked better than it did. In practice, most of the Ming emperors after Yongle were neither talented nor humane. Some took the throne as children and were simply not capable of ruling. Some preferred drinking, hunting, or the pursuit of Daoist immortality to the dreary business of holding audience, reading documents, and giving orders. In such cases, the people closest to the emperor exercised his power on his behalf. As in past dynasties, strong imperial women (empresses dowager, empresses, and concubines) might play significant roles. In the Ming, however, the most influential individuals close to the emperor were generally the chief eunuchs and the grand secretaries.

Eunuch participation in politics was nothing new, but Ming eunuchs did play a more powerful role, and on a more consistent basis, than they had in previous dynasties. The Grand Secretariat was a Ming innovation. Without a prime minister to manage the day-to-day business of government, the Ming emperors appointed a few personal secretaries to help them to handle the massive flow of paperwork. These men were chosen from among the Confucian scholars in residence at the Hanlin Academy, a sort of imperial thinktank or talent pool. The leading grand secretary often made decisions on behalf of the emperor and could, in the case of a young, weak, or incompetent emperor, come to dominate the government. Thus there were times when court officials had to report, not to their emperor, but to a chief eunuch or a grand secretary.

The Ming government's Six Ministries made policy for the empire, but officials at the provincial level and below were responsible for putting policy into action. The empire was divided into thirteen provinces, which were in turn subdivided into 159 prefectures, 240 sub-prefectures, and 1,144 counties.²³ In the late Ming, about 24,000 officials staffed the bureaucracy, including about 1,500 in the imperial government in Beijing. This was a rather small number of men to manage the affairs of an empire of 1,500,000 square miles (3,900,000 sq km) with a population of over two hundred million in 1600.

At the base level, the magistrates of the 1,144 counties were responsible for carrying out the day-to-day business of government. The term "magistrate" as used here may be misleading: these officials were in essence surrogates of the emperor. They were in charge of everything from collecting taxes to investigating crimes, apprehending and trying criminals, settling civil disputes, maintaining public order, and fostering social harmony and morality.

To guide them in their work, county magistrates and higher-ranking officials looked to a body of written law. The Hongwu emperor had ordered his officials to draft a body of law, the *Great Ming Code*, which took its final form in 1389. Supplementing this code of law were the *August Ming Ancestral Instruction* and the *Great Ming Commandment*, in which he laid forth the rules for the imperial clan and regulations regarding the operation of the government. Later emperors were obliged to respect these documents as the will of the imperial founder, but they

could and did supplement and change the laws by issuing their own imperial orders which, compiled from time to time, were yet another source of law. The laws defined a number of crimes, laid forth a range of punishments, and provided the magistrates with the power to punish undesirable behavior not specifically prohibited in the laws by analogy to existing provisions.

With the average county standing at 1,300 square miles (3,400 sq km) and ninety thousand people in the late Ming,²⁴ the magistrate could not hope to enforce the laws and to do all the other tasks required of him without a set of institutions designed to help him to manage people, land, grain, and other resources. Because the magistrate was the lowest level of formal government, those institutions harnessed the power of the local elite to assist the magistrate. Under the *li-jia* system, families were organized into groups of ten households, called *jia*, with an eleventh household serving as *jia*-head. Ten such *jia* formed a *li* of one hundred ten households. The head households of the *li-jia* system were to keep track of the composition of each family, encourage productivity, resolve disputes, and help maintain order.

To organize tax collection, households were to be counted and the records kept in books referred to as the “Yellow Registers.” Officials also made detailed surveys of the farmers’ fields which, when mapped, formed patterns like the scales of a fish, and were thus called the “Fish-scale Registers.” Armed with the Yellow Registers and the Fish-scale Registers, officials could divide each prefecture into tax-grain sectors. They would then appoint a wealthy family in each tax-grain sector to be responsible for collecting and delivering the grain tax and other miscellaneous taxes to the government granaries and offices.

Local elites were also responsible for a range of social activities: running community schools, organizing local irrigation and flood control projects, and carrying out rituals designed to build and maintain a harmonious, moral community. The best-known of these were the libation ceremony and the community compact. The libation ceremony involved ritual drinking of rice wine or other alcoholic beverages and the expression of respect for family and community elders. The community compact brought families together to encourage moral behavior, censure immoral behavior, and assist one another in times of natural disaster.

As they carried out the business of government, defended the legitimacy of current or proposed policies, or expressed criticism of existing policies and personnel, everyone from local elites to county magistrates to the emperor, his grand secretaries, and the chief eunuchs referred back to Neo-Confucianist learning. Taking his cue from the Yuan dynasty, the Ming Hongwu emperor elevated the Zhu Xi school of Neo-Confucianism to the status of state-sanctioned orthodoxy. This particular interpretation of the Confucian tradition was attractive because it emphasized filial piety and loyalty, and relied on classical texts (rather than introspection and intuition) as the authoritative source of moral standards.

During the Ming, state-sanctioned orthodoxy could have a stronger impact than ever before because now, for the first time, the civil service examinations became virtually the only path to a government career. As we have seen, earlier dynastic regimes had used varying combinations of recommendation and examination to select officials. In the early Ming, Zhu Yuanzhang experimented with both techniques, but in the end, he and his successors to the throne settled on an intensive, three-level civil service examination system as the way to choose candidates for government employment. Through their preparation for the examinations, scholars and officials all studied the same core texts: the Confucian Four Books and Five Classics and the standard histories of the previous dynasties—as edited and annotated by Zhu Xi and other Song Neo-Confucian scholars.

While moral indoctrination played an important role in Ming political life, the Ming emperors and their advisors clearly did not trust their subordinates. The system was designed to prevent any one official or small group of officials from becoming too powerful. At court, the Hongwu emperor built a personal security force, the Embroidered Uniform Guard. Later emperors added more such forces, including the notorious Western Depot. Emperors and their surrogates, particularly the chief eunuchs, used the Embroidered Uniform Guard and the Western Depot to spy on, apprehend, torture, and execute rivals in the vicious factional struggles that so often absorbed the attention of the Ming court.

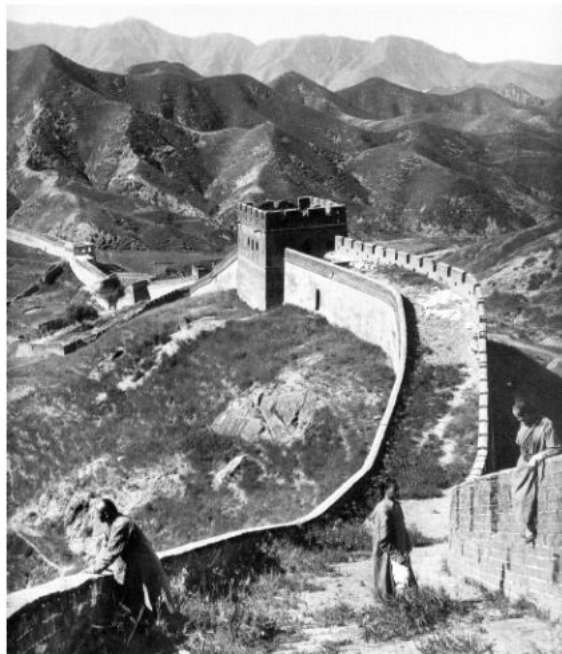
At the provincial level and below, division of administrative duties prevented concentration of power. A province would have two administrative commissioners, a surveillance commissioner, and a military commissioner. Large cities, including the capital and the southern capital, were generally divided between two counties, each responsible for part of the city. The military, too, was arranged to prevent the emergence of regionally based military strongmen. The Five Military Commissions in the capital were responsible for training and maintaining troops in specific territorial commands around the empire and for tactical decisions in wartime. The Ministry of War—a part of the civil bureaucracy—was responsible for the disposition of troops and for strategic decisions.

Together (but not without tension among one another), the various elements of the “Ming system” functioned for nearly three centuries. The longevity of the Ming government should not, however, be taken to indicate that these were centuries of stability or stagnation. The Ming Empire of 1600 was quite different from the Ming Empire of 1400. Much of this change was due to environmental, demographic, and economic factors beyond the control of the government. Some was the result of government action as emperors and their advisors sought to adapt to changing circumstances around them. The Yongle emperor’s decision to move the capital from Nanjing to Beijing in order to take a more aggressive stance against the Mongols is one example of the way in which government action could lead to developments that the emperor himself could not have foreseen.

Imperial Beijing, the Grand Canal, and the Great Wall

Many of the world’s great empires are justly admired for their great cities and architectural wonders. Rome had its aqueducts, temples, and coliseums, the Ottomans the gracious palaces and mosques of Istanbul. The Ming is known for the imperial city of Beijing, the Great Wall, and, though it was originally constructed in the Yuan, for the re-dredged and improved Grand Canal. Each of these triumphs of engineering and construction has left a permanent mark on the history and the landscape of China; yet each was the controversial and expensive outcome of often contentious debate about the best way of addressing a series of challenging problems. The answers—and perhaps some of the problems themselves—started with the city of Beijing.

As a young prince, the Yongle emperor had been stationed at the former Yuan capital of Dadu. As emperor, he decided to move the Ming capital from Nanjing to Dadu, which would be renamed “Beijing.” This was part of Yongle’s strategy for dealing with the Mongols: that is, to take the fight to the Mongols, pursuing them into the steppes when necessary.



The Great Wall of China, as photographed by Herbert Ponting in 1907.

It was an aggressive and also an expensive approach to the “Mongol problem.” Not much was left of the Yuan capital. The new walled city of Beijing overlapped the footprint of Dadu and incorporated many features of the older city—particularly some of the temples and a series of man-made lakes. However, most of Beijing, including the imperial palace, was new construction.

The plan for Beijing drew consciously on the ideal design of a capital as transmitted in ancient texts that claimed to describe the capital of the Zhou dynasty: thus the north-south orientation, the gridwork of major streets, and the city wall, pierced by regularly spaced gates. Beijing's roughly rectangular walls defined a city of around 12 square miles (31 sq km). Within was a smaller, also roughly rectangular walled Imperial City, which in turn held the walled palace complex, the Forbidden City.

The Yongle emperor recruited (or enslaved) craftsmen from across the empire to design and build the Imperial Palace. The lead architect was an Annamese eunuch, and many of the laborers were convicts. The Yongle emperor spared no expense in the construction. Timber was shipped from Sichuan, Hunan, and Zhejiang, special bricks and gold from Jiangsu, red clay from Shandong, and stone quarried from around Beijing. When completed, the Forbidden City was a complex of six major palaces occupying 179 acres (723,600 sq m).²⁵ The buildings themselves followed traditional Chinese architectural style. Gates, walls, and buildings within the palace complex subdivided space into courtyards. Outside walls of buildings were made of brick and mortar, with the rest of the construction being mainly in wood. The roofs were supported by a system of pillars and beams. This palace complex remained the political center of the Ming and then the Qing Empire until 1912.

When the Yongle emperor built his capital there, Beijing was a rough, lightly populated frontier town, albeit one with memories of a glorious past as the capital of the Yuan Empire. Over the centuries, Beijing developed into a great capital city, known for its scenery, its temples, and most of all for its role as the seat of imperial power.²⁶ None of this, however, could change the fact that Beijing was perched precariously on the northern fringes of the settled agricultural world of the Han Chinese, perilously close to the deserts and grasslands of the Mongols, and dangerously far from the economic, agricultural, and intellectual heartland of the empire in the Yangzi Valley. Beijing's peculiar location explains the city's close relation to two massive engineering projects that extended thousands of miles from the city itself: the Great Wall and the Grand Canal.

When the Hongwu emperor defeated the Yuan's Mongol forces, the remnants of defensive walls left behind by previous dynasties were not the defining element of the Ming's strategic posture vis-à-vis the Mongols. The boundary between Ming territory and the Mongolian steppelands was defined by a series of fortified mountain passes following roughly the line along which the Great Wall would later be built. At first, the Yongle emperor pursued the Mongols beyond that line, but he found it impossible to build and maintain the supply lines necessary to keep his troops in the field long enough and far enough into Mongolia to effectively meet and defeat the Mongol enemy. After the Yongle reign, the Ming reverted to a defensive posture on the northern border, pulling back to the passes along the future Great Wall line and using various combinations of diplomacy, alliances, and trade to divide, weaken, hem in, and pacify the Mongols.

One significant exception to this defensive posture came in 1449. The Zhengtong emperor, twenty-two years old at the time, fancied himself a great warrior—an illusion which his powerful chief eunuch, Wang Zhen, encouraged. When the Mongol leader Esen raided Ming territory and showed signs of uniting the Mongol tribes, Zhengtong insisted, against the advice of his cautious civil officials, on personally leading an expedition to hunt down and punish the powerful Mongol.

Zhengtong and Wang Zhen's badly managed expedition brought them to the border area of Datong, where they failed to locate the enemy. Declaring victory (after all, the enemy had fled, had he not?) they returned to Beijing by a vulnerable northern route. Esen attacked the emperor's encampment near the town of Tumu, utterly defeating the exhausted and demoralized Ming forces and capturing the emperor who, according to accounts, had simply sat down in a field to cry.²⁷

The Tumu disaster shook the Ming dynasty. In Beijing, a power-hungry faction of officials placed Zhengtong's brother on the throne. Esen followed up with an abortive attack on Beijing. With his followers abandoning him for his failure, Esen later returned his useless ex-emperor hostage to the Ming, where he remained under house arrest until 1457, when another court faction deposed his brother and returned Zhengtong to the throne, older (but not much wiser), to reign anew as the Tianshun emperor (r. 1457–64).

The disaster at Tumu underlined the continued dangers that the Ming faced from the Mongols. For over a century after the events at Tumu, Ming officials, generals, and emperors debated about the most effective ways of dealing with the problem. Policy on the ground changed with the ebb and flow of the debate and with the seriousness of the threat. Punitive expeditions, negotiated, regulated trade, and construction of defensive fortresses and walls at key points and lines along the border were all attempted at various times.²⁸

Much of the debate involved the problem of Mongol tribes who had occupied the Ordos—the area enclosed within the great bend of the Yellow River. The question was whether the Ming should fight to recover this lost

territory, or simply give it up and build defensive walls to keep the Mongols from advancing any further. In the mid-16th century, these debates settled around what was essentially a compromise position. At the time, a large Mongol force under the leadership of the Altan Khan demanded trade and threatened war when the Jiajing emperor (who despised Mongols) refused to have anything to do with them.



[Defenses on the Ming northern frontier.](#)

In order to defend the frontiers against the Altan Khan, first one, then another in what became a linked series of defensive walls was constructed—one of which cut across the Ordos, implicitly accepting the permanent loss of a large part of that strategic territory. Thus the Great Wall emerged—a 3,000-mile (4,800-km) system of walls, fortified passes, watchtowers, and signal towers. In some areas, such as the vicinity of Beijing, the wall was built of stone, brick, and mortar. In more remote areas, wallbuilders employed the age-old rammed-earth technology. By the end of the 16th century the Great Wall as we know it today was complete. A hundred years later, it was a relic: the Qing Empire ruled a territory which extended far beyond the wall to Manchuria in the northeast, Mongolia in the north, and Xinjiang in the northwest. Nonetheless, the Ming wall survived. In the 20th century, it acquired a new function as a symbol of the Chinese nation.²⁹

If walls protected the cities and, by 1600, the northern frontiers of the Ming Empire, it was rivers and canals that linked the walled cities together and supplied Beijing and the troops on the northern frontier with grain. Southern China, particularly the lower Yangzi Valley, was laced with navigable rivers and canals, which brought tax grain, timber, cotton, silk, textiles, and other materials from the rural areas and small market towns to the great cities. The most important of all these canals was the Grand Canal, which linked the lower Yangzi Valley to the capital of Beijing, over 1,000 miles (1,600 km) to the north.

The Grand Canal was actually a system of canals and rivers, which extended from Hangzhou in the south to Tongzhou, a suburb of Beijing, in the north. Another small canal linked Tongzhou to Beijing. Some sections of the Grand Canal had been constructed during the Sui and Tang dynasties. The part linking the Yellow River to Beijing was built during the Yuan, but had silted up. The Ming dredged and repaired the canal, digging a new channel across the highlands of Shandong to improve access to Beijing.³⁰

The Grand Canal was an impressive feat of engineering and enabled the Ming government to haul as many as 6.7 million piculs (about 900 million pounds, or 400 million kg) of grain in a year from the Yangzi Valley to the capital. But the canal was environmentally unstable and tremendously expensive to maintain and operate. Silting was a constant problem, especially when the Yellow River flooded and overran the adjacent sections of the canal. The problem of maintenance limited the canal's carrying capacity so severely that it was unable to deliver enough grain to supply the capital and frontier troops in the late Ming period. Similar problems had led the Yuan to abandon canal shipping in favor of maritime grain shipments. The Ming authorities, for reasons that remain unclear, believed that

maritime shipping was too dangerous and too expensive. They preferred to continue to rely on the canal. Some historians argue that the low carrying capacity of the Grand Canal contributed to a serious shortage of grain supplies in the last decades of the Ming, contributing to the fall of the dynasty.³¹

The Transformative Power of Economic Growth

When the Yongle emperor commanded that the Grand Canal be repaired, his goal was to provide reliable transportation of grain to Beijing. Merchants, soldiers, and canal workers, however, soon found ways of using the canal for their own profit. Private boats and even government grain barges carried all manner of commodities north and south along the Grand Canal, enriching the lives of Beijing consumers and the pocketbooks of Jiangnan merchants.³² This trade was part of the economic growth and marketization that helped to make the mid- and late Ming Empire so different from the early Ming, and from Zhu Yuanzhang's ideals.

In the long-term view, Ming economic growth was an extension of trends already in place in the Song and Yuan periods: increasing grain (especially rice) production, large-scale, proto-industrial production of iron and porcelain, and growing domestic and international trade.³³ In the short term, however, the early Ming government inherited the economic and demographic setbacks of the late Yuan. Like other dynastic founders, the early Ming emperors established systems of household registration, taxation, and corvée labor so that they could lay hands on and deploy the farming population's surplus labor, grain, and textile production and put it to use supplying the armed forces, the government, and the imperial house.

Much of early Ming economic policy drew on familiar practices. The government repaired flood control and irrigation systems. It moved farmers from crowded areas to less populated parts of the empire, especially along the borders. Both the Hongwu and Yongle emperors forced powerful Jiangnan families to relocate to areas around their capitals (Nanjing, and then Beijing). The Hongwu emperor settled soldiers on military agricultural colonies along the northern frontiers, where they were to both protect the empire and keep themselves supplied with grain.

The government also encouraged trade to develop in ways that would be beneficial to the state. Under the imperial salt monopoly system, private merchants could earn permits to buy and sell salt by delivering grain to the government. Some merchants hired farmers to open fields and grow the grain that they could then use to enter the lucrative salt business. The government also tried to regulate and profit from trade by issuing paper currency and requiring merchants to use it.

It is hard to say just how successful these early Ming government policies were. Some scholars suggest that because the Ming population was relatively small, and the economy fairly simple, the Hongwu and Yongle emperors were able to try, and to some extent succeed in, setting up a rigid, highly controlled system intended to encourage taxpaying farmer households to produce grain and textiles.³⁴ But it is not clear that these policies were implemented consistently across the Ming Empire or for any long period of time. Consequently, historians continue to debate the causes of Ming economic growth: Did the early Ming government policies actively foster an economic recovery and lay the foundations for future growth? Or was the Ming government's only contribution to have restored peace and stability so that farmers, artisans, and merchants could go about their businesses, working within, around, and in violation of Ming rules and regulations according to their best interests?

Whether we seek the causes in government policy, in the creativity and labor of the Ming people, or in some combination of the two, the economy of the late Ming (1550–1644) was strikingly different from that of the early Ming. The population had grown significantly, farmers produced more grain than ever before on their smaller farms, both domestic and international trade were booming, and silver had become the preferred medium of exchange. What remained the same was that the fundamental source of wealth was a rural population that produced as much grain and textiles as possible and whose labor the state drew on for its army, for large construction and public works projects, and to supply a variety of goods and services.

Wars, famines, and epidemics had caused a population decline in the late Yuan. With order restored (and perhaps a warmer global climate and longer growing season), population rebounded and continued to grow in the Ming. Estimates based on the census, tax records, and other data suggest that the Ming Empire had a population of eighty-five million in 1380, rising to one hundred fifty-five million in 1500, and two hundred sixty million in 1600.³⁵

For most of the Ming period, this growing population could expand into thinly populated land, especially in the south and southwest. Farmers migrated willingly from more crowded and heavily taxed districts (especially in the lower Yangzi Valley) to frontier areas such as modern Hubei, Hunan, and Guangdong provinces and to resettle

depopulated land in Sichuan.³⁶ But by the last decades of the late Ming, population growth had begun to put a strain on the available arable land: the Ming was becoming a heavily populated place.³⁷

In general, though, more people meant more labor power. Farmers brought new fields into production and cultivated all their land more intensively than their ancestors had. As a result, they produced sixty percent more crops per *mou* (one-sixth of an English acre, or 650 sq m) of land than their Song counterparts.³⁸ Most of the gain in production was made when Ming farmers applied existing technology more intensively and consistently than ever before. Very few new tools or techniques were necessary.³⁹ New crops, however, did contribute to the gains in productivity. Sorghum became popular in northern China, both as an alternative grain food and for animal feed. New World crops—peanuts, maize, and sweet potatoes—were introduced during the Ming. Farmers readily adopted maize and sweet potatoes, both of them drought-resistant crops that did well in rocky upland soils.⁴⁰

The growing agricultural surplus was an engine driving the Ming market economy. Markets were, of course, nothing new. For most Ming farmers, marketing remained what it had been: an opportunity to exchange small amounts of surplus agricultural product for other goods or for copper cash. What was new about the Ming was an intensification of the market economy and a great increase in interregional trade. These developments were largely confined to the Yangzi and Huai River Valleys, the communities along the Grand Canal, and other areas, mostly in the east and southeast, which were either adjacent or had good transportation links to major urban markets.

In places that had access to transportation and markets, families could concentrate on growing crops or producing other goods for the market. Some planted a few cash crops alongside their staple food crop: sugar cane, fruit trees, vegetables, or (in the late Ming), tobacco. But when the circumstances were right, some farmers would devote most of their time and land to cash crops. Farmers in Shandong grew cotton, which merchants bought and shipped for sale to the weaving households of Jiangnan. Families on some mountain areas grew trees in response to a strong market demand for timber. Other families specialized in oil crops or dye crops, or in growing mulberry leaves to sell to households who specialized in silkworms. Huizhou, an Anhui town known for its poor soil, became famous for its wealthy merchants when a number of families abandoned farming in favor of trade. Jianyang, in northern Fujian, happened to have the right trees, bamboo, and other natural resources to make woodblocks and paper, and to have good transportation routes to the great cities of the lower Yangzi Valley: Jianyang had thus been a center for publishing and printing since the Song—a business that increased as the Ming elite, and the Ming examination system, stimulated the demand for books of all sorts.⁴¹

Urban consumer demand, especially in the mid- and late Ming, drove the development of textile, porcelain, incense, paper, and book production to new heights. Much of this production, and especially that of textiles, was performed by individual households. Merchants played a key role in making that possible. It was merchants who bought raw materials in numerous small market towns, transported them to major centers of production, and sold them to individual households that specialized in weaving or other crafts. It was merchants who bought the finished products and transported them to the great centers of consumption. Merchants re-invested their profits in more trade, in land, in moneylending, in educating their sons for the civil service examinations, and, of course, in luxurious lifestyles, fine furniture, art, comfortable houses, and lovely gardens.

A booming market economy required a reliable medium of exchange. Here we have a vivid demonstration of the limits of the Ming government power. The early Ming emperors issued small amounts of copper (actually bronze) cash. They preferred that the economy run on paper money, which the government issued at will and tried to force merchants to use. The paper money soon lost all its value to inflation: in the 1430s, it traded at one-thousandth of its nominal value.⁴² Merchants were understandably not willing to use it. Copper cash, unwieldy for large transactions, was in short supply. The Ming government minted only small amounts, and much of it was lost to foreign trade with Korea and Japan, both of which allowed the circulation of Chinese coins in their territories. The shortage of copper cash presented a great opportunity for counterfeiters: by the mid-Ming, most of the copper cash in circulation was probably counterfeit.⁴³

Because the government could not supply a reliable currency, merchants used silver ingots of a standard weight, which we translate as one tael (a little more than one ounce, or 37 g) as their preferred medium of exchange. These silver ingots were not government-issued currency, and thus did not have the drawbacks of money—arbitrarily set value, varying mixtures of silver and lesser metals, and government creation of money (and inflation) via the printing press. Silver was simply a commodity that was accepted as a unit of exchange. The actual value of silver varied with market demand.

At first, the imperial government prohibited the use of silver. When repeated bans failed to have any effect, and the paper currency lost its value, the government itself began to accept taxes in silver and to use silver to pay its

expenses. By the 1430s, silver was the preferred medium of exchange for all major transactions. As the Ming economy grew, and as the government not only accepted, but required, tax payments in silver, the demand for silver soared. As we will see in the next chapter, this presented a very profitable opportunity for Portuguese, Spanish, and Dutch merchants when they began trading New World silver for Chinese luxury goods in the 1500s.

While noting the strengths of the Ming economy, we should not ignore its limitations. The extent to which farmers were producing for the market varied tremendously across the empire. Some of the highly developed core areas of Jiangnan, with its extensive system of river and canal transportation, had so many families devoting so much land to the production of cash crops that Jiangnan, once a great exporter of rice, became a net rice importer, thus stimulating rice production in the new rice-export areas of Hubei, Hunan, and Guangdong. Land-poor areas such as Huizhou, in Anhui province, and parts of the mountainous Fujian province became famous for their merchants, as families realized that they could make far greater profits from trade than from the land.



This giraffe, painted by Shen Du in 1414, was brought from Africa to the Ming court by one of Zheng He's ships.

On the other hand, farming families in much, perhaps most, of the Ming Empire were only peripherally involved in the market economy: while they routinely exchanged goods in the nearest small market town, they had no opportunity to devote substantial amounts of land to production solely for the market. For most Ming farmers, life was still a matter of growing enough to survive and to pay taxes and, if they did not own their own land, rent. And for everyone, even the moderately well-off, life was precarious. The Ming economy produced tremendous wealth and supported a vibrant urban elite culture, but it rested on fragile environmental and political foundations.

Notes

1. Zhu Yuanzhang, "The Placard of People's Instructions," trans. in Edward L. Farmer, *Zhu Yuanzhang and Early Ming Legislation: The Reordering of Chinese Society Following the Era of Mongol Rule* (Leiden: Brill, 1995), 197.
2. Ibid.
3. Zhu Yuanzhang, "The Great Ming Commandment," trans. in Patricia Buckley Ebrey, ed., *Chinese Civilization: A Sourcebook*, 2nd ed. (New York: The Free Press, 1993), 207.

4. This periodization scheme and the trajectory of change that it implies (and which I describe in this and the next chapter) follow the work of Timothy Brook, *The Confusions of Pleasure: Commerce and Culture in Ming China* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1998). This, like all periodization schemes, is subject to discussion. Sarah Schneewind, for example, makes a strong case for a four-part division: early Ming (1368–1430), mid-Ming (1430–70), high Ming (1470–1530) and late Ming (1530–1644). See Sarah Schneewind, *Community Schools and the State in Ming China* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2006), 4.
5. On the uses, both positive and negative, of Zhu Yuanzhang's image and example, see the discussions in Sarah Schneewind, ed., *Long Live the Emperor! Uses of the Ming Founder Across Six Centuries of East Asian History* (Minneapolis: Society for Ming Studies, 2008). See also Wm. Theodore de Bary, *Waiting for the Dawn: A Plan for the Prince: A Study and Translation of Huang Tsung-hsi's Ming-i tai-fang lu* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1993); and Anita M. Andrew and John A. Rapp, eds., *Autocracy and China's Founding Emperors: Comparing Chairman Mao and Ming Taizu* (Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield, 2000).
6. This discussion of Zhu Yuanzhang and the rise of the Ming draws on John W. Dardess, *Confucianism and Autocracy: Professional Elites and the Founding of the Ming Dynasty* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1983); Edward L. Dreyer, *Early Ming China: A Political History 1355–1435* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1982); and Farmer, *Zhu Yuanzhang*.
7. Whether he had ever seriously held such beliefs in the first place is open to question.
8. Zhu's relations with the Confucian scholars of eastern Zhejiang are discussed in Dardess, *Confucianism and Autocracy*.
9. Albert Chan, *The Glory and Fall of the Ming Dynasty* (Norman: Oklahoma University Press, 1982), 12–3; Charles Hucker, "Ming Government," in Denis Twitchett and Frederick W. Mote, eds., *The Cambridge History of China, Vol. 8: The Ming Dynasty, 1368–1644, Part 2* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), 73–4.
0. Sarah Schneewind, "Visions and Revisions: Village Policies of the Ming Founder in Seven Phases," *T'oung Pao* LXXXVII (2001): 326.
1. Schneewind, *Community Schools*. Schneewind notes that in calling for the establishment of community schools, Zhu was again drawing on Yuan precedent—and that Zhu ultimately did not seem to have much interest in the schools.
2. Schneewind, "Visions and Revisions."
3. Zhang Kaizhi, ed. *Zhongguo lishi Yuan Ming Qing juan* (Chinese history: Yuan, Ming, and Qing volume) (Beijing: Gaodeng jiaoyu chubanshe, 2002), 120–2; John D. Langlois, Jr., "The Hung-wu Reign, 1368–1398," in Frederick W. Mote and Denis Twitchett, eds., *The Cambridge History of China, Vol. 7: The Ming Dynasty, 1368–1644, Part 1* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988), 139–42.
4. Hok-lam Chan, "The Chien-wen, Yunglo, Hung-hsi and Hsuan-te Reigns," in Mote and Twitchett, eds. *The Cambridge History of China, Vol. 7*, 185.
5. This section on the Yongle emperor draws on the following: Shih-Shan Henry Tsai, *Perpetual Happiness: The Ming Emperor Yongle* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 2001); and Hok-lam Chan, "The Chien-wen, Yung-le, Hunghsi and Hsuan-te Reigns."
6. Edward L. Dreyer, *Zheng He: China and the Oceans in the Early Ming Dynasty, 1405–1433* (New York: Pearson Longman, 2007), 33–4.
7. Tsai, *Perpetual Happiness*, 38; Louise Levathes, *When China Ruled the Seas: The Treasure Fleet of the Dragon Throne 1405–1433* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1994), 57–9.
8. Description of the voyages draws on Levathes, *When China Ruled the Seas*, and on Dreyer, *Zheng He*.
9. Dreyer, *Zheng He*, 29, 56, 86. Dreyer suggests that Zheng He's ships may have carried some gunpowder weapons, but finds no evidence that they were equipped with cannon.
0. Hok-lam Chan, "The Chien-wen, Yunglo, Hung-hsi and Hsuan-te Reigns," 276.
1. Tsai, *Perpetual Happiness*, 129–47.
2. Ibid., 133.
3. The number of administrative divisions, government personnel, and population fluctuated over the course of the dynasty. The figures presented here and below reflect the situation in the late Ming and are taken from Hucker,

- “Ming Government,” 10, 15, 29.
4. Hucker, “Ming Government,” 15.
 5. Tsai, *Perpetual Happiness*, 125–8; Yu Zhuoyun, *Palaces of the Forbidden City* (New York: Viking Press, 1984), 32.
 6. Susan Naquin, *Peking: Temples and City Life, 1400–1900* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2000), 249–50.
 7. Frederick Mote, “The Tumu Incident of 1449,” in Frank A. Kierman and John. K. Fairbank, eds., *Chinese Ways in Warfare* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1974), 243–72; Arthur Waldron, *The Great Wall of China: From History to Myth* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990), 88–90.
 8. For the debates and the history of the building of the Great Wall, see Waldron, *The Great Wall of China*.
 9. Waldron, *The Great Wall of China*, 194–226.
 0. Timothy Brook, “Communications and Commerce,” in Twitchett and Mote, eds., *The Cambridge History of China*, Vol. 8, 597–603.
 1. Jung-pang Lo, review of *Mingdai haiyun ji yunhe de yanjiu*, in *Journal of Asian Studies* 21.4 (August 1962): 541–2.
 2. Brook, “Communications and Commerce,” 602–3.
 3. Li Bozhong, “Was There a ‘Fourteenth-Century Turning Point’? Population, Land, Technology, and Farm Management,” in Paul Jakov Smith and Richard von Glahn, eds., *The Song-Yuan-Ming Transition in Chinese History* (Cambridge: Harvard University Asia Center, 2003), 175.
 4. Paul Jakov Smith, “Introduction: Problematizing the Song-Yuan-Ming Transition,” in Smith and von Glahn, eds., *The Song-Yuan-Ming Transition*, 22–3; Robert Hymes, unpublished paper on the plague in Chinese history, 21 (cited by permission).
 5. Martin Heijdra, “The Socio-Economic Development of Rural China During the Ming,” in Twitchett and Mote, eds., *The Cambridge History of China*, Vol. 8, 438–9.
 6. *Ibid.*, 434.
 7. *Ibid.*, 439.
 8. Li Bozhong, “Was There a ‘Fourteenth-Century Turning Point’?”, 170.
 9. Smith, “Introduction,” 11–12.
 0. Zhang, ed., *Zhongguo lishi Yuan Ming Qing juan*, 147–8.
 1. Lucille Chia, “*Mashaben*: Commercial Publishing in Jianyang from the Song to the Ming,” in Smith and von Glahn, eds., *The Song-Yuan-Ming Transition*, 287.
 2. Shih-Shan Henry Tsai, *The Eunuchs in the Ming Dynasty* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1996), 173.
 3. This and the following discussion of silver draws on Richard von Glahn, *Fountain of Fortune: Money and Monetary Policy in China, 1000–1700* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1996), 70–112.

The Mid- and Late Ming

Economic growth and commerce made the later years of the mid-Ming (1450–1550) and early decades of the late Ming (1550–1644) times of fabulous wealth and cultural creativity. Asian and European merchants regularly made the long, dangerous voyages from Korea, Japan, Southeast Asia, the Indian Ocean, Europe, and the Americas to cash in on the benefits of trade with the Great Ming. Within the empire, wealth changed the lives of urban and rural elites and even of many common folk. A growing market spurred production and innovation in the arts, entertainment, and literature.

Greater wealth and more comfortable lifestyles did not come without a price. Scholars, officials, and the imperial government still treasured ideals which they derived from the teachings of the Southern Song philosopher Zhu Xi (even when they contradicted those ideals in their own lives). In their imagination, the perfect society would be a stable hierarchy of four categories of person, ranked in order of their status, respectability, and economic value to the state: scholar-officials, farmers, artisans, and merchants.

In practice, the boundaries between these four categories of person and their real-life social, economic, and political status were quite different from the Neo-Confucian ideal. Merchants were often far wealthier and more influential than farmers, artisans, unemployed scholars, and even low or midranking officials. Men from merchant families became scholars and officials; men from scholar families became merchants. Scholars and officials invested in business enterprises, and everyone who had money invested in land.¹

Although the Ming elite enjoyed their more luxurious lifestyles, some of them found wealth disturbing because it undermined their moral vision of a simple, hierarchical agrarian society. However, the real danger facing the Ming dynasty was not a collapse of moral standards: it was the fragile economic basis and the inherent weakness of the Ming imperial state. In its last decades, the Ming Empire suffered from natural disasters. The imperial government's revenue declined while expenses increased annually. The despotic, but weak Ming court faced infighting and constant criticism from irate scholars and officials who accused their emperors, the eunuchs, and each other of moral bankruptcy and malfeasance. While officials, eunuchs, and emperors engaged in ruthless factional struggles, popular rebellions within and invasions from the newly arisen Manchus in the northeast stretched the Ming to the breaking point in the 1630s and early 1640s. Among those who witnessed the wealth and the weakness of the Ming were a newly arrived group of people: European traders and missionaries who had come in search of profits, and of souls.

Silver, Cannon, and Missionaries

Trade routes had linked Europe to the various Chinese states since at least the Han dynasty. Most of the trade was indirect, with goods passing through the hands of many merchants. During the Yuan dynasty, a few European merchants and papal envoys made their way to Yuan cities. These visitors from afar had no significant economic, cultural, or political impact. The elite men of the mid-Ming knew nothing of Europe, nor was there any reason that they should have.

Some Europeans, however, had very definite impressions of the East, including China. They knew that Muslim merchants dominated the lucrative trade in spices and other goods in the Indian Ocean. From Marco Polo's account, they knew that Yuan China was a wealthy and sophisticated place. In the margins of his copy of Polo's *Travels*, alongside a description of the Yuan capital, Christopher Columbus wrote: "*mercaciones innumerables*" ("incalculable amount of trade").²

The Portuguese were the first Europeans to sail directly to the Ming Empire in search of this "incalculable amount of trade." With their fast ships and superior cannon, they advanced up the East African coast, across the Indian

Ocean to India and Southeast Asia, occupying key port cities such as Kilwa, Goa, and Malacca along the way. In 1514, Portuguese merchants made the trip from Malacca to the south China coast. Here, they encountered a world very different from that of the Indian Ocean and Southeast Asia. The Ming Empire, with millions of subjects and heir to a long naval tradition, easily defeated the Portuguese in 1521 and 1522 when they tried to force their way into the port of Guangzhou with gunboats.³ Furthermore, the Ming emperors had a decidedly ambivalent attitude toward maritime trade. The emperors (other than Yongle) had always regarded maritime trade with suspicion. Beginning with the Hongwu emperor, the Ming had repeatedly limited, and sometimes absolutely prohibited, private maritime trade.

Chinese, Japanese, and even some Ming officials responded to Ming limits on private trade by becoming smugglers and pirates.⁴ Chinese and Japanese trading and pirate fleets (there was considerable overlap between these two categories) could be as large as tens or hundreds of armed ships. From the 1640s to the 1660s, pirates raided at will along the southern and southeast coasts and up the Yangzi River, attacking cities, towns, and villages and inflicting thousands of casualties in a single raid. The marauders were called “dwarf pirates” (“dwarf” being a disparaging name for Japanese), but they included many Chinese as well as Japanese men and ships. Clearly, the Ming imperial government could ban trade, repeatedly, and deploy its armies to defend against pirates, but trade and piracy continued nonetheless.

The Portuguese adapted well to this situation. At first, they traded illegally along the south China coast. In 1557, with the connivance of local Ming officials, they established a foothold at the port of Macao, not far from the major trading city of Guangzhou. Twenty years later, the Ming government allowed them to build a permanent trading post at Macao, but also built a wall across the neck of the peninsula to serve as a clear boundary between Ming civilization and the “barbarian” Portuguese.⁵

From the mid-1500s to the end of the Ming (and beyond) the Portuguese used Macao as their port for the China trade. Soon, they were joined by other European merchants. The Spanish made the Philippine port of Manila their base for the China trade in the early 1570s. From 1624 to 1663 the Dutch East India Company occupied the island of Taiwan, which the Ming had never administered and cared little about. Neither the Portuguese nor the other European merchants had any manufactures of their own to exchange for Chinese goods. They did, however, have a strong demand for silk, porcelain, tea, and other luxuries. The three most significant things that the Europeans brought to the Ming were silver, guns, and missionaries.

Silver was the only commodity that the Europeans had in large supply and for which the merchants of the Great Ming had an apparently insatiable demand. Silver ingots were an important medium of exchange in the large and growing Ming economy, but the Ming produced very little silver of its own. Consequently, the value of silver in relation to gold and other goods was higher in the Ming Empire than elsewhere around the world.

The great silver producers of the late 16th and 17th centuries were Japan and the Spanish colonies in the New World. The Americas were beyond the reach of Chinese ships, and the Ming emperors had banned trade with Japan. This presented European merchants with a wonderful opportunity. Portuguese ships sailed from Macao with loads of silk, gold, and other Chinese goods, traded them in Japan for silver, and then traded the silver for even more Chinese goods back in Macao or Guangzhou. The captain of a ship making the run from Macao to Japan and back could retire a rich man on the profits of a single voyage.⁶ The Spanish, the Dutch and, later, the English, exchanged New World silver for Chinese goods.

These exchanges of silver for Ming luxury goods became a major part of the emerging global economy. Historians estimate that as much as one-third or even one-half of all the silver mined in the Spanish colonies ended up in the Ming Empire from the mid-16th to the early 17th centuries.⁷ Foreign trade, driven by silver, had a significant effect on the Ming. Certain geographical areas (Guangdong, Fujian, and Zhejiang provinces) and industries (silk, porcelain, and tea) were deeply involved. As a result, some sectors of the Ming economy were closely tied to the emerging early modern global economy: they benefited from global trade, but they were also vulnerable to fluctuations in the global marketplace.

The second area in which Europeans influenced the Ming was through the import of European guns and cannon, and the techniques for manufacturing them. Chinese artisans had invented gunpowder. The Song, Khitan, Jurchen, and Mongols had put it to various military uses, but the Europeans had gone further than any other people in developing cannon and gun technology. As the Portuguese arrived along the south China coast, they brought with them the arquebus—a muzzle-loading matchlock gun—and various cannon, both muzzle- and breech-loaders. Mid-16th-century Ming officials and military leaders were favorably impressed with the new weapons and quickly incorporated them into the Ming arsenal. Portuguese instructors were hired to teach gunnery, gunsmithing, and

cannonmaking to Ming soldiers and craftsmen, and military manuals helped to circulate the new technology.⁸ The new gunpowder weapons did not fundamentally change the nature of warfare: there was no Ming “military revolution.” Instead, Ming generals simply incorporated the new weapons alongside the older, and still effective, bows, guns, and spears.⁹



Portrait of Matteo Ricci, a Jesuit missionary in the late Ming.

Along with silver and guns, the Portuguese brought Jesuit missionaries.¹⁰ The Jesuits set up missions in several major Ming cities, including Beijing, in hopes of converting incalculable numbers of souls to the Catholic faith. The best-known of these men are the Italian Matteo Ricci (1552–1610) and the German priest Adam Schall von Bell (1591–1666). Ricci came to Macao in 1582 and spent the rest of his life in the Ming Empire, receiving permission to reside in Beijing in 1601. Von Bell came to the Ming in 1619 and remained after 1644 to serve the new Qing rulers.

The Jesuit strategy for Christianizing China hinged on converting the elite (ideally, the imperial household itself): if the elite converted, the theory went, then the masses would follow. Accordingly, the Jesuit fathers spent a great deal of time and energy in building friendships and credibility with Confucian scholars, high-ranking Ming officials, and emperors. They learned the Chinese language and high culture, dressed like Confucian scholars, and taught European arts, science, and technology.

Many scholars, officials, and even emperors were quite willing to learn from the Jesuits. Ricci, von Bell, and others taught what the Ming gentlemen and officials found most interesting: mathematics, music, astronomy, geography, cartography, ballistics, and cannon-making. They also brought with them all manner of fascinating novelties, especially clocks, which proved quite popular. Ricci taught court eunuchs to play Western and Chinese tunes on clavichords and harpsichords.¹¹ Von Bell designed and supervised a foundry at which the Ming manufactured its own Portuguese-style cannon. The court employed Jesuits, notably von Bell, as court astronomers. Their predictions of eclipses and other astronomical events, and their calculations for the Ming calendar, were more accurate than those of the Chinese and Muslim court astronomers.

All of this activity was intended to further the Jesuit fathers’ ultimate goal: to convert the Ming rulers and subjects to the Roman Catholic religion. Some Ming gentlemen and women did adopt the new religion, including several high-ranking officials and generals. But just as Western guns and cannon did not fundamentally change Ming warfare, Jesuit science and technology did not fundamentally alter the Ming elite’s view of themselves, the world, or the universe. The Ming elite accepted what was useful to them and incorporated it into their own worldview. The Jesuits’ religious teachings seemed the least useful of the many things that the fathers had to offer.

Orthodoxy and Heterodoxy

The Jesuit fathers could be welcomed and employed, yet make little progress in winning converts to their religion,

because the emperors, officials, scholars, merchants, and ordinary folk had their own strong sense of religious truth and moral standards. The state-sanctioned orthodoxy included the scholarly Neo-Confucian tradition and an eclectic mix of religions: Chinese and Tibetan Buddhism, Daoism, and Islam, as well as popular belief in a variety of gods, spirits, and ghosts. State-sanctioned or “orthodox” philosophy and religion existed alongside a variety of heterodox beliefs and practices.

Through government policies, peer pressure, and popular practice, the Ming state, elites, and commoners defined orthodoxy and heterodoxy in the context of strong pressure for conformity in ritual and spiritual matters. The “Confucianization of Chinese society” which we saw under way in the Song and Yuan periods continued stronger than ever. Under Zhu Yuanzhang and his heirs, “Confucianization” acquired a new connotation: strong emphasis on Han Chinese cultural identity and rejection of the Central Asian, and especially Mongol, component of what had been a multi-ethnic empire.

For example, Muslims, part of Chinese society since the Tang, further assimilated to Han Chinese custom. They adopted customs, clothing, surnames, and lifestyles closer to those of the Han majority.¹² Mosques, which had already, in the Song dynasty, begun to lose some of their Central Asian–Middle Eastern architectural features, incorporated more and more Chinese architectural motifs so that they closely resembled Chinese temples from the outside, while retaining the prayer hall, oriented toward Mecca, within.¹³ In the southwest, indigenous people such as the Hmong (whom the Han people called Miao) were increasingly forced to adopt the basic elements of Han culture: sedentary agriculture, submission to the imperial administrative system, and the Han Chinese language.

State-sanctioned orthodoxy supplied the moral standards and defined a schedule of ceremonial observances that gave structure and meaning to each year and to each lifetime. Emperors (if they were conscientious) observed a rigorous annual schedule of daily court audiences, annual sacrifices to Heaven and Earth, plowing and harvesting ceremonies, and many other major and minor rituals. The year of the average Ming subject was punctuated by regular ceremonies in honor of the family ancestors, Buddhist holidays such as the Ghost Festival, and Confucian observances like the mid-summer festival in honor of the poet, official, and Confucian martyr Qu Yuan. Major turning points in life—coming of age, passing the examinations, official appointment, marriage, birth of children, and the deaths of relatives—were marked by Confucian ritual. Superstitions indicated auspicious and inauspicious days for a variety of tasks and events, from marriage to embarking on a journey.

From emperors to scholars to common farmers, the people of the Ming held an eclectic set of popular religious beliefs. Naturally, there were exceptions, and various individuals held various sets or subsets of beliefs. In general, however, the Ming people believed in reincarnation, in the spirits of their ancestors, in various Buddhas, bodhisattvas, Daoist transients, local city and earth gods, the Stove God (a symbol of the household who reported the family’s doings annually to the Jade Emperor in Heaven), and a Heavenly hierarchy of gods that reflected the bureaucratic hierarchy of the emperor.

They believed that this broad variety of gods and spirits took an active interest in their daily lives and could intercede, for better or worse, in human affairs, the weather, and the success or failure of their crops. Worship of gods and spirits rose and fell in popularity to the extent that the gods and spirits were recognized as being efficacious. If “word on the street” was that a god enshrined at a particular temple had answered prayers or performed miracles, then business at that temple would pick up considerably as new petitioners, hoping for celestial favor, came with their offerings.

Although it is generally called a philosophy, Neo-Confucianism itself had a strong religious aspect. Neo-Confucian thinkers understood moral truth as a manifestation of Heaven and an innate part of human nature. In an ideal world, each individual would express that innate moral nature in the family, society, and world through his or her actions: correct and heartfelt performance of ritual, practice of benevolence, and proper fulfillment of one’s assigned roles in family and society. To do so was in itself an act whereby one found religious meaning “within a human community rather than by gaining access to a separate ‘sacred’ realm.”¹⁴

The concepts of filial piety and female chastity were central to the moral and religious beliefs of the Ming. Filial piety required passionate devotion to and reverence for one’s parents and ancestors and, by extension and analogy, to one’s elders, teachers, social superiors, and to the emperor and the imperial clan. For men, filial piety in the family was paralleled by reverence for the emperor. Officials, in particular, were expected to show supreme and unwavering loyalty to the imperial house, which had supported them (and perhaps their ancestors as well) with employment and its prerogatives.

The loyalty that an official owed to the emperor was often compared to the loyalty that a woman owed to her husband as expressed in the ideal of female chastity. Female chastity implied a fierce, self-sacrificing devotion to

family and husband—a single-minded devotion that must, if necessary, be proved through suicide.¹⁵ Ideally, a woman was to remain loyal to one man, honoring and caring for his parents and bearing and raising children, particularly sons who would carry on the family line. Under ideal circumstances, a woman whose loyalty to her husband was threatened or compromised, for instance by rape or by pressure to remarry when widowed, would nobly resist and remain “chaste,” if necessary by committing ritual suicide. Women who did so were regarded as heroines and role models. The imperial government regularly honored loyal widows with plaques and stipends, and recognized women who had committed ritual suicide by erecting memorial archways in their communities. Between 1368 and 1644, the Ming government honored over forty-thousand female suicides.¹⁶

The cult of female chastity was part of a Ming trend in which the roles of women in family, society, and economy were more narrowly constricted than had been the case in the Tang and Song periods. The changes are particularly clear in the matter of inheritance. In the Song, daughters had been able to inherit land from their fathers. The Yuan ended this practice, preferring a more strict patrilinealism in order to guarantee the continued existence of military households with land to support them. The Ming followed the Yuan example, not out of concern for maintaining hereditary military households, but because the Ming state regarded a stable patrilineal system as a social and moral good. Similarly, Ming law reduced the family authority of widows and limited the possibility of widow remarriage. In each case, increased legal restrictions on women were derived from Yuan dynasty practice but were legitimized in terms of ostensibly “Han” Chinese moral principles.¹⁷

Foot-binding, a physical restriction on women’s mobility, also became widely popular during the Ming. The origins of the custom are obscure, but it had certainly become popular at the court of the Northern Song. The Mongols further encouraged the practice. From the Yuan through the Ming, foot-binding spread throughout the country, and from the elite to the lower classes.¹⁸ Mothers would use long strips of specially woven cloth to bind their daughters’ feet tightly, beginning at the age of five or six. The result was a deformed, but very small foot, which both men and women considered to be the height of beauty. In the Ming, the ideal was for the foot to be about 3 inches (8 cm) in length. Foot-binding was an essential part of the process of preparing a young woman to play her prescribed roles within the patrilineal household.¹⁹

Both female chastity and filial piety involved loyalty to one’s generational and social superiors and proper performance of one’s roles in the hierarchies of family, society, and state. Males and females, youth and elders, all had their prescribed roles to play. How could one know what was expected? How were moral norms and ritual expectations communicated? Elite men absorbed the Neo-Confucian orthodoxy as they studied for the civil service examinations. Neo-Confucianism did not, however, remain an affair of the elite. Ming scholars wrote revised versions of Zhu Xi’s manual of family ritual, simplified and adapted to the needs of common families of their own time. They sometimes incorporated customs and practices that had not been a part of the original Confucian rituals.²⁰ Primers, literature, popular encyclopedias, and morality books all helped to transmit Neo-Confucian expectations of filial piety, female chastity, and correct performance of ritual to a wide audience.²¹

Orthodoxy is always defined in relation to heterodoxy. Ming subjects were expected to conform to ritual, moral, and religious orthodoxy, but they often failed to do so. More widowed women remarried than committed ritual suicide, and men, even emperors, regularly violated ritual norms. The Zhengde emperor was far more concerned with drinking and Daoist medicines of immortality than in rectitude and ritual. The Wanli emperor completely ignored his ritual and political responsibilities for some twenty years. The Tianqi emperor devoted himself to carpentry (at which he was not very good), and referred questions of state to his eunuchs.

The imperial government fought a constant battle against heterodoxy of all sorts. The state sanctioned the Zhu Xi school of Neo-Confucianism—which made all other interpretations of the Confucian classics suspicious at best. The imperial government also regulated the activities and teachings of Buddhism and Daoism in order to prevent them from becoming independent and possibly disruptive forces. Both were economically hobbled and intellectually subordinate to Confucianism. The government tried to control popular religion by incorporating local gods into a hierarchical empirewide pantheon.

In practice, the struggle against heterodoxy was a losing battle. The overextended Ming bureaucracy could not micro-manage society. Lay Buddhist organizations and popular religious movements like the “Three-in-One Religion” (which combined Confucianism, Buddhism, and Daoism) developed independently, especially in the heavily populated and culturally vibrant Jiangnan region.²²

Most of these local religious movements posed no threat to social or political order. But occasionally, the worship of local gods or Buddhist or Daoist deities took on strong political overtones. A variety of religious leaders collectively referred to as preachers of the White Lotus sect, for example, taught reverence for an “Eternal Mother”

who had created the world. Some White Lotus leaders claimed that the end of a cosmic era was approaching and that the followers of the true (White Lotus) teaching must overthrow the government to usher in a new era of peace. Although prohibited, the White Lotus teachings remained a stubborn subcurrent of popular religion in the Ming and Qing dynasties.

High Culture and Cheap Entertainment

With a more commercial economy and a larger literate population than ever before, the 16th-century Ming saw a growing market for entertainment. Village communities, temples, and market-town and city theaters staged dramas for audiences of farmers, urban workers, and merchants, as well as scholars. Plays explored a wide variety of themes: morally uplifting stories of loyal subjects, honest officials, filial sons, and chaste wives, and thrilling (but not quite as morally charged) tales of romantic love, martial heroes, and the supernatural. Rural elites organized theatrical performances in the rural areas, which consequently tended toward the morally didactic themes. Theatrical performances in the market towns and cities were more likely to address themes that the elite and the state might find less healthy.²³

The publishing industry, too, catered to a growing number of literate, but not highly educated commoners as well as men and women of scholar families. Cheap woodblock editions of primers, almanacs, encyclopedias, morality books, and manuals of Confucian ritual helped to spur a recovery of the publishing business, which had languished during the first half of the Ming.²⁴ Morality books told stories showing how virtuous conduct is rewarded and evildoing is punished in a framework that combined Daoist and Confucian moral precepts with a scheme of retribution derived from the Buddhist concept of karma.

Some morality books, called “ledgers of merit and demerit,” included lists of virtuous and unvirtuous behavior with points assigned: one hundred points for ensuring the fidelity of a woman, for instance, or one point for giving a meal to a hungry person.²⁵ With such a ledger, an individual could use simple bookkeeping methods to track his or her behavior and keep a quantitative moral “balance sheet.” Morality books, encyclopedias, primers, and the like were popular in both elite and commoner households. They played an important role in building a more uniform, shared Confucian cultural identity that cut across the boundaries of class and region but that, overall, represented the transmission of elite values to common folk.²⁶

Cultural influence was not all one way. The tales of the popular storytellers who entertained common villagers and townsfolk with tales based loosely on historical events and personalities were crucial in the development of a new form of elite literature: the Chinese classic novel. The four most famous Ming novels are the *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*, *The Water Margin*, *Journey to the West*, and *Jin Ping Mei*.²⁷ These works, written in the vernacular language, were popular chiefly among the elite.

The *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*, *The Water Margin*, and *Journey to the West* grew out of popular stories and dramas, eventually taking their current form in the Ming.²⁸ The *Three Kingdoms*, written as though it were a history, tells the tale of the Three Kingdoms period, with emphasis on the complex relationships between Cao Cao, Sun Chuan, and Liu Bei. *The Water Margin*, set in the Song dynasty, recounts the adventures of a gang of outlaws. The hero, a low-ranking official named Song Jiang, is “driven to Liang Mountain” in Shandong province by corrupt superiors. He and the other martial outlaw heroes who haunt the marshes around Liang Mountain fight each other, rival bandits, and the Song government, but their ultimate loyalty is to the emperor who, like so many emperors, is portrayed as being misled by the corrupt officials around him. Song Jiang leads his comrades to make peace with the government, and they then do their best to serve the emperor by fighting various rebels and the Khitan Liao.

Both the *Romance of the Three Kingdoms* and *The Water Margin* portray martial heroes whose values include loyalty to friends, loyalty to the emperor, condemnation of corrupt officials, and gargantuan appetites for food, drink, and fighting. By contrast, the *Journey to the West* claims to tell the story of the Tang monk Xuanzang and his journey to India in search of Buddhist sutras. The novel, however, makes no pretense to historical accuracy. It is a Buddhist allegory in which fantastic characters—the mischievous monkey Sun Wukong, a voracious monk with the head (and appetite) of a pig, and others—accompany a clueless and finicky Xuanzang on a journey that involves dangers from a variety of monsters and demons. Sun Wukong, the irrepressible monkey, emerges as the hero of the story, with his bravery, his magical powers (including the ability to change into virtually any shape or form), and his unflinching sense of humor.

The fourth great Ming novel, *Jin Ping Mei*, was written in the 16th century.²⁹ The novel describes the lives and

relationships of a fictional Ming gentleman named Ximen Qing, his five wives, concubines, and various lovers. The author combines enthusiastic descriptions of sex, food, and vicious scheming with a thoroughly Confucian/Daoist/Buddhist moral: overindulgence (particularly sexual overindulgence) and selfish scheming will inevitably meet with punishment in this life and the next. Modern readers value the book most, not for its moral lesson, but its rich descriptions of everyday life in an elite household of the late Ming.

Men and women like the fictional Ximen Qing and his household were the product of economic growth. Elite families, the imperial court, and even overseas markets provided a growing demand for luxury goods. The anonymous craftsmen of the huge state-owned and private kilns in Jiangxi province's Jingdezhen turned out cartloads and boatloads of porcelain, particularly the stereotypical Ming "blue-and-white," which is highly valued by collectors and museums today. The same patterns of consumption spurred the beginning of the "golden age" of Chinese furniture in the mid-1500s.³⁰

Ming gentlemen did not collect contemporary porcelain or furniture: they were, however, connoisseurs of Song porcelain, ancient bronzes, calligraphy, paintings, and other antiques. The nouveaux riches, often merchants who aspired to scholar-official social status, could purchase handbooks to learn the basics of taste and discrimination, lest they make fools of themselves or be cheated by clever craftsmen selling fakes and forgeries.³¹ Wealthy Ming scholars and merchants also designed and built urban gardens, carefully landscaped retreats in which oddly-shaped rocks (often purchased at great expense), trees, ponds, and pagodas were carefully arranged to give the illusion of a Daoist paradise.

Wealthy Ming gentlemen played at being Daoist hermits in their "rustic" gardens, but even in their enjoyment and practice of the fine arts, they were part of a changing, more commercialized, and more opulent 16th-century world. Though some resisted it, and some lamented it, the power of the market had eroded the distinctions between high and low, amateur and professional.

Those distinctions did still exist, especially in the minds of the scholar elite. No one, for example, would have regarded mass-produced, hand-colored woodblock prints of Buddhist deities as high art. Such things were cheap decorations for the houses of ordinary people.³² There were, too, professional artists whom the literati could look down upon. The Ming court employed professional painters, often giving them sinecure appointments in the Embroidered Uniform Guard. In cities, independent professional artists produced work for wealthy patrons or for direct sale on the market. Most professional artists were anonymous, many of them the men and women of multigenerational families of professional artists. A few earned substantial reputations. Qiu Ying (c. 1494–c. 1552) worked largely on commission for wealthy literati customers, and was famous enough that Qiu Ying fakes were marketed even in his lifetime. His daughter, Miss Qiu (active c. 1550–80), followed her father's style in landscape and figure painting, but she is particularly famous for her portrayals of Guanyin, the female Bodhisattva of Mercy.³³

Ming scholars and officials patronized professional artists like Qiu Ying and Miss Qiu, but did not consider them as equals. It was the wealthy literati of Jiangnan (the portion of Jiangsu province that lies south of the Yangzi and the adjoining province of Zhejiang), with their dominance of the intellectual world, their buying power, and their artistic production itself, who set the aesthetic standards of the Ming elite. As they had since the Song, literati painters cultivated a style of carefree amateurism. Educated men produced paintings and calligraphy on social occasions and for presentation as gifts to friends. Women of scholar-official families also painted, some of them being recognized for the high quality of their work by their female and male contemporaries alike. Courtesans, too, painted—some because they were very good at it, others because painting was one of the skills that they used to make themselves agreeable and intellectually interesting companions to the elite men who were their customers.³⁴

The painter and calligrapher Dong Qichang (1555–1636) articulated the difference between amateur and professional in theoretical terms. Dong argued that two styles of painting had competed since the Tang: the "Northern School" and the "Southern School." By "Northern School," Dong meant painting that emphasized craftsmanlike professionalism, with results that he compared to the Northern School of Chan Buddhism and its gradualist approach to enlightenment—no real enlightenment at all, in his opinion. By the "Southern School," Dong meant painters who took the individualistic creative approach of the amateur, with results that he likened to the "sudden enlightenment" of the Southern School of Chan—a sudden flash of realization of one's identity with the universe.³⁵

Dong's theory reflected his ideals, and was tremendously influential: later generations of Chinese artists and Chinese and foreign art historians viewed the development of Chinese painting and calligraphy through Dong's binary "scholar-amateur vs. professional" formula. In fact, neither the work of the past nor of Dong Qichang's time fit this scheme with all its moral connotations. Some professional painters of the late Ming painted in the carefree,

individualistic style typically associated with scholars. Men and women of scholar families were known to sell their work for money. Even paintings and calligraphy originally produced as gifts for close personal friends sooner or later ended up as commodities in the art marketplace. With the publication of painting handbooks like *Master Gu's Pictorial Album* (1603) or *Ten Bamboo Studio Manual* (1633), professionals and amateurs alike could imitate the Song and Yuan scholar-painters, whose individualistic, quirky styles now became hackneyed orthodoxy.



Dong Qichang's "Wanlun Thatched Hall." Hanging scroll, ink on paper. Ming dynasty.

Some late Ming gentlemen expressed deep concern, even outrage, about the extent to which their society had, in their eyes, fallen from the exemplary simplicity and order of the early Ming to the commoditized, luxury-loving place of their own time. There was more than a little of the armchair historian's idealization of the past in the writing of men who criticized the way their peers rushed pell-mell in search of profit or who lamented that "the poor cannot stand up to the rich who, though few in number, are able to control the majority. The lord of silver rules heaven and the god of copper cash reigns over earth."³⁶ Nonetheless, we cannot entirely dismiss the views of the perceptive gentlemen late Ming: their country was very different in 1600 than it had been in 1368 or 1500. The wealth and sophistication of the Ming were unmatched in the world and the object of admiration and imitation throughout East Asia.

At the same time, the Ming government would be hard-pressed to deal effectively with any serious challenge, whether external or internal. The heart of the problem was a brutal factionalism that the late Ming emperors—uniformly untalented men—completely failed to control. The main actors in this drama were the usual suspects: scholars and eunuchs.

Scholars, Eunuchs, and Cutthroat Politics

The Ming emperors relied on scholars and eunuchs to administer the affairs of the realm. Scholars, chosen by competitive examination, filled the ranks of the bureaucracy. Eunuchs, recruited from among the poor, the criminal, and prisoners of war, served the emperors as household slaves. In a despotic political system, the power and the status of both eunuchs and scholar-officials was derived from the person of the emperor himself: whoever controlled the emperor's mind and body controlled the imperial government. Scholars (both in and out of office) and eunuchs formed factions. Each faction sought to further its political agenda and self-interest by gaining access to or control over the emperor. The fact that the last four Ming emperors were overwhelmingly incompetent (but still violent and short-tempered) men who often took little or no interest in matters of government made factional struggle all the more serious and dangerous.

Most scholars simply did whatever was required to make progress in their careers: write essays in the correct style

(or memorize other men's essays and reproduce them on the examination), make the right friends, and use public office to enrich themselves. Nonetheless, the Ming did produce Confucian scholars and officials who criticized the examination system, the government, their superiors, and their emperors. Some men rejected the orthodox Zhu Xi school of Neo-Confucianism. Making criticisms or expressing unorthodox opinions was a dangerous game: it could lead to demotion, exile to the frontiers, vicious beatings, or execution. But Confucian morality taught men to speak up for truth, for justice, and on behalf of the common people, or at least to phrase their political rhetoric in those moralistic and unselfish terms.

The most influential heterodox Confucian philosopher of the Ming was the general and statesman Wang Yangming (1472–1529). Wang had a career as a successful scholar and official. At the age of thirty-seven, while out of favor at court and assigned to a remote district in the southwest, he experienced a sudden flash of enlightenment.³⁷ The Zhu Xi Neo-Confucianism that he had studied taught that people should seek to understand the moral principle underlying the universe by observing and studying “things” in the world around them: nature, Confucian texts, histories, and so on. Wang now realized that if Principle pervades everything, then one's own mind is a manifestation of that same moral principle: one need, then, only look within one's own mind to discover the truth.

Wang Yangming's understanding of Principle and Mind was essentially the same as that of Zhu Xi's contemporary and intellectual rival, Lu Xiangshan. Wang revived and reinvigorated Lu's emphasis on the identity of Principle and one's own Mind. He argued that all people, even the most ordinary farmers and laborers, have “innate knowledge” of moral Principle. By looking within, anyone can understand Principle: to act in accordance with Principle, one need only act spontaneously on the basis of one's inner realization. Wang placed special emphasis on action: you do not really understand an abstract concept such as filial piety, moral principle, female chastity, or reverence for one's ruler unless you act on it. Without action, there is, Wang said, no knowledge.

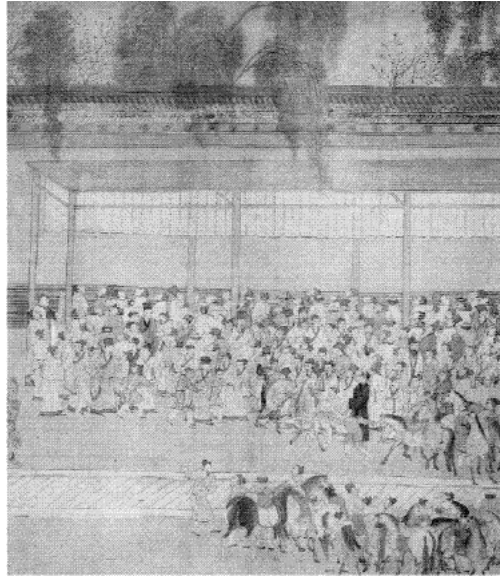
Wang Yangming himself was a conservative man. He firmly believed that if one truly understood and acted on one's “innate knowledge,” then one's actions would invariably be in accord with the moral expectations laid forth in standard Confucian texts. In practice, though, the ideas of “innate knowledge” and spontaneous action opened the door to moral relativism and eccentric behavior. Some of Wang Yangming's students and later self-described followers argued that to understand “innate knowledge” requires “neither study nor deliberation, as the Heavenly is what comes naturally.” Others stressed that “all men are sages” and emphasized the need to act decisively on one's “innate knowledge,” particularly when it came to correcting one's superiors and one's ruler.³⁸

Critics in the late Ming and Qing charged that Chan (Zen) Buddhism had adversely affected the thinking of Wang Yangming and his followers. Certainly, the Chan concepts of “sudden enlightenment” and the “universal Buddha spirit” did influence the Wang Yangming school. The career of Li Zhi (1527–1602) demonstrates the way in which the intellectual legacy of Wang Yangming could be combined with Buddhism in such a way as to appear a threat to Ming society.

Li Zhi was a man from Fujian province.³⁹ He had a moderately successful career as a low-ranking official and then retired early, in 1580, to “pursue the Way.” Rather than return home and shoulder the burdens of family and society, as a scholar should, Li settled at a private Buddhist temple owned by some friends in Hubei province. There, he put into practice the ideal of acting naturally and spontaneously. For Li Zhi, this involved dallying with prostitutes, shaving his head like a Buddhist monk (but continuing to wear Confucian robes), and writing books in which he lambasted Confucian morality and official hypocrisy in general, and in which he made personal attacks on a leading member of the community in which he was living.

In everything that he did, Li Zhi made powerful enemies and gave them ample ground on which to denounce him to the emperor as a man whose negative example was causing a widespread decline in public morality. The charges grossly exaggerated Li Zhi's influence (though many scholars did find his books amusing). Nonetheless, the Wanli emperor had Li Zhi arrested on charges of publishing perverted and seditious interpretations of history, consorting with prostitutes, and undermining the morals of women of good family. In a last act of resistance, Li committed suicide in prison.

Men like Li Zhi impress us with their eccentricity, but they posed no real danger to the Ming dynasty. It was men who spoke from the most orthodox Confucian moral and philosophical points of view who presented the gravest threat to their opponents within the government: rival scholarly factions, eunuchs, and the emperors themselves. The most significant examples were the official Hai Rui (1513–1587) and a group of scholars and officials known as the “Donglin Party” (active during the first thirty years of the 1600s).



Students awaiting the results of the civil service examination, as painted by the Ming artist Qiu Ying around 1540.

Hai Rui, a man who had achieved only the second degree in the examination system, served for many years in low-ranking posts.⁴⁰ He acquired a reputation for living only on his salary (highly unusual in an official), maintaining an almost impossibly austere lifestyle, and deciding law cases that involved money or land in favor of poor commoners. He also made a point of publicly holding others to the same strict standards of morality and austerity. He often found reason to criticize his peers and his superiors when they failed to live up to his expectations.

Hai Rui might have spent his life as a minor official. But when one of the powerful men at court whom he had criticized fell from power in a factional struggle, Hai found himself suddenly promoted to a high-ranking position in Beijing. Here, he had ample opportunity to observe the corruption and incompetence of the imperial court and the virtual absence of the Jiajing emperor, who preferred to spend his time trying to achieve immortality by practicing various Daoist arts.

What he saw at court was more than Hai Rui could stomach. He wrote a strongly worded memorial blaming the Jiajing emperor for all the many problems allegedly facing the realm: poverty, immorality, corruption, banditry, and high taxes. Scolding the emperor for being a failure as a man and as a ruler, he said: “It has already been some time since the people under Heaven started to regard your majesty as unworthy.”⁴¹ Shocked by such straightforward criticism, the emperor hesitated for months before having Hai Rui thrown in prison to await execution. Execution never came: the Jiajing emperor died in 1566. Hai Rui was pardoned and released.

Hai Rui had earned a lasting reputation. Even today, he stands as a potent symbol of moral rectitude, concern for the suffering common folk, and fearless criticism of corrupt, incompetent despotism. But in practice, Hai Rui’s belief that complex administrative and economic problems could be solved by demanding that everyone practice strict Confucian morality was a failure. As he botched one assignment after another, his peers and the new Longqing emperor accorded Hai Rui the greatest of respect while pushing him into meaningless jobs (where he could do little harm) and then into retirement. When he died, the emperor honored him with the epithet “Loyal and Incorruptible.”⁴²

For all his long-term significance as a symbol, Hai Rui was a solitary man. Like the troublesome Li Zhi, he was easily shunted aside. With the Donglin Party, we have a group of men who, for better or worse, were active in Ming court politics for decades. They, too, have acquired an enviable historical reputation as moral exemplars, particularly because they clashed with (and many were executed by) the powerful court eunuch Wei Zhongxian.

“Donglin Party” was a name given by their enemies to scholars and officials loosely identified with a private Confucian school in Wuxi (Anhui province) called the Donglin Academy. Re-opened in 1604 by a former imperial official, the Donglin Academy attracted well-known scholars and many less famous men who visited briefly to take part in discussions and social gatherings. Soon, Donglin became the center of a wide-reaching network of more-or-

less like-minded scholars, both in and out of office, most of them from Anhui province.⁴³

For the Donglin men, everything revolved around filial piety. Their particular interpretation and application of the ideals of filial piety to real political situations led them into conflict with other officials and with Ming emperors. For example, the Donglin men strongly suspected that the Wanli emperor was trying to demote his heir apparent (the eldest son of his empress) in order to put the son of his favorite concubine in line to inherit the throne—a major violation of the principles of filial piety and family hierarchy. So when a lone man with a stick attacked the heir-apparent's palace on 30 May 1615, Donglin officials argued that it was an attempted assassination and demanded wideranging enquiries and arrests. Their opponents argued that the “man with the stick” was mentally ill and not part of any plot whatsoever. In this and several other cases involving the affairs of the imperial family, succession, and control of the person of the emperor, Donglin men presented themselves as defenders of loyalty, filial piety, and respect for the imperial institution.

Donglin men moved in and out of powerful positions at court during the late Wanli (r. 1572–1600), Taichang (r. 1620), and Tianqi (r. 1620–1627) years. They maintained that the key to a reversal of dynastic fortunes lay in the restoration of virtuous behavior and virtuous men. Their opponents, too, presented themselves as defenders of morality. During the short (one month) Taichang reign, Donglin men had been brought back to court and seemed to be in a position to take a leading role in government. However, their downfall was at hand. The Tianqi emperor proved to be both stupid and uninterested in government. He entrusted virtually all decision-making to his favorite eunuch, Wei Zhongxian.

Wei, a street-tough from Beijing, had submitted to castration (for reasons unknown) and entered the court as a eunuch. He had served the Tianqi emperor for years. Wei, though illiterate, was clearly an intelligent and very ambitious man. Like many others (eunuch, official, empress, or concubine) who had controlled emperors in the past, Wei appointed personal friends to key positions, built networks of support, punished his enemies, and generally gathered to himself as much wealth and power as he could. Of course, he was quite jealous of the emperor's affection and ruthless to anyone who threatened to undermine his relationship with his sovereign.

The Donglin men, like their predecessor Hai Rui, were driven to denounce whatever they regarded as immoral, unfilial behavior on the part of the emperor or anyone around him. A leading Donglin activist and highranking official composed a memorial denouncing Wei Zhongxian's “Twenty-Four Crimes.” The Tianqi emperor stood by his faithful (though truly corrupt) eunuch. As a result, Wei Zhongxian acquired the power to carry out a series of brutal investigations, arrests, tortures, and executions of scholars and officials of the “Donglin Party.” Scholars and officials from rival factions enthusiastically assisted Wei Zhongxian in pursuing alleged misdeeds of the Donglin men.

When the Tianqi emperor died, Wei Zhongxian's career came to an end. First one, then many officials wrote memorials to the new Chongzhen emperor, denouncing Wei for crimes and corruption. Facing the wrath of the emperor and with nowhere to flee, Wei Zhongxian committed suicide on 14 December 1627. Wei's death did not mean that the Ming court could return to any semblance of health and efficiency. The court continued to be wracked by factional struggle. The atmosphere was so thoroughly poisoned that the Chongzhen emperor simply did not trust any of his officials. It was an utterly incompetent Ming imperial government that tried to deal with the very serious challenges of the first part of the 17th century. It is little wonder that it failed.

Crisis and Collapse

The Ming dynasty ended in 1644. Confucian scholars at the time and afterward blamed the disaster on imperial misbehavior, society-wide indulgence in luxury, and a general decline in public and private morality. Truly, worthless emperors, greedy eunuchs, and a corrupt, faction-ridden bureaucracy were among the many problems of the last decades of the Ming. At the same time, a booming economy had made it possible for emperors, officials, scholars, merchants, wealthy landowning families, and even rich farmers to enjoy more comfort and luxury than ever before in Chinese history. Nonetheless, moral explanations for imperial decline leave far too much unaccounted for.

In order to understand the process and the causes of the Ming collapse we need to look at a number of factors: the global and domestic economies, taxation and land distribution, climate, natural disasters, external threats, and internal rebellions. As we observe the relative importance of and relationships among these various factors, we may get a clearer picture of how and why, after over two hundred fifty years in power, Zhu Yuanzhang's heirs were

finally overthrown. However, there remain a number of issues on which historians are in fundamental disagreement.

The first such issue has to do with the effects of global trade. The 17th-century Ming Empire, particularly its most economically advanced areas such as the southern and southeast coasts and the lower Yangzi Valley, were part of the global trade network that linked Europe, the Americas, South Asia, Southeast Asia, and East Asia. This global trading system experienced some setbacks in the 17th century. Production of silver at Spanish mines in Peru declined. The English and Dutch preyed on Spanish ships headed for Manila, and the Spanish government tried to limit trade with the Ming.⁴⁴ Some historians argue that this caused a decline in silver shipments to East Asia, which in turn led to a downturn of the Ming economy from the 1620s through the 1640s.⁴⁵ Other historians find that there was no “sudden diminution of silver imports during the last years of Ming rule.”⁴⁶

Historians also disagree on the significance of taxation and land distribution as causes of the Ming collapse. It was popular rebellions that fatally weakened and then overthrew the Ming government in Beijing. Some historians suggest that oppressively high taxes and a high concentration of land ownership led to rural impoverishment and severe social stratification, which, in turn, sparked and fed the rebellions.⁴⁷ Others argue that taxes were actually quite low and that while the imperial house, Zhu Yuanzhang’s many princely descendants, and some wealthy families did own large estates, most land, even land that was rented to tenants, seems to have been the property of small landholders.⁴⁸ If this is the case, then the real problems of 17th-century Ming economy and government had more to do with an inefficient tax system and natural disasters than with overtaxation and concentration of land ownership.

When Zhu Yuanzhang and the Yongle emperor built the basic institutions of Ming government, they wanted to prevent the emergence of regional strongmen. They were keenly aware that the Han, Tang, and Yuan dynasties had broken up when regional governors and/or commanders acquired enough power to challenge the central government and each other. The Ming founders and their heirs wanted to avoid this fate. They also wanted to demonstrate humane government by setting tax rates at low levels and periodically waiving back taxes owed to the government. As a result, the empire as a whole was very lightly taxed.⁴⁹

Although taxes were light on average, the system for collecting and disbursing taxes was incredibly complicated and inefficient. Most tax revenue was retained to pay for expenses where it was collected, at the county level. Some revenues in grain, in silver, or in kind were sent directly to designated military units on the borders, to the imperial government in Beijing, or elsewhere. Officials used complex and often inconsistent rates when converting between piculs of grain, taels of silver, copper cash, paper money, and other goods. The government applied surcharges, transportation charges, tax increases, tax reductions, and tax waivers often, inconsistently, and in accordance with mathematical formulae which sometimes called for calculations out to as many as seven decimal places. The government itself did not even collect the agricultural taxes directly: county magistrates assigned tax-collection and transportation duties to civilian households. Tax captains in turn assigned tax payments to the households in their communities—not always on an equitable basis.

In the early 17th century, natural disasters added to the Ming’s financial problems. In a territory as large as the Ming Empire, natural disasters were bound to occur somewhere every year. The last decades of the Ming were punctuated by many more disasters than usual. Records indicate an average of 113 floods and 118 droughts for each twenty-year period from 1470 to 1609, and 113 floods and 108 droughts from 1609 to 1629. But from 1630 to 1649, there were 124 floods and 207 droughts recorded. These floods and droughts were often followed by serious epidemics, especially between 1637 and 1644.⁵⁰

These natural disasters significantly weakened the Ming government. Reduced grain production led to smaller demand for manufactured products and luxury goods and a subsequent decline in the commercial economy.⁵¹ Smaller harvests (or no harvests) meant more tax remissions and increased tax evasion, which further weakened a government already underfunded and unable to deliver famine relief in a timely and efficient manner. Lack of tax revenue meant failure to deliver pay and grain to the armies on the northern and northeastern frontiers. The Grand Canal’s limited carrying capacity may also have prevented sufficient supplies of grain from reaching the capital and the northeastern frontier. As a result, the Ming government was unable to deal effectively with the serious external and internal military threats.

Ming military strength had been in question since the Tumu disaster of 1449. Over time, the system of self-supplying military garrisons on the frontier fell apart. Incompetent hereditary commanders collected the pay of nonexistent soldiers. Officers and merchants converted military grain land into private fields, and recruited mercenaries took the places of the hereditary soldiers. Through a combination of luck and occasional victories, the Ming was able to maintain an acceptable degree of security along the northern frontiers (often because the Mongols

were divided among themselves). Military weakness and constant disagreements on how to deal with the Mongol threat eventually led to the construction of the Great Wall in the 16th century.

The Great Wall was built as a response to the long-standing threat from the Mongols, but the military challenges of the late 16th and early 17th century came from other directions. In 1590 Ming forces began a major campaign against Miao (Hmong) people in the difficult terrain of the southwestern region of Guizhou. This was just one of a series of campaigns which extended from the Ming through the mid-19th century as Han colonists and the Ming (and later Qing) governments increasingly penetrated the non-Chinese areas of the southwest and incorporated the land and the people into the Chinese economic, cultural, and tax systems. This particular campaign ended with a Ming victory in 1600.⁵²

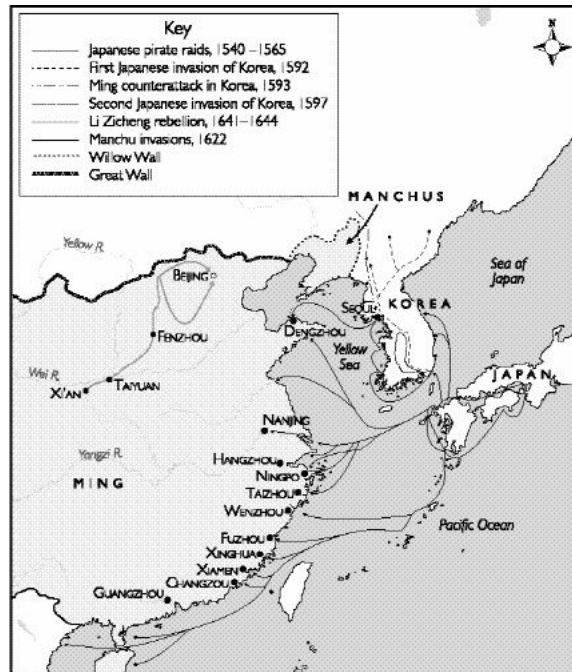
While fighting the Miao in the southwest, the Ming Wanli emperor also sent a large army to the aid of his vassal, the king of Korea. In 1593 the Japanese warlord Hideyoshi (1536–1598), perhaps hoping to eventually conquer the Ming, sent an army of one hundred fifty thousand to invade Korea. Over a hundred thousand Ming soldiers helped the Koreans to fight the Japanese invaders to a standstill, but it took six years and cost the Ming government 10 million taels (ounces) (375,000 kg) of silver. In 1598, after Hideyoshi's death, the Japanese withdrew.⁵³

Its strength exhausted by the strains of war against the Miao and Japan, the Ming was unable to respond to a new enemy: the Manchu. The Manchu people were a conglomeration of Jurchen tribes. Their leader, Nurhaci (1558–1626), had welded them together and given them a new identity as “Manchu.” Nurhaci and his son, Huang Taiji (1592–1643), drew on Jurchen, Mongol, and Chinese ideas and institutions to build a strong Chinese-style imperial government and an efficient army in the area northeast of the Great Wall, which we consequently know as “Manchuria.”

In the first decades of the 17th century, Nurhaci and Huang Taiji fought the Ming over control of key cities and agricultural land in areas of modern Liaoning province beyond the Great Wall. The Ming forces facing the Manchu were underpaid, undermanned, poorly supplied, and poorly commanded. Factional struggle between pro- and anti-Donglin forces at court further undermined the command structure when officials from opposing factions refused to cooperate with each other in carrying out operations against the Manchu. In 1629, Manchu forces launched a long raid on Ming territory near Beijing and in Shandong province.

While struggling against the Manchu in the northeast, the Ming also faced popular uprisings on their own territory. The rebellions began in the arid and unproductive northwestern provinces of Shaanxi and Shanxi.⁵⁴ Drought and famine hit this area hard in the late 1620s and 1630s. Starving people sold their children and were reduced to eating bark and earth. Some turned to cannibalism.

In 1627, rebellions broke out in communities across the northwest. Some were uprisings against local officials who insisted on collecting tax grain from their starving people. But the major source of rebel strength came from military garrisons whose soldiers were angry because the government consistently failed to send them pay and supplies. In one incident, troops from Gansu, Shaanxi, and Shanxi ordered to fight the Manchu invasion of 1629 joined the rebels when the government failed to deliver their pay and rations. In 1630, when the Ming government tried to save money by cutting the postal system by thirty percent, laid-off postal couriers joined the rebels. In the 1630s, more and more men joined rebel bands, which merged to become huge armies, tens of thousands strong, which swept across Shanxi, Shaanxi, and neighboring provinces to the south. Of the several major rebel leaders who emerged, the most important was Li Zicheng (1606–1644).



Military challenges in the late Ming.

Like many rebels, Li Zicheng had been a soldier in the Ming army before joining a rebel group in 1629. His fortunes rose and fell over the next decade, but in 1640–1641, he led his army from Shaanxi into Henan province. Here, in the heart of the Central Plains, drought and famine had devastated towns, villages, and cities. Desperate men flocked to Li’s armies, which grew first to five hundred thousand, then a million men. Some Confucian scholars, who saw Li as a man who might become emperor, also joined him. With their advice and assistance, he began to build a reputation as a man who cared for the people by remitting taxes and distributing wealth seized from corrupt Ming princes. Li Zicheng and his advisors also set up a shadow imperial government. In 1642, Li Zicheng announced the establishment of the Shun dynasty—but carefully did not yet claim to be emperor.

With the area of modern Henan and Hubei provinces under his control in 1643, Li Zicheng faced a strategic choice: Turn south to conquer Jiangnan and the Ming southern capital of Nanjing? Or go north to Beijing? The southern option would cut the Grand Canal and leave the Ming court to face a two-front war against the Manchu and Li Zicheng’s Shun without the tax revenue of Jiangnan. An advance to the north would bring a swift end to the Ming dynasty, but it would leave Li Zicheng to face the Manchu.

Li Zicheng chose to strike north toward Beijing. Ming forces crumbled before the power of the armies of the Great Shun. The Ming Chongzhen emperor’s advisors, still torn between pro- and anti-Donglin factions, offered conflicting advice: Stay in Beijing and defend the capital, or flee to Nanjing and resist the Shun “bandits” from there? Paralyzed by indecision, the Chongzhen emperor did nothing until it was too late. Then, on the morning of 25 April 1644, abandoned by his officials, the last Ming emperor climbed partway up the hill behind the Forbidden City and hanged himself.⁵⁵

With the Chongzhen emperor dead, it might seem that Li Zicheng’s Shun dynasty had triumphantly taken the “Mandate of Heaven.” But the situation in the spring of 1644 was anything but clear. Li Zicheng, it is true, had captured Beijing. But other rebel groups continued to roam across the territory north of the Yangzi. In the south, officials in Jiangnan were choosing a Ming prince to serve as their emperor and lead them in a reconquest of the north. To the northeast, a powerful Ming army under commander Wu Sangui (1612–78) guarded the strategic pass of Shanhaiguan against the Manchus—who had been observing the misfortunes of the Ming with keen interest. Would Wu Sangui accept Li Zicheng as his emperor or remain loyal to the Ming? Or could he be convinced to defect to the Manchus?

Notes

1. Timothy Brook describes the ways in which Confucian gentlemen found the wealth of the mid- and late Ming periods morally disconcerting in *The Confusions of Pleasure: Commerce and Culture in Ming China* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1998).
2. Jonathan Spence, *The Chan's Great Continent* (New York: W.W. Norton, 1998), 18.
3. C. R. Boxer, *The Portuguese Seaborne Empire 1415–1825* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1969), 49.
4. This discussion of piracy draws on James Geiss, “The Chia-ching Reign, 1522–1566,” in Frederick W. Mote and Denis Twitchett, eds., *The Cambridge History of China, Vol. 7: The Ming Dynasty, 1368–1644, Part 1* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988), 490–505. See also Kwan-wai So, *Japanese Piracy in Ming China During the Sixteenth Century* (East Lansing: Michigan State University Press, 1975).
5. Boxer, *The Portuguese Seaborne Empire*, 63.
6. *Ibid.*, 63–4.
7. Frederic Wakeman, Jr., *The Great Enterprise: The Manchu Reconstruction of Imperial Order in Seventeenth-Century China* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1985), vol. 1, 3. See also the discussions in William S. Atwell, “International Bullion Flows and the Chinese Economy circa 1530–1650,” *Past and Present* 95 (May 1982): 68–90; and Richard von Glahn, “Myth and Reality of China’s Seventeenth-Century Monetary Crisis,” *The Journal of Economic History* 56.2 (June 1996): 429–54.
8. Joseph Needham, *Science and Civilisation in China, Volume 5: Chemistry and Chemical Technology, Part VII: Military Technology, the Gunpowder Epic* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1986), 35–6.
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2. Zvi Ben-Dor Benite, “‘The Marrano Emperor’: The Mysterious, Intimate Bond Between Zhu Yuanzhang and His Muslims,” in Sarah Schneewind, ed., *Long Live the Emperor! Uses of the Ming Founder Across Six Centuries of East Asian History* (Minneapolis: Society for Ming Studies, 2008), 275–308; Dru C. Gladney, *Dislocating China: Reflections on Muslims, Minorities, and Other Subaltern Subjects* (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2004), 115, 122, 155, 294; Raphael Israeli, *Islam in China: Religion, Ethnicity, Culture, and Politics* (Lanham: Lexington Books, 2003), 100, cited in Benite, “‘The Marrano Emperor.’”
3. Luo Xiaowei, “China,” in Martin Frishman and Hasan-Uddin Khan, eds., *The Mosque: History, Architectural Development and Regional Diversity* (London: Thames and Hudson, 1994), 211, 220.
4. Patricia Buckley Ebrey and Peter N. Gregory, “The Religious and Historical Landscape,” in Ebrey and Gregory, eds., *Religion and Society in T’ang and Sung China* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 1993), 9.
5. See Victoria Cass, *Dangerous Women: Warriors, Grannies and Geishas of the Ming* (Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield, 1999), 3–6, on which this discussion is based.
6. *Ibid.*, 5.
7. Bettine Birge, “Women and Confucianism from Song to Ming: The Institutionalization of Patrilineality,” in Paul Jakov Smith and Richard von Glahn, eds., *The Song-Yuan-Ming Transition in Chinese History* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Asia Center, 2003), 220–1, 230.
8. Wang Ping, *Aching for Beauty: Footbinding in China* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2000), 31–3.
9. Dorothy Ko, *Every Step a Lotus: Shoes for Bound Feet* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2001), 54–61.
0. Patricia Buckley Ebrey, *Confucianism and Family Rituals in Imperial China: A Social History of Writing about Rites* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1991), 167–87.
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 3. Tanaka Issei, “The Social and Historical Context of Ming-Ch’ing Local Drama,” in Johnson, Nathan, and Rawski, eds., *Popular Culture*, 148–50, 159–60.
 4. Lucille Chia, “*Mashaben*,” 305–6, 326–8.
 5. For examples, see William Theodore de Bary et al., eds., *Sources of Chinese Tradition, Vol. 1: From Earliest Times to 1600*, 2nd ed. (New York: Columbia University Press, 1999), 899–916.
 6. David Johnson, for example, suggests that “one of the leading characteristics of Ming-Ch’ing culture is the extraordinary degree to which values and beliefs favorable to ruling class interests permeated popular consciousness.” Johnson, “Communication, Class, and Consciousness in Late Imperial China,” in Johnson, Nathan, and Rawski, eds., *Popular Culture*, 46.
 7. Discussion of these four novels is based on the novels themselves and on C. T. Hsia, *The Classic Chinese Novel: A Critical Introduction* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1968); and Andrew Plaks, *The Four Masterworks of the Ming Novel* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1987).
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 9. *Ibid.*, 637.
 0. Mark E. Mason, Jr., introduction to Robert Hatfield Ellsworth, *Essence of Style: Chinese Furniture of the Late Ming and Early Qing Dynasties* (San Francisco: Asian Art Museum of San Francisco, 1998), 16.
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 2. Craig Clunas, *Art in China* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1997), 127–8.
 3. *Ibid.*, 177–81; Marsha Weidner, Ellen Johnson Laing, Irving Yucheng Lo, Christina Chu, and James Robinson, *Views from Jade Terrace: Chinese Women Artists 1300–1912* (Indianapolis: Indianapolis Museum of Art, 1988), 34, 70.
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 5. Mae Anna Pang, “Painting in the Ming Dynasty,” in Edmund Capon and Mae Anna Pang, eds., *Chinese Paintings of the Ming and Qing Dynasties, XIV–XXth Centuries* (n.p.: International Cultural Corporation of Australia Limited, 1981).
 6. Zhang Tao (1609), quoted in Brook, *The Confusions of Pleasure*, vi.
 7. Fung Yu-lan (Feng Youlan), *A History of Chinese Philosophy, Vol. 2: The Period of Classical Learning*, trans. Derk Bodde (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1953), 596–7.
 8. Wm. Theodore de Bary, “Individualism and Humanitarianism in Late Ming Thought,” in de Bary, ed., *Self and Society in Ming Thought*, 145–247.
 9. This discussion of Li Zhi draws on Ray Huang, *1587, A Year of No Significance: The Ming Dynasty in Decline* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1981), 189–221; and on Jin Jiang, “Heresy and Persecution in Late Ming Society: Reinterpreting the Case of Li Zhi,” *Late Imperial China* 22.2 (Dec. 2001): 1–34.
 0. *Ibid.*, 130–55.
 1. *Ibid.*, 135.
 2. Charles O. Hucker, “Ming Government,” in Denis Twitchett and Frederick W. Mote, eds., *The Cambridge History of China, Vol. 8: The Ming Dynasty, 1368–1644, Part 2* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), 54.

3. The following discussion of the Donglin affair draws on Huang, 1587, 78–79; Ray Huang, “The Lung-ch’ing and Wanli Reigns,” in Mote and Twitchett, eds., *The Cambridge History of China*, Vol. 7, 532–56; and John W. Dardess, *Blood and History in China: The Donglin Faction and Its Repression, 1620–1627* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 2002).
4. William Atwell, “Ming China and the Emerging World Economy, c. 1470–1650,” in Twitchett and Mote, eds., *The Cambridge History of China*, Vol. 8, 408–9.
5. Atwell, “Ming China and the Emerging World Economy,” 407–11; William Atwell, “Some Observations on the ‘Seventeenth-Century Crisis’ in China and Japan,” *The Journal of Asian Studies* 45.2 (Feb. 1986): 229; Wakeman, *The Great Enterprise*, vol. 1, 6.
6. Von Glahn, “Myth and Reality,” 440.
7. Zhang Kaizhi, ed., *Zhongguo lishi Yuan Ming Qing juan* (Chinese history: Yuan, Ming, and Qing volume) (Beijing: Gaodeng jiaoyu chubanshe, 2002), 208–9.
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0. Kang Chao, *Man and Land in Chinese History: An Economic Analysis* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1986), 207; and William Atwell, “The T’ai-ch’ang, T’ien-ch’i, and Ch’ung-chen Reigns, 1620–1644,” in Twitchett and Mote, eds., *The Cambridge History of China*, Volume 8, 586–7.
1. Von Glahn, “Myth and Reality,” 447.
2. Huang, “The Lung-ch’ing and Wan-li Reigns,” 564–5; Mark Elvin, *The Retreat of the Elephants: An Environmental History of China* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2004), 225–32.
3. Huang, “The Lung-ch’ing and Wan-li Reigns,” 567–74.
4. This account draws on Wakeman, *The Great Enterprise*, vol. 1, 225–318; Chan, *The Glory and Fall of the Ming Empire*, 333–44; and Atwell, “The T’ai-ch’ang, T’ien-ch’i and Ch’ung-chen Reigns,” 615–6, 621–3, 634–7.
5. Wakeman, *The Great Enterprise*, 265–6.

[The Qing Dynasty to 1799](#)

While the Ming descended into famine and rebellion, a local strongman named Nurhaci (1558–1626) and his son Huang Taiji (1592–1643) were building a new kingdom in the Northeast. In 1636 Huang Taiji gave his people, a combination of Jurchen tribes, a new name, “Manchu,” and established a new dynasty: Qing (meaning “pure”). In 1644, when the Chinese rebel and would-be emperor Li Zicheng overthrew the Ming, the Manchu warriors came through the Great Wall, absorbed some of the remaining Ming armies and claimed the Mandate of Heaven for their Qing dynasty, which ruled in Beijing until February 1912.

In many respects, life in China went on much as it had before the Manchu conquest. The Manchu conquerors ruled as Chinese emperors, adapting the institutions, techniques, and laws of Ming government to their own purposes. Economic, cultural, and intellectual trends present in the late Ming continued on into the Qing period. These elements of continuity draw our attention once again to the fallacy of dividing historical eras rigidly according to the rise and fall of dynastic governments. Some historians even prefer to talk about a “Ming-Qing” period or a “late imperial period” that includes both Ming and Qing.

Nonetheless, the Qing dynasty was in some ways very different from the Ming. From 1644 to 1799 the first four Manchu emperors consolidated control over China Proper and drew on its resources to build an empire larger than those of any of the earlier dynastic states of China, stretching from Siberia to the Burmese border, from the oases of Central Asia to the island of Taiwan. The Qing’s large territory, diverse population, huge economic power, and sophisticated culture made it one of the most powerful empires of the 18th century. But by 1799, signs of the weaknesses that would bring the dynasty to its knees in the 19th century were already lurking below the surface of Manchu imperial grandeur.

The Origins and Rise of the Qing Dynasty

In the 16th century, the Ming considered Manchuria to be a part of their territory. Farmers cultivated the land lying west and east of the Liao River in modern Liaoning province, guarded by Ming military colonies. Identity was fluid in this frontier area. Some Ming farmers and hereditary military families picked up the language and culture of the Jurchen people of Manchuria, and even acquired Jurchen names.¹ Some Jurchens practiced settled agriculture, interacted with Ming officials, and learned the Chinese language. The Jurchens, after all, had a long history of interaction with China: in the 12th century one branch of the Jurchens had established the Jin dynasty and ruled northern China until they, in turn, were conquered by the Mongols in 1234.

Manchuria beyond the Liao Valley was still a land of Jurchen tribes whose interaction with China and Chinese culture was relatively limited. The Jurchens lived in permanent villages, but some raised livestock, which they moved from one pasture to another in a seminomadic lifestyle. Hunting, fishing, and trade in ginseng, furs, and other mountain products were very important, particularly in the areas farthest from Chinese influence. The Jurchen tribes were grouped into unstable, shifting confederations. The Ming tried to control the Jurchen through a “divide and rule” strategy in which the court “appointed” (in effect, recognized) a number of different Jurchen chieftains. Those men who gained Ming appointment received seals of office and were allowed to come to Beijing to “offer tribute.” They also had access to frontier markets where they exchanged horses, furs, and ginseng for Chinese textiles, salt, grain, iron goods, and oxen.

Ming forces occasionally intervened in disputes among the Jurchens. In one such operation in 1583, Ming troops killed—perhaps by mistake—the father and grandfather of the Aisin Gioro lineage of the Jianzhou Jurchens. They swiftly moved to make amends by confirming the grandson, Nurhaci, as successor to his father’s position as clan

leader. Nurhaci played along, but he evidently felt that he was owed a blood debt. First, he moved against his Jurchen rivals, forcing enemy tribes to submit to him. The Ming, who still regarded him as their client, awarded him the title “Dragon-Tiger General” in 1595.²

As the Dragon-Tiger General became stronger, Ming officials began to see him as a threat, closed down the border markets in order to deprive him of income, and lent military support to his enemies. In response, Nurhaci raided Ming territory repeatedly between 1616 and 1626. The immediate cause of the attacks was the need for food. The Jurchens were hungry.³ They were also very effective warriors. Some Ming forces were defeated. Others surrendered, the officers and men joining the Jurchens rather than lay down their lives for the Ming. To protect his eastern flank, Nurhaci had built an alliance with some of the Mongol tribes, who saw cooperation with the Jurchen khan as a way of restoring unity and stability to the fractured and warring tribal society of Inner Mongolia.⁴

While fighting the Ming and gaining the adherence of the Mongols, Nurhaci began to use Mongolian and Chinese techniques to build a stronger state and military. He declared himself khan, a Mongol title, of the “Later Jin dynasty” and established a capital, the captured Chinese city of Shenyang (called Mukden in Jurchen). His scholars devised a writing system for the Jurchen language, using the Mongolian alphabet as their model. Along with his newly conquered territories east and west of the Liao River (modern Liaoning province), he acquired a population of Chinese farmers and land on which to settle Jurchens as farmers or as landlords collecting rent from Chinese tenants. Nurhaci was creating a new style of governing, one which combined Chinese bureaucratic practices with the collegial, consultative decision-making typical of the Jurchens.⁵

Military reorganization accompanied political innovation. Nurhaci drew on Mongol precedent to reorganize the Jurchen tribes into companies and Banners. A company consisted of three hundred soldiers plus each soldier’s household. Thus a company included not just fighting men, but the entire familial support system for each warrior.⁶ About fifty companies formed one regiment.⁷ Regiments were combined in groups of five to form larger units, each symbolized by a banner: four of solid colors, yellow, white, red, and blue, and four more of the same colors, but each with a red border (except the red banner with white border). By 1642, Nurhaci’s successor Huang Taiji had added a further Eight Mongol Banners and Eight Chinese Banners. The Banner system weakened tribal and clan structure, focused loyalty on Nurhaci and gave him a strong, disciplined, self-supporting military. Over two hundred years later, it remained one of the fundamental institutions of the Qing dynasty.

When Nurhaci died in 1626, the Jin khanate was already a power to be reckoned with. His son and successor, Huang Taiji, built on this foundation. Huang Taiji forced more Mongol tribes to submit, took the rest of the territory west of the Liao River from the Ming, and launched raids across the Great Wall, deep into Ming territory, in order to support his growing army. Huang Taiji also moved farther away from the collegial Jurchen style of leadership and toward a more centralized, Chinese-style bureaucratic system. Huang Taiji ordered that key Chinese texts, including the *Analects* and histories of the Warring States and Three Kingdoms periods, be translated into Manchu so that he could read them. He used Chinese advisors in his government and Chinese officers and men, including men who could make and use cannon, in his armies.

As he built a more centralized government, Huang Taiji gave the Jurchen tribes a new name and identity: Manchu. In order to make his intention of conquering Ming territory perfectly clear, he also changed the name of the dynasty. On 14 May 1636, Huang Taiji, the khan of the Jurchen “Later Jin” dynasty, became Taizong, emperor of the Qing dynasty.⁸ When Huang Taiji died in September 1643, he left the throne to his son, the Shunzhi emperor (1638–1661), age five. Huang Taiji’s brother, Prince Dorgon, acted as regent. All this happened just as Ming armies were collapsing under the onslaught of the rebel forces of Li Zicheng, the “Dashing Prince” who would shortly enter Beijing.

The Qing Conquest

The Manchu conquest of China began 190 miles (300 km) east of Beijing, at Shanhaiguan—the mountain pass from the North China Plain to Manchuria where the eastern end of the Ming Great Wall meets the sea. In 1644 these fortifications were the key to defending Beijing from the Manchus. Even as Beijing fell to Li Zicheng, Ming commander Wu Sangui (1612–78) guarded Shanhaiguan with a formidable army of forty thousand. General Wu’s immediate family was in Beijing, captured by Li Zicheng’s rebels. An uncle and cousins were on the other side of the pass, serving the Manchu Qing dynasty.⁹ Would Wu join Li Zicheng? Or would he defend the Ming imperial house against the rebels?

As the general was weighing his options, word came that Li Zicheng had executed Wu Sangui's father. It was a fatal mistake on Li's part. General Wu asked Dorgon to bring the Banner forces through Shanhaiguan to assist in suppressing Li Zicheng's "bandits." In return, the Manchus would reap the rewards of plunder—and return to Manchuria. Dorgon and his Chinese advisers welcomed the opportunity, but had something else in mind: they would enter the pass, liberate Beijing, and go on to conquer "all under Heaven." General Wu agreed. The Manchus came through the pass, incorporated Wu Sangui and his army under their command, defeated Li Zicheng, and proceeded to Beijing. There Dorgon famously announced to the Ming people and former Ming officials:

The empire is not an individual's private enterprise. Whosoever possesses virtue holds it. The army and people are not an individual's private army and people. Whosoever possesses virtue commands them. We now hold it. We took revenge upon the enemy of your ruler-father in place of your dynasty. We burned our bridges behind us, and we have pledged not to return until every bandit is destroyed. In the counties, districts, and locales that we pass through, all those who shave their heads and surrender, opening their gates to welcome us, will be given rank and reward, retaining their wealth and nobility for generations. But if there are those who resist us disobediently, then when our Grand Army arrives, the stones themselves will be set ablaze and everyone will be massacred.¹⁰

The conquest of Ming territory went much as Dorgon had announced. Qing forces, greatly strengthened by the addition of Wu Sangui and other Ming turncoat generals and their armies, restored order to northern China and then marched south. Ming resistance was poorly organized. Some Ming loyalists organized their own armies to fight the Manchus. For example, Liu Shuying, the daughter of a Ming official, used her fortune to build an army of a thousand, which she herself trained and led into battle.¹¹ In the Yangzi Valley, Ming officials organized a "Southern Ming" court, placing first one, then another Ming prince on the throne, but they had few men and fewer resources. In a particularly famous case, a Southern Ming general stubbornly tried to defend the wealthy Jiangnan commercial city of Yangzhou. When he took the city, the Manchu commander chose to make Yangzhou an example to all others who might think of resistance: he turned his normally well-disciplined troops loose for five days of looting, killing, and rape.¹²

Most Ming officials were in no position to offer any serious military resistance. Rather than fight, they surrendered. Some chose the route of passive resistance. Many women and men of the Ming elite, sometimes entire families, committed suicide rather than live under the Qing. The mother of Gu Yanwu (1613–1682), a noted scholar, starved herself to death, exhorting her famous son never to serve the "barbarians." Others, like Gu himself, while unwilling to commit suicide, refused to serve the new dynasty. Such exemplars of loyalty were a minority whose spirit, though respected (even by the Qing rulers), faded with time. Together, the Manchus and their subjects transformed the Ming into a part of the Manchu Qing Empire, and the Manchu aristocracy into minority rulers of a realm that had its economic, political, geographical, and cultural center of gravity in China Proper.

The articulation of this new relationship between Manchu rulers and Chinese subjects can be seen in concrete terms in the changing cultural geography of China's major cities, starting with the capital city of Beijing. The Ming capital consisted of two parts. In the north was the original walled city with the imperial palace, government offices, and the residences of princes and officials. In the south, outside the original city walls, was the commercial section, which had been walled afterwards to defend it from Mongol invasions.¹³ When they took over Beijing, the Manchus cleared the north city of Han Chinese inhabitants to make way for the Banner forces and Manchu aristocrats. Banner forces were also garrisoned in other major cities, where they lived in segregated walled areas from which they could not stray far without permission.

The physical segregation of the Banner forces was meant to underline and preserve the distinct identity of the Manchu conquerors. The Manchus were a very small minority in their own empire. Even in the Banners, families of Jurchen ethnic background were only sixteen percent in 1644. In 1723, after Han Chinese Banner families had been urged to become ordinary citizens, the ethnic composition of the Banners was roughly sixty-eight percent Han, eight percent Mongol, and twenty-three percent Manchu.¹⁴ Banner people did not intermarry with the commoner population, and were not subject to control or punishment by the civilian government. Bannermen were barred from trade or other professions: they were to be a hereditary military elite.¹⁵ Physical and legal separation ensured that Banner people retained a separate identity, but it did not prevent their identity from changing over time. Within a few generations, ethnic Jurchen Banner people had largely lost the ability to speak, read, or write Manchu. They had also acquired many aspects of Chinese culture: they ate Chinese food, wrote Chinese poetry, and served in a

bureaucracy inherited from the Ming.

While Manchus adopted the culture of the Chinese elite, Chinese literati became loyal servants of the Manchu emperors. As a symbol of their submission, Chinese men were forced to adopt the Manchu male hairstyle—shaving the forehead and braiding the rest of the hair into a long queue. Scholars serving the Manchu court had to give up the long, loose robes of a Ming official and don the trousers, tight-sleeved coats, and boots, whose origins lay with the Manchu traditions of horsemanship and archery. More than one Chinese man lost his head for refusal to wear the queue or for suggesting that the world would be more peaceful if Qing officials were required to wear Ming-style court dress.¹⁶ But in the long run, the Ming people and their descendants adapted to Manchu rule.

Qing Empire-Building

The Qing Empire of the 18th century could not have been built without China and the Chinese. In retrospect, Nurhaci and Huang Taiji's unification of Manchus and Mongols and Prince Dorgon's conquest of China Proper appear as the first two stages of the construction of what became the Qing Empire of the 18th century. But neither the early Manchu leaders nor Dorgon could have predicted the way events unfolded in the generations that came after them. Dorgon's conquest of China took place during the reign of his nephew, the Shunzhi emperor (r. 1644–1661). Shunzhi died of smallpox in 1661. His successors, the Kangxi emperor (r. 1661–1722), the Yongzheng emperor (r. 1722–1735), and the Qianlong emperor (r. 1735–1796), used the immense economic and manpower resources of the Chinese agricultural economy to push their imperial domain outward into Inner Asia and over the sea to Taiwan.

Kangxi was a model emperor: intelligent, curious, hardworking, an avid hunter, a dedicated reader of philosophy and history, and the father of over fifty-six children.¹⁷ He came to the throne in 1661, at the age of eight. The early years of his reign were dominated by a regent, Oboi (?–1669—discussed further below), but Kangxi began to emerge from Oboi's shadow in the late 1660s. As an adult, he was deeply involved in the day-to-day management of affairs of state: reading memorials, writing responses (rescripts), meeting regularly with his officials, inspecting troops, and leading armies in the field.



Official court portrait of the Kangxi emperor in informal dress, holding a brush. Hanging scroll, ink and paint on silk.

Kangxi's first major challenge was the revolt of the "Three Feudatories"—three former Ming generals, including Wu Sangui, who had played a key role in the Qing conquest of the south, and had earned large fiefs as their reward. Wu Sangui controlled the southwestern provinces of Yunnan and Guizhou. Two other Ming turncoats had been awarded Guangdong and Fujian. Concerned about the military and economic power of these virtually independent Three Feudatories (who also received generous subsidies amounting to nearly half the imperial government revenue

in the 1670s), the young Kangxi emperor, against the advice of his ministers, tried to maneuver them into retirement.¹⁸ This prompted Wu Sangui to rise up in arms against the Qing in 1673. The Chinese generals of Guangdong and Fujian joined him. In 1681, after eight years of devastating civil war, Qing armies finally defeated the revolt of the Three Feudatories and established direct imperial rule over the south.

Operations against the Three Feudatories led to further moves to consolidate and expand the Qing Empire and to secure its frontiers. Off the coast of Fujian, a Ming loyalist merchant-pirate named Zheng Chenggong (known to Europeans as Coxinga—1624–62) had captured the island of Taiwan from the Dutch East India Company traders who had been based there. Zheng and his heirs ruled the island as their personal kingdom and used it as a base for trade and piracy. An early Qing ban on maritime trade, intended to starve the Zheng forces of income, failed, partly because the Three Feudatories ignored it. In 1683, Qing naval forces defeated the Zheng fleets. For the first time in its history, Taiwan was brought under the direct administration of a government based on the mainland of China.

Even during the war against the Three Feudatories, problems in Inner Asia also intruded on the Kangxi emperor's attention. Wu Sangui had won the tacit support of the Mongol-supported Dalai Lama in Lhasa and had entered into the tea-horse trade with Tibet—a serious matter, as horses were a strategic asset to whoever controlled them.¹⁹ Mongolia, too, was a threat. Manchu influence over the Mongols was loose—more a matter of alliances with numerous Mongol tribes than of control. And in the far west of Mongolia and the northern part of modern Xinjiang, the Zunghar Mongol khan, Galdan, was forging his own state, establishing close relations with the Dalai Lama, competing with the Qing for the loyalty of the Mongolian tribes, and seeking support from the Russian Empire.

The Kangxi emperor regarded the Zunghars as his most dangerous enemy. But before he could deal with the Zunghars, he needed to negotiate a peace deal with the Russians. As Russia expanded eastward in search of furs from the late 1500s to mid-1600s, they had begun to encroach on the Amur River Valley, which the Qing considered part of its own territory. After three years of careful preparations—building ships, preparing cannons and guns, gathering intelligence—some thirty-four hundred Qing troops attacked the Russian fort of Albazin on the Amur River in 1685, and again in 1686.

Aware that the Qing was militarily powerful, and more concerned about selling furs on the Chinese market than about territory, Russia agreed to negotiate. In the Treaty of Nerchinsk (1689), Russia and the Great Qing Empire agreed to a boundary along the Argun River and along the crest of the Outer Khingan (Stanavoi) mountain range. The treaty was negotiated according to European custom, with two of the Kangxi emperor's Jesuit priests serving as go-betweens and interpreters. Manchu, Latin, and Russian copies of the treaty were exchanged and solemnized by Christian oaths.²⁰

In signing the Treaty of Nerchinsk, the Russians gained access to the Chinese market. The Kangxi emperor gained a free hand in dealing with Galdan and his Zunghars, who now were unable to win Russian support. Kangxi carried out four grueling campaigns against Galdan, one in 1690 and three in 1696–97. The emperor himself took to the field to lead his troops in these operations, which he seems to have enjoyed:

While on the move, I'd live roughly and without formality—those passing in front of me didn't have to dismount, and as on hunts we would cook fish or food we caught in a simple way, and sit sometimes in the herders' tents and eat, and drink kumiss as we talked.²¹

Driving deep into Mongolia in pursuit of the Zunghar leader, stretching their fragile supply lines to the limits, Qing forces inflicted some serious defeats on the enemy, but failed to capture or kill Galdan, who could always flee beyond the reach of the Qing armies. In 1697 Galdan, on the run and with his forces decimated and divided, died suddenly—probably poisoned by one of his followers—just as the Kangxi emperor was carrying out logistical operations for his fourth campaign. The emperor adjusted the date of Galdan's death and announced it as a suicide in order to make it appear to be the result of his expensive military operation.²² Galdan was dead, but the Zunghar Empire remained in place, still a threat to the Qing, and still working to build relations with the Russians and the Tibetans. One of the Kangxi emperor's last actions was to send his armies into Tibet in 1720, in order to deprive the Zunghars of Tibetan support.

Kangxi's heir, the Yongzheng emperor, took a defensive attitude toward the Zunghars and Tibetans, though he did conquer the Tibetan/Mongol area currently known as Qinghai Province, which he incorporated into the Qing Empire in 1723. He also negotiated a second treaty, the Treaty of Khatka (1727), with the Russians. Yongzheng is best known for having built a more strongly centralized government and a more efficient tax system, which left his heir, the Qianlong emperor, with a generous surplus in the imperial treasury. Qianlong used his power—and his

treasure—in a series of campaigns which more than doubled the size of the empire.

First, Qianlong finally succeeded in thoroughly defeating the Zunghars. This required two campaigns. First, in 1755, Qianlong's armies helped to install Amursana (1722–1757) as khan of the Zunghars. Qianlong expected Amursana to be grateful and obedient. When Amursana rebelled, Qianlong responded with a second, larger expedition in 1756–57. The Zunghar campaigns “included three main armies, totaling fifty thousand men each, who stayed on each campaign for one to two years.”²³ In the second campaign, Qianlong, angered at Zunghar resistance, ordered a massacre. Deliberate killing of hundreds of thousands, combined with a smallpox epidemic, battlefield deaths, starvation, and enslavement completely destroyed the million or so Zunghars as a people.²⁴

Following up on his victory over the Zunghars, the Qianlong emperor moved to gain control of Altishahr and the Turfan Basin, both territories lying in Xinjiang, south of the Tianshan Mountains. The Turkic-speaking Muslim inhabitants of these regions lived in the oases that had been key links in the Silk Road trade since the time of the Han dynasty. The Qianlong emperor's forces allied with Muslim elite families in the Turfan region, closer to China, in order to wage a war of conquest against the oasis towns of Altishahr in 1758–59. Altishahr, subdued in 1760, was combined with Turfan and Zungharia to form a new administrative region: Xinjiang (which means “new frontier”).

The Qing dynasty's wars against the Three Feudatories, the Zunghar Mongols, and the Muslims of Altishahr drove home the strategic importance of Tibet. Tibetan religious figures, particularly the Dalai Lamas, had exercised tremendous political influence over the Mongols ever since their mass conversion to Tibetan Buddhism during the Ming. Mongol leaders, in turn, often played key roles in Tibetan politics, including in the selection and manipulation of Dalai Lamas. The Kangxi emperor's invasion in 1720 had broken Zunghar influence and marked the beginning of a Qing protectorate over Tibet. Subsequent expeditions and political deals during the Yongzheng and especially the Qianlong reigns shaped Tibet's place within the Qing Empire.



Qianlong emperor in ceremonial armor.

The conquests of Zungharia and Altishahr and the incorporation of Tibet mark the height of Qing imperial expansion. A Qing invasion of Burma (1765–1768), prompted by violent border incidents, proved to be a disaster. Manchu cavalrymen floundered in the jungle and were hit hard by disease and by enemy action. The Qianlong emperor's reaction to initial setbacks was fury: “How could we stop abruptly in midcourse? ... Moreover, our dynasty is right at its ascendancy. The Zunghars and the Muslims have all been suppressed. How can this trifling Burma not be exterminated?”²⁵ Further efforts led only to further defeats. In the end, the emperor was forced to conclude: “This is the gods' manifestation that it is no use for us to penetrate deeply into Burma. Moreover, the soldiers are all unable to withstand malaria. They are our servants and slaves; our heart cannot bear it. In addition, sustaining many casualties at the hands of the Burmese bandits is not worth it.”²⁶

Like so many leaders, before and since, Qianlong declared victory and withdrew. An attempt to intervene in a dispute over the Annamese (northern Vietnamese) throne in 1788–1789 also went poorly. This time, apparently having learned his lesson, the emperor agreed to a quick end to hostilities and again proclaimed a fictional “victory.” In 1788, and again in 1791, the Qing waged war against the Nepalese Gurkha kingdom, which had trade disputes and territorial ambitions in Tibet. The second Qing-Gurkha war brought Qing troops across the Himalayas to the

outskirts of Kathmandu, where they were defeated but, as in Burma and in Annam, declared victory.²⁷

The Qianlong emperor's fictitious "victories" in Burma, Annam, and Nepal were possible because the rulers of all three states agreed to enter into tributary relations with the Qing. In this way, they joined the outer defense perimeter of the Qing Empire. Tribute-paying states like Nepal, Burma, Annam, and Korea sent "tribute missions" to the Qing court according to a regular schedule. Their emissaries were received with pomp and ceremony, kowtowed before the Qing emperor, offered valuable goods as "tribute," and received gifts, which were often of greater value than what they gave. The tribute system offered the Qing a series of friendly buffer states on its borders. Foreign rulers, even those whose armies had defeated Qing forces, entered this relationship because it brought lucrative opportunities for trade, because Qing troops could be expected to help defend them from external and internal enemies, and because tributary status did not compromise their sovereignty within their own kingdoms.



[The maximum extent of the Qing Empire, c. 1780.](#)

The Kangxi, Yongzheng, and Qianlong emperors had conquered such far-flung areas as Xinjiang, Mongolia, Tibet, and Taiwan. The results of their conquests are still apparent in the shape of the map of China. The Qing had become a vast, sprawling, multi-ethnic empire, ruled from Beijing by Manchu emperors, but incorporating Han Chinese, Mongols, Tibetans, Muslims, and a variety of ethnic groups along the southwestern frontiers and on Taiwan. Ruling this vast empire and winning and maintaining the loyalty or at least the acquiescence of its people was a daunting task.

Governing the Empire

The first four Qing emperors and the regents who occasionally exercised power on their behalf each had their own particular style of rulership. Prince Dorgon, regent for the Shunzhi emperor, and Prince Oboi, regent for the young Kangxi emperor, both placed their trust in Manchu aristocrats. Shunzhi, and then Kangxi, fighting to free themselves from the influence of these powerful regents, used Chinese officials in their power struggles against the Manchu aristocracy. Shunzhi died of smallpox at the age of twenty-three, before he could develop fully as a leader. Yongzheng, Kangxi, Qianlong, and their key officials built the institutions and styles of imperial rule that would define the Qing and, to a great extent, its successor states, the Republic of China and the People's Republic of China.

Qing emperors presented different faces to different subject peoples. To the Mongols and Tibetans, Qing emperors were successors of the Mongol khans, and they were also Cakravartin kings and patrons of Tibetan Buddhism. To the Manchu, the Qing emperor was the personification and preserver of Manchu ethnic identity. To the vast majority of his subjects, the Chinese, a Qing emperor presented himself as the holder of the Mandate of

Heaven and patron and practitioner of the civilized arts of painting, prose, and poetry. These different faces of the emperors were expressed in court art. Yongzheng was painted in various guises expressing Manchu and Chinese roles. The Qianlong emperor was portrayed as a warrior in ceremonial armor, as a hunter facing down deer and tiger, as a bodhisattva in a Tibetan mandala, as a filial son revering his mother, and as a Confucian scholar. Both Kangxi and Qianlong underlined their identity with their Chinese subjects by taking grand tours of the Yangzi Valley, stopping to worship at Mount Tai in Shandong and to inspect hydraulic engineering projects on the Grand Canal and Yellow River, and visiting the great cities and temples of the wealthy Yangzi Valley itself.²⁸

The many different imperial images were accompanied by different techniques of administration. In the non-Chinese frontier areas of the southwest, west, and northwest, the Qing often chose to rule indirectly by appointing or recognizing local leaders, many of whom manipulated the Qing in order to enhance their own wealth and power. In the Muslim areas of Xinjiang, the Qing ruled through the *begs*, hereditary local leaders.²⁹ In Tibet, the emperors stationed a small garrison and one or two personal representatives called *amban* in Lhasa. The *amban* exercised loose supervision over a Tibetan government run by the hereditary nobility. The Qing court patronized the Dalai Lama, the Panchen Lama, and the Tibetan aristocracy in order to prevent any one of them from becoming too powerful. Qing authority was also expressed in the ceremonies surrounding the recognition of each new incarnation of the Dalai Lama. Tibetan monks would choose the next incarnation from among several candidates. Their choice was then validated by drawing lots from a golden urn presented to the Tibetans by the Qianlong emperor in 1793.

Administration of China Proper followed the Ming example. In Beijing, the emperors and their personal staff oversaw the work of the Six Ministries: Rites, Personnel, Revenue, Works, Punishments, and War. The Censorate exercised oversight and filed regular reports on current problems and cases of bureaucratic malfeasance and corruption. The territory of China Proper was divided into 18 provinces, the provinces were divided into 177 prefectures, and the prefectures in turn divided into 1,528 counties.³⁰

As hands-on administrators, the Qing emperors, like their Ming predecessors, concentrated power within their own hands and could exercise fearsome discipline against recalcitrant officials. But as minority rulers, they needed to balance power between the Manchu aristocracy and their far more numerous Chinese subjects. They did this by balancing Manchu, Mongol, and Han Chinese officials against each other when staffing the upper levels of government. For instance, by making dual appointments to positions such as minister and vice minister in each of the Six Ministries. The intent was to preserve Manchu ethnic sovereignty while preventing Manchu aristocrats from becoming a threat to the throne.

The Qing emperors also invented new ways to increase their personal control over the government. The Kangxi emperor established a secret “palace memorial” system through which high-ranking officials could submit memorials directly to the emperor, bypassing the multiple levels of bureaucracy that filtered normal communications before they reached the emperor’s desk. This system gave the emperors an alternative source of information and allowed them to deal with problems in a more innovative way than was possible when acting through normal bureaucratic channels.

The Yongzheng and Qianlong emperors further developed and used this “palace memorial” system. The Yongzheng emperor also relied on small ad hoc committees of personal staff members. Because he personally controlled and worked with these committees, the emperor could increase the degree to which he was actually in control of the administration of the empire.³¹ The Qianlong emperor went a step further: rather than use ad hoc committees, he created a permanent “Grand Council,” a special committee standing outside and above the regular bureaucracy which assisted him in handling day-to-day business. The effect was to put the Qing emperors in even closer personal control of their government and their officials than the Ming rulers had been.

No matter how closely they gathered power into their own hands at the center, the emperors needed a large field bureaucracy to manage the business of the empire. Manchu and Mongol officials could be appointed on the basis of their aristocratic heredity, but the vast majority of the Qing officials (even some Manchu aristocrats) earned the right to be appointed to their posts by passing the civil service examinations.

The Qing examination system, like the government administration itself, was inherited from the Ming. There were four levels of examination. Candidates first took a qualifying examination and then, if they passed, the triennial county-level examination, which bestowed the status of licentiate (*shengyuan*). Licentiates enjoyed privileged status before the law (exemption from corporal punishment), and were officially registered as students in the county school—a formality, since the county schools held no classes. Next were the triennial provincial examinations for the status of “recommended man” (*juren*), and then it was on to Beijing for the triennial Metropolitan Examination. Candidates who passed the Metropolitan Examination received the *gongshi* (tribute literatus) degree. Those who

placed in the top three ranks of Metropolitan Examination passers could go on to take the Palace Examination where, if successful, they would be recognized as *jinshi* (presented literatus).³²

Preparation for the examinations required years of intensive, and expensive, education. Boys would begin memorizing the Four Books, the Five Classics, the dynastic histories, and classical poetry from around the age of seven.³³ A boy's first teacher might well be his mother. More formal education was the task of hired tutors or of clan- or community-supported schools. Here students memorized texts and learned how to write poetry and how to turn out polished essays on the classics, on moral philosophy, and on issues of state policy, all in the very formulaic "eight-legged" style, and written in classical Chinese.



Rows of twelve thousand cells in the civil service examination compound in Guangzhou, photographed in 1900.

The examinations were highly competitive, multi-day affairs, held in sealed, guarded examination compounds. Of the two million men who might compete for the *shengyuan* degree in a given year, perhaps thirty thousand would succeed; of those, fifteen hundred might achieve the status of *juren*, and three hundred would make it to *jinshi*.³⁴ Organizing the examinations was a gargantuan task. The sheer volume of work (several thousand candidates generating over fifty thousand essays on some twelve thousand rolls of answers in a provincial examination, for example) introduced a degree of arbitrariness into the grading and ranking of candidates.³⁵ This, and the prevalence of cheating, encouraged a popular culture which regarded success in the examinations as something of an obscure combination of talent, hard work, fate, and the intervention of supernatural forces. Theoretically, the examinations were open to all, but practically speaking, only well-to-do landholding elites, merchants, and officials had the means to educate their sons and send them to sit for the examinations.

Those who passed the examinations at any level were eligible for official appointment, but with over one million examination passers competing for around twenty thousand civil service appointments, one practically needed to be a *jinshi* to be sure of official employment.³⁶ The highest-ranking *jinshi* might be directly appointed to jobs in the capital. Most degreeholders, however, would begin and end their careers in lower-level posts across the empire.

Grassroots Government: The County Magistrate

China's 1,528 counties were the basic building blocks of the Qing administration. The population of a county ranged from tens of thousands to several hundred thousand people, with the average around two hundred thousand by 1800.³⁷ Each county had one official in charge: the county magistrate, sometimes called the "father-mother official." He was responsible for all aspects of government: collecting taxes, investigating and trying criminal cases,

adjudicating civil cases, managing public works projects, maintaining public order, dealing with natural disasters, administering the county-level civil service examinations, and generally setting a good moral example. He typically served a single term of four years before being rotated out, and, by law, could not serve in his home province.

A magistrate was essentially the representative of the emperor. As the lowest-ranking official in a complex and closely supervised bureaucracy, he could not act in an arbitrary manner. His duties were clearly prescribed and his handling of administrative, civil, and criminal matters had to follow imperial orders and a written law, the Great Qing Code. The Qing Code dealt with administrative, civil, and criminal matters. Much of what we think of as family and property law (marriage, adoption, disputes concerning the ownership of fields and houses) fell under the category of “revenue,” as such things bore directly on tax liability and collection. There were five sanctioned punishments, each further subdivided into different levels of severity: beating with the light bamboo, beating with the heavy bamboo, penal servitude, exile, and execution.

County magistrates were routinely faced with the need to deal with disputes over property, which they could handle either by mediating between the parties involved or by applying the law. They were also responsible for criminal matters—many of which (particularly violent crimes) arose from property disputes.³⁸ The law contained detailed descriptions of offenses and the appropriate punishments. For example: “Whenever a horse, bovine animal, or dog rams, butts, kicks, or bites people and (*the owner*) has not marked or tied it in the right way, or if there is a mad dog and he does not kill it, he will receive forty strokes of the light bamboo.”³⁹ If a socially undesirable act did not correspond exactly to one of the Qing Code’s precisely-defined offenses, a magistrate could punish it by analogy to an existing offense or under the rule which stated “Everyone who does that which ought not to be done will receive forty strokes of the light bamboo. If the matter is adjudged to be more serious, he will be punished by eighty strokes with the heavy bamboo.”⁴⁰

Qing officials took great care in the investigation of criminal cases and in the assessment and imposition of punishment. Serious offenses were understood to have thrown the moral universe out of balance. The purpose of punishment was to restore that balance. Punishment had to be carefully calibrated to the seriousness of the offense and to the relationship between the offender and the victim. Patriarchal family ideology viewed an offense by a junior member of an extended family against a senior member of the family as more serious than vice versa. Inappropriate administration of punishment could have negative cosmic effects. It could also lead to social unrest. As a consequence, the Qing legal system provided multiple levels of appeal.⁴¹ County magistrates could order beatings to be administered, but more serious cases had to be remanded to the provincial or even imperial government for sentencing and punishment.

With so many responsibilities, a county magistrate needed a sizeable staff. The magistrate’s office and living quarters, and the offices of his assistants, were located in a walled compound called a yamen. Here, the magistrate carried out the business of government, assisted by his own personal secretaries (whom he paid from his own pocket) and a staff of yamen clerks and runners. Each yamen had a small budget which allowed for a small number of clerks and runners—perhaps around ten to twenty clerks to perform clerical work in the yamen, and as few as twenty-five to thirty runners, who were responsible for collecting taxes, apprehending criminal offenders, summoning witnesses, and so on. In practice, a magistrate might need around one to three hundred clerks and five to eight hundred runners in order to do the business of government.⁴²

Since there was no budget to pay so many clerks and runners, they were allowed to collect fees from the public. Both the extra-statutory clerks and runners and their fees existed in direct violation of the law, but without them, the Qing government simply would not have been able to function. Because they and their fees were illegal, there was considerable latitude for abuse and corruption; but in general, clerks and runners, with the magistrates’ knowledge and approval, set standard and fairly stable levels for the fees that they collected from taxpayers and from people involved in criminal or civil disputes.⁴³ Qing ideology frowned upon litigious behavior. Nonetheless, many Qing subjects did go to court, particularly to resolve property and inheritance disputes. When they did so, they might present their case themselves, or hire a professional scrivener to write their case materials up for them.⁴⁴

Most commoners had no contact at all with a magistrate, and encountered yamen personnel only if there was some problem with their taxes, if they were involved in a criminal dispute, or if they chose to bring a civil suit before the magistrate. The magistrate and his small staff could not possibly manage day-to-day life in China’s villages. Local elite families ran China’s village society. These included gentry, that is, families whose male household heads or sons had passed at least the lowest level of the civil service examination, and also well-to-do local landholders whose men did not necessarily hold an examination degree.

It was these local families, and especially the gentry, who advised the magistrates about local conditions,

mediated local disputes, organized local granaries and famine relief, built and maintained irrigation and flood control systems, opened schools, and led local militia. Their leading roles in local society were prescribed and justified by the Neo-Confucian philosophy of Zhu Xi. Their role in maintaining social and political order reminds us that the Qing's Manchu rulers did not simply impose their will on a subject population: they patronized and supported the social and moral norms that the Chinese elite subscribed to.

Neither emperors nor high-ranking officials nor local elites completely lived up to those social and moral norms. Emperors and officials could be brutal and corrupt; local elites could take advantage of their positions to evade taxes, exploit commoners, and even intimidate the magistrates.⁴⁵ But rulers, officials, and local elites were all constrained by influential ideas about the responsibilities of the ruler and the “superior man” to take care of the masses. Those ideals were both expressed and violated in the lives of ordinary and elite families alike.

Family Life

From the palaces of the Forbidden City to the mansions of great merchants to the humble dwellings of farmers, the boundaries between the exemplary, the acceptable, and the reprehensible were drawn and redrawn in the everyday life of families. The family—the *jia*—was the basic social, legal, and economic unit. Few families realized the ideal of “five generations under one roof,” but most experienced long periods of two and three generations living, working, and holding property as a unit. Individual families were understood to be parts of a lineage (a group of families tracing direct lines of descent to a common ancestor) or a clan (a group of families sharing a surname and tracing descent through multiple lines to a real or fictive ancestor). In the north, lineage and clan were relatively weak. In some areas, particularly in the south, they were powerful corporate entities that owned land or commercial property that generated income that they used to support schools, temples, and rituals, and even to give lineage or clan members stipends.

It was in the family that gender roles were defined, and sometimes violated. The ideal model was one of separate “inner” and “outer” spheres.⁴⁶ Men acted in the “outer” sphere of work, socialization, and service to the state and community beyond the walls of the family compound. Women were to be of the “inner quarters,” devoting themselves to the business of procreation, child rearing, household management, and certain types of productive labor, stereotypically weaving and embroidery, all carried on within the four walls of the family compound. Men held most property, but women could inherit land (if there were no male heir) and retained rights to their dowries, which could include land, commercial property, or cash, which could be invested.

As in the Ming, the state-supported cult of female chastity flourished, complete with memorial arches and publicly celebrated widow suicides. Footbinding also continued to be standard among elite Han women (Manchu women did not bind their feet), and was increasingly popular among urban and rural common folk of all levels. Bound feet were essential if a family wanted to marry its daughters well, and a beautiful daughter, if married to a family of higher social or political standing, could help to elevate her own family's status—daughters could be a form of social capital.

The ideal of separate spheres for males and females was conveyed throughout society in popular culture, literature, ritual, religion, and in the law, which upheld the gender hierarchy. It was difficult, though, for ordinary people to completely conform. Women in farming communities worked in the family fields and entered the labor force as artisans, tea pickers, servants, and prostitutes. Widows remarried more often than not, went to market, and did business on their own account. Some even brought complaints before the magistrate. Elite women were often educated, might manage large and complex households, and were more likely to live long and leisurely lives and to have influence on the worlds of politics, arts, and culture than common men. Nonetheless, the ideal, and to a great extent the reality, was that the places of men and women were defined in terms of a patriarchal hierarchy in which women were expected to be subordinate to their fathers and husbands, and everyone, male and female, was subordinate to their elders.

The vast majority of Qing families—perhaps ninety percent—were independent farmers, and a small percentage were artisans or workers in enterprises like porcelain kilns, mines, or salt works. But neither occupation nor social status was fixed by heredity. In theory, all but a few legally proscribed categories of people could at least hope to increase their wealth, purchase more land, educate their sons or grandsons, and rise into the ranks of the elite. In practice, it was more common for families to lose status than to enter the ranks of the examination-passing scholar-officials, but there was certainly some degree of movement into, as well as out of, the ranks of the local village,

provincial, and even national elite.

The Qing elite, broadly defined, were a disparate group.⁴⁷ Local village leaders might be families who owned a bit more land than everyone else. Any family that had enough land or other resources to educate their sons could be considered elite, as could anyone who identified themselves as a “student.” Merchants, although not students or holders of examination degrees, were members of the elite by virtue of their wealth. They shared the culture of the scholars, might educate one or more sons for the examinations, and could even gain the social and legal status of a scholar by purchasing a lower-level examination degree (which the state sold in order to generate revenue). In the narrowest sense, the scholar-official elite (sometimes referred to as the “gentry”) included only examination-passers and their families, who amounted to perhaps five percent of the total population.

Politics, Money, and Culture

Art, literature, and philosophy had always been profoundly political. In the Ming, they had also become increasingly commercialized. The commercialization of art and even of philosophy continued during the reigns of the first four Qing emperors, as did the perpetual struggle between state-sanctioned orthodoxy and various unorthodox ways of thinking, writing, and behaving. The commercialization of culture could both strengthen and undermine orthodoxy. State orthodoxy itself could also offer opportunities for entrepreneurs. The imperial court, through the civil service exams, helped to define and inculcate orthodox thought and behavior as articulated through the texts of the Zhu Xi school of Neo-Confucianism. This meant that publishers could make great profits selling classical texts or, better yet, collections of sample examination essays, which were better sellers than the classics and the dynastic histories.⁴⁸

The presence, the power, and the profitability of orthodoxy did not make the Qing Empire intellectually sterile or conformist. A number of Qing scholars and officials took very creative approaches to understanding their political and social worlds. In the early Qing, literati who had witnessed the fall of the Ming asked why their dynasty had collapsed. The explanation favored by straitlaced Confucian scholars was that the Wang Yangming school of Neo-Confucianism, with its Chan Buddhist–like subjectivism and relativism, had corrupted public morals. Huang Zongxi (1610–1695), himself a follower of the Wang Yangming school, placed the blame elsewhere. He argued that rulers had become selfish masters of all under Heaven instead of humble servants of the common good. Emperors, he said, needed to have their power checked by strong prime ministers and conscientious scholars and officials. These dangerous ideas received little circulation until the final years of the Qing dynasty.⁴⁹

Huang Zongxi’s contemporary and fellow Ming loyalist Gu Yanwu (1613–1682) was far more influential in the 17th and 18th centuries. Gu turned away from the metaphysics of both the Wang Yangming and Zhu Xi schools. He preferred empirical studies of phonology, geography, history, and classical texts. Gu analyzed the earliest possible primary sources—often stone inscriptions and bronzes—in order to verify historical events and to correct the errors or revisions that Song, Yuan, and Ming scholars had made when they transcribed, annotated, and interpreted ancient texts.⁵⁰

Gu’s work inspired 18th-century literati known as practitioners of “evidentiary scholarship.” The practitioners of evidentiary scholarship believed that Song scholars, including Zhu Xi, had muddled the true meaning of the classics by mixing them up with Buddhist and Daoist influences. Following Gu’s lead, they looked directly to the historical and philosophical texts of the Han dynasty, analyzing grammar and content in order to detect forgeries, hoping that they would thus gain access to the true principles of Confucian morality. The more idealistic of the evidentiary scholars believed that the ancient texts, purged of later distortions, would reveal timeless policies that, if put into practice, would restore order to the world.⁵¹

Though some may have pushed the idea of finding the key to good governance in restored Han texts to romantic extremes, the pragmatic, empirical strands of evidentiary scholarship had a significant influence on the theoreticians and practitioners of “statecraft” (*jingshi*, literally, “ordering the world”).⁵² Practitioners of statecraft did believe that the practice of ritual would contribute to the achievement of a moral society. However, they also believed that to build and maintain a morally satisfying society, the emperor’s officials would need to find and implement practical solutions to economic, legal, administrative, military, infrastructural, and social problems.

Evidentiary scholarship also played a major role in the Qing state’s attempts to define literary orthodoxy, and to root out literary heresy. It was the business of the imperial government to reaffirm and uphold Confucian morality in literature—and to reaffirm the legitimacy of dynastic rule by doing so. As a part of his own “ordering of the world,”

the Qianlong emperor initiated a major bibliographical project: the compilation of all the worthwhile literature of China into one massive collection, the *Complete Library of the Four Treasuries*.

Hundreds of scholars and editors worked from 1773 to 1782 to compile a list of 10,680 titles of extant works and copy 3,595 works in their entirety, each of which was placed in one of four categories: classics, history, philosophy, and *belles lettres*.⁵³ The Chinese scholars who carried out the bulk of the work were devotees of “evidentiary learning.” As a result, their “Han Learning” approach to the Confucian classics had a strong influence on the choice of works included in the *Four Treasuries*.⁵⁴ They and the many local scholars who helped to gather material for the project also had a great deal of influence over what did not get included. One of their charges from Qianlong was to censor texts that made uncomplimentary references to Manchus, Jurchens, and other non-Han northern peoples, such as Mongols and Khitans. The search for such “seditious” material resulted in many legal cases and the destruction of around 2,400 undesirable works.⁵⁵

While all educated men studied the same philosophical and historical texts, the fact was that only a small minority would ever pass the higher level of examinations and serve as officials. Fortunately, other careers were open to elite men. Employment as a professional secretary in county, provincial, or imperial government was one option. A life of leisure, supported by investments in land, commercial real estate, or business was another. And although it was the exception, some made their living as professional writers or artists. Manchu and Chinese alike saw appreciation of literature, and at least a moderate ability to produce essays, poetry, calligraphy, and painting as essential parts of elite identity. The empire’s vibrant 18th-century commercial economy, growing urban population, and relatively high rates of literacy (two to ten percent for women, thirty to forty-five percent for men)⁵⁶ also created a strong market for popular literature.

Some of the most successful writers of popular literature were men who had failed the civil service exams or given up their official careers. Their novels and stories give us vivid and entertaining insights into the lives and beliefs of the educated elite and of ordinary people. Pu Songling (1640–1715), who earned only the lowest (*xiucai*) degree in the examination system and eked out a marginal living as a writer, teacher, and private secretary, collected tales of ghosts, fox spirits, demons, and uncanny phenomena of all sorts, which became one of the most popular books of the late 18th and 19th centuries when it was finally published as *Strange Tales from Liao Studio* in 1766.⁵⁷ Wu Jingzi (1701–1754), another *xiucai*, dissipated his family fortune living the high life in Nanjing. Rather than be an official, he wrote a novel, *The Scholars*, in which he satirized the hypocrisy, venality, and mediocrity of the literati.⁵⁸ Cao Xueqin (1716?–1763), the son of a clan of Han Chinese bond servants to the Manchu imperial house, described life in a wealthy but declining extended family in his novel *Story of the Stone* (also translated under the title *Dream of the Red Chamber*).

Their novels, even if published posthumously, made Pu Songling, Wu Jingzi, and Cao Xueqin famous to later generations of Chinese and foreign readers. Poetry and *belles lettres* could make a man famous and wealthy in his own time. There were many Qing poets—good, bad, and indifferent. One of the most famous was Yuan Mei (1716–1797). Precociously brilliant as a boy and serving as a magistrate in Nanjing at the age twenty-nine, Yuan abandoned his official career in 1748 and made his living as an essayist, poet, and teacher. Yuan Mei’s fame became such that he could command as much as 1,000 ounces of silver for writing an epitaph. He was also known for his support of women poets (whose work he arranged to be published), his dalliances with prostitutes, and his close relationships with young male actors. When a Buddhist friend tried to convince Yuan Mei to curb his appetites in order to break the cycle of birth, death, and rebirth, Yuan Mei replied: “What makes a live man different from a dead one is precisely that he is capable of enjoying such pleasures. What you are asking me to do, is to behave as though I were dead, when in fact I am not dead. Can there be any sense in this?”⁵⁹

Yuan Mei and other professional writers were able to take the attributes of a civilized gentleman—poetry and prose—and turn them into commodities. Many artists did the same with painting and calligraphy. The most famous painters of the early Qing were men who considered themselves “leftover subjects” of the former Ming. These included artists like Zhu Da (1626–c. 1705, also known as Bada Shanren) and Zhu Ruoji (1641–c. 1710, also known as Shitao), both Buddhist monks and descendants of the Ming imperial house. Bada Shanren’s ruffled, grumpy-looking birds, Shitao’s landscapes, and other work by the leftover subjects expressed their mourning for the Ming dynasty, their resentment of the Manchus. Some, such as Shitao’s self-portrait of himself overseeing the planting of pine trees on a barren mountain slope, even seem to express dreams of a Ming restoration.⁶⁰

Bada Shanren, Shitao, and other notable painters of the early Qing were noted for their individualism and originality. As Shitao once put it, “When asked if I paint in the manner of the Southern or Northern School, with a hearty laugh I say I do not know whether I am of a school or a school is I; I paint in my own style.”⁶¹ Both he and

Bada Shanren eventually broke their monastic vows and pursued careers as professional painters, Bada Shanren in Jiangxi province's Nanchang city, Shitao in Yangzhou, a wealthy town at the confluence of the Grand Canal and the Yangzi River.⁶²



Bada Shanren's "Mynah Bird on an Old Tree." Hanging scroll, ink on paper, 1703.

Bada Shanren and Shitao were not alone, either in their individualist style or in their descent into the artistic marketplace. Most of the great Qing dynasty masters of the scholar-amateur style were neither officials nor wealthy men of leisure: their art was their main source of income.⁶³ They lived on sales of their work and relied on the patronage of wealthy officials, landowners, and merchants.

Competition for attention in the art marketplace drove some painters, notably some of the "Eight Eccentrics of Yangzhou," to adopt a cultivated "eccentricity" in order to distinguish themselves from the many competent, but run-of-the-mill artists of the 18th century.⁶⁴ All this blurred the theoretical distinction between the "amateur" and the "professional," so forcefully articulated in the Ming by Dong Qichang and still given fervent lip service in the Qing. The meaninglessness of the distinction was further underlined when professional artists, sometimes employing assistants, churned out hundreds of "scholar-amateur"-style paintings a year to be sold for cash.⁶⁵ The market for cheap decorative art also supported a booming business in mass-produced color woodblock prints, which featured urban scenes, beautiful women, illustrations from drama and literature, and special prints for Chinese New Year.⁶⁶

Ritual and Religion

In the face of a changing world, both the Qing court and ordinary people used ritual and religion to provide spiritual solace, preserve stability, and generally keep the universe on track. As historians have pointed out, "the Qing state was not a secular institution: rather, its legitimacy depended on assumptions about the ties between the Son of Heaven and the cosmos, and on his crucial role in creating harmony between human society and the supernatural world."⁶⁷ People defined, redefined, and enforced family and state orthodoxy through ritual and religion. Others used ritual and religion to change or challenge the status quo.

Like the Ming emperors, Qing rulers or their surrogates ritually worshipped Heaven and Earth and a variety of state-recognized deities and carried out rituals to express reverence for their ancestors.⁶⁸ Also following on Ming precedent, the imperial government required county magistrates to hold regular Village Lectures, at which they were to teach moral lessons to the masses. Magistrates were also to read and explain the Sacred Edict, a sixteen-point list

of moral injunctions originally issued by the Kangxi emperor and revised by his son Yongzheng. These included such standard Confucian fare as “Esteem most highly filial piety and brotherly submission,” “Behave with generosity toward your kindred,” and also messages of more direct political import, like “Put a stop to false accusations,” “Warn against sheltering deserters,” “Promptly remit your taxes,” and “Do away with errant teachings, in order to exalt the correct doctrine.”⁶⁹

Doing away with errant teachings was not always easy. State-sanctioned Confucian family rituals continued to become more standardized and widespread, thanks to the publication and wide circulation of simple handbooks, most based on Zhu Xi’s *Family Rituals*. While local practices still varied and scholars debated the details of ritual, there was wide agreement on the fundamentals: offering food and drink to the ancestors, introducing a bride to her husband’s ancestors, donning mourning clothes and wailing on the death of a close relative, and so on.⁷⁰ But there were many points at which popular practice departed from strict Confucian ritual norms.

Some of these heterodox beliefs and practices, though abhorrent to Confucian purists, did nothing to undermine social or political stability. Placing Buddhist statues in the ancestral temple, the incorporation of “delivery of dowry” (with all its un-Confucian implications of weddings as business transactions), and the incorporation of Buddhist and Daoist rites and lavish feasts into funeral ceremonies were all condemned by sticklers for proper ritual, but were standard practice nonetheless.⁷¹

What was far more threatening to local elites and to the imperial government itself was the spread of heterodox religions. The government patronized and controlled institutional Buddhism, Daoism, and a state-sanctioned pantheon of gods. But across the empire, some people continued to worship non-sanctioned local gods. Loosely organized religions with names like “White Cloud,” “Yellow Heaven,” and “Heaven’s Principle” provided alternative communities for the alienated, for elderly folks without family to care for them, for single men on the rough, lawless peripheries of the world, for farmers living in hopeless poverty, and for uprooted people working along the canals or in the cities.

Though “heterodox” in the sense of not enjoying the sanction of the state, these sects shared fundamental assumptions with the state-sanctioned religions, such as the concepts of re-incarnation, concern with the preservation of health and longevity, and the belief that the cosmos and its natural phenomena are closely linked to the human world.⁷² The heterodox religions even used Buddhist and Daoist scriptures, worshipped Buddhist and Daoist deities, and shared the basic moral assumptions that we associate with Confucian moral philosophy. However, they also generated their own scriptures and worshipped their own deities.

Some gathered in groups to chant religious texts or eat vegetarian feasts.⁷³ Others initiated followers into esoteric meditation techniques, breathing exercises, healing rituals, and martial arts exercises or spirit possession. Women often played leading roles in these sects. Most offered some form of healing ritual or medicine. Many also offered the promise of an easy journey through the underworld after death and a good re-incarnation—sometimes by selling paper or silk “passports” that guaranteed smooth passage through the underworld. Some taught that a new millennium was coming, and that it was their responsibility to prepare the way for a world savior, be it the Maitreya Buddha (the Buddha of the Future) or some other deity.

Generally, these popular religions posed little threat to the government, which tolerated them unless they showed signs of formal organization, such as building a temple or openly recruiting large numbers of followers. But under the right conditions, charismatic leaders could inspire large numbers of followers to take up arms against the government. Among them, the most notorious (from the government’s point of view) were the followers of the White Lotus religion. White Lotus beliefs involved worship of the “Eternal Mother” and the idea that she, or her messenger, the Maitreya Buddha, would soon usher in a new millennium of peace and prosperity. White Lotus devotees were generally content to chant their religious texts and wait. But the right confluence of events—economic stress, natural disaster, and perhaps the emergence of a charismatic leader—could inspire White Lotus followers to rise up in rebellion against the government in order to prepare the way for the imminent arrival of the Buddha of the Future.

The Troubles of Empire

The late 18th century provided just the sort of context in which sectarian uprising was liable to break out. In 1796, the Qianlong emperor, unwilling to exceed his grandfather the Kangxi emperor’s thirty years on the throne, formally abdicated in favor of his son the Jiaqing emperor (1760–1820). Qianlong had been increasingly distant from the day-

to-day business of governing since around 1780. He had delegated much authority to his favorite, a young Manchu guardsman named Heshen, who used his power to place supporters in key positions and to accumulate a substantial fortune through corruption. Nonetheless, the empire appeared to be at the height of wealth and power. But the factors that would fatally undermine Manchu rule in the 19th century were already present. These included imperial overreach, environmental stress, social unrest, ethnic tensions, and the increasing interest and strength of Western merchants and of their home governments in Europe and North America.

The size of the empire itself was one source of vulnerability. The Manchus had more than doubled their territory when they acquired Xinjiang, Qinghai, Tibet, and Taiwan. Control of Xinjiang and Tibet was particularly challenging. Garrisons and administrators in northern Xinjiang (Zungharia) cost tens of thousands of taels of silver annually. Qing officials tried to generate revenue from within Xinjiang by running businesses and taxing merchants, but their efforts fell short of the mark. As a result, every year, silver collected in agricultural taxes from the wealthier provinces was sent to subsidize the imperial apparatus in Xinjiang. Indirect rule of the Muslim Uighur oases of southern Xinjiang (Altishahr) was cheaper than the extensive garrisons in Zungharia, but left the frontiers poorly defended and open to invasion from neighboring Central Asian khanates.⁷⁴ As for Tibet, maintenance of garrisons and an administration would have been too expensive. Instead, the Qing allowed Tibetan monasteries and aristocrats to run Tibet with little intervention from the *ambans* and the small, underpaid Qing garrison in Lhasa.

Administration of the Chinese areas of the empire brought its own challenges. The Qing emperors had inherited and strengthened Ming autocracy. But even Yongzheng, Kangxi, and Qianlong were hemmed in by law, procedure, precedent, and by the sheer volume of the paperwork, much of which they had to delegate to their advisors. In addition, both practical and ideological constraints prevented the Qing imperial government from achieving a high degree of control over China's people and economic resources. First, there was the practical impossibility of managing a large territory and population within the constraints of premodern communications and transportation technology. As population rose from one hundred million to over three hundred million during the 18th century, the county magistrate's office, the lowest level of the Qing bureaucracy, was responsible, on average, for a population of two hundred thousand.

Second, the Qianlong emperor committed the Qing to a policy of minimal taxation and minimal government intervention in China's society and economy. A quintessential "small government" man, Qianlong "was content to see government revenues progressively shrink as a percentage of total economic output and even ... to let a growing percentage of the empire's wealth simply go unrecorded by the state."⁷⁵ In keeping government administration relatively small and taxation light, and avoiding active government involvement in the commercial economy, the Qianlong emperor was putting Neo-Confucian principles into practice.

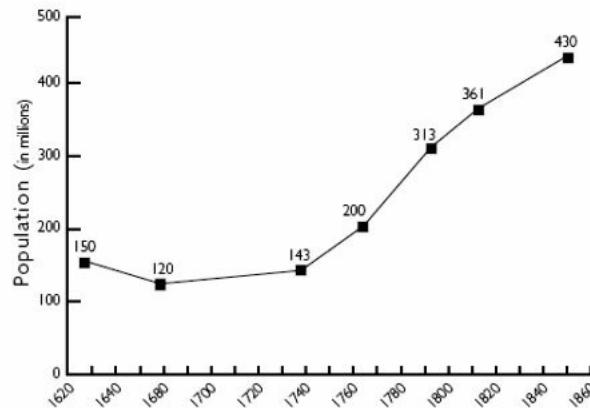
The same principles, and practical necessity, called upon local elites and social organizations to perform many of the tasks that would be performed by government in a modern Western state. County magistrates relied on local elites to provide information, help collect taxes, lead local militia, mediate disputes, and repair and maintain dikes and irrigation works, city walls, public buildings, and schools. Clan and lineage organizations played a prominent role in their local communities, especially in southern China. Merchants from Shanxi, Shaanxi, Anhui, and other provinces built provincial guild-halls in major cities throughout the empire to provide their fellow provincials with lodging, financial services, and social and business connections. Boatmen manning the tribute grain barges on the Grand Canal organized for mutual economic support and religious salvation. In the south and southeast, young men formed gangs known as "Heaven-and-Earth Societies" or "Triads" (referring to the triad of Heaven-Earth-Man). As mentioned above, religious organizations like the White Lotus Society offered spiritual, social, and material aid to their members.

Weak government, low levels of taxation, and a reliance on local elites and social organizations to deliver goods and services are not necessarily bad things. But they did leave the Qing government underfunded and poorly prepared to deal with major internal challenges. And although 18th-century China was one of the wealthiest places in the world, the weaknesses that would grow to crisis proportions in the 19th century were already evident.

The growing pressure on China's natural environment was one of the fundamental sources of popular unrest and state weakness. Over a century of relative peace in China Proper, increased agricultural production (partly driven by the introduction of New World crops like maize, potatoes, and peanuts) and lower death rates had combined to push the empire's population from one hundred million to over three hundred million during the 18th century. Since the acreage of arable land only doubled, the amount of land per family declined.⁷⁶

In highly productive areas like the Yangzi Valley, increased population density did not cause major social instability. But in drought-prone areas like Shandong province and the northwestern provinces of Shanxi and

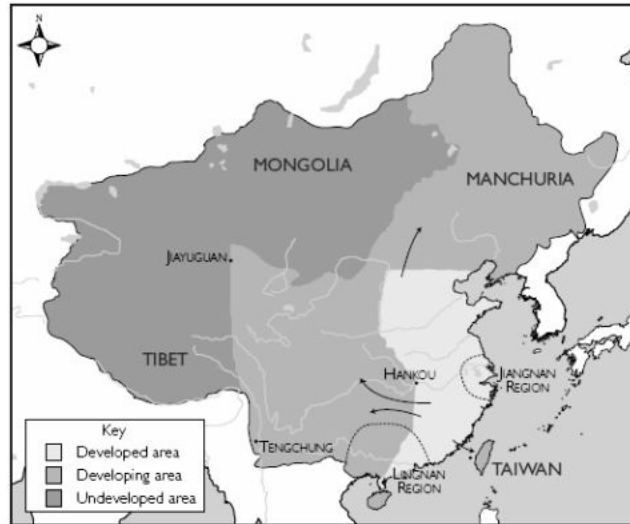
Shaanxi, less farmland per family and environmental degradation translated directly into grinding poverty, young men unable to afford marriage, and families living on the edge of disaster: prime conditions for banditry, the growth of religious sects, and rebellion. Population pressure spurred migrations of Chinese farmers and merchants to the more sparsely populated border regions of western Sichuan, Yunnan, Guizhou, Guangxi, Hunan, Taiwan, and (although Han migration was illegal there) to Manchuria. A small number of migrants, particularly merchants, moved north and northwest, into Mongolia and Xinjiang.



Population growth in the Qing period.

If imperialism is the acquisition and control of territories and their peoples through military domination and if colonialism is the settling of people on the conquered territory at the expense of its native inhabitants, then Manchu empire-building had created the framework under which Han Chinese colonialism flourished.²⁷ As Chinese colonists moved into areas inhabited by other peoples, disputes broke out over access to land, water, and mineral resources. Chinese merchants, well-supplied with attractive goods and money to loan at interest, often clashed with native peoples over debts and land ownership. Han migrants opening new fields and felling timber for sale put added pressure on the delicate natural environment of mountain areas, causing soil depletion, erosion, and flooding.

The Qing government's attempts to deal with ethnic difference and ethnic tensions were met with limited success. Moves to extend formal administrative control to Tibetan communities in western Sichuan and to Hmong (Miao) and other native peoples of Guizhou led to large-scale rebellions. Both were defeated, but at considerable expense. Attempts to prevent ethnic tensions by limiting migration into sensitive areas of Taiwan and the southwest and by keeping Han and non-Han communities separate failed because enforcement was impossible. As a result, Taiwan, Yunnan, Guizhou, and parts of western Sichuan developed into lawless frontier areas.



Patterns of migration in the 18th century.

Ethnic tension, poverty, environmental pressure, religious sectarianism, and government ineptitude combined to create a major rebellion at the close of the 18th century. The mountainous Sichuan-Gansu-Shaanxi border region had seen an influx of tens of thousands of migrants, who barely eked out a living as they opened marginally productive mountain land for agriculture. In 1796, White Lotus sectarians engaged in multiple small-scale clashes with the Qing authorities. The government's heavy-handed attempts to suppress White Lotus sectarian activity led to even larger and more violent uprisings. The Qing court transferred troops from around the empire to suppress the rebels. Generals and high-ranking officials exaggerated the scope of the rebellion in order to keep resources flowing to the military which provided tremendous opportunities for embezzlement.⁷⁸ Such scheming and corruption made many men's fortunes. It also helped to stretch operations against the White Lotus rebels out for nine years and pushed expenses up to over 200,000,000 taels of silver.⁷⁹

Although it was stretched thin, the Qianlong emperor's government was able to suppress uprisings like Sichuan's White Lotus rebellion and other, including a White Lotus rebellion in Shandong (1774) and a rebellion by the Heaven-and-Earth Society in Taiwan (1787). Qianlong also responded with decisive force against the more subtle internal threat of Han Chinese treason. The discovery in 1751 of multiple copies of a forged memorial (falsely attributed to a high-ranking official), which evidently contained personal attacks on the emperor and challenged the dynasty's legitimacy, led to thousands of arrests and the execution by slicing of the alleged perpetrator.⁸⁰ In 1768, the emperor received reports that itinerant Buddhist and Daoist monks and beggars were stealing the souls of men and boys by clipping off their queues—the symbol of Chinese male subordination to the Manchu. Convinced that there were serious political ramifications behind the reported incidents, he ordered officials across the empire to pursue such cases vigorously, only to conclude, after months of prosecution and torture of witnesses and accused, that the reports were the product of villagers' superstitions and their suspicions of the itinerant monks, beggars, and tradesmen who traveled through the countryside trying to eke out a living.⁸¹

Frontier violence, sectarian rebellions, and sorcery scares are all indicative of some of the problems lurking below the surface of wealth and power of the Great Qing. Economic growth had clearly not brought equal benefits to all parts of the empire and all of its subjects. But economic growth in the 17th and 18th centuries had made the Qing Empire, overall, one of the wealthiest and most productive places on the face of the earth. Western merchants recognized Qing wealth, and participated in its generation, by continuing to bring their ships to the ports of south and southeast China, particularly to the city of Guangzhou, also known as Canton.

The Qing rulers welcomed Western merchants, goods, and technology, but on their own terms. Jesuits had gained access to the Qing court with their command of mathematics, astronomy, metallurgy, mapmaking, and other useful arts. The Jesuits' open-minded attitude toward Chinese ritual helped them to make some converts and even to attract the curiosity of the Shunzhi emperor.⁸² The Jesuits defined Chinese ritual as "civil" and therefore compatible with Catholic Christianity. When the far-away Catholic pope, acting on reports from the Jesuits' Franciscan and Dominican rivals, ruled that Chinese rites were paganism and thus taboo for Chinese Catholics, the Kangxi emperor

responded that the pope had no business dictating to the subjects of the Great Qing and then ordered an end to Catholic missionary work.

This did not prevent Kangxi and his heirs from continuing to employ Jesuits in all manner of useful, nonreligious capacities. Jesuits instructed Kangxi's court eunuchs in the playing of Western music on the clavichord; designed Italianate buildings for the Qianlong emperor's great Summer Palace, the Yuanmingyuan; helped to make detailed maps of the Qing Empire; and cast cannon for use against the Tibetan rebels in western Sichuan. Jesuit painters, most famously Giuseppe Castiglione, painted for the Qing court and introduced European techniques of perspective and shading to their Chinese colleagues.

The maritime trade, too, continued to thrive under the Qing. Foreign merchants, particularly the English, having no products of their own that would be welcome in China, brought shiploads of silver to exchange for tea, porcelain, silk, and other goods. The trade centered on the southern port of Guangzhou, or Canton. Guangzhou was larger and better-equipped (in terms of merchants and warehousing) to accommodate Western traders than other ports on the southeastern coast. It was also close to the Portuguese enclave of Macao. When an English ship's captain petitioned (in Chinese) for more liberal trade policies in 1759, the Qianlong emperor responded with a decree that foreign ships would be allowed to trade only at the port of Guangzhou, and then only during the official trading season.

Each major nation trading at Guangzhou (Canton) maintained a "factory"—a complex of warehouses, offices, and accommodations—in a set area outside the city walls. Foreigners were confined to the factory quarter and were required to do business with one of thirteen licensed merchant houses, or "hongs," in the city. The "Canton trade," as it is called, generated its own cultural characteristics: Chinese artists painting portraits and landscapes in European oils for Western customers, the great porcelain works of Jingdezhen churning out dinner sets bearing European decorative themes and coats of arms, and Chinese merchants speaking a colorful and very serviceable pidgin English enriched by Portuguese and Cantonese vocabulary.

Foreign merchants chafed at the restrictions on their trade. They resented the need to pay various fees and bribes to port officials and to a man whom they called the Hoppo—actually a representative of the imperial household (*hubu*), whose job it was to supervise the trade and to collect taxes for the emperor. They resented, too, the fact that foreigners could be tried and punished under Qing law. When, for example, a salute fired from the ship *Lady Hughes* killed a Chinese bystander, Qing authorities, acting on the principle of collective criminal responsibility, rejected the captain's argument that no one could be punished because it was impossible to say which gunner's cannon had inflicted the fatal injury. In the end, a gunner was handed over for execution.



The western factories at Guangzhou (Canton) as painted by the British artist George Chinnery in 1833.

Despite their complaints, foreign merchants kept coming to Guangzhou. For all the difficulties, the taxes, and the bribes, the trade was profitable. The English had developed a gargantuan appetite for tea, on which China still had a monopoly. Wealthy Europeans and Americans enjoyed Chinese porcelain and other items so much as to drive two periods of *chinoiserie*—Chinese styles of garden and interior design. Qing officials and the Qing emperor himself were so confident of their wealth, their power, and the innate value of their civilization that they could easily look upon the foreign trade as a matter of peripheral interest. In 1793, the British diplomat George Lord Macartney (1737–1806) came to Beijing to negotiate the opening of more ports, the establishment of a permanent British trading post on a convenient island off the coast of Guangdong, and diplomatic representation in Beijing. He brought many gifts, including astronomical instruments, scale models of British warships, and examples of British manufactures.⁸³

The Qianlong emperor received Macartney and his gifts with great politeness, but little interest. He turned down all of Macartney's requests, saying: "I set no value on objects strange and ingenious, and have no use for your

country's manufactures. ... Our Celestial Empire possesses all things in prolific abundance and lacks no product within its borders."⁸⁴ Macartney returned to Britain with much new information, but no trade or diplomatic agreements. British and other Western merchants continued to trade at Guangzhou (Canton), exchanging silver for tea, silk, porcelain, and other Chinese products. For the Qianlong emperor and his court, life continued as before: The Macartney mission was not, in their view, a particularly significant event.

Retrospect and Prospect

It is easy, from a modern Western perspective, to attach too much significance to the Qianlong emperor's dismissal of Lord Macartney. Qianlong's remarks about not valuing "strange and ingenious objects" and not needing British manufactures belie the fact that he employed Jesuit astronomers, architects, painters, map-makers, and ballistic experts and that New World silver played a significant role in the Qing economy. It is worth remembering that the emperor did not want to eliminate trade but he wanted to regulate it on his own terms.

With the benefit of hindsight, it appears to us that the emperor's confidence in Qing wealth and power was misplaced. Environmental degradation, the pressure of population growth, social unrest, ethnic tension, and a small, underfunded, inefficient government were already undermining the Qing Empire from within. At the same time, the scientific revolution, political revolutions, the industrial revolution, and the rise of strong nation-states in Western Europe, North America, and (later) Japan would soon give the Qing some powerful new enemies. In the 19th and early 20th centuries, internal weaknesses and external challenges combined to bring the Qing dynasty to its knees. Beginning with the Opium War (1839–1842), the Qing would suffer a string of military humiliating military defeats at the hands of the Western powers and Japan. As a result, it would lose parts of its territory (notably Hong Kong and Taiwan) and be forced to pay crippling indemnities to the victors, and to sign a series of "unequal treaties" that gave foreigners economic, legal, and military privileges in Qing territory. From within, the Qing would be hit by natural disasters and multiple popular rebellions. The most severe of them, the Taiping rebellion (1850–1864), would take an estimated thirty million lives and thoroughly devastate the wealthy rice-growing regions of the middle and lower Yangzi Valley.⁸⁵

From the mid-19th century on, Manchu aristocrats and Han Chinese scholars and officials looked to the West and Japan for technology, institutions, and ideas that might help to strengthen the failing Qing dynasty and to enable it to withstand both its internal and external challenges. With foreigners resident in all the major cities of the realm, maritime trade growing by leaps and bounds, and Chinese traveling, working, and studying abroad, Western and Japanese art, music, literature, history, economics, and political ideas poured into the Qing Empire. The government, its bureaucracy, the educational system, the civil service examinations, the right of Manchus to rule, and the institution of monarchy itself all came under attack. Finally, in 1911, a republican revolution broke out. The six-year-old emperor Aisin Gioro Puyi, Qianlong's great-great-great grandson, abdicated on 12 February 1912. With his abdication, the Qing government was dissolved and the Qing Empire came to an end. But in one sense, the empire remained a reality. The Qing dynasty's successor states, the Republic of China (1912–1949 on the mainland, 1949–present on Taiwan) and the People's Republic of China (1949–present), defined the country of China as being composed of the territory and the various peoples of the former Qing Empire (although accepting the independence of Mongolia and the loss of parts of what are now Russian Siberia and Russia's Far Eastern Province). The task of the post-Qing leaders of China—a task that remains incomplete—would be to unite the far-ranging territories of the Qing under one strong, central government and to give their people—Han, Mongol, Tibetan, Uighur, Manchu, and other minority ethnic groups or "nationalities"—a new identity as members of a single, unified Chinese nation.

The impending dynastic collapse and all that followed was hidden from the Qianlong emperor. Although an elderly man, he continued to display an aura of strength and confidence. In 1795, while staying at his summer retreat at Chengde, the emperor wrote:

Autumn—the deer gather in herds in this season
Taking advantage of free moments [We] occasionally go hunting
Iron ball threading through [a pair of deer] the female falls first
Gunpowder smoke lingers as the mortally wounded male gallops off
Can't say the eyes are as sharp as in former days
[We] distribute, as usual [the meat], making many happy

Those Miao rebels, one shot will hit two traitors

[This is] an omen that we may hope soon to be perusing victory reports⁸⁶

Although aware of his age, the emperor displayed in his poetic celebration of the hunt the same self-assurance that he had brought to his reception of Lord Macartney. And why not? Beginning in 1644, Prince Dorgon, and then the emperors Shunzhi, Kangxi, Yongzheng, and Qianlong himself, had drawn on the incomparable economic resources, labor power, and talent of agricultural China to conquer an empire larger than that of any of the preceding dynasties. For the first time the peripheral areas of Taiwan, Manchuria, Mongolia, Xinjiang, Qinghai, and Tibet were all brought under the control of a government based in China Proper. Although there were still challenges (like the Miao rebels whom the emperor compared to the deer that he shot), Qianlong firmly believed that he would defeat them, just as he had the rebels on Taiwan, the Zunghars, the Muslims of Xinjiang, and (at least in his own mind) the Gurkhas, the Burmese, and the Annamese.

In 1796, having reigned for sixty years, the Qianlong emperor abdicated in favor of his son, the Jiaqing emperor (r. 1796–1820). The abdication was a carefully choreographed act of filial piety, undertaken so that Qianlong's reign would not exceed that of his grandfather, the Kangxi emperor. In fact, Qianlong continued to be the ultimate source of power until his death. In practice, even before his abdication, much of Qianlong's power was exercised on his behalf by his chief councilor, Heshen (1750–1799). Heshen, a Manchu guardsman, caught the emperor's eye in 1775. Qianlong showered the young man with affection, gifts, and promotions, making him a grand councilor within a year. Like so many imperial favorites before him, Heshen used his power to enrich himself, to appoint friends and supporters to key positions in the bureaucracy, and to reward them generously.

When Qianlong died in 1799, years of war had drained the Qing treasury, the White Lotus rebellion still raged in Sichuan province, Heshen and his clique dominated the court, and the Western powers, though not yet an imminent danger, were on the rise. In retrospect, it seems that the roots of the Qing dynasty's 19th-century crises were already lurking below the surface of the apparent splendor of the Qianlong era. But before we judge the Qianlong emperor and his officials too harshly for a failure to take note of impending disaster, we might ask ourselves how well we can discern the trends of the future in our own world and predict their political and economic consequences half a century out!

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6. The definition of “separate spheres” for males and females is not unique to China. Similar definitions of gender roles are found in most, perhaps all, premodern societies. The intent here is not to make an argument for Chinese exceptionalism, but simply to show how male and female roles were constructed in the Qing.
7. The following definitions of the “elite” follow Naquin and Rawski, *Chinese Society*, 115–6.
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9. William Theodore de Bary et al., eds., *Sources of Chinese Tradition, Vol. 2: From 1600 Through the Twentieth Century*, 2nd ed. (New York: Columbia University Press, 2000), 4–7. See also Huang Zongxi’s own work, *Waiting for the Dawn: A Plan for the Prince: Huang Tsung-hs'i's Ming-i tai-fang lu*, trans. William Theodore de Bary (New York: Columbia University Press, 1993).
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1. Quoted in Laurence Sickman and Alexander Soper, *The Art and Architecture of China* (Harmondsworth: Penguin Books, Ltd., 1971), 358.
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[Further Readings](#)

Full citations for the various sources consulted in writing this book can be found in the notes for each chapter. Readers who want to explore a particular topic in depth are advised to look to the endnotes to locate books and articles that may be of interest. The following list of selected further readings is far from exhaustive: its purpose is to provide readers with a basic list of easily accessible secondary works and/or primary sources relevant to a particular topic or time period.

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